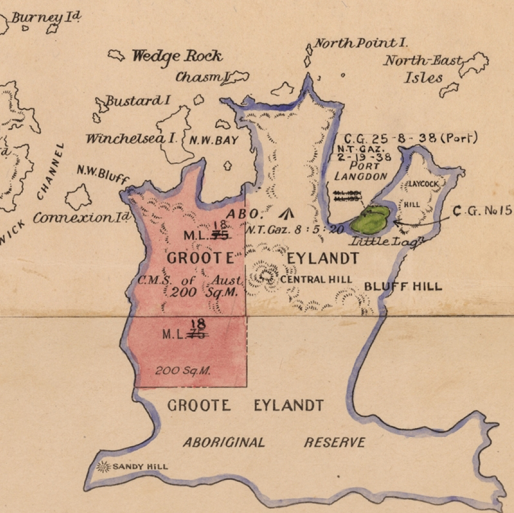
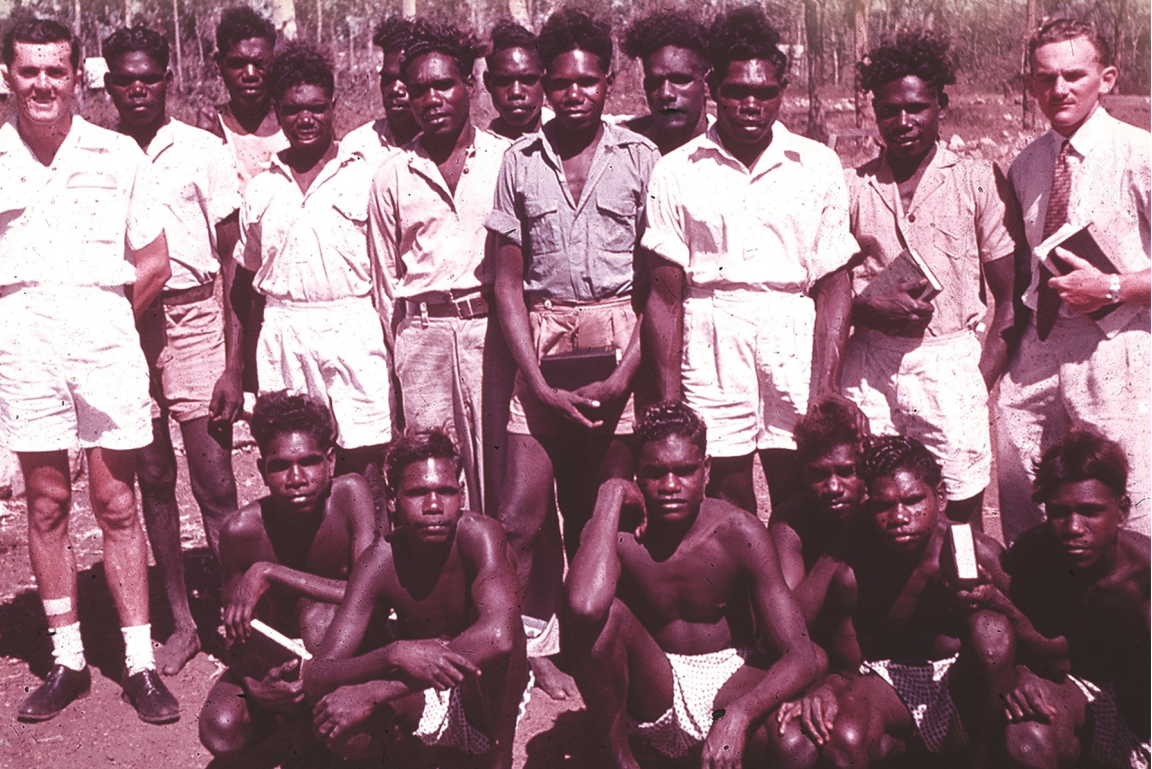




*Many Meanings on a
North Australian Mission*

FOUND IN TRANSLATION



LAURA RADEMAKER

FOUND IN TRANSLATION



series editors

*Noelani Goodyear-Kaʻōpua
and April K. Henderson*

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LAURA RADEMAKER



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*In memory of Rhoda Lalara, Nancy Lalara,
Benjamin Lalara, and Murabuda Wurramarrba*

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Preface

In song and story of the Anindilyakwa people, their language was carried to their island—Groote Eylandt off the coast of North Australia—long ago by the Creative Being, Yandarrnga, and his sons. The sons now sit as rock formations in the landscape, left behind when Yandarrnga traveled from the Australian mainland to where he now rests as Central Hill at the heart of the island. An Anindilyakwa man gave the anthropologist, David Turner, the story:

*Jagina nireberga Aburgmadja jaugulanwa mandja anaja
Bickerton . . . Nanberengagäna nabureriṇna bija äbina gambira
wanidjuwa wanibaranba agubuda nemamberugwa . . . Jingura
nenilwiljaga, jingura äna ajaugwa jaugulanwa nenadidjuwa äna.*

That Central Hill, he came out of the water at our country
Bickerton . . . He was drying himself but he sank down in the
mud, so he dropped some of his sons [as rocks] . . . Anindilyakwa
language, the sons took it, Anindilyakwa, this language of ours,
they spread it everywhere this one.¹

In the Yandarrnga story, language belongs to the land, it is a part of the land, inseparable from the very rocks that form it.

Like the Anindilyakwa and their story of Yandarrnga, the evangelical missionaries who came to the island in the twentieth century, hoping to convert Anindilyakwa people to Christianity and conform them to Australian citizenship, also told a story about language and place: the story of Babel. In this story the connection between place and language is ruptured and the people scattered everywhere. It was an ancient tale, translated into English, stemming from Near Eastern oral tradition. "And the whole earth was of one language," it begins. The people migrated to another place—Shinar—and attempted to build a tower to Heaven, saying, "let us make us a name." For their pride, they were strewn across the face of the earth, speaking all kinds of languages. Oneness and the right to name humanity were reserved for God alone.²

The Babel story encapsulates many of the tensions within the missionary project. Babel is a story about universal visions of advancement. Reaching Heaven: it is a utopian project. The people at Shinar, through technological superiority, were constructing a name for themselves, building a monolingual empire, perhaps not unlike a vision of a monocultural, English-speaking Australia, a settler-colonial dream. Evangelical Christianity, too, pursues a totalizing, universalizing vision: to bring all people under one faith, one orthodoxy, one vision. Is this Babel? Are missionaries the builders that their story condemns? The story presents Shinar as an empty place, *terra nullius*, ready for the people to settle, build their tower, and make their name. Settler-colonialism, with its desire to establish the name of the colonizers firmly in a place, then, is a Babel project. The Babel story can also be read as a denunciation of diversity. Humanity, scattered and speaking a different tongue in every place, is under divine punishment. By this reading, Indigeneity would be accursed.

Yet, there are other readings. At Babel, so the story goes, universalisms were frustrated and humanity given over to an endless task: translation.³ Whether translation—and all the ambiguities that might attend it—was a blessing or a curse is a matter of interpretation. Perhaps it was better to "live in translation."⁴ As we shall see, Aboriginal people have not always embraced the universals that missionaries offered. Babel could not be rebuilt on Australian soil easily. Translation itself, wielded by Indigenous people, was an important way to disturb its foundations.

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I was not alone writing this book; there are so many generous people who contributed. First, I thank the Anindilyakwa people of Groote Eylandt for allowing me to come to their country and delve into their stories. I still have more to learn and hope to continue listening to what they might teach me. I wish I could have completed this book faster. So many of those who assisted me and who became dear to me did not live to see its completion. I have been to more Aboriginal funerals now than to funerals of non-Indigenous people; such is the inequality between black and white in Australia. I am thankful to Jabani, Johnny and Danny, and Grant Burgoyne, as well as all the staff of the Anindilyakwa Land Council. In particular, Ben Hall and Judy Lalara assisted me with specialist knowledge on the anthropological front. I also thank the women at Groote Eylandt Linguistics: Sylvia Tkac, Carol Wurramara, Frances Hartley, Sally Smee, and, again, Judy Lalara.

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Note on Terminology and Language

The people of the Groote Eylandt archipelago do not have a name for themselves as a whole. Since this book is about language, I refer to people groups in terms of their language. I use “Anindilyakwa people” to refer to all fourteen clans of the Groote Eylandt archipelago that speak Anindilyakwa.

Though I use the word “clans,” this concept is actually a European construction. From an Anindilyakwa perspective, society is based, first of all, on songs and songlines—that is, the songs and journeys of Creative Beings (also called “totems”) over the landscape long ago (also called the “Dreaming”). These beings created the spiritual identities of people belonging to those places and determine their relationships with other people. The people who share a common spiritual identity and who are connected to the same songs, places, and Creative Beings make up what Europeans would consider a clan.

I often refer to individual Anindilyakwa people by (one of) their first names rather than by surname. Missionaries introduced surnames in the 1960s to satisfy the administrative requirements of the Commonwealth Government’s Welfare Branch. The clans chose names connected to the Creative Beings and songlines. Lalara, for example, means “dangerous snakes” and was chosen as a surname because of the king brown snake that traveled

around Lalara country on the mainland in the Creation Period. Not only are these surnames anachronistic when used for people before 1960, but since surnames follow clan lines, surnames are not useful for identifying individuals of the same clan.

In writing this history of language negotiations and translations, I too use language. Like the missionaries, I participate in a national culture of English literacy that can silence those who do not have access. All my interviews with Anindilyakwa people were conducted in English, sometimes with a friend or relative assisting where we had trouble understanding one another. Moreover, I am using *written* English to convey this history. History is shared through common language, and by using written English I communicate with a particular language community—you English-readers—as opposed to any other language community. Although I include passages in Anindilyakwa, I cannot tell an Anindilyakwa story, and to some extent, I exclude non-English-readers by telling the story in this way. Furthermore, this history of language engagements will be lopsided since I myself am a member of the community of English-speakers and -writers. My writing risks perpetuating the very colonizing ideologies I hope to uncover—that is, the assumption that English must be the language of public discourse, of authority, and of the intellect. I hope this will not be the case. Academic history writing has limitations, and its use of language to communicate only to a select audience is one such limit. But academic history is not the only form of history, and I hope my work will be of interest to Anindilyakwa-speakers; it will be theirs to translate, assess, and reinterpret in their own language according to their own historical practices.

Abbreviations

ABM	Australian (previously Australasian) Board of Missions
AIATSIS	Australian Institute of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Studies Archives
BFBS	British and Foreign Bible Society
BHP	Broken Hill Proprietary Ltd.
CMA	Church Missionary Associations
CMS	Church Missionary Society
LMS	London Missionary Society
ML	Mitchell Library
MOM	Methodist Overseas Mission
MSC	Missionaries of the Sacred Heart (Missionnaires du Sacré-Cœur)
NAA	National Archives of Australia
NLA	National Library of Australia
NSW	New South Wales
NTAS	Northern Territory Archives Service
RAAF	Royal Australian Air Force
SIL	Summer Institute of Linguistics
WMMS	Wesleyan Methodist Missionary Society

INTRODUCTION

When the Anindilyakwa people of Groote Eylandt in North Australia met their first missionary, he came singing. It was 1921 on the European calendar. The missionary waved his hands, encouraging the Anindilyakwa camp to join him: “Jesus loves me—this I know, for the Bible tells me so” (the missionary was already impressing an alternative epistemology, placing the written text over the oral word). Eager that his audience should understand, he attempted translation. With his finger pointing to his chest, the amateur linguist used exaggerated gestures to try to get his question across: “How do you say ‘me’? ‘me?’” So the Anindilyakwa listeners gave him their word for “chest hair.” “Jesus loves my chest hair” became his song.¹

For the missionary, this was an amusing incident of cross-cultural communication gone wrong, a funny story to retell to churches as one adventure among many in North Australia. Aboriginal people, he presumed, thought in such naïve and concrete terms that they misinterpreted his simple sign to mean the literal “chest hair” rather than the more abstract “self.” Perhaps their language had predisposed them to think this way. The joke was on them, or so he thought.



Missionary Alfred Dyer with Anindilyakwa men on Groote Eylandt (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

But had they really misinterpreted him, and who was laughing at whom? It is possible that the Anindilyakwa camp took an opportunity to make fun of the missionary. After all, a song declaring love of chest hair is a good deal more entertaining than the original. When the white missionary came with his song and book, the possibilities of translation—and of mistranslation—meant that the Anindilyakwa camp could reduce the missionary to a singer of nonsense songs. They effectively neutralized his claim to authority. So was this a willful mistranslation, or an unfortunate misinterpretation? And how can we tell the difference between the two?

Translation gives an illusion of certainty that might have appealed to colonial powers as well as to missionaries. The translator has the power of representation of the other.² Translation can be depicted as a kind of conquest or colonization: the taming of one language by another or the successful transfer of meaning from one context into a foreign one. But, of course, translation is more slippery than that. There is no perfect translation, only approximate equivalents. Translation arises in fluid encounters between different languages, their speakers and cultures. Whether intentionally or not, it creates space for ambiguity.³

This book is about mistranslations and misinterpretations in the encounters between missionaries and Indigenous people. It asks how Indigenous people have used translation—of language and of culture—to maneuver strategically in their engagement with missionaries. I focus on the Angurugu mission on Groote Eylandt in the Northern Territory of Australia. As the chest hair story indicates, it is not always clear where misinterpretation ends and evasion begins. So translation created opportunities for selective hearing. Sometimes what was lost in translation was better off discarded, and what was found was more valuable than either party ever intended.

We are familiar with the ways misinterpretation has devastated Indigenous societies. Indigenous people have good reason to be wary of misunderstanding. In Australia, the British colonizers misinterpreted Aboriginal cultures and practices in ways that suited their own imperial desires for expansion. Misunderstanding Aboriginal systems of land ownership, misrepresenting Aboriginal cosmology, and misinterpreting Aboriginal kinship systems, they imagined Aboriginal land as free for the taking. These apparent misunderstandings were fundamental to justifying (at least to colonizers themselves) the dispossession of Aboriginal people. In New Zealand, likewise, mistranslation in the bilingual Treaty of Waitangi provided British colonizers with a comforting illusion of informed Indigenous consent when many now insist there was none. Misinterpretation can be a powerful weapon. But it was a weapon that could also be wielded by Indigenous people.

Other historians before me have studied how cross-cultural encounters create “entangled” objects, empires, and lives.⁴ Language and linguistics are especially useful tools for finding these knots because translation and mistranslation are entanglements of meaning. Beyond entangling, however, translation can also be a strategy, a weapon. It can be directed toward particular interests whenever it draws upon one web of meaning over another. But, as in the chest hair story, the intentionality of these choices is not always evident. The messiness of translation—or mistranslation—can be part of its appeal.

I focus upon a North Australian mission because Australia’s mission history differs significantly from those of other places, in ways that make it a particularly poignant case for understanding mistranslations. The Australian

missions were much later enterprises than missions elsewhere (concentrated in the twentieth century, not the nineteenth), which allows me to use oral histories to learn Indigenous people's sides of the story. Also, the missionaries' approaches to Indigenous languages were quite distinct from those in other places. By the time missionaries came to North Australia, the European population in the southern states was highly literate, even within the working class. Schooling was compulsory because literacy was considered essential to the functioning of democracy. By the mid-twentieth century, a vision of cultural assimilation of Aboriginal people into white Australia had taken hold among many missionaries. Aboriginal people, by the efforts of missionaries, would disappear into the Australian nation. Some missionaries came speaking English and hoping for Aboriginal people to do likewise. They made little attempt to learn Aboriginal languages or translate Scripture. This meant that wherever Aboriginal people could keep their language strong, language could become a strategic way for Aboriginal people to evade missionaries. The charged encounter that resulted makes the Australian case ideal for exploring the possibilities of mistranslation.

The Groote Eylandt Archipelago and Its Language

The Northern Territory has a special place in the Australian imagination. Romanticized as the land of the "Never Never" and "Capricornia," the home of Crocodile Dundee, and more recently featured in Baz Luhrmann's *Australia*, it has long been an icon of Australia's settler-colonial frontier, the supposed *real* Australia, the "outback," only partly civilized. The main industry when the white man came to the Territory in the late nineteenth century (and it was mostly men) was cattle. Aboriginal people today remember their grandparents' stories of violent "dispersion" to make way for cattle.⁵ When the cattle stations were established, Aboriginal people provided the labor. Some formed positive relationships with their bosses, but others saw the relationship as akin to slavery, which it often was. Groote Eylandt, off the coast of the Northern Territory, was never a cattle station; the first white people to settle there were Anglican missionaries, hoping to save Aboriginal people from the violence and sexual exploitation of the expanding industry.

The Groote Eylandt archipelago lies about 40 kilometers (25 miles) off the east coast of the Northern Territory on the western side of the Gulf of Carpentaria (about 630 kilometers, or 390 miles, east of Darwin). The name Groote Eylandt simply means "great island" or "big island." It was named by the Dutch explorer Abel Tasman in 1644. The archipelago consists of over one hundred islands, of which Groote Eylandt is the largest (2,260 square kilometers, or 870 square miles), followed by Bickerton Island (210 square kilometers, or 80 square miles), located between Groote Eylandt and the mainland. Groote Eylandt is made up of dune fields, coastal plains, sand



Location of Groote Eylandt

plains, and a central sandstone plateau. Its rivers and billabongs teem with fish, crabs, prawns, and turtles. Its ducks, geese, and wallabies make for good food, as do its yams and fruits: the bush mango, custard finger, bush fig, passion fruit, and peach, as well as berries. The island's climate is tropical. The monsoon comes in December and lasts until April or March when the dry season returns.

The people of the Groote Eylandt archipelago do not have a name for themselves as a whole. The archipelago is the country of fourteen Aboriginal patrilineal clans, divided into two moieties (halves) of seven clans, each with their own territories. The clans are linked by ceremony and a common kinship and marriage system. The fourteen clans all speak Anindilyakwa,

Table 1 Anindilyakwa Clans

CLAN NAME	ASSOCIATED SURNAMES
Moiety 1	
Wurringkilyanba	Wurragwagwa
Warnungangwurrkwurrikba	Yantarrnga
Wurumaminyamanja	Maminyamanja
Warnungwamadada	Lalara
Warnungawerrikba	Wurrawilya
Warnungwijarrakba	Jaragba
Warnungwadarrbulangwa	Wurrabadalamba, Bara
Moiety 2	
Warnindilyakwa	Mamarika
Warnungwamakwula	Amagula
Warnungangkurrakba	Wurramara
Warnungwamulangwa	Bara Bara
Wurraliliyanga	Wurramarrba
Warnungwamakarjirrakba	Wurramarrba
Durila	Durila, Wanambi

though technically the language belongs to the Wanindilyakwa clan. The Bickerton Island clans are bilingual. They speak Wubuy, a language from the mainland, but have learned Anindilyakwa and live for extended periods on Groote Eylandt. I use “Anindilyakwa people” to refer to all fourteen clans of the Groote Eylandt archipelago that speak Anindilyakwa (see Table 1).

Anindilyakwa is a fascinating language, extremely grammatically complex. In 1942 linguist Arthur Capell described it as “by far the most complicated [language] in north Australia, perhaps in the whole of Australia.”⁶ Later, anthropologist Peter Worsley called it “ferociously difficult,” “one of the worst languages in Australia to learn,” and linguist Robert Dixon suggested it is “perhaps the most difficult of all Australian languages.”⁷ Most Australian languages belong to the Pama-Nyungan family, but Anindi-

lyakwa is one of a few non-Pama-Nyungan Australian languages. It was long believed to be a language isolate, that is, having no demonstrable relationship with other languages (like more famous language isolates such as Basque or Korean), but recently linguists have claimed it is actually part of the Greater Gunwinyguan family of Arnhem Land. Still, linguists know little about its relationship to even its closest cousin, Wubuy.⁸

Beyond its linguistic interest, the language is significant for other, spiritual reasons. Gula Lalara, the old man nicknamed “the professor of Groote Eylandt,” explained the deep value of Anindilyakwa words. The words come from the old days and contain the secrets of his country, ceremony, and kin.

*Ena ayaka eningarakburakba-kiya ngakwurra-langwa
nara-wiya a-kirukwularrina aduwaba ngakwurra-langa ena
ayakwa. . . . Ena Amurnduwurrariya amamurukwa-murra akina
na-ngekburakjungwunuma ngakwurra-langwi-yada, angalyi-yada
akwa warnumalyi-yada ngarraki-dirrburakinama.*

These words of ours are from the old days before we were born. . . .
The words come from our ceremonies to teach us about places and
relationships.⁹

In Aboriginal traditions, language and landscape are intertwined. Language indicates how one is related to the land.¹⁰ Each language is embedded in its particular country because it is the language of the Creative Beings (such as Yandarrnga, Central Hill) who brought the landscape into formation. From an Aboriginal perspective, land and language are inseparable; they were formed together. By recognizing the language of the country, therefore, one also recognizes the speakers of the language as owning and belonging to the land. Aboriginal languages can function as a kind of “passport.”¹¹ A traveler who speaks the right language in the right place is known in that country and has the right to be there. As people travel or intermarry, they will meet other languages. This means that translation is an inevitable, necessary part of life’s journeys.

The spiritual significance of language in Aboriginal cultures is consistent with anthropologists’ insight that communities are created and re-created by their speech, their texts, and their songs. Humanity is made up of communities defined by a common language. Through their common language, groups of people share their common history. Shared by young and old, stories and songs pass along the generations by a common language.¹² In this way, language is the foundation of culture.¹³ I am not referring here to hypotheses of linguistic relativity or of the inseparability of language and thought. The theory that thoughts are specific to language is notoriously difficult to prove.¹⁴

I mean that shared language creates common identities. When we communicate, we not only transmit information across time or space, we also participate in a community.¹⁵ Language creates communities and binds them together in a common culture.

According to Pierre Bourdieu, languages operate within “economies.” He describes linguistic competencies as a kind of capital, valuable within linguistic marketplaces. Certain linguistic competencies—the ability to speak this or that language or to speak in a particular way—maintain their social value where the community upholds status associated with that particular kind of speech. But this process is a struggle; various authorities compete to impose their way of speaking as the most legitimate and valuable mode of expression, and thus to establish their dominance.¹⁶

This struggle for dominance and legitimacy, I suggest, is why languages matter in settler-colonial contexts. Patrick Wolfe famously argued that settler-colonialism is marked by its “logic of elimination.” That is, it works in various ways to make Indigenous people invisible or eliminated so that their land becomes available to colonizers.¹⁷ I would add that, given the primacy of language in forming communities, settler-colonial projects also entail efforts to dissolve Indigenous ways of communicating, absorbing Indigenous people into the language culture of the colonizers or muting them by its dominance. Most drastically, this has resulted in the silencing of Indigenous languages altogether. In Australia, of the 250 or so languages spoken at the initiation of British colonization, only 13 still have strong speaking communities today. One of these is Anindilyakwa.¹⁸ Others were silenced by the death, forced relocation, or removal of their speakers. European colonizers carried out massacres of Aboriginal people, moved them onto reserves, and separated their families. At the same time the English language expanded its dominance, becoming virtually hegemonic in public spaces and discourse. But settler-colonial processes have also been seen in efforts to delegitimize Aboriginal ways of communicating. Aboriginal Englishes, pidgins, and creoles were dismissed as infantile, their languages ridiculed as gibberish, and their songs disparaged as “meaningless chants.” Europeans believed that English literacy was the answer to Aboriginal “advancement,” and so Aboriginal schools on missions and reserves forbade speaking Aboriginal languages in the belief that to do so would hinder the attainment of English literacy.¹⁹ Given the primacy of language in Aboriginal systems of belonging and land ownership—Aboriginal languages both belong to the land and bind their speakers to the land—the settler-colonial contest also involved a particular struggle over language and the sounds of Indigenous speech. As English spread, it could obliterate both the need for translation and the connections between language and country.

Missionary Linguistics and Colonization

In many places around the world, missionaries were the first Europeans to settle on Indigenous land, implicitly claiming it for their empire. This meant they were also often the first to bring both the colonizers' language and their ways of communicating. Missionaries believed in the power of language and of the Word. They especially believed in words in print. For evangelicals, text could have a life of its own; texts could take hold of people and convert them to the truth.²⁰ God spoke, mysteriously, through writing. So missionaries came not just to convert Indigenous people to Christianity, but also to transform Indigenous ways of communicating, and even to convert Indigenous people to writing. In the Australian case, this writing almost always came to Aboriginal people in English, the language of imperial might, rather than in their own languages.²¹ Conversion to a literate religion meant learning to communicate and to receive knowledge in the same manner as the colonizers.

Missionaries also believed in translation. That is, they believed that their Gospel could be transmitted across any cultural gulf and into any language and remain, somehow, the same.²² Some would say missionaries' faith in translation was misplaced. In the 1980s, Vincent Rafael and Louise Burkhart argued that translation worked both for and against missionaries. Translation of religious texts simultaneously instituted and subverted colonial rule, consolidating colonizers' authority while also validating local reinterpretations of the texts and establishing local identities.²³ Tejaswini Niranjana called translation, especially in the case of missionary texts, a technology of colonial domination, a containing force imposed on colonized peoples.²⁴ Yet she urged non-Western peoples to "live in translation," that is, to embrace the heterogeneity made possible by a multiplicity of interpretations of culture and identity.²⁵ Rafael later asked, therefore, whose side is translation on? Can translation ever be "faithful" to empire, or does it inevitably play into the hands of colonized peoples?²⁶

But in the 1990s, an alternative school of thought rejected suggestions that missionaries' power was so precarious. Translation was a weapon wielded against Indigenous peoples. In their 1991 study of colonial South Africa, anthropologists Jean and John Comaroff depicted the "long conversation" between missionaries and the Southern Tswana people. For them, colonization entails a struggle to control meaning, the way people represent themselves and their understandings of the world. Missionaries were, to the Comaroffs, the "foot soldiers of British colonialism" who sought to "change hearts and minds, the signs and practices" of Indigenous peoples.²⁷ Their project was the "colonization of consciousness."²⁸ By mastering the language of the Southern Tswana and translating the Bible, missionaries used the Southern Tswana's own symbols and language to penetrate their culture and remake it

from inside in their own image.²⁹ Though few Southern Tswana converted to Christianity, the missionaries succeeded in introducing a “hegemonic world-view” of rationalized modern civilization.³⁰

Determined to emphasize the agency of African converts, missiologists in the 1990s argued, on the contrary, that Africans’ Christianity was truly African. Though brought to Africa by European missionaries, Christianity was mediated by African languages and so assimilated into African cultures. Yes, some missionaries sought to dismantle Indigenous cultures, but missionaries’ use of vernacular languages was a “tacit surrender to indigenous primacy.”³¹ For these thinkers, the missionaries’ message took on a life of its own in translation and in encounter with African cultures.³² Indigenous people colonized Christianity.

More recently, historians of African and Pacific missions discovered a middle ground. Like the C. O. Rowley, Derek Peterson saw missionary linguistics—the “reduction” of Indigenous languages to writing—as an implement of colonization. Nonetheless, he found evidence of Indigenous voices and concerns embedded in the very texts missionaries used in their quest to transform Indigenous people.³³ Missionary linguists were dependent on dialogue with native speakers who taught, advised, and interpreted.³⁴ Indigenous people took up Christianity, transformed it, and even used it to combat and critique colonialism.³⁵ Missionaries envisaged their faith as a unified, rational system about a universal truth. In reality, African Christianity was out of control, because texts—especially when translated—could be constantly reinterpreted.³⁶ The biblical text gained new meanings in translation. But these new meanings were neither entirely Indigenous (their missionary heritage was never erased) nor entirely what missionaries had expected.³⁷



This book grew out of my personal questions about faith and imperialism. As a child, I was immersed in evangelical Sydney Anglicanism and heard a lot about missionaries. My own church had sent families to France and Cambodia with the CMS. Every morning their smiles greeted me from the kitchen; my parents, like many other families, had attached their photos to the fridge door to remind us to pray for our missionaries.

My sunny childhood view of missionary work, however, came under question as I reached maturity in post-Christian Australia. I studied colonialism and dispossession. I noticed the absence of women or of Indigenous evangelists in epic missionary tales and wondered what they were doing or thinking. I developed an ongoing interest in how the missionary project has been entangled in colonial projects. Thus, I approach this book as a non-Indigenous woman who remains a practicing Christian and can sympathize with missionaries in many ways. European missionaries somehow managed,

in Jeffrey Cox's words, to be both racist and antiracist all at once. Their faith in God's love for all people tugged them in one direction, while often an ethnocentric assumption of the inferiority of all cultures to their own pulled them the other way.³⁸ In some respects, missionaries were admirable people: ordinary folk who, unlike the "misfits" and "mercenaries," went north determined to save souls, heal disease, and teach the ignorant. Yet their benign appearance did not annul their involvement in a broader settler-colonial project. Given the nature of settler-colonialism—that its processes are often hidden, obscured behind peaceful agents of goodwill—it is all the more pressing to interrogate the missionaries.³⁹

At the same time, I reject a dualistic, "clash of cultures" model of mission history. Postcolonial histories can portray the world as if it were divided into only two types of people: colonizers and colonized. The dynamics of settler-colonialism must be recognized, but they do not explain everything. Overdependence on binaries—whether of colonizer and colonized, Aboriginal religion and Christianity, evangelists and evangelized—can limit the subjectivity of Indigenous people to either victimhood or resistance (rather than recognizing them as agents in history), and can cause us to overlook the variety and complexity of relationships and exchanges. Understanding Australian Aboriginal history in terms of settler-colonialism alone risks overshadowing Indigenous people's own varied experiences of meaningful life, work, and relationships, and forcing their stories into a grid already determined by a metanarrative of "disappearing natives." It can make Australian history appear driven solely by the actions of colonizers, rather than resulting from the entanglement of both Aboriginal and imperial history.⁴⁰ On Groote Eylandt, most older Anindilyakwa people remember the missionaries with fondness and respect, and many former missionaries feel the same way about them. A good number of both parties think of the mission days as the best days of their lives. Nevertheless, Aboriginal people and missionaries existed in highly unequal relationships within a settler-colonial structure. With this in mind, I explore how people negotiated changing and power-laden relationships, without downplaying the impact of settler-colonization. The structural logic of settler-colonialism operated simultaneously with mutual agency and diversity among missionaries and Aboriginal people alike. Looking for translations (and mistranslations), I find, can reveal how colonizers and colonized also operated in dynamic, creative, sometimes even productive engagement with each other.

I have structured this book both chronologically and thematically, focusing on major issues in mission life as well as on periods of change. It begins with a broad-brush story of Christian missionary expansion across the South Pacific, placing the unusually unsuccessful Australian missions in their imperial missionary context. It then moves to the establishment of Angurugu Mission on Groote Eylandt in the early twentieth century and

the processes of negotiation and translation involved in creating a multilingual, multicultural mission community. The third and fourth chapters offer a close examination of the use of spoken and written English, respectively, at the mission. Chapter 5 addresses the changing mission context of the 1960s and the missionary turn to linguistics in the face of these changes. Chapter 6 considers the ideological underpinnings of the new missionary attitude to the Anindilyakwa language and Anindilyakwa uses for translation projects. The final chapter focuses on the mission's songs in linguistic and cultural translation, exploring how Anindilyakwa people used song to engage with and reimagine Christianity in their own unexpected ways. There was much to find in the mistranslation.

MEETINGS

New Meanings on Southern Shores

The providence of God has permitted ancient nations, together with their languages, and numerous tribes, with their various tongues, to pass away and others to take possession of and dwell in their tents, just as we in New South Wales and the neighbouring colonies do now, in the place of the original inhabitants of the land.

—*Lancelot Threlkeld, former missionary to
Aboriginal people of New South Wales, 1857*

On the last day of 1841, the first Christian mission to Australian Aboriginal people failed. The mission to the Awabakal of New South Wales (NSW) was, perhaps, the London Missionary Society's (LMS) least successful venture, an embarrassment, especially compared to the great harvest of converts the society was reaping in its neighboring Pacific missions.¹ After seventeen years, there had been no baptisms. As its sole missionary, Lancelot Threlkeld, closed the station, the religious press published news of mass revivals erupting across the islands: Tonga, then Tahiti, Rarotonga, the Big Island of Hawai'i, and, most recently, Samoa. Threlkeld himself had started his missionary

career with the LMS on Raiatea, near Tahiti, in 1817. He had baptized a thousand people there.² Perhaps now, quietly, he wished he were still in Tahiti.

But the “sole” missionary did not really work alone. Sarah, his wife, was there. She had married him in 1824 so that she, too, could be a missionary to Aboriginal people. There was also Biraban (meaning “Eaglehawk”), an Awabakal man who had dedicated fifteen years to teaching Threlkeld his language and translating the Bible. Kidnapped by colonists as a child, he had worked in the military barracks in Sydney. His English was fluent. Threlkeld thought him a good language teacher: persistent, teaching Threlkeld “almost daily,” and thorough, sounding out syllables slowly and distinctly.³

Biraban also became an evangelist who taught other Aboriginal people about the newly encountered faith. He recounted prophetic dreams of eagles’ wings, connecting the biblical God to *Koun*, the Eaglehawk man, a powerful Creative Being. Despite Biraban’s labors, Threlkeld refused to baptize him, citing his habitual drinking and his leadership in Awabakal ceremonial life.⁴ Though Threlkeld never acknowledged it, a cultural entanglement, a translation of sorts, had occurred. Threlkeld had ventured deep into Awabakal thought and cosmology, and Biraban had become an apostle of a translated faith that was both Aboriginal and Christian all at once. The first mission to Aboriginal people was perhaps more successful than Threlkeld realized or Biraban revealed.

The Australian missions were very different from those in Africa, the Pacific, or the Americas. In many mission histories, Australia features as a mere stopover on the way to more vibrant Pacific neighbors. For decades, missionaries in Australia felt they had nothing to show for their efforts: no native church, no translated Bibles, no revivals. Nineteenth-century missions in Australia—the boom time for missions in Africa and the Pacific—collapsed quickly. Most were isolated attempts by eager individuals like Threlkeld. They struggled to attract finances and converts. European settlers often resented them as competitors for farmland. Meanwhile, the Aboriginal population dwindled. The early missionary experience in Australia was so bleak it threatened to undermine the core assumption of the global missionary movement: that their Gospel was a universal Gospel for a universal humanity. Perhaps Aboriginal people were so different, such an “inferior race,” that they were beyond the reach of Christianity.

It took until the early twentieth century for large-scale, ongoing Christian missions to take root in Australia. Efforts to convert and “civilize” Aboriginal people through Christian missions peaked, in Australia, in the 1950s. So when Africa was decolonizing, Australia was reaching its mission heyday. The project to convert Australian Aboriginal people to Christianity was among the last of the age of global colonial expansion.⁵

It is not as if the Australian missions were isolated from global missionary networks. Missionary societies based in Australia also operated in other

fields, especially the islands of the Pacific. Missionaries to Aboriginal people were often the very same individuals who labored in the Pacific. By viewing Australia as part of Australasia, with close ties to its Pacific neighbors, we can sharpen some of the distinct features of Australia's missionary past. In particular, the settler-colonial context within which Australian missions operated influenced the actions and assumptions of both missionaries and Aboriginal people. This context limited the possibilities for cross-cultural translation. Over time, as the Australian mission project became embroiled in the state and national visions, its mission story became increasingly unusual.

This chapter focuses on the ways Indigenous people and missionaries engaged with each other's worlds through linguistics and translation in the early missions of the Australia-Pacific region. Christian missionaries the world over negotiated an apparent tension between the universal claims of Christianity—its impulse to bring all peoples together under “one Lord, one faith, one baptism”⁶—and the need to “vernacularize” their Gospel, that is, to make it meaningful in the language and culture of the people they sought to convert. Vernacularization was more than a pragmatic move to make the religion more attractive. The imperative stretched back to the beginning of the faith. On Pentecost, the Apostles' message could be heard, miraculously, in all kinds of languages. Pentecost proved to missionaries, first, that all languages could be instruments of the one God and, second, that God had blessed his church with the ability to understand them. In other words, translation was possible.⁷ Since the Gospel message could be expressed equally truthfully in every language, it was universally true across all cultures, even if it took another form. Vernacularization, then, flows naturally from Christianity's universal vision.⁸ But evangelical Protestants went further still, believing that for a community to be truly converted, its faith must somehow embody its own unique thought and culture; this was a truly Indigenous church.⁹ The imperative for missionaries, therefore, was to translate the message.

Nevertheless, missionaries faced a practical tension between vernacularizing their Gospel and separating themselves from “heathen” practices, ideas, and authorities. Those who crossed the line—“going native”—diluted the Christian Gospel and preached syncretism, an impure Christianity, tinged with “paganism.” But where was the line? As Lamin Sanneh demonstrated, the translatability of Christianity across cultures is both its strength and vulnerability. Vernacularized Christianities risk submitting to the very cultures they seek to convert.¹⁰ For missionaries, linguistic translation was particularly risky. By becoming students of Indigenous people, learning Indigenous languages and concepts, missionaries found themselves entangled in Indigenous ways of viewing the world, often using, to communicate their message, the very concepts they hoped to correct or erase. As long as

missionaries translated their message, it would be born again as an entangled Gospel, a union of both Indigenous and missionary spiritual insight.

Further complicating the dilemma were Indigenous people's own views on the matter. Indigenous people have had their own reasons for embracing, resisting, or redirecting missionary attempts at vernacularization. They pushed and pulled missionaries into or away from their own worlds. This engagement took place in diverse, often colonial, contexts, meaning that missionaries and Indigenous people negotiated various competing loyalties and had unequal access to power and resources. Though missionaries all over the world faced the challenge of vernacularization, the ways they navigated this together with Indigenous people, as we shall see, varied significantly across times and places.

The missionary approach to vernacularization in Australia differed from that of other places, as seen most starkly in the question of translation of Indigenous languages. In some places, missionaries turned to translation as their chief instrument. In Southern Africa, according to the Comaroffs, mastering the language of the Southern Tswana was, for missionaries, "a primary objective, *the* key to the civilizing mission."¹¹ This was also true of the Pacific. There, Indigenous peoples seized the possibilities of translation and writing, considering them among the missionaries' most valuable resources.

But this was not the case in Australia, where missionaries generally gave scant attention to Aboriginal languages until the 1960s and Aboriginal people, on the whole, did not seem to demand it. Protestant missionary linguists' great ambition, the translation of the entire Bible, was only accomplished in any Aboriginal language as recently as 2007 (in Kriol).¹² Despite the growing number of Aboriginal missions in the early twentieth century, few missionaries learned languages or translated Scripture. Several wanted to, but the large number of Aboriginal languages, local language politics, and relocation of people from their homelands meant that often English became the *lingua franca*. Many Aboriginal people, meanwhile, preferred missionaries to focus on teaching English. This general failure to engage with the languages—and with them, the philosophies and cosmologies—of Aboriginal people marked the Australian missions and their approach to vernacularization as distinct from their Pacific neighbors. It also shaped the options available to Aboriginal people, who, perhaps despairing of any possibility of mutual cross-cultural understanding, turned to mistranslation and evasion to manage the missionary and settler presence on their land.

Mission Fields in the South Seas

Australia and the Pacific entered the European missionary imagination together. James Cook's travels piqued public interest in the region. The islands of the Pacific seemed, to Europeans, an Edenic garden. But Cook's violent

death proved it was a fallen paradise. The peoples of this corner of the world were in need of redemption. So English evangelicals reimagined antipodean lands as mission fields and transformed “natives” into a ready spiritual harvest.¹³

Following Cook’s accounts of Australian shores, the evangelical Eclectic Society discussed launching overseas missions in 1786—in particular, the prospect of “planting and promulgating the Gospel in Botany Bay” (present-day Sydney). Australia became a potential mission field even before the colony was established in 1788. When the Missionary Society (later the LMS, an interdenominational evangelical missionary society) was formed in 1795, it had the South Pacific in mind. Its members had close connections with the Eclectics, giving them advice on how to establish their own missionary society (this came in 1799 when the Eclectic Society established an evangelical Anglican Society for Missions to Africa and the East [later the CMS]).¹⁴ In 1791, the LMS sent thirty missionaries to Tahiti and Tonga and, in 1797, the Marquesas. The Tongan and Marquesan missions soon failed, but the Tahitian mission became a hub for LMS activity across the South Pacific.

Initially, progress was slow. The first missionaries were young and poorly educated, and they received little support from the LMS. Some could hardly read. Even their European peers thought they were bad preachers.¹⁵ The Tahitians probably thought them worse. It took several years, until 1802, for Tahitians to hear a sermon in their language and twenty-six years until two missionaries were competent in Tahitian conversation.¹⁶ In this regard, Threlkeld was actually more successful than the first LMS experiment.

Once they established communication, Pacific Islanders found the missionary message incredible. Missionaries recorded their theological debates. They tried hard to convince Tahitians that their belief in a resurrection was anything but ridiculous, but they had little success. Despite Tahitians’ early skepticism, they thought the missionaries brought something of particular value: writing. By 1804, the Tahitian chief Pomare II was literate in his own language.¹⁷ Writing in Pacific languages became a central plank of the mission strategy across the Pacific.

Tahitians had their own agenda for working with the missionaries and embracing the missionary religion. Missionaries were useful for their knowledge of English, their access to European weapons, and their powerful god. So Tahitians applied their existing traditions for incorporating strangers into their society to the missionaries. Converting to new, more powerful gods (*atua*) was not unusual in Polynesian religious practice. The vanquished cult of Oro itself—which Pomare II “banished” in 1815—was only a recent phenomenon that had likely replaced earlier cults. The missionaries’ god, translated into the Tahitian society, proved to be the most powerful and the most useful *atua* for many Tahitians in the early nineteenth century. The Tahitian church grew from this foundation.¹⁸

In New Zealand, the Māori chief Ruatara invited CMS missionaries to the Bay of Islands in 1814. Having spent time in Sydney, he was impressed by European technologies. But he had also seen the fate of Aboriginal people: how they were moved off their land, massacred, and plagued by disease. Perhaps an alliance with missionaries could prevent this in his homeland. Or perhaps the missionaries would be the forerunners of large-scale European settlement. The relationship was uneasy from the start.¹⁹ Key Māori leaders became missionaries' patrons; the missionaries could not hope to navigate the Māori society, or even survive in a foreign landscape, without their support. For the patrons, missionaries offered wealth and prestige, political power, and a means to negotiate with Europeans.²⁰ But it took over a decade for many Māori to take an interest in the missionaries' message. The Māori missions struggled until the 1830s, when many Māori turned to Christianity.

Following these delayed successes, the missionary expansion across the Pacific was rapid. The Wesleyan Methodist Missionary Society (WMMS) started with New Zealand in 1822, then expanded to Tonga, Samoa, Fiji, Rotuma, and the Bismarck Archipelago. By 1850, the Methodists claimed two thousand converts in Fiji alone after only fifteen years.²¹ In 1836, Pope Gregory XVI entrusted Western Oceania to the Society of Mary, or Marists, and they commenced work in Tahiti, Fiji, and New Zealand. In 1846, the Presbyterian Church began its mission in Aneityum in Vanuatu. Within a decade, almost the entire Aneityumese population called themselves Christian.²² The Anglican Church established its Australasian Board of Missions in 1850 for the evangelization of Australia and the Pacific. This led to their Melanesian mission in Vanuatu, the Solomon Islands, and New Guinea. To the missionaries, the Pacific experience echoed the miracle of Pentecost; in these "interesting Islands," they saw "triumphs of Christianity resembling those of the primitive age."²³

But it was Pacific Islanders themselves who spread Christianity. In many areas, missionaries had little to do with it. Before the WMMS arrived in Samoa in 1835, Tongan families had already introduced Christianity. They had discovered the faith through the influence of the LMS on the Society Islands.²⁴ The faith spread along existing trade networks and complemented relationships of reciprocity that dictated trading patterns.²⁵ In New Zealand, Māori spread Christianity and Māori language literacy (they went together). Evangelism presented Māori—especially those of chiefly status—with an opportunity for greater honor and authority.²⁶

Indigenous Christianities sprang up too quickly for missionaries to have any hope of controlling them. The spread of local, hybrid Christianities was amplified by the missionary practice of sending so-called native evangelists ahead of them. The first understandings of the Gospel propagated in the Pacific were those of Indigenous preachers. Missionary societies sought

to harness the networks and the cultural and linguistic knowledge of Indigenous converts. Polynesians instructed by the LMS went all the way to the Cook Islands, New Hebrides, New Guinea. The first missionaries in New Guinea were Melanesians in the 1870s, followed by Polynesians in the 1880s. Europeans only came in substantial numbers in the 1890s.²⁷ These native evangelists were, in Matt Matsuda's phrase, the advance guard, preparing the way for European missionaries.²⁸ They often worked as interpreters. This, too, had the effect of putting the message in the hands of Indigenous peoples. Missionary George Brown, for example, preached in "pigeon English" in New Ireland. His coworker, Kapen, translated his words into Le Bera, and a local man translated this into the local language. Brown knew his message might be mistranslated and reinterpreted, but he had no other option.²⁹

Christianity had many benefits for Pacific Islanders, but missionaries were a mixed blessing. The primary benefit was Christianity's spiritual blessing, which offered a new relationship with a deity of love and mercy, justice and power. But there were also political and material benefits. Europeans seemed blessed with material wealth, which, according to existing beliefs, would suggest that their god would be a powerful ally.³⁰ Christianity presented local leaders with opportunities to centralize their political power. It meant an opportunity to reconfigure local social orders, suited to a new era of contact with Europeans.³¹

Yet increasingly, over the course of the nineteenth century, missionaries acted as "surrogate imperialists," establishing a *de facto* colonial rule over Pacific Islanders and ultimately preparing the way for European colonial administrations.³² Though missionaries have been much maligned for the destruction of Indigenous cultures, they actually intended generally to uphold them, albeit in part and on their terms. Their hope to establish truly "Indigenous" (or "vernacularized") churches meant encouraging the incorporation of Indigenous languages and traditions into Christian worship. But, ever wary that Indigenous people would stray into syncretism, missionaries reserved the right to judge which traditions and meanings could be Christianized and which could not. Though the severity of mission discipline varied across missions and denominations, they each worked in their own way to abolish local practices. Their efforts at "civilizing" and Christianizing Pacific peoples left cultural traditions dramatically altered. The missionaries' ambivalent relationship to Pacific cultures left its mark; even today, many Pacific peoples celebrate the coming of Christianity to their islands and observe the missionaries' traditions, even as they strongly uphold their own unique cultural identities.³³

Meanwhile, a "literate revolution" rolled through the Pacific. Indigenous peoples had a huge appetite for the written word. Although their precise motives are debated—they had diverse reasons for wanting translated Bibles—it is clear that, generally, they associated script with European power and

prestige. Reading offered opportunities for new spiritual knowledge, so the translated Bible was of great interest.³⁴ Missionaries reported that Tahitians were obsessed with reading, day and night.³⁵ Of course, missionaries had reason to exaggerate this enthusiasm, but the quantity of literature they produced attests to a huge Pacific appetite for texts. The Māori New Testament was printed in runs of twenty thousand copies in 1841, 1843, and 1845. That works out to two New Testaments for every three Māori every two years.³⁶

Missionaries partnered with Indigenous translators to satisfy this desire for translated texts as quickly as possible. In 1877, under the heading “Islands of the Pacific,” the British and Foreign Bible Society (BFBS) recounted its progress. There were translations of the entire Bible in Māori, Ōlelo Hawai‘i, Fijian, Samoan, Rarotongan, and Tahitian. Rotuman, Niue, Aneityum, and the Gilbert Islands had the entire New Testament. Portions were complete in Lifu, Iaian, Eromanga, Efatese, Marquesan, Kusaie, and Ebon.³⁷ By 1912, the BFBS boasted of Scriptures in sixty-two Pacific Islands, including twelve completed Bibles.³⁸ These Bibles circulated widely. In 1877, the BFBS claimed to have circulated tens of thousands of translated New Testaments in the Pacific: 81,000 in Māori, 20,000 in Tongan, 18,000 in Tahitian, 4,000 in Aneityumese, and 20,000 full Bibles in Samoan.³⁹

Missionaries tried to harness this linguistic revolution, but could never control it. Pacific peoples developed their own scriptural hermeneutic. Some Māori, for example, took literally the Bible’s promises of salvation from death and so, when they saw converts and missionaries sicken and die, pointed out that the Bible must be in error. To missionaries this was the fault of Māori misinterpretation. Yet to Māori who did not convert, it could be a useful “misinterpretation”—that is, one that enabled them to critique and undermine missionaries.⁴⁰ Other Māori saw the Europeans as misinterpreting or, worse, ignoring Scripture. When the Europeans failed to rest on Sundays, Māori rebuked them for breaking the Sabbath.⁴¹ A similar pattern was replicated across the Pacific. In Aneityum, for example, as Helen Gardner explained, “the missionaries and the Aneityumese together created a new heaven.”⁴² The translated Gospel produced an entangled Christianity, born of both missionary and Indigenous traditions.

The translation project also changed the missionaries. One translator, Thomas Kendall, felt the attraction of Māori cosmology so keenly that he was struck by a crisis of faith. Saying he felt “overpowered” and “overwhelmed” by the ideas of the Māori, he also lived with a Māori woman. He was dismissed from the CMS in 1823.⁴³ As Anna Johnston explains, “going native” was actually symptomatic of spiritual crisis, the result of deep immersion in an alternative religious world.⁴⁴ This sense of total immersion was not unique to New Zealand. In Aneityum, Charlotte Geddie felt herself forgetting English. She saw the same happening to missionaries in Samoa.⁴⁵ Vernacularization meant thinking like locals and going, little by little, native.

Misunderstandings in Australia

Threlkeld and his LMS missionary colleagues arrived in Sydney in 1824 as heroes. News of mass conversions in the Pacific, after years of what seemed no progress, had reached the religious press. On their arrival, the missionaries noted the appalling living conditions of Aboriginal people. There had been minimal attempts to evangelize and no efforts to learn Indigenous languages or translate Scripture, the missionary practice that had been so successful in fomenting the “literacy revolution” among their island neighbors. Christian missions, they concluded, had not been properly tried. Threlkeld would be the first.⁴⁶

Threlkeld went to the Awabakal people, establishing the mission at Lake Macquarie, 140 kilometers (87 miles) north of Sydney, far from the “immoral” influences of the convicts. His strategy was to “act here upon the same plan we found so successful at Raiatea.”⁴⁷ So, just as he had learned Tahitian, he quickly turned to Awabakal. Despite the similarity of approach, he found work in Australia monotonous. After two years, there were no crowds flocking. But he had hope that he would yet see “the same effects in the minds of Aborigines as has opened the minds of ten thousands in the Southern Seas.”⁴⁸

Threlkeld’s approach presented an opportunity for Biraban, his co-worker. Biraban used Threlkeld to transform his knowledge into print. The Gospel of St. Luke in Awabakal, completed in 1831, became a tangible record of his language in a medium the colonizers recognized as valuable. It now conveyed the Word of God: evidence that its speakers were also made in the image of God. Biraban translated Christian texts into the language of his own ceremonial life. His vision of god resembled Koun, the Eaglehawk man. Koun gives the law to initiated men, sometimes appearing in dreams. Biraban’s descriptions of Koun shining brightly like fire mirror those of the biblical God. But instead of vernacularization, Threlkeld saw mistranslation. When searching for a word in Awabakal for the Christian deity, Biraban had suggested Koun. Threlkeld thought it inappropriate and introduced one from the Hebrew: Eloi. But Biraban continued to dream of Koun. In a strategic “mistranslation,” his god was Aboriginal. Although Threlkeld thought he had no converts, some Awabakal people came to experience Threlkeld’s god as a spiritual power in their lives, though perhaps they understood him more as a Christian Koun, than as Threlkeld envisaged him.⁴⁹

The LMS sacked Threlkeld in 1829 after a series of disagreements, financial and personal. He closed the LMS mission and opened a new one on the other side of the lake funded, this time, by the colonial government. The government withdrew its support in 1841. By then, the Awabakal population had collapsed. Settler and intertribal violence, disease, and dispossession had taken a heavy toll. He had buried sixty people at the old mission house, most

of whom had died of flu, whooping cough, or measles.⁵⁰ By 1840, there were only sixteen people left on the mission. Biraban, devastated, had turned to alcohol and died in 1842. With the breakdown of the language community, Threlkeld could not find a publisher for the Awabakal Gospels.⁵¹ Luke was finally published in 1858, as a “curiosity.” Toward the end of his life, Threlkeld described himself as “the unprofitable servant who attempted to ameliorate the pitiable condition of the aborigines and attain a knowledge of their language:—‘He has done what he could.’” The implication was that, ultimately, he failed.⁵²

Following Threlkeld’s apparent failure, the missionary trajectories of Australia and the South Pacific increasingly diverged. Australia lost its status as a missionary field. Enthusiasts of the missionary enterprise in Australia continued as senders, funders, and promoters of missions, with Sydney remaining an important hub for the South Pacific, but the work of evangelism happened farther afield.

The CMS also attempted a short-lived mission to Aboriginal people. They went west of Sydney, to the Wiradjuri people of central-western NSW at the Wellington Valley in 1832. The mission provided food and medical aid, and was a refuge from violent settlers encroaching on Wiradjuri land. Missionaries made strides in learning Wiradjuri, translating Scripture, and teaching children to read it. But, just as the CMS missions to the Māori were thriving in New Zealand, this Australian project closed in 1842. The missionaries had baptized no Aboriginal people, though some had requested baptism.⁵³ Angered by the mission’s harsh treatment of their children (the missionaries had even kidnapped some of them), the Wiradjuri people moved away. Drought struck the mission farm. Missionaries quarreled among themselves. Like Threlkeld, the mission depended on colonial government funding, which was withdrawn when the mission became dysfunctional and colonial enthusiasm for missions faded.⁵⁴ Settlers claimed the land.

This pattern of short-lived attempts continued around the Australian continent. The next attempt was made by the WMMS at Buntingdale in Victoria in 1838. It, too, relied on the colonial government. By the 1840s, Aboriginal people valued the mission as a refuge from settler violence, and some were learning to read English. Still, there were no conversions, and the WMMS considered it a failure. In 1850, the colonial government withdrew even the missionaries’ grazing license, and the Aboriginal residents were moved on.⁵⁵ An alliance of Presbyterians and German Lutherans attempted a mission at Moreton Bay in 1838 but retreated, disillusioned, in 1844. One of the missionaries, Karl Wilhelm Schmidt, later went to Samoa, where he experienced great success.⁵⁶ Four Passionist priests established a mission on Stradbroke Island in 1843 but left after only four years. The New Norcia Bene-

dictine mission and monastery in Western Australia had far better fortunes, continuing from 1846 to 1974 as an orphanage.

By this stage, much of white Australia suspected Aboriginal people could not be evangelized or “civilized.” In the mid-nineteenth century, support for Christian missions in Australia waned, just as it did elsewhere across the empire. The rise of social-Darwinist views challenged missionaries’ assertions that all humanity, made of “one blood,” could convert to Christianity. The Indian Uprising and Morant Bay rebellion eroded British belief in the unity of humanity (though missionaries continued to insist on it) and, with it, imperial missionary zeal.⁵⁷ Wars between settlers and Māori in New Zealand also stifled support for missions in Australia. Some thought missionaries, with their antisettler sentiment and their use of the Māori language, were to blame for Māori resistance.⁵⁸ They feared Aboriginal people would also rise up if given the resources, the opportunity to organize, and the ideological justification that missions afforded. At the same time, however, Aboriginal people were dying at such a rate that others imagined there would soon be none left to evangelize, anyway. As the value of missionary work seemed increasingly questionable, missions around the British Empire in the late nineteenth century tended to be the work of smaller, fringe missionary societies. This was also the case in Australia, where groups such as the Moravians took the lead.⁵⁹

Moravian missionaries were famous for their success where others had failed. Australia was attractive to them, partly because of its reputation as a field with “hard soil,” but also because they anticipated financial support from colonial governments. Their first attempt at Lake Boga (1850–1856) had no converts, but their subsequent partnerships with the Presbyterian Church at the Ebenezer mission (1859–1904) and Ramahyuck mission (1862–1908) in Victoria were the first to see better results.⁶⁰

There was hope at Ebenezer. Nathaniel Pepper gained renown as the first Aboriginal convert, announced at a meeting of the LMS in 1860.⁶¹ Pepper, like Biraban, was a Bible translator and, according to missionaries, converted as he put the Psalms into his language.⁶² Yet, as Robert Kenny points out, Pepper’s conversion was truly confirmed to missionaries when he began preaching in Wergaia, his own language.⁶³ Eventually, however, the colonial support upon which Ebenezer and Ramahyuck depended evaporated. Aboriginal people living there were moved onto government reserves, and the missions were dissolved.

There was a second wave of missionary activity in the latter half of the nineteenth century. Its more successful examples were the Aborigines’ Friends Association mission at Point McLeay (1858–1916), the Anglican Lake Tyers mission (1862–1908), and Poonindie mission (1850–1896).⁶⁴ Meanwhile, in South and Central Australia, German Lutherans worked hard to evangelize

Aboriginal people in the deserts. Their unfamiliarity with the desert climate, among other things, led to their failure at Killapaninna (1866–1881), but they also established their most famous mission, Hermannsburg (1877–1982) near Alice Springs, which lasted into the era of twentieth-century missions.

For Aboriginal people, life on these missions was, sometimes, the least bad option. The missions presented opportunities to gain access to Western knowledge, skills, and spirituality, and could be a refuge from violent settlers and poverty. Yet the missions also operated with strict discipline and work regimes, aimed at reforming Aboriginal people. As missions were generally under-resourced and located on the poorest farmland, residents (called “inmates”) and sometimes missionaries alike lived in poverty. Although missionaries respected Aboriginal people as equally human, they held patronizing views of Aboriginal cultures as underdeveloped and unsophisticated. Most focused on the children, believing adults were too steeped in their traditions to be “civilized” or “Christianized.” This could be devastating for Aboriginal families, especially when missionaries forcibly removed children or used dormitories to limit children’s contact with their kin.

Missionaries in Australia were unlikely to build their work on a foundation of linguistics and translation. Still, of all Europeans in Australia, missionaries were the most likely to study Aboriginal languages. William Ridley, an itinerant Presbyterian missionary, published notes on the Kamilaroi language. George Taplin, of Point McLeay, translated “Bible Selections” into Ngarrindjeri, published in 1864. German missionaries, perhaps due to their Lutheran tradition of Bible translation, or perhaps their unfamiliarity with English, made significant efforts. C. G. Teichmann and C. W. Schurmann wrote a grammar of the Kaurna language of the Adelaide region in 1840, using Threlkeld’s orthography (in order to be consistent with those used in Polynesia).⁶⁵ Carl Strehlow, in partnership with the “native evangelist” Moses Tjalkabota, made progress in the Arrernte language. (Strehlow was one of the few who acknowledged his Aboriginal cotranslator; we do not know the names of others.) Johann Reuther of the Killalpaninna mission even completed a Dieri New Testament, published in 1897. Nonetheless, their efforts were small. Aboriginal people were quickly learning English, finding that it brought them opportunities to defend their interests, so it was easy for missionaries to justify their operation in the language of the settler-colonial state. Dispossession of land and displacement of Aboriginal people often meant that distinct Aboriginal language communities were thrust together, so Aboriginal people used English, or an English pidgin, as a *lingua franca*. There were a handful of others, but none got as far as Reuther, or even beyond the very earliest efforts of Biraban and Threlkeld, until the twentieth century.⁶⁶

Settler-Colonialism and the Web of Missions

These few, small Christian missions to Australian Aboriginal people were part of a web that stretched across the Pacific by the movement of people, resources, and ideas. Tony Ballantyne describes Sydney as an imperial hub, connecting British activity across the South Pacific.⁶⁷ It was also a crucial node in a growing network of mission activity; the Pacific missions all had close ties to Sydney, with missionaries spending time in NSW on their way to and from the field. Most societies used Sydney as a base. Missionary personnel crossed the Tasman and circulated among the islands. Most Methodist missionaries in Fiji from the mid-nineteenth century on came from Australia. Some went back and forth. Schmidt, for example, went first to the Moreton Bay mission, then Samoa, and finally established a Lutheran mission in Queensland. Lutheran missionaries across South Australia, Queensland, and New Guinea were connected by their common ties with the Neuendettelsau Missionary Society in Germany and moved across Australasia. Johann Flierl, for example, worked at Killalpaninna and Cape Bedford mission (in North Queensland) before going to New Guinea. Often, the very same missionary societies that struggled in Australia saw success in the Pacific. For some, Australia and the Pacific were, officially, a single mission field. When the Anglican Church established its Australasian Board of Missions, its sphere of activity was to be Melanesia, New Zealand, and Australia. The BFBS likewise considered its work in “Australasia” a single operation (even if the local Australian auxiliaries felt otherwise), and its lists of translations included Aboriginal languages under the heading “Islands of the Pacific.”⁶⁸

Given the connections across Australia and the Pacific, their contrasting experiences are surprising. Much can be put down to the distinct cultures, actions, and situations of Indigenous peoples. Pacific societies are more hierarchical than Aboriginal, which meant that missionaries could focus on alliances with powerful chiefs. Aboriginal people have no chiefs, though old people play important leadership roles. The Aboriginal Dreaming—both past and present all at once—upholds the fundamental changelessness of the cosmos. Pacific spiritualities, however, allow for the replacement of old *atua* by new and so, perhaps, lend themselves more readily to the acceptance of the Christian god. Unlike Aboriginal people of Australia, the Māori *iwi* (tribes) speak a common language with mutually intelligible regional dialects. When settlers first came to Australia in 1788, Aboriginal people spoke at least 250 distinct languages. A spiritual, linguistic, and cultural engagement was simply more difficult in Australia.

Yet, in my view, the most marked difference between Australia and the Pacific was that, in Australia, European missionaries arrived after European settlers. This fact shaped Indigenous and missionary actions, as well as the two groups’ perceptions of each other, directing the nature of their encounters.⁶⁹

In the Pacific, missionaries were lone Europeans in Indigenous worlds. They were isolated from the British empire commerce. Instead, they had to depend—sometimes uncomfortably so—on the hospitality of local people. This dependence fostered the exchange of resources and ideas. Although such a worldly pursuit as trade made the missionaries uncomfortable, they found they needed to enter the realm of commerce to win the favor of Pacific peoples and even to survive.⁷⁰ Their dependence also led them to vernacularize their message to a greater extent than they would otherwise risk. Such dependence also opened opportunities for Indigenous people to reinterpret and “mistranslate” the message as they needed, with missionaries powerless to correct them. It was only later, once colonial administrations strengthened their grasp, that from a position of relative security missionaries could exert more control over Indigenous lives. By this stage, many Indigenous people had embraced Christianity, and a complex cultural translation was already under way.⁷¹

New Zealand, like Australia, did become a settler-colony, but Christianity arrived before settlers. Following the signing of the Treaty of Waitangi in 1840, the relationships between missionaries and Māori changed drastically. Missionaries boasted that they had paved the way for colonization: “If the Bible had not preceded, colonization could not have been accomplished.”⁷² By the 1860s, many Māori had reached the same conclusion. As the Māori saying goes: The missionaries pointed them toward Heaven, but as they gazed up, settlers took their land from under their feet. Many rejected the missionaries and their message: “We got our Christ from you, now we return it back,” as a Māori leader told the bishop of Waiapu in 1865.⁷³

When the structural context of their relationship changed, not only did Māori increasingly assert independence from missionaries, but they also reinterpreted missionary texts, finding, within the missionaries’ book, ways to express their rejection of the missionaries themselves. Suspecting as much, the Anglican bishop opposed the gradual publication of the Old Testament in pamphlet form, fearing that Māori would develop strange new reinterpretations. When it finally came into their language in 1858, Māori liked the Old Testament better than the New. Its narrative of slavery, liberation, and imperial domination resonated. It was more easily integrated with existing Māori beliefs and practices. From the 1860s, a new generation of Māori called themselves “Tui,” that is, “Jews.” They were God’s chosen people. They called their land Kanana, that is, Canaan, the Promised Land: God’s inheritance for them.⁷⁴ Of course, to missionaries, these were misinterpretations, but Māori, by then, were less interested in listening to missionary readings. When the new settler-colonial context altered the terms of their relationship, Māori disengagement from missionaries, as well as “misinterpretation” and “misreading” of the missionary message, followed.

In Australia, missionaries arrived to find a penal colony and, later, a settler-colony. Aboriginal people were already facing loss of land, violence, and disease. Their population was in rapid decline. Missionaries, meanwhile, had the backing of colonial governments. There was little imperative to make concessions for their Indigenous flocks or to respect Indigenous authorities.⁷⁵ The Australian missions, therefore, made heavy use of dormitories and strict discipline of adults and children alike. While missionaries in the Pacific were compelled to err on the side of vernacularizing their message, those in Australia had less incentive to pursue such engagement and the vulnerability it entailed. Of course, missionaries still needed to negotiate with Aboriginal people if they wished Aboriginal people to listen at all, but the structural dynamics of their context meant that they did so from a position of power.

As Patricia Grimshaw argued, Australian missions were also marked by dependence on the settler-colonial authorities. Mission societies assumed that Australian churches would provide financial backing for missions in Australia. When these were not forthcoming, missions turned to the state. When missions closed, often it was because they no longer served the interests of colonial administrations under pressure from settlers vying for land. The Australian missions, therefore, were not only limited in their ability to critique the injuries inflicted on Aboriginal peoples by settlers and colonial regimes, they also effectively operated as an arm of the state.⁷⁶ The close cooperation between church and state in Aboriginal welfare became entrenched. It persisted into the twentieth century (and even continues today).

Settler-colonial assumptions did not determine evangelical thought—evangelicals were among the loudest critics of settler violence and the earliest non-Indigenous advocates of Aboriginal land rights—but they framed missionary understandings about the possibilities of their missions and the future of Aboriginal people. In some ways, missionaries directly contributed to a “logic of elimination,” even as they hoped to save Aboriginal lives.⁷⁷ Their practices of removing children from families, regulating Aboriginal family life, and disallowing Aboriginal ceremonies all had the effect of hindering Aboriginal people from maintaining their spiritual, social, and economic connection to their land.

The logic of elimination shaped missionaries the most when it directed their visions for Aboriginal people. Assumptions about dying or disappearing natives dampened enthusiasm for missions. Australian evangelicals erased Aboriginal people when they reimagined the Australian continent as a source of missionary personnel and funds, rather than as a mission field. “Natives,” in their minds, existed overseas. Such a vision had no space for the presence of Indigenous people but rather conceived of the land as naturally belonging to settlers. Notably, therefore, by the latter half of the nineteenth century, many of the missionaries to Aboriginal people came from outside the British

empire (they were often German) rather than from within the Australian colonies.

These assumptions were also a major barrier to missionary interest in Aboriginal languages. What was the point of translating Scripture if no ears remained to hear it? Even Threlkeld, the pioneer of linguistic study in Australia, succumbed to this view, attributing the destruction of Aboriginal communities to the mysterious providence of God—a precursor of later social-Darwinist ideas—and linking depopulation to the silencing of languages. God had permitted the “original inhabitants” of the land and, with them, their tongues to pass away. How could these languages become God’s instruments if, as seemed to be the case, God had forsaken these people, along with their languages and cultures? In navigating the global missionary tension between vernacularization and separation, missionaries in Australia were more likely to remain aloof from Aboriginal cultures.

Doomed-race theories were not unique to Australia. Europeans also applied the theory that Indigenous populations vanished on contact with themselves, the “superior race,” to Pacific peoples in the late nineteenth century. Pacific Islanders, too, suffered population losses as European diseases swept through. But Christian missions had already established footholds by this stage. Theories of “doomed” and “inferior” races meant missionaries in the Pacific in the late nineteenth century were reluctant to grant full ecclesiastical authority to local leaders, but they did not dull enthusiasm for missions entirely.⁷⁸ The devastation of Australian Aboriginal people spurred Australian humanitarians and missionaries to argue for a different type of colonization in places like Fiji. This meant a policy of “protecting” so-called weaker races through a “benevolent” colonialism that would bar white settlement and support Indigenous leadership under white rule (just as Australian missionaries had done in the Pacific for years).⁷⁹ In the Pacific, these theories did not operate in concert with the expansion of a settler-colonial society, and their explanatory power to Europeans was, perhaps, lessened compared to the case in Australia.

This settler-colonial context, though it did not determine everything, also shaped the responses of Aboriginal people to the missionaries. Missionaries were a different kind of European, but they were Europeans nonetheless. This lessened the attraction of the missionaries’ message. By the time many Aboriginal people had the opportunity to become literate (nearly always in English, not in their own languages), for example, writing came as an instrument of assimilation into a “civilized” settler-culture and loss of an Aboriginal identity. Its benefits for political organization were less apparent to Aboriginal people than in the Pacific, where it was immediately put to use in local affairs. Some Aboriginal people did see that writing could be made to serve their interests. Aboriginal people educated at the Point McLeay and Ramahyuck mission schools, in particular, used English literacy to challenge

the state. But others found writing, especially in English, to be too closely associated with powers of oppression to be attractive.⁸⁰ The same could be said of missionaries and their Gospel.

Into the Twentieth Century

By the mid-twentieth century, many Australian missionaries believed that Aboriginal Australia was the “toughest mission job in the world.”⁸¹ When they looked to their peers in the Pacific or to revivals in Africa, it certainly seemed the case. There had been a renewed push to Christianize and “civilize” Aboriginal peoples in the early twentieth century. Churches recognized the living conditions of Aboriginal people as a humanitarian crisis. They looked, in particular, to Aboriginal people in the far north of Australia who, as yet, had little contact with Europeans. North Australia presented an opportunity to replicate the conditions of the Pacific and operate with as little interference from settlers as possible. By the 1920s, there were over twenty mission stations in remote parts of North Australia—often isolated islands—with the vision of transforming Aboriginal people into “civilized” Christians, thereby strengthening them to face the coming of Europeans (presumed to be inevitable). They hoped to protect Aboriginal people from annihilation, but if this task of protected strengthening proved impossible, they could at least provide charity and “smooth the dying pillow” of the race. The Church Missionary Society’s work on Groote Eylandt was part of this effort.

The Pacific connection, therefore, continued to shape these missions. The Methodists continued their practice of sending Pacific Islanders to prepare the way. In 1891, James Watson went with a party of Fijians, Tongans, and Samoans to establish a mission in Papua. In 1916, he adopted the same approach to the Northern Territory, bringing Torres Strait Islanders and later Fijians and Tongans to work on Methodist missions, evangelizing the Yolngu people of Arnhem Land. These were to be “industrial missions”—training Indigenous people in Western agriculture and industry—a common Methodist approach across the Pacific. Catholic missions acted similarly. The priests of the Missionaries of the Sacred Heart (MSC) also operated across Fiji, New Caledonia, Kiribati, Nauru, and New Guinea. Francis Xavier Gsell, the first MSC priest sent to Aboriginal people, had begun in Papua. The Anglican Church continued to support the Melanesian mission across Vanuatu, Santa Cruz, and the Solomon Islands through the Australian (previously Australasian) Board of Missions (ABM) but also established similar industrial missions in North Queensland and New Guinea. Yet settler-colonial assumptions were ever-present in the Australian mission projects and continued to distinguish them from their Pacific partners. Despite the close Pacific connections, the expectation that the coming of European settlers was just around the corner underpinned missionary actions.

Over the first decades of the twentieth century, far from becoming extinct, the Aboriginal population grew. English-speaking Australia more widely acknowledged that Aboriginal people were not, in fact, doomed to extinction. But this development did not produce a surge in missionary linguistic activity. Though Aboriginal people might survive, their languages and cultures, surely, could not. Through an alliance of church and state, the Australian missions became an essential plank of a government policy to assimilate Aboriginal people into white Australia. This national vision of assimilation meant that for most evangelicals, Aboriginal missions were fundamentally different from missions “overseas.” In a transposition of the settler-colonial dream of “disappearing natives,” missionaries now believed that Aboriginal people, by their efforts, could be absorbed into white Australia society.

There were exceptions to the disregard of Aboriginal languages. In 1956, T. G. H. Strehlow published the New Testament in Arrernte with a team of Aboriginal cotranslators from the Hermannsburg mission. Missionaries at the Ernabella “Anthropological” Presbyterian mission also advanced translation into Pitjantjatjara, as did the Methodists into Yolŋu Matha. Yet as late as 1964, linguist Arthur Capell wrote of recording languages so that they “may be handed down to generations who will see them only as darker members of a European culture.”⁸² Linguistic work was largely considered a matter of preserving for posterity, not of vernacularizing the message. There was no imperative to listen closely to Aboriginal people. The Aboriginal future was in English.

TRANSLATING THE LANDSCAPE

Negotiating the Mission

*Akina yada nangajinuma wa akwa wuyarrirda aruma nangajuk-
wama akina Yadikba Mission. Ababurna alikira wurrariyakama
wurrilukulya kembirra wuyarrirda nuwarriyakama akina.
Kemba narralarra wurrakina wurrabiyarbuwa warnungkwarba
biya nuwilyaba Wuarrmarrba akwa nuwilyaba Wurramara
akwa nuwilyaba Lalara akwa wurrukwa warnuingkwarba
Numbulwar-langwa wurr-Murrungun nilikena-murru-manja
numangkadirra nenumikirra Bill Hodge.*

These are Jabani Lalara's words. He is telling the story of the formation of Angurugu mission back in 1943 to the children at the Angurugu school. His words were translated into English by the women at Groote Eylandt Linguistics for the benefit of us English-speakers:

CMS and the local people did a lot of talking, and they used the older half-caste kids to translate Anindilyakwa to English and vice versa to decide to look for a better place to live. The men who went on the search were from four tribes, one from Wurramarrba,

Wurramara, Lalara, and some men from the Murrungun tribe, and Bill Hodge.¹

The men stopped at Angurrkwa, the mouth of the river, and discussed if this was to be the place. No, when the *Yinungkwura* (North West Wind) blows, the water becomes salty, so they continued up to Mungwardinamanja. Because it was so difficult for the white fella to say that name, they took the name from the river mouth. Mungwardinamanja is where they're going to stay. So they had to change the name from Mungwardinamanja to Angurrkwa so the white fella could pronounce it. The old men took the river mouth's name Angurrkwa. After that they went back to Emerald River and told the people about the new place that they found which is now "Angurugu."²

The Church Missionary Society also taught the story of the mission's beginnings to children through its magazine, *Australian Round World*, in 1944:

The mission station is situated on the Emerald River—now it is going to be moved to a new site about 8 miles away on the Ungooraku River. All the "old men" of the tribe were consulted about it and one conference with them ended at twenty past twelve at night. The native name for the new mission station is Nawadinamadja which means: "The place of falling waters"—there are two very nice waterfalls at the spot . . . At Ungooraku there's to be a church and school a dispensary and mission homes—and the native people are to be encouraged to form a village nearby, to build their own little homes and have garden flats around them.³

In other CMS publications, missionaries reported that they considered "the necessity not to infringe tribal areas so held two "Big Talks" with the "tribal leaders." The site recommended by Aindilyakwa people "needed confirmation after proper surveying." The final decision for the mission location came from white experts.⁴

I found the two versions of the story surprising. Of course, some differences are expected. There are differences of form and provenance: Jabani spoke of events witnessed by his father, Old Banjo Lalara, and passed down orally to him, while the *Australian Round World* was written only months after the events by either a missionary or an editor using written reports. Jabani elaborated on the journeys his old people took over the Groote Eylandt landscape, telling the story as one of creation, kin, and country. The CMS, however, was concerned with projects and plans: the new site, its location, its prospects. The CMS accounts fail to mention that the "white fella" could not

pronounce the name of the site. Nor did CMS accounts explain the changing of names from Mungwardinamanja (or Nawadinamadja) to Angurrkwa (Ungooraku). As we might expect, the missionaries felt no need to justify their naming and renaming of the landscape. The CMS does, however, take care to mention the “Big Talks,” insisting that the “old men” were “consulted” at length. Our postcolonial assumptions about missionaries forcibly establishing themselves on Indigenous people’s land are thus rendered somewhat more complicated.

Jabani’s account is surprising, especially for those of us used to “fatal impact” narratives of missionaries charging into communities without a thought to Indigenous consent or cooperation. While in the CMS accounts, Aboriginal people were merely “consulted,” according to Jabani, they led the whole expedition. Moreover, the “white fella” had particular weaknesses (in this case linguistic) that required accommodation. In Jabani’s story, Anindilyakwa and Nunggubuyu people chose the site of the mission, using their knowledge of the wind and river to guide the floundering missionaries to an appropriate place. The old men were from four clans, two clans from each of the two moieties, such that the *jungai* (those of one’s mother’s country clan who function as “boss”) could oversee procedures. The three clans from Bickerton Island and the other, Murrungun, from the mainland decided together where they would establish the mission. None of the clans were indigenous to Groote Eylandt itself (though the Lalara clan has country on Groote Eylandt). According to Jabani, at the establishment of the mission, Anindilyakwa and Nunggubuyu people sanctioned its construction and location, and asserted their ownership of the mission and the continuance of their clan identities and practices for decision making in the new mission context. They translated the CMS initiative to establish a new mission into their own worldview and social structures.

They chose Mungwardinamanja to be the site, but they decided to call it Angurrkwa. From the very beginning, according to Jabani, Angurugu was founded on accommodation and negotiation between the missionaries and Anindilyakwa people. Anindilyakwa people translated themselves for the benefit of the missionaries, to facilitate a productive relationship with them. When the “white fella” could not pronounce “Mungwardinamanja,” “Angurrkwa” would suffice. Perhaps the old men were simply exasperated at the missionaries’ clumsy pronunciation and poor memory for Anindilyakwa words. Willingness to compromise on this, however, shows their ability to negotiate change and incorporate these new missionaries into their world. When I asked Jabani Lalara later what the old people thought of this name change, he insisted they were in full control: “all the people, the people there were responsible for it.”²⁵ Later, Angurrkwa morphed into Angurugu as the name became further anglicized. Eventually the missionaries forgot that it had ever been Mungwardinamanja, thinking that Angurugu was an Anindilyakwa name.

Both sides tell stories of negotiation. Both mention translation. Interestingly, both present themselves as the dominant party and the party that, out of respect, made concessions to the other. But how could both parties understand themselves as the dominant negotiators in the genesis of Angurugu? Obviously, both accounts attempt to portray their own people in a positive light. There is reason to think that nostalgia for more stable mission times of the past may have crept into Anindilyakwa memory, particularly for leading men like Jabani, whom missionaries respected. But it is also possible that the emphasis both stories place on concessions reflects what were, in fact, complex negotiations and translations that took place in the early mission years.

Anindilyakwa Traditions of Translation

Anindilyakwa-speakers have been translating and interpreting language and culture for centuries. They traded with people from the mainland, exchanging their spears for red ochre, quartzite knives, and spear heads. Nunggubuyu people (literally, “people who speak Wubuy”)⁶ also live on Groote Eylandt, having come before the mission times, bringing their own ceremonies and songs from the mainland. Wubuy-speakers traded with Anindilyakwa-speakers, intermarried with them, and sang with them in ceremony.⁷ Wubuy has some grammatical similarities to Anindilyakwa, and both are quite distinct from other Australian languages. Their vocabularies are very different, however, and they are mutually unintelligible. Some Nunggubuyu people returned to the mainland when their own mission, Numbulwar, was established by the CMS in 1953. Others chose to stay. Many come and go between the two.

The Makassans journeyed to the island on the annual northwesterly Bara winds. Makassan crews were multicultural and multilingual. Most were Makassarese-speakers from Makassar in Sulawesi, but crew members also came from Borneo, Timor, Java, New Guinea, and other parts of North Australia. The crews spoke Malay Creole, a language based upon Sumatran and Malay languages, with a strong Portuguese influence.⁸ They came to harvest trepang (sea slugs), and they had been trading with Anindilyakwa-speakers since at least the late 1700s.⁹ They came in fleets of up to sixty vessels with crews of thirty, remaining for the wet season and returning on the southeasterly *Mamarika* winds. Some Anindilyakwa-speakers traveled widely with the Makassans on their journeys and sojourned in Makassar for years at a time.¹⁰

For over a century at the least, Anindilyakwa-speakers interacted with Southeast Asian languages and cultures through the Makassans. The Makassans brought Islam to the region; there is evidence of Islamic influence in northeastern Arnhem Land song cycles.¹¹ Anindilyakwa people traded for

fish hooks, glass, cloth, tobacco, rice, and alcohol. They worked for the Makassans, shelling and trepanning. Some Anindilyakwa women formed relationships with the visiting crews and had children with them. Anindilyakwa crew members learned Malay Creole. Others learned Makassan Pidgin, a lingua franca across North Australia. Anindilyakwa-speakers incorporated Makassan words into their language: *jurra* (from *surat*, meaning “paper”), *dambakwa* (tobacco), *waja* (sugar), *djara* (from *djarung*, meaning “needle”).¹² Names of places also reflect the engagement with the Makassans: Badelumba, the North West Bluff on Groote Eylandt, and also the name of the family of that place (Wurrabadalamba), is derived from Makassarese *batu lompoa*, meaning “large stone.”¹³ Likewise, Anindilyakwa people told me that Umbakumba is “not the proper name for that place, Umbakumba is a Makassan word.”¹⁴ It comes from the Malay *ombak-ombak*, meaning “lapping of waves.”¹⁵

The Makassan visits ended abruptly. The South Australian government, which governed the Northern Territory from 1863 to 1911, began charging the fishing boats exorbitant rates for licenses in the 1880s and, in 1906, ceased issuing licenses to Makassans altogether. This move was consistent with the notorious White Australia policy, legislation designed to restrict Asian immigration and make Australia white. The Makassans did not come in the wet season of 1906–1907.

The Japanese also came and went from the island. Sometimes they caused trouble. According to Murabuda Wurramarra, “Japanese used to be muck around with black woman, and they used to fight.” Generally, though, relations between the Japanese and Anindilyakwa people were positive. Murabuda remembered the Japanese from his childhood and told me how they formed productive relationships. A Aboriginal person worked for Japanese divers and were paid in rice. “Good people, Japanese.”¹⁶

The Missionaries Land

Meanwhile, the missionaries came, and they were different. The CMS missionaries were also translators, though not in the same way as Anindilyakwa people had been in the past. The missionaries’ Bible taught them that God “hath delivered us from the power of darkness and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son”;¹⁷ “translation” at conversion was how evangelicals understood their Christian identity. They brought this offer of “translation” into the “kingdom” for others. They wanted not simply to interact and negotiate with Anindilyakwa people, but to change and convert them. They also came as members of a settler-colonial society that assumed Groote Eylandt was already its land. This is where a story of the negotiation and struggle for the continuing legitimacy of the Anindilyakwa language and culture

begins. Unlike the Makassans and Japanese, CMS missionaries settled on the island, bringing English, a new culture, and a new religion with them, intending to implant them permanently.

The CMS had emerged out of the evangelical revivals in late eighteenth-century England. Despite the original intent to evangelize Botany Bay, the work of the CMS in Australia was limited during the early nineteenth century, its only attempt being the short-lived Wellington Valley mission of the 1830s. In 1892 Church Missionary Associations (CMA) were established in New South Wales and Victoria, both independent of the Parent Society. These sent Australian missionaries around the world and operated Aboriginal missions in Victoria (Yelta, Lake Tyers, and Lake Condah) and later Arnhem Land. In 1916 the associations came together to form CMS Australia. The CMS distinguished itself from the other Anglican mission organization in Australia, the Australian Board of Missions (ABM), in that it was governed by lay people, not by the church establishment. Also, the CMS was a low church evangelical society—that is, it was skeptical of elaborate liturgies and ecclesiastical authority, unlike the ABM's high church tradition, which placed more value on the priesthood and sacraments. Although CMS Australia remained autonomous, the Australians considered themselves “a true heir to the Society of the 19th Century,” sharing the heritage and evangelicalism of the Parent Society in England.¹⁸

The CMS began sustained efforts to evangelize Australian Aboriginal people in the Northern Territory in 1908, when the Victorian CMA established the Roper River mission (now Ngukurr). In 1914, the Commonwealth government divided the Northern Territory into missionary “spheres of influence,” giving permission for various Christian denominations to operate within these areas in return for providing “welfare” and keeping Aboriginal people away from major towns. This allowed the CMS to establish further missions, beginning with Groote Eylandt's “half caste” mission on the Emerald River in 1921, Oenpelli (now Gunbalanya) in 1925, Angurugu mission in 1943, and Rose River mission (now Numbulwar) in 1952. When the English trepanger Fred Gray established Umbakumba Native Settlement on the north side of Groote Eylandt in 1938, the CMS and Gray had a cooperative relationship at first. But it did not take long for the CMS to make designs to acquire it from him and consolidate their influence on the island. They eventually did so and established Umbakumba mission in 1958.

The CMS's first exploratory expedition to Groote Eylandt was in 1916. They were not welcome. One missionary remembered how Anindilyakwa people “often told us to go.”¹⁹ The missionaries skirted the coast of the island, taking turns to rename its features after their friends and relatives. It is not clear if the land was, to them, a blank slate, devoid of existing names and meanings, or whether this was a deliberate act to wipe away Aboriginal

claims to the land. Hubert Warren quite literally made his mark on the island when he renamed Yandarrnga (Central Hill) "Mt Ellie," in honor of his wife. He carved her name into the rock, "spoiling the axe but improving the rock."²⁰ So began their endeavor to improve, transform, rename, and translate Groote Eylandt.

After exploring the island, the missionaries agreed on the Emerald River at Yedigba on Groote Eylandt as a location for a new mission, and in August 1921 they commenced construction. The missionaries' new Emerald River mission was not a mission for Anindilyakwa people of Groote Eylandt but a mission for Aboriginal children of mixed racial descent. These children had been taken from all over the Northern Territory and brought to the CMS mission at the Roper River on the mainland. Government policy was to forcibly remove "half caste" children from Aboriginal camps, and the mission accepted children who had been taken from their families into its care. By 1917, so many "half caste" children lived at the Roper River mission that they formed a majority of its children.²¹ Roper River mission was becoming unviable. It could not keep up with the number of children. Termites were destroying the garden, the soil was barren.²² Groote Eylandt's climate is more temperate, its soil more fertile. The CMS, therefore, proposed to transfer the whole Roper River mission population to Groote Eylandt, beginning with the "half castes."²³ Granting the CMS request, the Secretary of the Department of Home and Territories made the whole of Groote Eylandt an Aboriginal Reserve in 1920, with a portion on the west coast on the Emerald River to be the site of the "half caste" mission.

Having renamed the landscape in English, the missionaries established an English-speaking community on Groote Eylandt. The "half caste" children spoke various languages, so English became the *lingua franca* of the mission. But the children spoke Kriol among themselves. For some children, Kriol was their first language. Gerry Blitner, who was taken to the island as a child, remembered that his mother was fluent in three Aboriginal languages, but he himself was not allowed to speak any Aboriginal languages in the Emerald River mission, only English.²⁴

According to the superintendent, the "half caste" children lived in "complete segregation from the blacks."²⁵ One of the children, Connie Bush, remembered how "the mission was fenced and we weren't allowed to speak to one Aboriginal there."²⁶ Though missionaries restricted the children's movement and forbade them from mingling with Anindilyakwa people, the children established friendships with the islanders and began to learn Anindilyakwa.²⁷

Missionaries also made contact with Anindilyakwa people, but their intentions were limited mainly to humanitarian and evangelistic work. Reports from 1927 indicate that Anindilyakwa people were visiting regularly to



“Half-caste inmates,” 1928 (National Archives of Australia: A263)

trade with missionaries and to receive medical treatment. From a round 1932, Anindilyakwa people moved into camps around the mission.²⁸ Missionaries reported in 1934 that the “Bickerton Island tribe” was “said to be merging with the Groote Eylandt tribe.”²⁹ This was perhaps the Lalara clan, which came over to Groote Eylandt around this time. Most of those who settled by the mission were from the Bickerton clans. Some Anindilyakwa children, including the “professor,” Gula Lalara, attended the school and began learning to speak English. As a child Gula Lalara was featured in a CMS magazine for children, *Australian Round World*, in a series titled “Groote Eylandt Imps.” He was a missionary favorite from a young age.

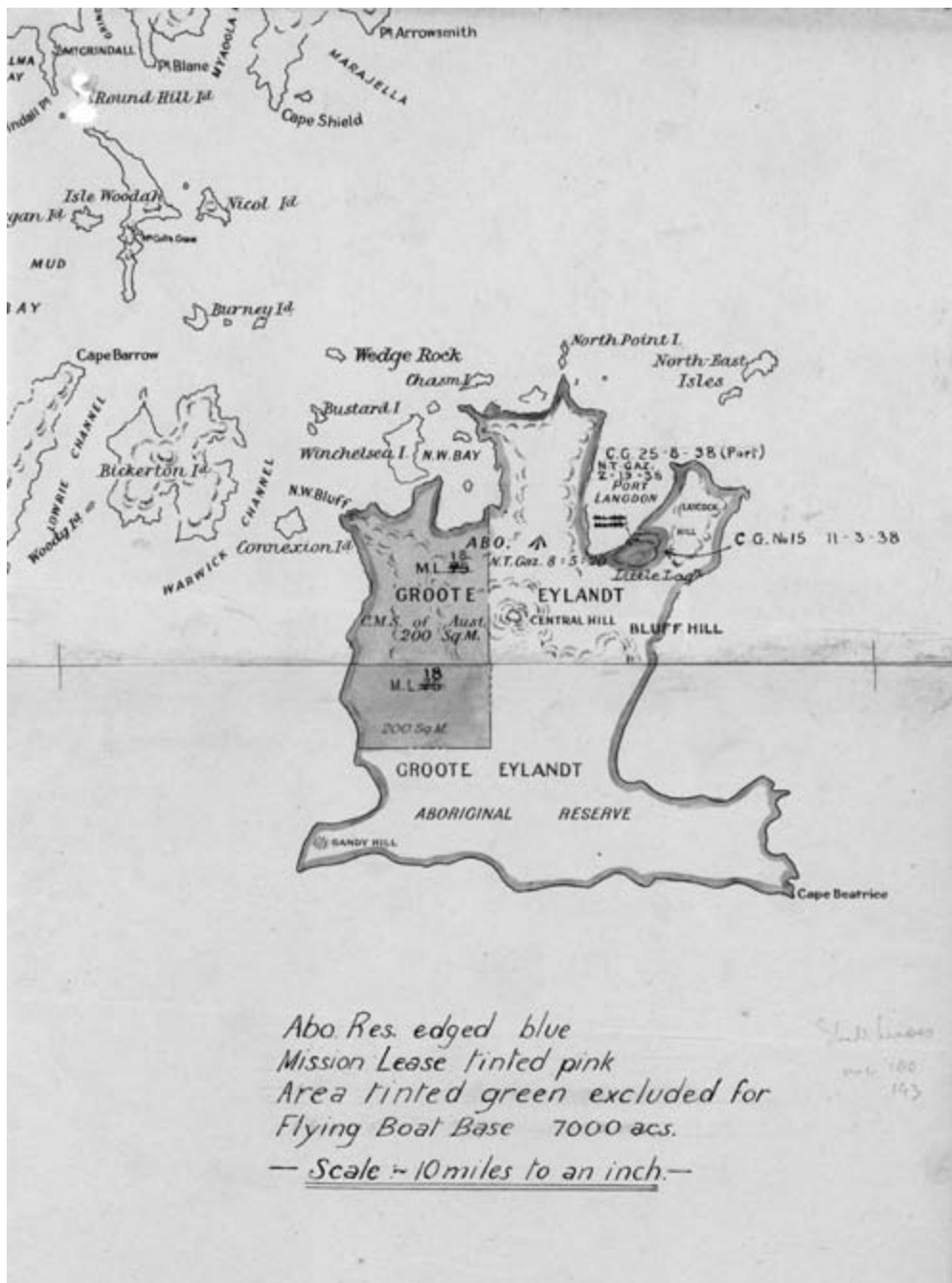
Another imp story—Hurrah!! The imps are our old friends now, and we are getting to love each one in turn. Well, we’re ready to hear about NAGLABENNA [Gula] . . . Your first impression on looking at this boy would be his gentleness. He has long, spindly legs as most natives have (this is caused by much walking), and perfect grace is his bearing. His eyes are bright and kindly, and his manners almost faultless. Unlike most black boys, he rarely ill-treats boys younger than himself.³⁰

Though it had not been the missionaries' original intention, Anindilyakwa people inserted themselves into the small mission community, making their presence known, befriending and charming the missionaries as they liked.

The missionaries were not the only English-speakers with interests on the island. Little Lagoon, on the northeastern side of the island, is a protected expanse of water, perfect for seaplanes. The Shell Company saw it as a suitable location for a service point for Qantas flying boats and in 1937 proposed establishing a base there. Missionaries strongly opposed the proposal to operate on an Aboriginal Reserve, the National Missionary Council stating that the "Welfare of Aborigines should be first concern," and that this protection required isolation.³¹ Nonetheless, construction of the base began in 1938 on land excised from the reserve. That year, Gray established what became his Native Settlement. He built a settlement at Umbakumba, an old Makassan trepanning camp, to manage the Anindilyakwa people who constructed the base. He did so in response to the CMS's request, as the mission did not have the staff to do so themselves.³² According to Mamarika clan stories, two old Anindilyakwa men wanted "Fred Gray to stay here and settle down to make a settlement . . . Those men, they say 'yes.'"³³ In their stories, he was invited.

The CMS thought his presence on "their" island was temporary, but Gray did not leave his camp once the base was completed. Moreover, the staff at the flying boat base also began to make contact with Anindilyakwa people. The initial understanding with CMS was that the flying boat workers would not be allowed to enter the reserve. But in 1939, the bishop of Carpentaria suggested that boat base staff should be allowed to enter the reserve "for recreational purposes" (as a high churchman he was suspicious of the evangelical CMS operating within his diocese). The bishop also expressed his view that "Mr Gray was doing excellent work" and so should remain at Umbakumba.³⁴ The administrator of the Northern Territory took the bishop's advice, though it infuriated the CMS. The CMS was ostensibly concerned about Gray's suitability as a superintendent. But perhaps more threatening to the CMS was the existence of an alternative settlement and influences on Anindilyakwa people and an alternative representative of "civilization."

Meanwhile, terrible reports of the "half caste" Emerald River mission in the 1930s reached government officials. They heard that children were roped together and made to haul logs like cattle; that girls wore only hessian bags for dresses, causing blisters and rashes as they worked in the garden in the hot tropical sun; that children were punished in wooden stocks and isolation cells; and that almost half the older children suffered from leprosy, having become so susceptible because they were malnourished, living on little more than rice and bread.³⁵ The missionaries used chains, according to Connie Bush, "that used to be tied around a post . . . and that would be wound around the girl's leg . . . so they wouldn't move."³⁶ In 1942, patrol officer Bill Harney



compared Gray's Umbakumba Native Settlement with the Emerald River mission:

I certainly was disappointed when I saw this Mission Station. Years ago, from 1922 to 1930, it had a large garden and numerous buildings etc., also pumps. To-day it is in the process of decay, no water system . . . The garden is overgrown with grass and compaired [*sic*] with the one man unsubsidised settlement at Grey's [*sic*], the place is a complete failure . . . I would certainly recommend Grey's Native Settlement as the future welfare centre of the Groote Eylandt.³⁷

Gray was an embarrassment to the CMS, which urgently needed to improve if it was to maintain government favor and its position on the island. Furthermore, by this stage, so many Anindilyakwa people participated in the mission economy, working for the mission, attending school, or receiving rations and aid, that it became apparent to the CMS that it could no longer keep the "half caste" children separate from them. What was needed was a second mission on the island, a fresh start, exclusively for Anindilyakwa people themselves. The CMS Federal Council resolved to build a new station, ten miles from the Emerald River mission, according to its "principle of the segregation of the Aboriginal from Half Caste work." This new mission, "Anoraku" (Angurugu), would serve to gather Anindilyakwa people in one place such that "the rest of the island" could be "adapted for the Half Caste scheme."³⁸ The CMS's intention was that the "whole island" would be converted into a cattle station as "part of the half caste activity."³⁹ Their ambition mirrored, on a small scale, settler-colonial strategies that would transfer Indigenous people into small reserves, eliminating their presence on their land.⁴⁰ Although the expedition narrated by Jabani depended upon Anindilyakwa leadership, negotiation, and concessions to CMS missionaries, these negotiations occurred within a highly unequal context. It is unclear whether the "old men" knew of the CMS intention to restrict them to a small corner of the island. Perhaps if they had known they would not have been so cooperative.

World War II disrupted the plan. After Japanese forces bombed Darwin, the "half caste" children were evacuated to Mulgoa in New South Wales, leaving only a skeleton mission team at Emerald River mission. Anindilyakwa people remained on their land. The Royal Australian Air Force (RAAF) took over the flying boat base and stationed its personnel only a kilometer away from the mission. The RAAF depended on Anindilyakwa labor, and Anindilyakwa people accordingly acquired new skills.⁴¹ They cleared the runway for the RAAF and built the roads from the mission to the RAAF base to the flying boat base. The CMS received the seven and a half pennies Anindilyakwa people

earned per hour, while the Anindilyakwa people themselves received rations of food and tobacco.⁴² The war brought a sudden incursion of modernity to Groote Eylandt. Anindilyakwa people came into contact with new technologies, medicines, weapons, and modes of transport on a greater scale than ever before. They were drawn into the international conflict; Groote Eylandt could no longer be viewed as a secluded outpost, isolated from “civilization,” modernity, or white Australia. The flying boat base and then the RAAF base apparently proved that the coming of English-speaking “civilization” to Groote Eylandt was inevitable.

For Anindilyakwa people, it was not their war. They were in the middle of resolving their own ongoing disputes between clans. Nor were they surprised that another people might want to claim the land. Murabuda explained to me: “We didn’t care about the war because the people we’ve just been fighting . . . they’re fighting a white man fight and we fighting that black man fight.”⁴³

[When the war came] we didn’t frightened because Aborigine, Aborigine people they just fighting too, and just the white and the white, we didn’t care about it! . . . And they got some of them Australian made a big bomb in the Japanese area, really danger bomb you know. . . . But Japanese are good people, but I don’t know what they’re fighting for Australia. Maybe Australia is the richest.⁴⁴

The Evolution of Assimilation

During World War II, white visions of Australian nationhood, and subsequently of Aboriginal people, shifted. It was a period of change toward assimilationist thinking. The CMS’s initial intention to run an Aboriginal mission at Angurugu, segregated from the “half caste” mission, was based on a doctrine that “half castes” could be assimilated into the Australian nation but “full bloods” could not. Through the 1940s, however, this assumption came under challenge. Aboriginal people demonstrated their abilities to white authorities as many of them, including those on Groote Eylandt, assisted Australian forces. During the war, racialized views of nationhood began to dissolve, and with them theories of biological absorption of Aboriginal people.⁴⁵

In the 1940s, the CMS understood that it would have to choose how to approach its missionary activities. Would Anindilyakwa people be “saved” by assimilation into Australian citizenship and the modern world, or by segregation from it?

Both options involved a translation of sorts. The first was for missionaries to “translate the Christian faith into terms of Aboriginal daily life” by

themselves becoming nomadic, sharing in Aboriginal life and culture. Going as nomadic missionaries was not as far-fetched as it may sound. Anthropologist Donald Thomson had lived with Yolngu people in northeastern Arnhem Land (not far from Groote Eylandt) and in 1936 advocated “acceptance of the nomadic habits” of Aboriginal people. For him, preservation of Aboriginal cultures and even the survival of Aboriginal peoples depended upon “absolute segregation” from white society.⁴⁶ Missionaries, therefore, would have to submit to Aboriginal patterns of life. He suggested that missionaries should be “prepared to visit the people in their own country and not to gather them about a station.”⁴⁷ Thomson’s view had some influence among missionaries. Methodist missionary Theodore Webb also concluded in 1936 that it would be “in the best interests of the Aborigines” for missionaries to “live with them in their camps.”⁴⁸ In the late 1930s and early 1940s, the CMS had advocated introducing Christianity in such a way that Aboriginal people would maintain a separate cultural identity. In 1939, the CMS stated that “the CMS as far as Groote Eylandt is concerned is not out to civilise the natives. . . . We want Groote people to . . . be preserved as a people in whom God can delight.”⁴⁹ Likewise, as late as 1940, its newsletter declared that “the CMS is not out to ‘Europeanise’ the Aborigines. . . . We want the Aborigines to take Christ into their camp.”⁵⁰

But later CMS missionaries considered this option—segregation and the possibility of nomadic missionaries—hopelessly inadequate and fundamentally neglectful. As one CMS missionary, Bob Palmer, explained:

If we went as nomadic missionaries to a nomadic people translating the Christian faith into terms of the daily life of a stone age nomad there would, for one thing, not be a less expensive missionary enterprise in the world. . . . But this isn’t the stone age and the fact is that the aboriginal has found out that it’s the 20th Century and he is determined to have a 20th Century culture at any price—even though, unbeknown to him, that price may be his own extinction. To prevent that we simply have to step in and give him our culture in such a way that he becomes a national asset instead of a national liability and in such a way that he becomes not only a terrestrial asset but a celestial one too.⁵¹

For Palmer, Aboriginal people had already made a decision to move away from their traditions. It was too late to consider the nomadic missionary option because Aboriginal people themselves had already abandoned their culture. By locating Aboriginal culture somewhere in the past, the CMS had no other option than to step in and replace Aboriginal culture. In this way, Aboriginal people were cast as the agents of their own cultural dispossession. Missionaries would be the bridge. They would integrate Aboriginal

people from “the Stone Age” into the Australian nation. Missionaries established themselves as translators, not of their Christian faith, making it comprehensible in an Aboriginal context, but of Aboriginal people themselves, making them assets for the Australian nation.

This view was advocated by the prominent anthropologist and Anglican priest, A. P. Elkin. In 1944, just after the establishment of Angurugu, Elkin published *Citizenship for the Aborigines*, affirming the necessity of gradual change so that Aboriginal people could “make progress towards civilisation and citizenship.”⁵² Elkin’s plans for Aboriginal people proved very appealing to the CMS, as they also did to policy makers in Canberra. The popularity of Elkin’s vision over Thomson’s lay in its promise that Aboriginal people could be made to fit into the nation as modern people. Elkin appeared optimistic as he advocated citizenship rights for Aboriginal people, appealing to white Australia’s visions of itself as modern, civilized, and successful.⁵³ When it became obvious in the 1930s and 1940s that Aboriginal people were not, after all, doomed to extinction, assimilation offered a way forward without resorting to racial segregation. Assimilation meant a reconsideration of race-based notions of nationhood and put forward civic qualities as a foundation for national unity in a modern Australia.

Technically, Aboriginal people (along with all other Australians) became Australian citizens in 1948, according to the Nationality and Citizenship Act of that year. Yet their formal legal status did not enable them to exercise their rights as citizens. In the Northern Territory, Aboriginal people were deemed wards of the state, and so deprived of the normal rights of citizens (including the rights to vote, enjoy freedom of movement, even to marry whom they chose). In 1949, the right to vote in federal elections was extended only to those Aboriginal people who had served in the armed forces. It was only in 1962 that all Aboriginal people were permitted to vote in territory and federal elections, and not until 1967 were they included in the national census for determining the number of voters in an electorate. In the 1940s, Aboriginal people were citizens largely in name only. Before they could enjoy their rights as citizens, white Australia insisted, Aboriginal people must adopt citizenly behaviors, proving their capacity to exercise such rights.

The CMS authorities embraced assimilation policies and looked to Elkin for direction. Assimilation had many meanings and multiple interpretations even among missionaries within the CMS. One CMS publication explained it in seemingly benign terms: simply “black and white . . . living together as neighbours.”⁵⁴ The CMS’s first policy constitution in 1944 (for which the CMS sought Elkin’s advice and approval) defined assimilation as the set of processes by which Aboriginal people would come to function as equal citizens on white terms in white society. The society moved away from theories of genetic or racial hierarchies (stating that “the explanation for the retarded development of the Aborigines” lay in “their isolation from the rest of man-

kind . . . and not in the absence of inherent qualities"). The problem, in their view, was that "too rapid a contact with European civilisation" caused Aboriginal disadvantage. The solution, inspired by Elkin, was therefore a period of "development" in a location "segregated from undesirable influences and contacts," where missionaries could work in the areas of evangelism, education, medicine, industry, and agriculture. Through this, the CMS envisaged that Aboriginal people would one day "take their place in the general Australian life . . . in our civilised communities."⁵⁵ Christian education would supposedly enable Aboriginal people to develop the inner fortitude to meet the coming "civilization" without being corrupted by it. This is why the CMS was more concerned with the realization of civic behavior—a functional citizenship—than with the granting of rights. The task was to make citizens, not merely to grant citizenship, as rights without citizenly capabilities would be a "legal fiction."

One of Elkin's favored metaphors was the progression from the Old Testament to the New; just as Christianity had reinterpreted and "completed" the religion of ancient Israel, so he proposed building upon Aboriginal cultures, reinterpreting them to suit Australian citizenship and Christianity.⁵⁶ In the same spirit, the CMS constitution explained in 1944:

Natives shall not be cut off from their own tribal life, but rather the Missionaries shall aim at the far more difficult task of helping these natives to build up the Kingdom of God on the basis of their old tribal organisations and customs, where these are not opposed to Christianity . . . Any worthwhile elements in tribal life tending to social cohesion, discipline and moral uplift shall be preserved as a foundation upon which the ethical principles and wholesome truths of the Gospel are to be built.⁵⁷

The CMS's assimilation vision meant converting or translating aspects of Aboriginal cultures so that they could operate within a Christian framework. The missionary was not to demolish Aboriginal cultures but to identify the translatable aspects of Aboriginal culture, and to modernize and convert these into Christian practices so that Aboriginal people could operate as evangelical Christians and Australian citizens.

Though they spoke of assimilation, the missionaries were not representative of English-speaking Australia. Most Australians claimed membership in one of the Christian denominations, but in 1947 only 35 percent of Australians claimed to be "regular churchgoers."⁵⁸ In 1947 the Anglican Church in Australia published *Towards the Conversion of Australasia*, a comprehensive report on "the decline in churchgoing" and "collapse in moral standards" among white Australians.⁵⁹ Missionaries themselves did not seek assimilation into mainstream white Australia, a society they saw as corrupted by alcohol,

tobacco, licentiousness, and gambling. Instead, they distanced themselves from it. The coming of this civilization, in their minds, threatened to destroy Aboriginal people.

Aboriginal people were, rather, to be assimilated into an idealized citizenship, based on evangelical norms. Missionaries sought not assimilation into white Australia but, in historian Bain Attwood's words, "to make Aboriginal people in their own image."⁶⁰ In their minds, the ideal citizen would be evangelical, and it was through Christian teaching, moral improvement, and training that Aboriginal people would outlast the temptations of modern civilization. As the Anglican archbishop of Sydney argued in 1945, "The best way for every child to become the best citizen of the Commonwealth of Australia is to be taught that he is citizen of the Kingdom of God."⁶¹ An ideal and useful citizen of the Commonwealth was, for evangelicals, a member of the Kingdom of God. Assimilation was such a lofty ideal that it had heavenly overtones. As one CMS publication put it, in the "Heavenly country" all will be "assimilated" as a realization of equality according to Christian ideals. The CMS Secretary for Aborigines, J. B. Montgomerie, explained in 1958:

We have to get rid of the "white-race" superiority feeling. Think of the Aborigine as one for whom Christ died, just as He did for white people. One day believers will all live together in a Heavenly Home. There will not be separate dwelling places for black and white, or any other colour. We will all be thoroughly "assimilated" then, citizens of the Heavenly country, and one in Christ Jesus. It should be so now.⁶²

Assimilation emerged in the 1940s as the only viable policy if white Australia was to realize its vision of an antiracist, civilized, and Christian society. For the CMS, the virtue of assimilation became such that they could not help but imagine assimilation in Heaven itself.

The other type of translation work missionaries saw for themselves was their role as interpreters or mediators between Anindilyakwa-speakers and the settler-colonial state. Palmer further explained that the CMS aimed to "act as a guide and liaison officer between the native and the outside world."⁶³ The CMS would communicate with governments and other external parties, interpreting Anindilyakwa people's wishes and interests for outsiders in order to "protect" Aboriginal people. They saw no conflict of interest between their mediating role and their self-appointed role as translators of Aboriginal cultures into Australian citizenship and evangelicalism.

By constructing themselves as mediators between Aboriginal people and a dangerous outside world, missionaries distanced themselves from colonists and disguised their own participation in settler-colonialism.⁶⁴ They felt a genuine tension. As many historians have noted, missionaries felt pulled in

many directions. Their conflicting loyalties to Indigenous peoples, churches, and empires meant that their relationships with the empires in which they worked were ambiguous. They critiqued these empires even as they enabled and perpetuated their dominance. They often considered themselves to be in opposition to the empire surrounding them, determined to “put Empire in its place.”⁶⁵ In North Australia, the CMS often constructed itself as paying reparation on behalf of white Australia for the injustices of colonization. The white man had a “debt of sympathy and help,” wrote the CMS newspaper, and this “debt we owe to our Australian Aborigines still remains unpaid.”⁶⁶ The federal Secretary explained missionary obligations in terms of land rights: “we have a responsibility to our Aboriginal stations . . . because the people there are natives of this land we enjoy—it is their land!”⁶⁷

Paradoxically, these missionary visions of making “reparation” through accepting Aboriginal people as citizens presumed that Aboriginal land was now in fact Australian soil, owned by the nation. Though the CMS’s strategy of constructing itself as a benign mediator and repaying the debt owed for colonization implicitly critiqued colonization, it also masked the missionaries’ presence as colonizers and continued their attempts to translate Aboriginal people into their vision of Australian citizens. The missionaries constructed themselves as preparing Aboriginal people for the coming settler-colonizers, as mediating between Aboriginal people and colonizers, and even as paying reparation for colonization. Their belief that Aboriginal people had already come under the authority of the settler-colonial state masked their actions as the first outsiders to bring the state’s presence to Groote Eylandt.⁶⁸ But the CMS’s concern that Anindilyakwa people be prepared for citizenship betrays their colonizing intent; their ambitions were directed at realizing Groote Eylandt and its people as part of a modern, united Australian nation.

Over the course of the 1940s, assimilationist thinking became doctrine. The absence of the “half caste” children meant that Anindilyakwa people had the CMS’s full attention on Groote Eylandt. Yet, for most of the decade, the expectation was still that the “half castes” would return to Groote Eylandt, a system of racial segregation would be established, and missionaries would integrate the “half castes” into the Australian polity and provide humanitarian assistance to “full bloods.” In 1946, however, “a party of walkabout Natives” destroyed the Emerald River station, burning it down.⁶⁹ Perhaps they knew of the CMS’s intention to devote their island to “half caste” work. Since there was now no accommodation for the “half caste” mission, the CMS considered sending the children elsewhere but found no suitable place. Enthusiasm for “half caste” projects was dwindling. Then, in 1947, after a conversation with the bishop of Carpentaria, the administrator of the Northern Territory came to the opinion that the CMS was “not, in effect, a true missionary society” (likely because it was not managed by the Anglican Church, but was a

lay organization) and recommended that the children be handed over to the ABM.⁷⁰ The children were sent to St. Mary's Hostel in Alice Springs in 1949. "Half caste" work no longer had a place in CMS operations; assimilation for "full blood" Aborigines became its policy and priority.

This assimilation doctrine came to set Aboriginal missions apart from the CMS missions overseas in the minds of evangelicals. The CMS Secretary for Aborigines stated in 1954 that "we know that Aboriginal missions are different from others."⁷¹ The regional Secretary for Aborigines in 1961 contrasted North Australia to "normal" missionary fields.⁷² In 1962 the CMS federal Secretary noted that it was "hard to correctly relate our work in the North to the normal working of the Society overseas" because the "large social programme" in North Australia was unlike anything else.⁷³ In 1962, Irene Jeffreys, CMS South Australia Secretary, contrasted the CMS's work of evangelism overseas with "the gov[ernmen]t's assimilation policy" in Australia.⁷⁴ CMS Aborigines Secretary George Pearson in 1962 likewise distinguished overseas missions from those in North Australia because Aboriginal missions aimed at "rapid integration into or assimilation into the general Australian community."⁷⁵ As a settler-colony, with no imagined independent future for Aboriginal people, Australia was fundamentally different from other mission fields.

This distinction cast doubt in the minds of many, including missionaries themselves, as to whether Aboriginal missions like that on Groote Eylandt were even "real" missions and their staff "real" missionaries. The lack of mass conversions on the scale of those in Africa and the Pacific did not help. As missionary Wilma Taylor explained, churchgoers down south were unsure.

There was a certain section of people who thought, "oh, but you're not really a missionary because you haven't been overseas." We used to say "we've been over to Groote Eylandt, that's overseas." We weren't able to give, sort of, lists of how many people were converted during our ministry and all that sort of thing. I mean up North it was a very slow process.⁷⁶

The work in North Australia was so distinct that some CMS officials seriously doubted that the CMS, a supposedly "overseas mission" society, should continue to operate in North Australia.⁷⁷ Did Indigenous people within a settler-colony even count as a mission field? Could Aboriginal missions really have a place in the CMS agenda, which prioritized global evangelism and the establishment of "Indigenous churches"? Of course, CMS officials answered yes. The apparent tensions between global evangelism through vernacular translation of the Gospel and the preparation of Aboriginal people for Australian citizenship were overcome by understanding assimilation as the process by which Aboriginal people would share in a British evangelical heritage. The

North Australian mission was, to the CMS, part of a story of “rapid integration into the general Australian community.”⁷⁸ Eventually this modernizing mission would supposedly incorporate Aboriginal people into English-speaking Australian society with a shared British, Anglican heritage. “It is for the white man to welcome the coloured man into his society, into his Churches, into his national heritage, so that both may share it together,” declared Arthur Capell in 1962.⁷⁹ Evangelism, even vernacularization, would occur through assimilation.

Anindilyakwa Interpretations of the Mission

As these changes were occurring, Anindilyakwa people were building Angurugu mission, largely unaware of the new CMS doctrine that would have them assimilated. It “became a hub of activity” as Anindilyakwa people laid foundations for buildings, cleared the bush, and planted gardens. Jabani described the work, which occurred in his childhood:

In 1943 then they begin, start to clear away the whole area where they’re going to build the mission. So they said, “we’re going to start building.” And everybody had a job: cut timbers, milling the cypress tree, or sometime other trees, cut it down for houses. The number 1 missionary’s [house] and number 2 missionary’s [house] and church. They were built in the same year.⁸⁰

Anindilyakwa people viewed (or came to view) the construction of the mission as an Anindilyakwa project. Anindilyakwa people incorporated the foreign CMS designs into their own social fabric, taking ownership of the mission. *Everybody* had a job; it was everybody’s mission. Their situation had some similarities to that of Aboriginal people who worked in exploitative conditions on cattle stations. Historian Minoru Hokari found that Aboriginal people could simultaneously find meaningful labor in stock work, calling it “no shame job,” while still remembering and resenting the mistreatment by white stockmen.⁸¹ Likewise, the old people at Angurugu today feel that they had some ownership over the construction of Angurugu and that they did a good job. This was made clear to me when Jabani expressed his resentment that Anindilyakwa labor and hospitality on their island were never acknowledged by the CMS.

Even though this old people came here to do this job, great job, . . . even though in those days people used to work, missionary and the government people, you know, and for our people what they’ve done, they never think of give them reward. They should have reward for that, for finding this place to give ’em to the missionary.⁸²



Angurugu construction (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

European accounts have generally overlooked the negotiations that occurred between missionaries and Aboriginal people. Talking to Anindilyakwa people, I learned of deeper translations and reinterpretations—that missionaries perhaps knew nothing about—that reveal how Anindilyakwa people expressed their agency and ongoing authority in the early mission. Aboriginal people interpreted missionary actions with cultural resonances that the missionaries could not understand. Jabani also told me the story of how St. Andrew's Church came to stand at its site at the center of the mission.

That man [missionary Dick Harris] was standing here, about here, and the old man [Old Bill] was standing here with the wheelbarrow, the wheelbarrow. And he said, "we're going to find a place for a church." And he said, "Yeah? Well where?" And the old fella, he said, "well I've got a stone here. If I throw that stone, if we see that stone where it's gonna landed, that's where the church, we're gonna build church." So that man, Dick Harris, he threw the stone from

here to there. And that stone, it's landed there. "We're gonna build that church there." "Oh, that's good."⁸³

Though this story does not feature in CMS records, I heard it repeatedly from the old people on Groote Eylandt. It is important. For the CMS, Superintendent Harris simply chose a site for a church and oversaw its construction. The story about the stone shows, however, that the church was built with Anindilyakwa consent. More than this, the site was not determined by the missionary. Rather, it was the "old fella's" stone, an object belonging to the island, that settled on a site for the church. The story of the church's foundation mirrors, almost, the story of old Yandarrnga who cast off rocks, which then became the landmarks of the island. While Yandarrnga's stones spread Anindilyakwa words across the country, this stone spread a different Word. Jabani's story shows how the new Angurugu church was woven into the stories about Groote Eylandt. These newcomers and their actions were translated into Anindilyakwa stories and worldview, featuring Anindilyakwa people and symbols.

It is possible that Aboriginal people view the past through rose-tinted glasses, ordering and containing an otherwise chaotic and distressing story. Given the continuing dissatisfaction with current governments, there is now even nostalgia for "mission days." Yet it is important to listen closely to Anindilyakwa understandings of the past, especially those which may serve as a corrective to stories that privilege missionary agency. Hokari argues strongly that instead of "the academic politeness" of respecting a story as "memory" or "myth," historians must recognize Aboriginal historical knowledge if we are to avoid reproducing a knowledge and power relationship that silences Aboriginal voices.⁸⁴ It is possible that over time, Anindilyakwa historical memory evolved, crediting Anindilyakwa people with greater agency and control. It is probable, however, that in 1943, Anindilyakwa people already interpreted events differently from Europeans, translating as they went, asserting their agency in ways missionaries may not have perceived.

Though Anindilyakwa people cooperated with the missionaries for their own reasons, a burgeoning assimilation doctrine meant missionaries increasingly dominated the "long conversation" with Anindilyakwa people at Angurugu. Assimilation entailed the conversion of Anindilyakwa culture in a more total way than the previous humanitarian mission. At the new mission, Anindilyakwa people worked for rations: tea, sugar, rice, flour. Anindilyakwa people came and went, but little by little, most eventually settled either by the mission or at Umbakumba. The CMS missions worked toward assimilation for Anindilyakwa people through practical measures: training people in agriculture, carpentry, and domestic work. They matched Aboriginal "house girls" to missionaries' wives, requiring them to cook and clean, iron

and wash. Other women worked in the school, as cooks or in the garden growing fresh produce for the town. Men also worked at school, in the timber mill, or as builders, mechanics, pearl-ers, or agriculturalists. Church was compulsory: it was “no pray no tucker [food],” as the saying went. Rations were contingent on church attendance.⁸⁵

The missionaries brought children into dormitories (especially girls), marching them to and from the school and the church so they could receive their Christian education. From July 1942, child endowment payments were available from the Commonwealth government for children in institutions, so the CMS began receiving ten shillings per week per child in its care. This was in addition to its annual government subsidy of £725.⁸⁶ The dormitory, therefore, became more than simply a means of educating children; it was a fundraiser.⁸⁷ The child endowment system encouraged constant supervision of Aboriginal people. For example, when women and children “went walk-about” during holidays in the dry season, the mission lost its child endowment payments. Missionary women, therefore, began arranging “camping trips” to ensure continual contact with the children and receipt of funds. The dormitory was also a means of bringing whole families into prolonged contact with the mission. If children were kept there, relatives would not be far away.

The mission was staffed by a cluster of white evangelical families and a few single women from the southern states of Australia: the superintendent and his wife and children; the chaplain, his wife, and family; a mechanic or agriculturalist with family; and some nurses and teachers. They were typically middle- or working-class people, depending on their occupation. The staff expanded over time along with government subsidies for missions.

Although the mission offered new services and goods to Anindilyakwa people, missionaries were not the only channel through which Anindilyakwa people could engage with modernity. The missionary dominance on the island was never absolute. After Gray’s Umbakumba Settlement received such favorable reports compared to the mission, bureaucrats saw no reason to exclude him from also receiving the child endowment payments.⁸⁸ The CMS wanted him gone. In February 1945, they offered to purchase his station for £1,250, requesting that he leave the island.⁸⁹ Gray refused. With the end of the war in 1945, the air base closed. Though Umbakumba lost its market for its products, Gray continued on. The administrator of the Northern Territory made Gray “caretaker” of the base in 1946. From a government perspective, the presence of another settlement on the island could be a positive influence on the CMS, providing some healthy competition.⁹⁰ As in other parts of the world, competition between colonizers accelerated the process of colonization, as each station struggled to prove its efficiency in “civilizing” Aboriginal people to bureaucrats. For Anindilyakwa people, the competition between the

settlements expressed a nd exacerbated t he existing rivalry between t he Bickerton and Groote Eylandt clans. Generally, the Bickerton clans settled with the missionaries and the Groote Eylandt clans at Umbakumba with Gray. Anindilyakwa people increasingly identified themselves with t he different types of English-speakers as “the mission mob” and “the Umbakumba mob,” and over time the two settlements deepened the distinctions between clans.⁹¹ The tension between Umbakumba and the mission was not only a dispute among English-speakers, it was also an Anindilyakwa dispute.

Not all CMS missionaries were antagonistic toward Gray. Missionary nurse Elizabeth Taylor wrote to the director of native affairs in 1945 defending Gray: “He is a man greatly loved and respected by Natives . . . [yet] persecuted by CMS.”⁹² This “persecution” took the form of pressure to make him leave. In 1947 the CMS began asserting to government the necessity for it to have “full control of the whole island.”⁹³ Gray must go. They offered him £1,500 for the station in 1948.⁹⁴ Still he did not leave. Gray remained a thorn in their side, hanging on at Umbakumba until 1957, when the Department of Territories eventually compelled him to leave (and provided £8,000 in compensation).⁹⁵ For the CMS, its own missionaries were the only legitimate representatives of the idealized Christian civilization they envisaged for the island.

Anindilyakwa engagement with the missionaries’ actions increasingly occurred in a context of unequal power. Missionaries used violence and fear of exile to compel Anindilyakwa people to respect their authority and to show them that Groote Eylandt was under the English-speakers’ legal system, not their own. In 1946, a man called Killa Killa was speared and killed in a fight. In response, Harris and the local constable arrested twenty-three Anindilyakwa men at once, sending them to the mainland and charging them with “fighting on mission Reserve.”⁹⁶ Twenty-one were found guilty and sentenced to seven days’ hard labor. But on completing this sentence, they were not permitted to return because the actual killer was still at large. The reason missionaries cited for the prolonged exile was simply so that the constable would have “his work made easier.”⁹⁷ Exile was a physical reminder of missionary and police authority over the land. When the men finally returned, Harris tellingly advised the CMS committee that “no chains had been used on them.”⁹⁸ Though CMS records never mention the use of chains on Aboriginal people, Harris’s need to clarify that he did not use chains in this instance is revealing. Oral history interviews with Anindilyakwa-speakers confirm that, at this time, missionaries chained men to the trees beside the church before sending them away for trial and punishment.⁹⁹ Nostalgia only stretches so far; some things about the missionaries are not forgotten.

Interpreting Opportunities

Despite the use of force by missionaries, force alone could not hold the fragile mission community together. Furthermore, the nature of their mission—to transform Anindilyakwa people into Christian citizens—precluded the use of force alone. Anindilyakwa people must also be convinced of the missionary message, and this required language, not violence. The newly established community was culturally and linguistically diverse. Anindilyakwa people spoke both Anindilyakwa and Wubuy, and some spoke still more Aboriginal languages. Kriol was also a part of Angurugu's linguistic culture, as some of the "half castes" remained on or returned to the island as adults to work on the Angurugu building project. This meant that, functionally, Standard Australian English was not always the language of influence or power in the fledgling community. At first, missionaries depended on Kriol-speakers' knowledge of Anindilyakwa. A small group of returned adult "half castes" became leaders and negotiators because of their valuable linguistic skills in Anindilyakwa.

As the mission was being built, missionaries envisaged a racial and linguistic hierarchy for Angurugu, with white English-speakers situated above "half caste" Kriol-speakers who directed, at the bottom, the "full blood" speakers of Aboriginal languages. Gerry Blitner, one of the "half castes," worked first for the RAAF, and then later on the building of Angurugu. He remembered being put in charge of the Anindilyakwa workers as foreman, sharpening the saws and judging the quality of the timber.¹⁰⁰ Toward the end of the war, the CMS sent five additional "half caste boys" back to the island to work under Blitner as laborers but also as interpreters. As Jabani Lalara remembered, "translation went on."

Coloured boys. When they moved from Emerald they were here, all that children that'd been taken away from Ngukurr area. When they moved from there they stayed . . . And they were helping, ay. Helping. They used to work with the white staff. They used to work with the traditional, with the Aboriginal people. Translation and all that. They work together. They would speak English and translation went on, you know.¹⁰¹

Though the missionaries depended on the linguistic abilities of the "half castes," they did not speak as missionaries wished. Missionaries blamed Blitner and other "half caste" workers for the spread of Kriol among Anindilyakwa-speakers.¹⁰² Murabuda remembered how the "half caste" workers spoke "half English" and "half Kriol," and Anindilyakwa-speakers learned Kriol from them.¹⁰³ The CMS encouraged the "elimination of pidjin [*sic*] English" among "half castes," in order that "there may be no feeling of

separation from whites on that basis.”¹⁰⁴ Deviations from Standard Australian English were to be eliminated in the name of equality. That is, nonstandard Englishes and Kriol were, to missionaries, a mark of inferiority. The elimination of Kriol, they hoped, would consolidate the value of Standard Australian English at Angurugu, bringing Angurugu’s language economy into closer conformity with that of white Australia and consolidating missionaries’ authority.

When a segment of the Anindilyakwa people themselves learned English, they took over this mediating role. Missionaries became dependent on Anindilyakwa-speakers as interpreters for their success as evangelists, as well as for the more mundane, day-to-day running of the mission community. Judy Lalara’s father, Gula Lalara, was one of these interpreters. “He works in-between white and black,” she said.¹⁰⁵ Linguistic diversity was an opportunity for the interpreters.

Missionary sources name the interpreters, and the same sets of names recur over the years. They were usually young men in their teens or early twenties. Wherever missionaries needed to communicate clearly, these men were there: Gula, Nabilya, Nangwarra, Punch, Murabuda, Nandjiwarra, Gulpia, and Galima. As boys, they had been featured in missionary publications about the Emerald River mission. They had associated closely with the missionaries since childhood. As young men and interpreters, missionaries praised them and gave them special privileges. They were featured in missionaries’ prayer letters and accompanied the chaplain on evangelistic travel.

Many of these young men were brothers. Gula, Punch, Galima, and Nabilya were Lalara men, sons of Old Banjo Lalara. They also shared a particular connection to the land. Angurugu sits on Maminyamandja country. But when the Lalara family came over to Groote Eylandt, the Maminyamandja gave the land to Numulyarrgariya Lalara, the father of Old Banjo Lalara. The two clans share a spiritual affinity: They sing the same songs, but on different tunes. Though it was widely accepted during the mission years that the Maminyamandja clan had made an agreement with Numulyarrgariya, there was disagreement on the details of the extent of the land given to the Lalara. Some Maminyamandja living at Umbakumba even denied that the land was ever given to the Lalara. To accommodate multiple clans, Angurugu itself became considered a kind of neutral zone.¹⁰⁶ So while the land functions as neutral, it is also Lalara, but deep down it remains Maminyamandja.¹⁰⁷ Perhaps the Lalara men, especially the eldest son, Gula, felt a special obligation to ensure smooth relationships between missionaries and Anindilyakwa people at Angurugu as part of their responsibility for the land and to uphold their claim to it. Their status as Lalara men, sons of Old Banjo, on Lalara land meant that they could appeal to other families to cooperate. Interpreters functioned to give the missionaries legitimacy and support. Though missionaries themselves may not have been aware of the significance of the

clan identities of these Lalara men, perhaps the support of these Lalara interpreters gave missionaries legitimacy in the eyes of other clans.

These men were also among the first to engage with the missionaries' religion. In 1944, according to Harris, Gulpia "gave his life to the Lord."¹⁰⁸ Nandjiwara Amagula came forward in church to "dedicate his life to Christ" in 1945.¹⁰⁹ Gula, Nandjiwara, and Nabilya were, in 1949, among the first at the mission to be baptized and then confirmed in 1952. Historians have debated whether Indigenous converts in mission contexts converted for pragmatic reasons—in order to win missionary favor and privileges—or because they found the missionaries' Gospel (or at least their interpretation of it) intrinsically attractive.¹¹⁰ The possibility that they chose Christianity because it enriched their spiritual life should not be discounted. Yet I find the dichotomy between religious and secular motivations unhelpful where a dynamic combination of both pragmatic and spiritual attractions is likely. There is no reason to separate the secular and spiritual, as it is unlikely that A nindilyakwa people would have made this distinction. Judy Lalara told me that Gula "wanted to learn more about the missionary"; he was "learning the new things."¹¹¹ Learning new spirituality, becoming literate, and gaining new skills were attractive to young men. The new religion offered potential spiritual, social, and material benefits.

Christian faith, responsibility, and fluency in English went hand in hand in missionaries' eyes. In 1952, the superintendent assessed Nandjiwara, then twenty years old, as having "a good understanding of English" and "a happy personality," and as being "trustworthy and reliable."¹¹² Gula Lalara was "a very steady and reliable worker" and had "a good understanding of the Christian life."¹¹³ Missionaries rewarded interpreters with responsibility and privilege, shoring up their continued cooperation and asserting a privileged place for English in Angurugu's language economy. Following Gulpia's conversion, he was given oversight of the women working in the garden. In 1950, Gula was given responsibility for the "little boys" in their gardening.¹¹⁴ If missionaries looked for evidence of success, they quickly found it in these men.

In return, the young men managed their relatives. Gula, for example, was so trusted that he became the missionaries' detective. The need for such a position reflects the instability of the mission community; missionaries were not entirely in control. As his daughter Rhoda Lalara explained to me, whenever the missionaries were afraid—perhaps a house had been broken into or they heard someone in the night—they went to Gula.

When people [missionaries] needed help, they went to see [Gula]. During the night someone went up and called around the house. They had seen somebody walking or maybe breaking into one of the houses. They went to see the footprint and they couldn't recognize the footprint so they went up to my father and "can you

recognize this footprint?" "Yes it belong maybe from Wurramurra clan." And he just told them which tribe they were.¹¹⁵

Missionaries needed this young man to read both the land and its people. Gula knew the island and could interpret each clan's imprint upon it. By brokering this knowledge to the missionaries, he made himself indispensable.

At the same time, other Anindilyakwa people, particularly the older people, resented the missionaries. As a result, interpreters sometimes faced hostility from their own relatives. Anindilyakwa people who interpreted in the school in the early 1950s had the unenviable role of disciplining the children, often with corporal punishment, which distressed their families. The young interpreters were obliged not only to their old people and relatives, but to missionaries who provided them with new knowledge and influence. The old people and missionaries competed to influence and retain the loyalty of these young people, realizing that the bilingual youth held a pivotal position in the community. Judy Lalara remembered how other relatives criticized her father for his cooperation with missionaries:

My grandmother, my father's mother, she used to say to her son, "why do you keep going to those missionary? They don't belong to us, they came from another world." That's what she used to say to my father. And my father saying back to her, "they're missionaries, they're here to bring the story about Jesus." That's what he used to tell my grandmother. My grandmother was a whingy [cranky] old lady. Whenever she saw missionary going up towards my father, she'd just get up and walk away, you know. She didn't like the missionary because one of my father's brother, her other son, they treated him real bad, they chained him around at the church. That's why she hated missionary, my grandmother didn't like the missionary.¹¹⁶

Despite his mother's appeals, Gula continued his work for the time being. The CMS hoped that these young, English-speaking converts would grow in influence under the missionaries' guidance. The CMS Secretary for Aborigines explained that since "the Holy Spirit has spoken . . . in a foreign tongue" (English) to some men, these men could now "preach the Word of God to their own people."¹¹⁷ He envisaged that the young, English-speaking men would become the missionaries' allies and agents of evangelism in the camp. Evangelism can be a way by which new converts honor their obligations to missionaries.¹¹⁸ The young interpreters, likewise, honored missionaries by managing their relatives' discontent as well as by actively evangelizing them. As the young converts grew in influence, the CMS would also drive a wedge between young and old in Anindilyakwa society by inverting traditional structures of authority and knowledge.

Missionaries did not admit, or perhaps they were unaware of, the extent to which they depended on the support of the young interpreters. Gula Lalara, for example, spoke on behalf of the missionaries in Anindilyakwa when his relatives were angry, even protecting missionaries from assault. Judy Lalara explained:

When the missionaries were in trouble from other Aborigine men he used to talk for them too, missionary he used to protect them. . . . [Telling people] not to hate those missionaries because they're here to show us the new things. . . . He used to protect the white people from Aborigine men. Because some didn't like white people coming over to Groote Eylandt. . . . He was protecting the missionary people every night. He has to go round and check them that they were safe, that not any people would harm them.¹¹⁹

For men like Gula, befriending and assisting the missionaries as an interpreter was both a way to benefit from missionaries and also a way to mitigate the effects of their presence. Though interested in the modern world brought by the missionaries, they were also concerned to protect their people and country. At times Gula was frustrated and disappointed by the missionaries. Nonetheless, he saw the future in cooperation with missionaries. The missionaries may have been oblivious to the extent of his efforts, but Gula's daughter insisted that he also ensured that missionaries did not interfere too much with his land, ceremony, culture, and family. "He wanted to work at to protect the two worlds," she said, to engage with the missionaries' culture but not be subsumed by it.¹²⁰ His knowledge of languages enabled him to stand in the pivotal position between Anindilyakwa- and English-speakers, and negotiate for his and his family's interests. In so doing, he continued a long Anindilyakwa tradition of engagement and selective adoption, a vernacularization of aspects of other cultures. Thus, the intimacies between missionaries and interpreters were strategic for both; friendship across language and culture could be used to influence and to manage others' presence.¹²¹

Angurugu in its early years, therefore, was a translating community. Its very name, as we have seen, was the product of translation and accommodation, compromise and change. It was a community dependent on interpreters who walked the middle ground between missionaries and other Aboriginal people, holding the fragile community together. Aboriginal people found ways to negotiate, to manage the mission, to incorporate it into their lives. They reasserted their continuing authority and connection to country in ways missionaries failed to understand. But the negotiations occurred in an unequal power relationship. Anindilyakwa people were not fully informed about the mission's purpose or the potential consequences of the missionary presence.

In the early years of the Angurugu mission, the relationships were not as unequal as they later came to be. Unable to speak the language and far from their home and family, missionaries depended on the goodwill and cooperation of a core group of Anindilyakwa-speakers who had added speaking English to their skills. The missionary dependence on interpreters meant that the mission was unstable. Missionaries relied on the very people they hoped to change and convert to translate their messages faithfully. As we have seen, though the interpreters had much to gain from missionaries, they also had reservations about missionary impositions on their culture and lives. Though the young men who worked as interpreters willingly cooperated with missionaries at this stage, we shall see in later chapters that they increasingly refused to acquiesce to missionary demands as they grew older.

As Anindilyakwa people cut the timber and built the mission houses and church, a new CMS doctrine on race and citizenship was developing. While the four “old men” who led the CMS to the site at Angurugu would have expected a humanitarian mission, what they eventually received from the CMS was an assimilation project, an effort to translate their culture and convert their children into Christian citizens of the Australian nation. We can only wonder whether, if they had known, they would have built the mission at all. This new doctrine of assimilation would shape the uses of languages throughout the mission years. In 1946, when assimilation was in its infancy, CMS policy for “half caste” education was the “teaching of good English and the elimination of pidjin [*sic*].” When it came to “Native Education,” however, they were very open to Aboriginal languages and advocated bilingual education, stating that “elementary education on all stations ought to be given in the local vernacular.”¹²² As assimilation took root, the mission’s openness to Aboriginal languages began to diminish. From a missionary perspective, English would do away with dependence on interpreters, eradicate the instability of constant negotiation, and allow a missionary voice to dominate. English, they increasingly argued, was necessary for all Aboriginal people as a pillar of Australian citizenship. As we shall see in coming chapters, to be a fully functioning citizen, for them, demanded fluency and literacy in English.

For Anindilyakwa people, however, their language was irreplaceable; it connected them to their land and their kin. Anindilyakwa is embedded in the land, in its songs and stories. It is a marker of belonging to people and country. Anindilyakwa, sung by the ancestors as they traveled over the island, is rooted in the landscape of Groote Eylandt. English could never simply replace Anindilyakwa for Groote Eylandt and its people. English, the language of settler-colonizers, could say little about ceremonies, places, and kin.

For all the interpreting, translating, and negotiation that occurred at the mission, there was an underlying tension. For Anindilyakwa people, the Anindilyakwa language was irreplaceable. Groote Eylandt’s songs, stories,

and ceremonies belonged in Anindilyakwa from “the old days,” and Anindilyakwa belonged in the mouths of its people. Many Anindilyakwa people were interested in learning from the missionaries, but also worked to “protect the two worlds” and maintain a separateness. For missionaries, presenting Aboriginal people to English-speaking Australia as fluent, literate English-speakers became a crucial component of their task of transforming Aboriginal people into citizens. For them, English was necessary if Groote Eylandt was to realize itself as Australian soil, belonging to a united modern Australia. It was, therefore, embedded in a settler-colonial project that would recast Aboriginal land as naturally belonging to the settler society and Aboriginal languages as belonging to a distant past. The mission years under assimilation policy, therefore, were characterized by ongoing negotiations and unanswered questions. Whose vision for the island and its language would prevail?

EARS TO HEAR

The Sounds of Speech

Ängirraja ayaugwa äna nänguwawa niñi-yänbinama
Nengängirraja ayaugwa agina yine-maginama nungulanwa manja
mada?
Wawiyäbajina
Biya nara alerrajema añärriba añgarrema
Emba yaugujin ñäwa wawiyäbjina
Arrawa agambilya nungulanwa manja manma augwa nada.

Listen to this word I am speaking to you
 Do you understand that word I am telling you in your ear?
 Put it in
 But don't let it go right through and fly away
 But put it inside there still
 Let it stay inside your mind and ears.

—Mother's advice to daughter, told by Derama,
 translated by Judith Stokes

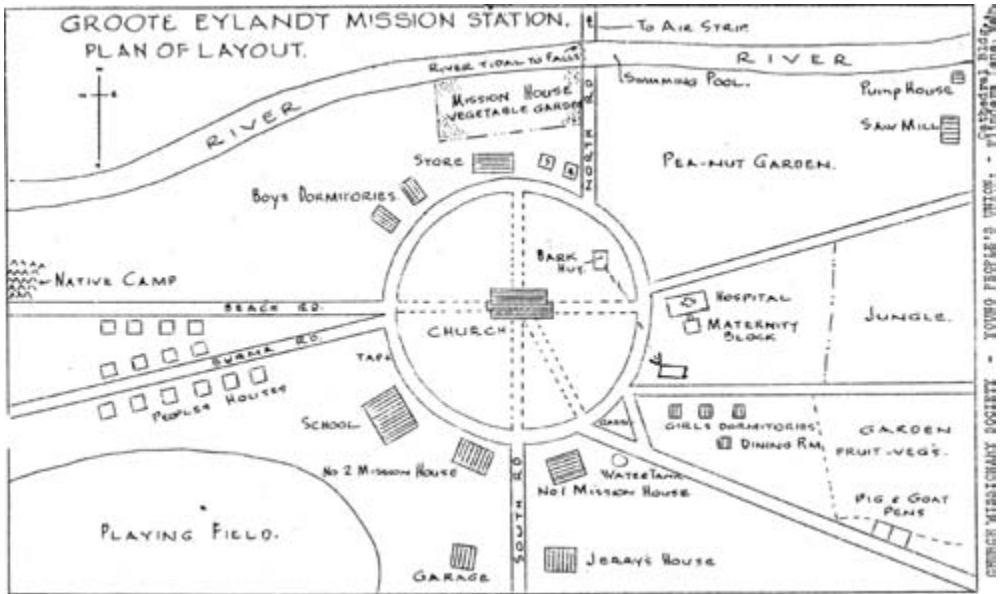
For Anindilyakwa people and evangelical missionaries alike, listening mattered. One had to have “ears to hear” and keep what was heard inside the mind and ears. In Anindilyakwa culture, to learn the deeper things, one must listen patiently, persistently. Gula Lalara told the missionary linguist and teacher, Judith Stokes, how he learned to sing. It was not by practicing but, according to Anindilyakwa tradition, by listening, over and over.

Ki-ngayingena-manja emba k-akakirumaka jungwuna-manja, ningkene-ka adinumba-wiya k-angmakuwlalama k-engkirrajama . . . K-engkirrajama ningkena, nara enjirrikajum. . . . ‘Ningki-yamarrkama ningkena ningk-akirumaduma?’ yama kwureya gayu-wa. Ngaya ningena ning-akakirumaduma ningena-bu ning-angmakwulamuma ningi-yamama adinuba-wiya, ningena ning-angmakulaluma nunbwarrka-manja ngawada. Nara kini-lalika nungwarrka-da.

If you want to learn the clan songs, first of all you must sit down and listen. . . . You must listen and not be in a hurry. . . . You ask me, “However did you learn?” I learnt first by sitting down, sitting down all the time with my father. I never left him.¹

Missionaries understood their spirituality in auditory terms. Christianity grew out of an ancient Hebrew oral tradition; the Word of God was spoken and heard. The Christian tradition always represents God as speaking, not writing.² For Christians, “faith cometh by hearing.”³ Missionaries also believed in “callings.” Most missionaries I interviewed told me of their experience being called to the mission field. “I had a very strong call from God to work with Aboriginal people,” one told me. Another “felt that God was calling me to work amongst Aboriginal people.” Another “sensed God calling me to be a missionary.”⁴ The entire mission project in North Australia was, to the CMS, an answer to a call. The CMS had been “called to bring these Aboriginal communities to the knowledge of God.”⁵ Most important, they came to announce a “call” to Aboriginal people. The call was universal, as A. P. Elkin explained: “The call to all peoples is the same—to fulfil their destiny as members of the one Kingdom of God.”⁶ When missionaries came to Groote Eylandt, they came with their English words and with their Word, a message or “call” for Anindilyakwa-speakers. The missionaries’ objective was to convince Anindilyakwa-speakers to listen and answer.

This was a difficult task because the way people speak and listen depends on their social contexts, a factor that did not necessarily operate in missionaries’ favor. That people speak differently in different spaces is especially true for those who are multilingual. Joshua Fishman popularized domain theory



Angurugu layout, 1950s (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

in sociolinguistics. In multilingual communities domains are social contexts that determine “who speaks what language to whom.”⁷ Anna de Fina argued further that language choice in bilingual community domains is a means of constructing and asserting social identities.⁸ Various historians and social scientists have likewise put forward the hypothesis that missionaries divided life on missions into spheres that marked boundaries of norms of behavior. Space and time were managed at missions, establishing spheres of life and distinguishing “civilization” from “the wild” according to a civilizing and Christianizing agenda.⁹ Gwenda Baker argued that the Methodist Mililingimbi mission in North Australia existed in two spheres: the mission space where missionaries dictated how Yolngu people would live, and the space beyond the mission where Yolngu people maintained control.¹⁰ In contrast, Joy Sandefur examined the history of Ngukurr (CMS Roper River mission) and argued that Aboriginal people used the mission space to maintain their cultures, blurring the boundaries imagined by missionaries.¹¹ There is a risk, therefore, of believing missionaries’ own rhetoric and their constructed boundaries of “civilization” and “primitivism,” which may not have been so clear-cut.

So what did the mission sound like? In light of the spiritual and social significance of listening for Anindilyakwa-speakers and missionaries alike, this chapter turns to the Angurugu soundscape, particularly the sound of spoken language. The various “spheres” of the mission—the church, the camp, the school, and the mission space—all sounded different. Missionaries used speech and language in these spaces to proclaim an ordering of the mission that they hoped would coax Anindilyakwa people to listen. The aural spheres of the mission would establish missionary speech—and with it their message and culture—as dominant and legitimate in the mission’s language economy. The spheres, then, could be considered an auditory settler-colonial strategy. But the sounds of the mission also point to Anindilyakwa interests. Did the construction of various spheres of life and speech allow missionaries to achieve their goal of forming willing listeners who heard the call?

The Sounds of the Church

For missionaries, the church was the heart of mission life. It lay at the geographical center of the mission with all roads emanating out from it. The location was designed as a “sign to everybody that the things of God are central and take place in all that we do here on this mission.”¹² It was here that the missionaries most clearly articulated their gospel and broadcast their message. The missionaries understood preaching as fundamental to their very identity and purpose in life. For them, to be a missionary was to be a preacher.

Church was compulsory for the first decade of the mission. It was “no pray no tucker.”¹³ The missionaries enforced attendance by distributing Sunday rations only to those who sat through the service. The services were conducted almost entirely in English. This was because some missionaries believed that church could be a means of teaching English.¹⁴ To the missionaries, if people heard their message often enough and loudly enough, they would eventually listen. In 1951 the chaplain reported his evangelistic method as “constant preaching of the Word of God.”¹⁵ In addition to the Sunday service, there were morning services every weekday, which all children attended, and evening Camp Services or “fellowship services,” as well as prayer meetings, Bible study meetings, and baptism and confirmation classes on weeknights. Only on Saturdays were the preachers silent.

In the initial years of the mission, it seemed that Anindilyakwa people were listening. In 1944, only months after preaching began at Angurugu, eight of them made “decisions for Christ.”¹⁶ But as the years went by, missionaries no longer enjoyed such responses to their message. In 1962, the chaplain Ben Moore confessed that attendance at church services was so poor that “there is the possibility of men living on a CMS station within 400 yards of the church, never hearing the Gospel.”¹⁷ They searched for strategies that might attract interest: films, tapes, records, puppet shows, flannelgraph pre-



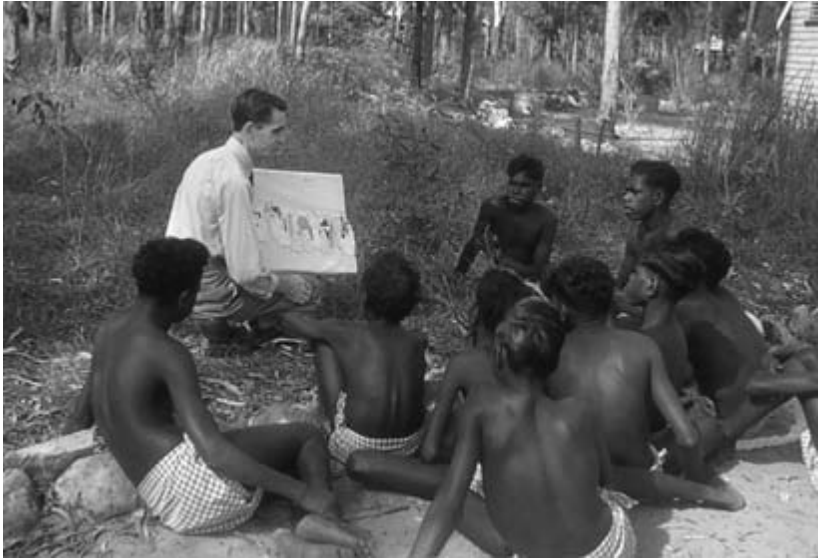
Angurugu church, 1951 (Keith Hart Collection, Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

sentations (storytelling with felt images), pictures. In 1951, the missionaries arranged for Nabilya Lalara to record Christian messages in Anindilyakwa on records, hoping that the sound of Anindilyakwa and new technology would catch people's attention.

*Ganuṅgararbiya gerredarrenga! Wāṅgirradya God
nilyaṅmanduguna nambilyamerra aṅubina mandya. Wāṅgirradya
ānelaṅura ayaugura.*

Men and women! Listen God is indeed true/honest. He lives in
Heaven. Listen to his word.¹⁸

"Listen! Listen!" was Nabilya's (scripted) message. Chaplain Jim Taylor's strategy was simply volume: "I talk loud enough to be heard in Darwin."¹⁹ Later that year, he reported his excitement that Jabani and Nalagaiyowa were willing to lead "a Bible Study-come-English lessons-music-games," a gain linking speaking English with becoming Christian. He wrote with anticipation of results: "far more will be 'hooked.'"²⁰ In 1965, a chaplain hoped that tape-recordings with Christian stories and illustrations would induce "even the toughest" Anindilyakwa people to listen. He reported excitedly that the



Boys' Sunday school (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

old people now “wanted to hear.”²¹ Even a cyclone in 1967 was an opportunity for evangelism. After people’s flimsy homes were washed away, they camped in the church, thereby coming within earshot of the preacher. “I let them stay at the back of the building . . . Some of them have shown no interest in the things of God and so in this unusual way came within sound of the Gospel,” explained the chaplain.²² His primary concern was that they would hear, if only he could make them listen.

The Sounds of the Camp

Just beyond the mission was the “camp,” later called the “village.” Missionaries believed they competed with an alternative voice on Groote Eylandt—the message of the camp and the old people. Camp people had only intermittent contact with missionaries, and missionaries generally had limited knowledge of camp life. They rarely visited, and it seems they felt unwelcome or out of place. There was an unspoken rule that missionaries did not frequent the camp. One mentioned that other missionaries told her “not to go down to the village at night time,” even though in her own experience it was “perfectly ok.”²³ This norm could have arisen out of respect for privacy or fears for safety, or it could have been because their visit might have been mistaken as an en-



People in village, 1951 (Keith Hart Collection, Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

dorsement of camp life. A 1958 CMS publication explained that “it is hard for the Christian Aborigine to turn away from the old way of life.” This was because “the old people who have not accepted Christ still teach the old way.”²⁴ According to the superintendent in 1962, the “teaching of Christianity still battles against strong adherence to old customs.”²⁵ The camp and mission, they believed, were diametrically opposed.

Missionaries could hear the sounds of the camp from their houses and interpreted them as signs of otherness. To missionaries, the camp sounded foreign, brutal, and chaotic—everything that the mission hoped not to be. The distinct sounds of languages marked where the mission ended and the bush began; there was no English in the bush. One missionary both loved and feared the sounds of the camp and described its music, the sound of the didjeridu.

The clapping sticks are hard wooden sticks that have a real ring about them as they tap out the rhythm. Their syncopated beats can be quite complicated. The drone of the didjeridoo fill the stillness of the night and echoes all over the mission.²⁶

While the camp music was strange but benign, she found the sound of Aboriginal voices disturbing. The sounds of the spoken language emanating

from camp proved to her that it was untamed and other. In her mind, the primary use of language in the camp was to express abuse or terror; she recalled “loud argumentative voices” and “the cries of frightened children.”²⁷ This was not the mission; the sounds erupting from the camp made this clear.

Ceremonial wailing sounds of ritual mourning resounding from the camp also unsettled the missionaries. CMS publications described these sounds to churchgoers: “For people who do not believe, death is a fearful thing . . . the Aborigine will wail loudly when someone dies and cut themselves.”²⁸ In contrast to the sound coming from the mourners was the “quietness” of the Christian convert. That Old Banjo Lalara’s funeral in 1965 “had little of the wailing” common in previous years was, to missionaries, “a real cause for thanksgiving.”²⁹ The CMS contrasted the “hopeless wailing” with the “quiet trust” of the Anindilyakwa convert, Widjari, on the death of her husband. She had “settled down” as a schoolteacher and had “come to know the power of the Lord Jesus.”³⁰ They saw in her quietness and domesticity the evidence of a clear distinction between the “civilized” Christian mission and camp life. Nevertheless, the mission needed the contrasting sounds of the camp to justify its continued presence. The sound was evidence of the need for further evangelism and civilizing.

Despite their unfamiliarity and discomfort with the sound of Anindilyakwa, on the rare occasions when missionaries did enter the camp, they avoided English. In the camp services, even in the performance of apparently Western Christian activities, the Anindilyakwa language was allowed to dominate. These services were usually led by an Anindilyakwa-speaker, or at least run with the assistance of an Aboriginal interpreter.³¹ Missionaries saw themselves as reaching out to camp people, operating on camp terms. By avoiding English at the camp, they also pronounced that the camp was beyond the mission; it was, to them, not yet civilized.

Likewise, by maintaining their own languages in this space, Aboriginal people asserted that the camp was outside missionary influence. For the few missionaries who wished to learn Aboriginal languages, visits to the camp were the only way to immerse themselves. After hours of teaching in the English-only classroom, missionary teacher (and eager linguist) Judith Stokes would visit the camp. Only there would people reply to her in Anindilyakwa, while if the exchange had taken place within the mission, she found it would be in English.³² Only by venturing beyond the mission to the camp could she convince people that she wanted to speak and hear Anindilyakwa. Visiting the camp, Stokes placed herself under Aboriginal people and sought to operate on their terms, in their space. Rhoda Lalara remembered how confusing this was to her as a child. She distinguished missionaries and Aboriginal people according to speech, not color, but Stokes confounded these categories:



Judith Stokes (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

I used to think, “how come she knows this language?” . . . I was thinking to myself, maybe her mother was an Aboriginal, that’s why she knows our language. But, *nara* [no], it was those older people, older women and men used to show her how to speak in our language.³³

By leaving the mission space and speaking Anindilyakwa, Stokes disrupted the boundaries that regulated mission life, blurring the speech-based categories of missionary and camp person. Stokes, however, was the only missionary at this time who ever approached fluency, so her studies did not significantly disrupt the language politics at the mission. Nonetheless, the boundary between camp and mission was more fluid than some missionary reports would suggest.

Listening at School

The school was a strategic space for the CMS where the use of (English) language, they hoped, would attune children’s ears to listen to their teachings.

The school was also the sphere of mission life most strongly influenced by government. The Commonwealth government introduced a provisional syllabus for Aboriginal schools in 1950 and provided the CMS with much-needed subsidies for teaching staff. According to the Commonwealth, school was the primary means of achieving assimilation. It was to be the “integral part” of the mission.³⁴ In 1955, the Minister for Territories, Paul Hasluck, flew into Angurugu, explaining to missionaries how the “problems aborigines faced” could be “overcome by education.”³⁵ Missionaries understood and accepted this agenda, with one explaining that schools were to “speed up the process” of introducing Aboriginal people to “the acceptable general Australian lifestyle.”³⁶ That is, assimilating them into the culture of the settler-colonists.

Commonwealth policy was that all instruction must be in English, and English-only instruction was a condition of government funding. Speaking “good” English, conforming to a national standard, was understood as necessary for effective citizenship.³⁷ As a concession, “native languages” could be used with preschool groups, but education would be exclusively in English from age six onward.³⁸ Not only was learning English essential, but English was to dominate all aspects of school life. As the new syllabus insisted:

It cannot be too strongly emphasised that instruction in “English” will not be confined to formal lessons in language. Every part of the curriculum and almost every lesson should be partly directed towards the acquisition of skill in the use and comprehension of English.³⁹

Bizarrely, the Commonwealth Office of Education promoted this English-only policy despite acknowledging “psychological and philosophical arguments in favour of beginning instruction in the vernacular . . . and despite a considerable amount of scientific evidence.” It cited two reasons for rejecting the scientific consensus on the benefits of bilingual education for literacy. First was the great number of Aboriginal languages. Second was that Aboriginal languages were “limited in vocabulary” and “adapted to the thought content of the culture of which they are a part” and thus were “of limited value as a medium through which to explain the ‘European’ way of life.” Aboriginal languages were presumed to hinder the development of “civilized” thinking, as it was believed they lacked a suitable vocabulary. “The policy of assimilation demands a *lingua franca* as soon as possible . . . that *lingua franca* must be English” was the Commonwealth’s conclusion.⁴⁰ There was no pretense that English in the classroom might have educational merits, perhaps aiding students in literacy. Instead, the primary justification was the assimilation policy. The decision to use English alone in

Aboriginal schools was rooted in settler-colonial concerns to eliminate Aboriginal people's distinct cultural identities and philosophies, not in educational concerns.

The Commonwealth Office of Education planned for what they called the "substitution" of Aboriginal languages with English. They explained their objectives to missionary societies as comparable to the substitution of Christianity for Aboriginal beliefs. English, they believed, would hasten both assimilation and conversion.

There is a need everywhere for a planned, vigorous and maintained drive for English. Substitution of a new language for the old is not likely to disrupt the traditional social structure of the people any more than the substitution of Christian religion for their old religion and superstitions. In fact the former might assist the latter process.⁴¹

Conversion to Christianity was portrayed as analogous to becoming an English-speaker. The two objectives were closely linked, even mutually reinforcing, for policy makers and missionaries alike. The statement also betrays a misunderstanding of Aboriginal kinship systems as a purely secular matter, as if these could be separated from knowledge of the Creative Beings that formed them.

As late as 1969, the Commonwealth government's Welfare Branch (which presided over Aboriginal policy) presumed that "remedial work" might be necessary due to the "inhibitory influences" of "bilingualism in education."⁴² Aboriginal languages were actively discouraged. Welfare Branch required teachers in mission schools to report whether, how often, and for what reason they used Aboriginal words.⁴³ Linguist and CMS board member Arthur Capell lamented in 1964 that the Commonwealth was not even "paying lip service to the vernacular" but was "definitely and actively opposed" to its use. "It seems clear," he continued, "that government policy looks forward to the loss of Aboriginal languages, so that the Aborigines may be 'assimilated.'"⁴⁴

From the 1950s, children in Angurugu school received "constant drill" in oral English. The children found it difficult. Missionary teachers commented on their shyness and "tendency to withdraw."⁴⁵ Pupil records from the 1950s and 1960s reveal that girls in particular were consistently quiet or shy.⁴⁶ This shyness could be for cultural reasons: gender norms, kinship avoidance rules (children were often in class with those whom they would traditionally avoid), and cultural aversion to direct questions. It also could be because the children were uncomfortable speaking English. The head teacher, Ted Egan, found it necessary to adjust his teaching style, stating that the Anindilyakwa children's "refusal to be 'told' anything rules out

‘chalk-talk’ teaching.”⁴⁷ The children simply would not cooperate. Perhaps the “shyness” also was their means of rejecting the English-only policy. Nonetheless, the school continued to pursue its aim that all children “speak up” in English.

Some of those children, however, retained positive memories of speaking English in school. Judy Lalara spoke fondly of her favorite missionary teacher because she taught her to speak English well:

She teach me how to speak English and write in English. She was the one that teach me how to speak good English. So I was the best student for her. In my class, I was the best student from her. Sometimes I used to go out after school I used to go visit her, talk about the times, you know, the days of things been changing and seeing the new things coming in.⁴⁸

Since most children were “shy” in the English drills, a more successful method for teaching the children English was in song, both nursery rhymes and religious songs.⁴⁹ Missionaries were vaguely aware that the children did not understand the songs sung in English, but they hoped that the lyrics would become ingrained so that when their proficiency in English caught up with their singing ability, they would understand the Christian message. Children at Angurugu learned dozens of choruses at school and in Sunday school in the 1950s.

Not all missionaries supported the English-language policy. Teachers were among the most eager missionaries to use Aboriginal languages, a trend across several Aboriginal missions. A common refrain in the mission staff minutes in the 1950s was the “dilemma” over language in the classroom. The children apparently concentrated better with Anindilyakwa, but this was not mission or government policy, so the matter remained unresolved.⁵⁰ Teachers were the most entangled in an Anindilyakwa-speaking world, and perhaps, through their daily interactions, Anindilyakwa-speaking children and parents convinced the mission teachers that using their language would be the best approach. Though these teachers did not reject the importance of winning children to Christian teaching, they doubted whether excluding Anindilyakwa from their classroom served this goal. Nonetheless, the mission teachers felt strong pressure to promote English according to what they called “the Welfare Department’s rules.”⁵¹

In Sydney, the CMS Aborigines Secretary, J. B. Montgomerie, paid lip service to the value of Aboriginal languages and their educational value. He also acknowledged that Anindilyakwa people “would appreciate it.” Yet when missionaries suggested more use of Anindilyakwa, his answer was always that “the Department,” the “Director of Native Affairs,” or the “government” prevented it.⁵² Given that his missions were perpetually understaffed, it seems

Montgomerie found that the government policy provided welcome relief: At least his missionaries would not have to take on language study on top of existing duties. Furthermore, his belief that the old people in the camp would undermine missionaries' teaching "because the young can understand them better" indicates that, for him, teaching English to children was a means of winning children's loyalty at the expense of their relatives in the camp.⁵³ It is possible that Montgomerie's unwillingness to challenge the Commonwealth government's English-language policy was partly due to the strategic role of English in alienating the Anindilyakwa youth from the camp sphere.

Despite the "rules," the Anindilyakwa language was always present in the Angurugu school. The CMS's inability to staff its schools fully presented an opportunity to Anindilyakwa-speakers. Several Anindilyakwa individuals pursued roles as teachers, so there were always Anindilyakwa teaching assistants who interpreted for the children. The main recorded use of Aboriginal languages in the classroom in the 1950s and 1960s was discipline. Stokes used Anindilyakwa to warn the children when they misbehaved. As Rhoda Lalara explained:

When we used to get silly, she said "*nara n'awilyamba*" "don't fight." When we used to get silly, you know, "*nara aruwariya eningaba nungguwa*" "you stay good and don't be bad." When she was in the classroom, she used to speak Anindilyakwa.⁵⁴

Since missionary teachers were not fluent in Anindilyakwa, they depended on Aboriginal teaching assistants, especially when children misbehaved. The teaching assistants had responsibility for disciplining the children, often with corporal punishment. For this, they faced hostility from their relatives in the camp who opposed the mission's disciplinary measures.⁵⁵ Some interpreters even quit the school due to the "upset in the camp" caused by their actions, thus putting the demands of their family above those of the missionaries.⁵⁶ Nancy Lalara told how her father, Gula, used to give out "five lashes on your legs." "I hated that because my dad did it," she said.⁵⁷ It was even more unsettling because traditionally, an Anindilyakwa child's aunts or uncles are responsible for discipline, not her own parents. She thought that perhaps he was more loyal to the mission than he was to her. Although Aboriginal languages were present in the classroom, their connection with discipline meant that they were used in a way that stirred up conflict in Aboriginal families and communities but strengthened the power of the school. English was associated with good behavior, but Anindilyakwa meant punishment.

Schoolchildren also actively made efforts to speak their own language even when separated from the old people. As Nancy Lalara remembered:

We spoke our language . . . Our language was maintained, when we were sort of hung around amongst one another. But when we went to the church to congregate and the young women wanted to say, to talk after church to their parents or anything, all we did was go to church and then we went our separate ways. We only saw grand-parents come up maybe sometimes on the weekend.⁵⁸

Despite government standards and CMS intentions, the school was not a sphere apart from camp life where English reigned. Rather, social relationships across the school and camp were intertwined due to missionary dependence on Anindilyakwa for classroom management.

Cacophony of the Mission Space

In the mission space outside the school and the church, language and power were contested. For missionaries, this was a pivotal space where their language, they hoped, would encourage Anindilyakwa submission and win Anindilyakwa people to their message. Superintendents asserted their dominance over Anindilyakwa people through sound and language. Dick Harris's booming voice made people listen. As missionary Barry Butler remembered, Harris was "very firm and strict but very fair . . . The Aboriginal people I think respected him, even though he spoke strongly and maybe slapped one or two of them."⁵⁹ For Butler, Harris was respected *despite* strong speech and "slaps." However, when I discussed Harris with two senior men at Angurugu, they insisted that the "strong words" and strict discipline were *reason* to respect the superintendent.

[Jabani La lar a]: Dick Harris . . . He was a great man. He was a carpenter, all sorts.

[LR]: Was he a hard man also?

[Jabani]: Oh, hard man!

[Murabuda Wurramarrba]: Hard man bringing us under-standing.

[Jabani]: Very strong.

[Murabuda]: Very strong word, ay. When you speak very soft that he can't take it. Hard language. Hard things and make you really make right in your life and heart and mind. That's the way we learn, Aborigine people, in the beginning when the white man came to this island.⁶⁰

Perhaps Jabani saw a connection between the strong words of Harris the carpenter and the words of Christ the carpenter of whom Harris preached. To Murabuda, the missionary's authority to speak on matters of "life and

heart and mind” was connected to the strength of his words. Perhaps the Anindilyakwa men I spoke with accepted as legitimate the missionaries’ use of language to assert authority. Some would suggest that missionaries’ authoritarian regimes may have been culturally appropriate in ways that more recent and chaotic government programs have not.⁶¹ The older men believe such discipline is lacking today, so they remember Harris’s strong speech with respect. But it could be that, in painting a positive image of Harris’s authoritarianism, they were appealing to what they imagined were the interviewer’s own values—what they thought I wanted to hear as a Christian and a white person. Given the apparent success of this use of language, Harris and subsequent superintendents cultivated their reputation as the “strong man” of the mission through the sound of their voices.

For the superintendents or chaplains, indications that their voice might not convey authority over Anindilyakwa-speakers were deeply concerning. Some took drastic measures to ensure they could evoke fear. Exile from the mission had been the standard punishment for minor crimes. Major crimes, however, warranted exile to Darwin and prosecution. By 1958, the chaplain suspected some men were deliberately challenging his authority in the mission space. They were unafraid of jail in Darwin and even curious to visit and see the city.⁶² It is telling that, for some, jail in Darwin might have been more attractive than the mission environment and that the missionaries knew it. The government’s chief welfare officer, Ted Evans, invented a solution. They would send offenders somewhere where they could not understand the language. Montgomerie was relieved.

By sending these chaps to Hooker’s Creek, it is a real punishment, [Evans] says, because they speak an entirely different language, without any possibility of making each other understand what they are saying . . . The Welfare Branch officers are up to all the tricks now, and they are not playing into their hands in any way. Punishment now means punishment.⁶³

Hooker Creek (now Lajamanu) was a government settlement for Aboriginal people on the edge of the Tanami Desert, approximately 800 kilometers (497 miles) away from both Groote Eylandt and Darwin. By sending men there, the CMS and the Welfare Branch used language to assert their authority over the men and the mission space. They demonstrated their awareness of the connections between language and landscape: An effective exile must be both linguistic and geographic. Still the Anindilyakwa men resisted. They escaped twice and attempted to cross the desert by foot. The eventual result, however, was gratifying to both the CMS and the Welfare Branch; after their recapture, the men were “sullen and unresponsive.”⁶⁴ Together, the CMS and the Welfare Branch finally silenced the Anindilyakwa men. Assuming the

place of God at Babel, the CMS punished the men by confusing their languages.

Despite such displays of power through language, the mission space remained contested. Unlike the school, which was governed by an explicitly assimilationist curriculum, the mission space had no clear framework for how assimilation would be achieved or how language would be used. Missionary chaplain David Woodbridge explained to me that missionaries mostly improvised within a general framework of evangelism and assimilation.⁶⁵ Around the mission the use of language was more fluid than at church and school, as both policy and practice were experimental. Another missionary described the sounds of many languages spoken in the mission sphere:

[One hears] the sound of friendly voices chatting in one's own language. The sound of equally friendly voices trying to say exactly what they want to say in often hesitant English. The harsh sound of a strange language that requires all your powers of concentration to comprehend the full meaning of what is said.⁶⁶

These sounds were not without emotional resonance for her. They were friendly or harsh according to the degree to which she could understand. The sound of Anindilyakwa unsettled her. It suggested that this was not her country and that some things were beyond her understanding. Language was certainly not always under missionary control or used according to missionaries' hopes.

When talking with each other, Anindilyakwa-speakers continued to speak their own languages even within the mission space. The boundary of the mission and the camp was not so clear. Continuing to speak this way was an assertion that the mission was not owned or even controlled by missionaries. It remained Anindilyakwa country. Speaking Anindilyakwa could be a way of escaping the missionary gaze, of communicating freely within the mission without missionary interference. The language barrier meant that the CMS missions could never become totalizing institutions. For example, when supervision of the girls' dormitory was taken from Gulpia Lalara and given to missionaries Stokes and Norma Farley, the missionaries struggled to make the girls "settle down" and reported a new "tendency towards disrespect." This, they believed, was due to the missionary ignorance of Anindilyakwa.⁶⁷ When Stokes became increasingly competent in Anindilyakwa, not all Anindilyakwa-speakers welcomed her fluency. Some treated her with suspicion or even disapproval. Her understanding was a threat; she upset the established pattern of relationships at the mission. Aboriginal people maintained their own sphere of operation within the mission through language and through keeping control of translation. Missionaries were reminded daily that, despite any strict work regime or external discipline they imposed,

they themselves remained foreigners, outside the domain of Aboriginal communication, never properly aware of what people were thinking or feeling.

Missionaries used English with each other, hoping that Aboriginal people would pick it up. The missionaries had some success; one Anindilyakwa woman explained to me that she and her peers had learned English, not from the school, but by listening to missionaries.⁶⁸ Most missionaries argued that since Aboriginal people supposedly possessed greater linguistic aptitude than white people, it was simpler to make them learn English than for the missionaries to learn Aboriginal languages.

Insisting that Aboriginal people should learn English appealed to missionaries for practical reasons. It also reinforced a hierarchy that established themselves as experts and Aboriginal people forever as learners. One liked the “friendly” sounds of “hesitant” English. For her, Aboriginal people were less threatening when restricted by a foreign language and when speaking to her on her terms. Furthermore, if the mission operated in a language in which the missionaries would always feel most competent, missionaries could feel secure that they really did have an obligation to teach and correct Aboriginal people in all spheres of life. English functioned, for some missionaries, to confirm to themselves their belief in their superior knowledge and in Anindilyakwa people’s need to listen to missionaries. She conceded that Aboriginal people would miss the “subtleties” of communication in English. To her this was no great loss, as she never expected Aboriginal people to need to understand subtleties. The English language, therefore, was a means by which some missionaries confirmed to themselves their belief in their own sophistication, civilization, and superior knowledge.

Anindilyakwa-speakers could not be forced to learn English. Though missionaries could speak and teach English, English would only become the dominant and legitimate language of the island if Anindilyakwa-speakers recognized it as such. Many did not. For most daily tasks, fluency in Standard Australian English was unnecessary; becoming fluent in English depended on Aboriginal people’s desire to master the language and on their exposure to it. They learned English as far as served their interests and to the extent that they had the opportunity to learn.

Various degrees of English competency could be used to control one’s engagement with the mission and achieve the desired benefits from missionaries. Missionaries praised Aboriginal people who mastered Standard Australian English. It indicated that the mission was functioning successfully, assimilating people into the broader English-speaking, white Australia. Those people who had the best grasp of English and worked as interpreters gained higher positions in the school and church. These privileges served as incentives to learn English, but they also required a greater commitment to the mission sphere of life and affected the interpreters’ relationship with older people who could not speak English. Anindilyakwa-speakers made different decisions about

the degree to which they would engage with the English-speaking world. Perhaps some Aboriginal people resolved to learn as little as possible as a means of escaping missionary authority and teaching. It is likely that some refused to comprehend commands given in English when they were unwilling to follow them, as a way of evading the missionaries. Sometimes it was preferable not to “have ears to hear” what missionaries had to say.

More threatening to missionaries than Anindilyakwa was the sound of Aboriginal Englishes and Kriol in the mission space. Australian academics held an overwhelmingly negative view of Aboriginal Englishes, pidgin, and Kriol until at least the late 1960s.⁶⁹ Kriol was “bastardised English.”⁷⁰ Elkin declared, “Pidgin English is quite unsatisfactory. Blacks can learn good English.”⁷¹ Kriol was, to these academics, a disturbing fusion of Aboriginal and European cultures, authentic to neither and therefore of no value at all. For missionaries, Kriol and Aboriginal Englishes blurred the distinction between camp and mission, belonging neither to Aboriginal tradition (in missionaries’ minds) nor to English-speaking Christian “civilization.” In some parts of the world, evangelical missionaries worried, therefore, that pidgins and creoles would lead to unstable, syncretic conversions, rather than to a “pure” faith associated with Indigenous languages.⁷²

The original 1944 CMS policy, therefore, was to “discourage” what they called “pidgin English.”⁷³ Later, in 1964, the CMS rearticulated its policy that “fluency and familiarity with English, as the language of Australia, must be aimed at for all the people and corrupted forms of English should be discouraged.”⁷⁴ By eschewing Kriol, CMS distinguished itself from other groups of white people in the contact zone of North Australia, such as those in the pearling or cattle industry. Fred Gray, for example, was known to speak “pidgin” at Umbakumba. But “we use English (not pidgin!),” declared a missionary in 1965.⁷⁵ If Aboriginal people were to become “civilized” citizens, only Standard Australian English would do. The presence of other Englishes challenged visions of Australia as a civilized and modern nation. It also challenged missionaries’ conception of their own civilizing influence and their binaries of civilized and wild spaces.

The missionaries reacted to the presence of Aboriginal Englishes and Kriol by resolving to uphold “good” English in the mission space. Standard English erases the evidence of the birthplace and origin of the speaker, pointing toward a generic citizenship. Standard Australian English functions to strengthen speakers’ ties to the nation over ties to the city or region where they grew up.⁷⁶ Similarly, insisting on “good” English was a means of distancing Anindilyakwa people from their ties to their country and replacing those with ties to the nation. It was also a way of disciplining missionaries themselves. While the missionaries spoke Standard Australian English, there was diversity even among them according to their background and education. In the 1950s many white Australians were uneasy about their accent. For the

sake of Australians' respectability in the world, it was necessary to speak English well. Likewise, missionaries felt the need to model "good" English for those whom they were training to become citizens. CMS policy makers instructed teachers in 1954 to teach "correct English."⁷⁷ Missionaries themselves were made to monitor their speech, understanding that it fell short of what they perceived as a more legitimate English possessed by those in authority over them. CMS officials, for example, noted when missionary candidates made "grammatical errors in speech."⁷⁸ In 1956, the Angurugu staff resolved that they should all "watch their grammar more carefully" and "use better English when speaking to the people."⁷⁹

Despite their resolutions to uphold linguistic standards, missionaries were compelled to adjust their expectations and attune their ear to Aboriginal Englishes. As Jenny Green, a missionary in Angurugu in the 1960s, remembered:

The other thing we needed to learn originally was anglicized, Aboriginal words, English I suppose, like "plower" for "flour." "Tilip," "plower," and "juka," they were the three things that people would come to the shop to buy . . . Flour, sugar, tea-leaf.⁸⁰

Not only were missionaries compelled to learn to understand Aboriginal Englishes, they even reverted to Aboriginal Englishes or Kriol themselves, sometimes deliberately, sometimes inadvertently. As much as missionaries asserted the legitimacy of Standard Australian English, competency in Kriol and pidgin was of greater functional value in Angurugu's language economy. Missionaries had to tacitly confirm the legitimacy of nonstandard Englishes at Angurugu if they were to communicate effectively. In his oral history, Superintendent Jim Taylor very quickly began using Aboriginal English in his reflections, as in this example: "I said to him 'you know what Nambadj, this is silly business, this chuckin' spears at each other, proper silly buisness.'"⁸¹ Aboriginal English, in his use of "buisness" and "proper," had become second nature to him. David Woodbridge, the mission chaplain, earned the nickname Kriol Boy from Aboriginal people since he openly preferred to converse in Kriol with Anindilyakwa-speakers.⁸² Missionaries had referred to grown Aboriginal men as "boys," but here the missionary was infantilized as the Kriol-speaker.

In light of such transgressions, the staff resolved to teach "their people the proper names of things so they can ask for what they want properly."⁸³ There would be no more tolerance of requests for "tilip" or "plower" at the shop. The Angurugu staff reminded each other in meetings that "when pidgin English is used to the people they very quickly do the same . . . the use of good English is imperative when speaking to Aboriginal people."⁸⁴ Missionaries presumed that Aboriginal people would follow the missionaries' lead.

What seems more likely, however, is that missionaries (perhaps unconsciously) imitated Aboriginal speech and spoke Aboriginal Englishes or Kriol.

For missionaries, it was not only the content of their speech—their use of grammar or Aboriginal Englishes—that was concerning, but also the way that they spoke. Their speech was to be civilized and self-controlled, unlike the presumed uncontrolled shouting and wailing of the camp. Only through modeling such Christian speech would they maintain the respect of Anindilyakwa-speakers and cause them to listen to their Christian message. Yet missionaries' own strict ideals for civilized speech also presented an opportunity for Anindilyakwa people to outmaneuver missionaries when missionaries' own standards proved impossible to meet.

Aboriginal societies across Australia have strict norms regulating swearing. Swearing can be used to resolve conflicts, to start fights, or to punish. Yet it is also often prohibited in the presence of certain relatives. Aboriginal "joking relationships"—where rude jokes and swearing are sanctioned—operate according to kinship relationships and regulations. With other relatives, such behavior is prohibited.⁸⁵ Swearing was also strictly regulated in Anindilyakwa society. Jabani Lalara explained that swearing is "a shameful thing in hurting big ceremony man. We're not allowed. Even the girls doesn't swear in front of his [*sic*] brother."⁸⁶ "We never swear in front of the old people or mother," Murabuda Wurramarrba explained.⁸⁷ The missionaries were aware of Anindilyakwa swearing taboos. This created further pressure among missionaries to conform to an idealized model of proper English speech. If they were found swearing or shouting inappropriately or uncontrollably, Anindilyakwa people would have reason to ignore the missionary message.

Missionaries paid close attention to each other's speech. Their tropical houses forfeited privacy for ventilation. The mission house had only partitions between the rooms, such that every conversation could be overheard. Missionaries lived with constant auditory monitoring of each other. It was an impossible standard. On one occasion in 1958, a missionary nurse, Joy Pascoe, broke down, swore, and shouted. Her colleagues reported her language to CMS officials, like witnesses to a crime.

Joy rushed into her room in the house near the Dormitory,
and screamed at some of the people and Dormitory girls . . .
She screamed at the people, "Go away, I hate you, go away,
I hate you!"⁸⁸

The sister had blown up and had been swearing badly at the hospital. . . . She called all the people (natives) who were in sight

"Devils," and said a couple of times "There is no God!" and was swearing quite a lot.⁸⁹

Pascoe resigned soon after the incident. She was under immense stress and, it seems, had little support from her colleagues. Most missionaries neglected to mention Pascoe's hearing impairment in their reports. Pascoe was an outsider among other missionaries because of her deafness. She could not participate in polite conversation. She felt excluded by the inaccessibility of missionary norms of speech and sound. "She quite often didn't bother to follow the light hearted chatter . . . yet not following it made her feel out of things and she became very moody and depressed."⁹⁰ "Light hearted chatter" was evidently an important activity for the single missionary women, a way to relax as well as to model "civilized" speech for Anindilyakwa people. Yet Pascoe could not participate.

Missionaries distanced themselves from Pascoe's swearing and shouting by reporting her offenses to CMS officials in detail. Gossip and scandal such as these cultivate social standards and discipline community members to conform to these standards. The detailed reports of Pascoe's breakdown reflect the missionaries' desire to uphold a standard for themselves as models of self-controlled speech and to reassert their identity as speakers of "good" English in the contested mission space.

Missionaries' main complaint about Pascoe's breakdown was that it had occurred within earshot of Anindilyakwa people. Since Anindilyakwa people had heard the outburst, they could also gossip about missionaries. Gossip can also be a weapon of the relatively powerless. It reveals contradictions, double standards, hypocrisy. Missionaries were therefore deeply concerned about Anindilyakwa gossip. Superintendent Taylor, for example, believed that lack of "proper supervision" in the mission sphere "allows people again to gossip, which in turn leads to strife and fighting."⁹¹ Taylor intended the work regime in the mission sphere to silence gossip, but even this could not suppress Anindilyakwa talk.

The Anindilyakwa girls relished the Pascoe episode. "They mimicked her so realistically that Leila . . . thought it was Joy again," Farley reported.⁹² Mimicry was the girls' way of seizing missionary power. Yet for Europeans, mimicry has been a sign of primitiveness. So the girls confirmed to missionaries their own "uncivilized," even "devilish," state through an act of resistance. The girls did not need a missionary to experience a personal breakdown, in order to find material for gossip about missionaries' inappropriate language. They manufactured their own situations. Missionaries were especially vulnerable due to their ignorance of Anindilyakwa and inability to translate. Even little children could outmaneuver and undermine a missionary through speech. Nancy Lalara remembered feeding the most

hated missionary schoolteacher swear words as a kind of payback, using mis-translation as her weapon.

We hated her . . . Every time we told her something and told her it meant something else, she'd go to the older people and pronounce it in a way that they could understand and they could ask the people that we hung out with "what did she say that missionary woman" then my cousin or my sister would say to my auntie or mother "she said this" and it's a swear word . . . It was a swear word that we were telling them it means "a dog" or "hello" or something like that. But then sometimes it was a serious one, like your private parts, which is a really shameful thing for a white person to understand.⁹³

Perhaps Pascoe also fell victim to the girls' pranks. "These people are past master at playing on weakness," wrote one superintendent, commenting on Anindilyakwa-speakers' tendency to "stir up problems" and "provoke trouble" to goad missionaries and make them lose their tempers.⁹⁴ The dormitory girls clearly found the incident entertaining. Missionaries were eager for Anindilyakwa-speakers to imitate their speech and listen to their message, but now they imitated missionaries only in jest. The missionary fear of the girls exposed a deep insecurity in the contested mission sphere; the missionary display of good speech and the façade of control were so thin that even schoolchildren could challenge it.

Though many missionaries imagined a contest between the teachings of church and camp, between standard "civilized" English and Aboriginal modes of speech, the Anindilyakwa themselves did not necessarily recognize that contest as valid. Anindilyakwa people understood missionaries' attempts to construct a dichotomy of camp and church, but many did not accept this binary. As Murabuda Wuramarrba explained, "we learn both way."⁹⁵ To Murabuda, it was not a genuine or necessary contest but one manufactured by missionaries. As the old men today look back on mission days, the important division they remember was not church teaching versus the camp, but the binary of law and lawlessness, of listening to elders and of ignorant hubris. Murabuda explained that in mission times, Anindilyakwa people listened to the teaching of *both* the camp and the church sphere, but they do so no longer.

We learn from in the beginning when the missionary come. We just got a real foundation in life, strong. After that we bin go through the our culture, our ceremony, is to come that way. And those two just work together, missionary law, gospel song or gospel story and those things.⁹⁶

Murabuda's memory of mission times could be shaped more by the frustration of his old age—the way Angurugu is today—than how it was in his youth. Nonetheless, his memories suggest that the division missionaries tried to create between listening to the church in English or to the camp in Anindilyakwa did not resonate with Anindilyakwa people. Moreover, missionaries' constructed boundaries of mission life were constantly challenged and transgressed, even by missionaries themselves, lending credence to Murabuda's insistence that the division was stronger in the minds of missionaries than in his experience.

A Fluid Soundscape

Missionaries envisaged mission life as divided into spheres—the camp, the school, the church, the mission space—each with its own language norms. From the missionary perspective, the use of language in these spheres would direct Anindilyakwa away from the teaching of the camp and encourage them to submit to the teaching of the church. Furthermore, the existence of distinct spheres, especially the camp and mission dichotomy, reassured missionaries that there was no need for them to listen to Anindilyakwa people. The spheres of speech and sound reinforced a message that Anindilyakwa culture was harsh, strange, and wild, and destined to disappear. The missionaries worked within a system and a set of spheres of life that made listening closely to Anindilyakwa people difficult, if not impossible. In this way, the construction of language spheres was a settler-colonial strategy, directed at silencing Indigenous voices and eventually eliminating their presence. Some missionaries did listen. Most, however, were more concerned with getting their message across: preaching at Anindilyakwa people, rather than conversing with them.

From an Aboriginal perspective, these spheres could be used to manage the engagement with the mission and to keep culture and language strong. The Anindilyakwa people managed Angurugu's language economy; they listened just enough and learned enough English according to their interests, but kept linguistic difference that enabled more control of their own affairs. Language functioned for missionaries and Anindilyakwa-speakers as a useful means for constructing different spheres of life and identities.

Yet these spheres were subject to change, and the boundaries were fluid. Through consideration of language, the missions emerge as contested spaces where various missionaries and various Aboriginal people pursued sometimes competing interests. There was no agreement among Aboriginal people or missionaries as to how language would be used, when, and where. Some missionaries subverted the mission structure by learning Anindilyakwa, listening to the old people, and visiting the camp. Both strategies were made possible by linguistic difference and the requirement to translate. Still others

spoke Aboriginal Englishes and Kriol in the supposedly “civilized” mission space. Missionaries found they needed to compromise, alter their expectations, and adjust to Anindilyakwa norms of speech and sound. Anindilyakwa-speakers did not conform to missionary spheres; they continued to use Anindilyakwa and Aboriginal Englishes in all contexts in resistance to missionaries. The settler-colonial dichotomy between civilized mission and savage camp was difficult to maintain and was constantly challenged, both by missionaries and by Anindilyakwa-speakers. As Superintendent Jim Taylor commented in 1969, “our veneer of civilisation runs very thin at times.”⁹⁷

By the 1960s, it seemed to many missionaries that Anindilyakwa-speakers simply were not listening to their message. Perhaps they were too fixed to their expectations of contestation to perceive or listen to Anindilyakwa moves toward plurality or synthesis. One missionary commented in 1969 that although Anindilyakwa men had heard the missionaries preach in English, few understood Christianity and most were not listening.

Christianity has been fully understood by very, very few of the people here . . . The notions my scripture class (of senior boys) have of God are pathetic, especially when one considers the amount of teaching they had in scripture (all in English) alone. Some staff having been here longer and seen more, would disagree, but my own impressions are that, even as I can skim a flat stone across a still, dark pool, so has our Christian teaching gone; across the surface, leaving ripples, but failing to sink in.⁹⁸

They had heard the message, more often than many English-speakers, but it had not “stayed inside their ears.” Did they have ears to hear? The situation became so dire that in 1973 a CMS official commented that “I think we need again to reassess our role, purpose and responsibilities . . . in Arnhem Land, where we have been preaching the Gospel for the past 20–60 years.”⁹⁹ Perhaps Anindilyakwa people would never listen and it was time to leave, she mused.

THE LETTER KILLS

Writing in English

The letter killeth but the spirit giveth life.

—2 Corinthians 3:6 (King James Version)

In many places where missionaries introduced the written word, Indigenous people eagerly adopted it.¹ This is just what missionaries hoped, but also just what many might expect Indigenous people to do. Western narratives of modernization would suggest that societies emerge out of orality, casting aside previous traditions when they encounter the power of literacy. Walter Ong wrote, for example, that “orality is not an ideal,” arguing that although oral societies value their traditions, when introduced to writing, they inevitably “want to achieve literacy as soon as possible.”² Similarly, social anthropologist Jack Goody claimed that writing “underpins civilization” because its permanence fosters critical thought.³ The dichotomy of orality and literacy has been used to draw a line between “modern civilizations” and “premodern societies” based on writing, implicitly preparing a script for Indigenous people to follow.

Anindilyakwa people departed from that script. Anindilyakwa people's ongoing contact with English-language documents began with the establishment of the evangelical Angurugu mission in 1943. Despite constant missionary encouragement to become literate in English, many Anindilyakwa-speakers never did so. For various reasons, they understood writing as not in their interests. Others did learn to read and write in English, expecting these skills to bring new opportunities. Yet these opportunities did not always eventuate. This chapter uncovers how Anindilyakwa people used writing in English in ways that challenged the missionary narrative, which anticipated a movement from traditionalism to "civilization" to accompany a move from orality to literacy. Those who did write in English used writing in ways missionaries did not foresee and sometimes could not accept, performing literacy in their own ways.

Anindilyakwa Encoded Images

Long before English-speakers brought their writing to Groote Eylandt, Anindilyakwa people encoded meaning in images. Senior people used message sticks to communicate from afar, often to announce a ceremony. The notches and pictures on message sticks are mnemonic devices, guaranteeing that the messenger will be able to pass on the message over a long journey. The markings on the stick also confirm the genuineness of the message and the authority of the messenger.⁴ The message stick tradition continued into the twentieth century, but in new ways for new purposes. For example, in 1951, patrol officer Gordon Sweeney reported the use of message sticks in eastern Arnhem Land as invoices. Circular markings signified the money desired, and other marks represented the groups to be paid.⁵ Message sticks were even used as love letters: John Mathew reported in 1886 that young men living near the Mary River, Queensland, sent pieces of wood with encoded carvings to girls whom they desired.⁶

Anindilyakwa people have their own artistic traditions, too. Groote Eylandters have been painting on rock for millennia. They also make bark paintings that are famous for their iconic black backgrounds and isolated figures. In Aboriginal art, levels of meaning are encoded in paintings. Everything is meaningful. Paintings are not merely representations of ancestral beings, but are actually their manifestations.⁷ Hence, signs in paintings contain and channel spiritual power, related to ceremonies and associated with particular clans and their lands.

Once someone has learned to read a language with an alphabetic script, its written texts are open to be read and interpreted.⁸ Not so for Aboriginal art. Unlike writing, Aboriginal art cannot be "read" by strangers. Even those with some knowledge of symbols and stories represented in art cannot "read" its deeper layers of meaning unless they are granted access by senior people.

The messages are secret, impossible to decode on their own, open only to those who have a legitimate right to know.

Missionaries and Their Writing

Writing was, for evangelical Protestants, the foundation of both their faith and their civilization. Protestantism has its origins in Western literary culture in the sixteenth century and the distribution of the printed Bible. Personal knowledge of Scripture was considered the avenue to truth and salvation, so Protestants took care to study the Bible closely. As Joseph Errington explains, for Protestants, “the gift of faith went with the gift of literacy.”⁹ Over the twentieth century, as evangelicals faced challenges from liberal theologies, evangelicals increasingly emphasized their biblicism over and above their more pietistic traditions. As leading evangelical theologian John Stott declared in 1977, “we evangelicals are Bible people.”¹⁰ Evangelicals were particularly devoted to the Bible, finding “all spiritual truth” within its pages.¹¹ They constantly quoted and alluded to it as they sought to lead “biblical” lives, and they honored it in nearly all their communal activities—Bible study, church, fellowship meetings—as well as in their daily private devotional practice. The Bible was, to them, supreme authority in life and faith. CMS missionaries likewise proclaimed themselves a “people of a Book, and that Book the Bible.”¹² The Thirty-Nine Articles of the Church of England confirmed in writing the doctrines of the faith in the *Book of Common Prayer*. This prayer book also taught them to pray that they might “mark, learn and inwardly digest” the Scriptures.¹³ As conservative evangelicals, CMS missionaries clung to these writings as second only to the Bible. To them, to be Christian was to read. As the CMS newsletter explained, converts could not be baptized until they could read because “every Christian should be a reader.”¹⁴

Missionaries were used to turning to books in their spiritual practice. Their practice included Quiet Time (daily private reading of Scripture and prayer), Bible Study (group discussion of biblical passages), and Sunday Services (using the prayer book, hymn book, and Bible). The missionaries’ reading and writing was not primarily about learning information (they had read the Bible many times before); rather, it was a ritual act, a participation in evangelical culture and a reaffirmation of their identity and community.¹⁵ So dependent was their community and spiritual life on reading these texts that Norma Farley commented in 1962 that she found it difficult to form friendships with Anindilyakwa people who could not read the Bible.¹⁶

The predominance of written language in their religious practice functioned as a way of collectively identifying with churches beyond the mission in space and time, as other Anglicans around the globe read the same words. Reading the Bible aloud has long been a means for families and communities

to assert identities within a Christian framework.¹⁷ When they read, they were no longer isolated but connected with their churches at home and with an international Anglican fellowship. The language of the church was not the language missionaries used in conversation, but the antiquated English of the Authorized Bible and their hymns. The language had the effect of constructing the church sphere as separate from other, more mundane activities of life. This language pointed to the church's timelessness and solemnity.

It also pointed to its Englishness. The King James Bible was, for English-speaking Christians, a "masterpiece of English literature," and the English language itself was a vessel crafted by God for the task of conveying his message in this form.¹⁸ The Bible came to the colonies as "the Englishman's book," the "landmark text in the history of the English people."¹⁹ Though the CMS missionaries gathered on Aboriginal land in North Australia, they created a small patch of English Christianity when they read the language of their Bibles and prayer book. National and Christian identities met within the pages of the King James Bible.

Writing also meant citizenship. Alan Atkinson has told the history of Australia as a history of voices and communication. For him, the spread of literacy among the non-Indigenous population in the nineteenth century was a "revolution in communications."²⁰ Though literacy did not achieve everything nineteenth-century visionaries imagined, it fundamentally reshaped white Australian society—its governance, culture, identity, even patterns of thinking—opening up new opportunities to those who could read, but aiding in the dispossession of Aboriginal people who lacked English literacy.²¹ Through the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, literacy (particularly in English) became a key marker of being "civilized."²² With the growth of democratic ideals in the nineteenth century, the perception that potential voters must be educated became ever more pressing. The citizens of a democracy had to be informed participants in debates, so literacy was an essential skill. Not only should citizens be literate, but also they had to be literate in English. English-speakers considered their language the only language fully capable of expressing the ideals of a democratic nation.²³ In the United States, for example, well into the twentieth century, illiteracy was cited as a reason to exclude African Americans from franchise. In Australia, public school reformers would fashion a "mass culture for the nation state" through achieving universal literacy; schools were creating literate citizens for the nation.²⁴

For the missionaries, writing in English reminded them of their civilization and their Christian faith. It also functioned as a way of keeping things under control, including both themselves and Aboriginal people. The most important sphere of the mission, the church, was dominated by writing. Westerners often presumed writing was reliable because the content could not change. The Bible itself concludes with condemnation of those who dare

tamper with the written record. For missionaries, written language enforced the authority of their message and guarded against deviations from it. The written text, even when read aloud, is alienated from the speaker. It is not the speaker's own words; the speaker becomes merely a "vessel" of a disembodied message. The message's origin beyond the speaker transmitted through a book was evidence to missionaries of its timelessness and hinted at its divine origins.

Writing was a tool of self-regulation. It held the missionaries to Christian orthodoxy and civil behavior. By limiting the church service to readings, missionaries ensured that its content was authorized. They attributed great powers to writing. It was potentially dangerous, potentially corrupting. The staff minutes at Angurugu record in 1955 that after "lengthy discussion" on "the *Golden Bells* hymn book as to its suitability," the staff would consider "the merits of a nother suggested hymn book, *The Church Hymnal for the Christian Year*." They decided not to distribute this new one until it had been "studied."²⁵ Given the power they attributed to the written word, the missionaries scrutinized texts, especially those to be admitted into their church sphere. Though fiction was in high demand among missionaries, they took very seriously the matter of which books the CMS office sent up for them. In 1960 one missionary commented that "we need some form of relaxation." Bishop Clive Kerle suggested "lighter reading be sent up." Montgomerie, the Aborigines Secretary, said he had done so but "they were not able to censor them in the office before sending them North" and other missionaries who had received such books regarded them as "only fit to be burned."²⁶ Missionaries insisted that their own reading be censored, perhaps as a demonstration of their own suitability for the mission field, perhaps for their own spiritual edification, or perhaps as an example to Aboriginal people whose reading would also be censored. If no suitable material could be found, they could always read more of the Bible.

When the missionaries were not reading, they might be writing. They often spent Saturdays attending to correspondence and writing reports. Their writing, they believed, pointed to their authority, their self-discipline, and their civilization, as well as to the significance of their work (which would, they believed, be of interest to future generations). The CMS missionaries wrote almost everything down. Their records extend from formal reports to more trivial items such as the minutes of the Angurugu table-tennis club and social club. Each missionary diligently wrote monthly reports for the Aborigines Committee in Sydney. They kept statistics on school attendance and grades; pawpaw, banana, pineapple, and peanut production; injuries and hospital treatments; births, deaths, and marriages. They also wrote regular prayer circulars to their local CMS branches with news and "prayer and praise points." Superintendents kept a daily journal, as well as preparing bi-annual and annual reports.

The CMS bureaucracy in Sydney lived on written reporting. The movements of paper from the missions enabled centralized control from the Sydney headquarters. Through insisting on regular updates, statistics, and reports, Montgomerie gained intimate knowledge of Angurugu. David Woodbridge remembered that the Aborigines Committee was “really hands on” and that Montgomerie “was the one who drove it, he was the boss.”²⁷ Missionaries demonstrated their loyalty by taking care to report to him. He scolded them for making decisions without deferring to him or for neglecting to provide him with regular updates. In January 1950, for example, a whooping cough epidemic caused such chaos among staff that they overlooked reporting to Montgomerie. His first concern, it seems, was not the sixteen Aboriginal deaths, but the fact that he had not been informed.²⁸ Written reporting allowed the mission to be structured in a carefully managed hierarchy, top down, from the Aborigines Secretary Montgomerie to superintendents, missionaries, and, at the bottom, Aboriginal people.

Government bureaucracies demanded written records, too. The missionaries dutifully provided regular lists of names of the dormitory “inmates” and mission residents in return for financial support. Paul Hasluck, the minister for territories, devised the Welfare Ordinance of 1953, which required a full list of “wards,” such that nearly all the Aboriginal people in the Northern Territory were registered. The Mission Roll was constantly in need of attention. The mission depended financially on child endowment payments, which it managed on behalf of Anindilyakwa mothers. Accurate records of the numbers of eligible children were imperative. (Of course, this “management” system also worked to minimize Aboriginal autonomy, as Aboriginal mothers had little opportunity to ensure they received value for their money or to consent to expenditure decisions made on their behalf.) As occurred at many missions and reserves in various parts of the world, non-English-speakers found that the use of English-language documents monitored nearly all aspects of their lives.

Missionaries and governments trusted in writing to keep things under control, but it often proved an ineffective instrument. Rather than delivering on the promise of clarity and decisiveness, English-language records often proved to be a source of confusion and contention. Thus, the number of children at Angurugu was often in doubt, since many were under the care of their aunties or “other mothers” (according to Anindilyakwa family norms), making miscounts highly likely. Missionary and government systems for recording family relationships, which presumed Western biological conceptions of family, motherhood, and fatherhood, proved inadequate. Anindilyakwa family life, where children have numerous “mothers” and “aunties” and “uncles” who share the responsibilities to “grow them up,” could not easily be reduced into the schema for child endowment payments. The missionary and government frameworks were the wrong size and shape.

There were further problems with roll books. In 1958 the chaplain complained about “adamant ‘linguists’” who adopted the “that’s what I think it is” method to spelling Aboriginal names.²⁹ The lack of standardized spelling for Aboriginal names was a recurring dilemma. One missionary explained her approach to spelling names for census lists in 1968:

I think that names should be written in such a form that the ordinary Australian can pronounce them reasonably correctly . . . So I am including alternative names as pronounced, as nearly as I can, though sorely perplexed where the pronunciation varies with the individual aborigine when it comes to vowels (just as it does amongst us!).³⁰

The missionary records proved unable to contain the reality of Anindilyakwa lives. Aboriginal people were, to her, still not “ordinary Australians” until their lives conformed to her European systems of knowledge and recordkeeping. Her attempt to present people as “ordinary Australians” was an attempt to present Aboriginal people as citizens, if only on paper. But missionaries’ reports and spellings could not convey the reality of Anindilyakwa life. That they could not agree on spellings for names and that the Anindilyakwa vowels just would not fit into the Roman alphabet, indicates that their faith in writing to convey reality was misplaced. Writing proved to be ambiguous, inadequate, and particular to the missionary culture, rather than a universal authority on the world. Rather than ordering Aboriginal lives according to missionary expectations, attempts at representing them in writing only exposed to missionaries how Aboriginal people continued to uphold their own systems of family life and naming.

Not only did writing fail missionaries as an instrument of control, but also they found it was easily turned against them. While they imagined that their frequent correspondence and comprehensive bureaucracy would lead toward efficiency and unity, instead, writing became a source of division and disappointment. Letter writing was missionaries’ primary means of communication beyond the island (only the superintendent had unfettered access to radio). Missionary work was more than a job; most saw it as their life’s work, their passion and vocation. There was also the added pressure from their families and home churches (which had donated funds and prayed for the cause) that they would succeed in the field. A government official explained in 1949 that missionaries’ “living standard is not just mere frugality but abject poverty, unable to save they have no sense of security, complete frustration resulting in the number of cases of nervous disorder.”³¹ In this situation, letters became an avenue to vent their frustration and strengthen their position, sometimes at others’ expense. The possibilities of writing, far from directing missionaries toward Christian civil behavior, meant that it could

become an outlet for unchristian, uncivil criticism. We saw in chapter 3 how missionaries wrote letters to CMS officials in 1958 regarding the anxiety experienced by their colleague, missionary nurse Joy Pascoe. Hers was not an isolated case. The majority of letters were penned in a tumultuous period in the late 1950s. They were cutting:

Many's the time they have both floored us with their rudeness and contempt for work. . . . Often [she] turns up her nose at the midday meal—hates dugong and turtle and general attitude is sickening for one supposed to be a Christian. She wants to be placed in a famine area for a while she might appreciate the good food God gives. . . . We've sacrificed all—time, money, enjoyment, the lot for God and this work. I've yet to see these others here do the same.³²

At times [she] has no control over her temper, and is tactless to a point beyond nastiness when in a temper, that it is impossible to keep the staff united while [she] is here.³³

Aware of each other's criticism, missionaries wrote counterattacks and even preemptive strikes to protect themselves and their own.

We feel very upset to hear that you have received unfavourable reports and criticisms of Kevin by letter. We don't know the details of the criticism, but we want you to realise that, even if another member of the staff has been critical, we think very highly of Kevin and of his leadership.³⁴

But paper could be intercepted. One missionary had the misfortune of “discovering” another missionary's letter complaining about his leadership. He sent a retaliatory letter:

I have just been going thru my office mail envelope and came to a letter, . . . and thinking it to be a monthly report read it and I'm amazed at some of the content. . . . If there are complaints . . . they are magnified faults and don't take into account their own which I have not attempted to mention to you.³⁵

Writing is disembodied, disconnected from the original author, and can take on a life of its own. Recontextualized and reinterpreted without reference to the author's intention, writing is risky. In 1960, when the newly arrived twenty-eight-year-old chaplain, Jim Taylor, was appointed acting superintendent over the older and more experienced Arthur Howell (Howell was appointed works supervisor), Howell and Taylor disagreed on the divi-

sion of their responsibilities, and consequently Angurugu was in disarray. A poorly written letter from Dick Harris was the source of the confusion. Taylor read it as simply “a pep talk” to Howell, but Howell believed it gave him “oversight over all the mission.”³⁶ Both Taylor and Howell appealed to the letter to justify themselves. The episode was extremely disruptive and led to Howell’s resignation.

The appointment made many Anindilyakwa people angry. Though Taylor came to be respected in Angurugu, at first, many thought he was too young to be their “boss.” They had an existing working relationship with Howell, but Taylor was unknown. To Anindilyakwa people, it seemed that writing encouraged self-interested interpretations. Writing, it seemed, fostered dishonesty, as its disconnectedness from the speaker meant it could be twisted to suit personal needs. Hokari recounted how Old Jimmy, a Gurindji elder, complained that “paper”—European laws and letters—could be changed, reinterpreted, thrown away. His Aboriginal law was in the earth, which “never change . . . (law) still there.”³⁷ Old Jimmy’s word challenges Goody’s thesis of the permanence and subsequent superiority of written literacies. While writing is “just paper”—subject to editing, reinterpretation, damage, or loss—Aboriginal oral traditions have a solid foundation, in the land.³⁸ Though writing was, to missionaries, a symbol of their control over Anindilyakwa people, to Anindilyakwa people, missionary literacy could also seem an unreliable and weak instrument, in many ways inferior to their existing oralities.

English Literacy and Australian Citizenship

Despite these weaknesses apparent in writing at the mission, policy makers and missionaries alike considered English literacy essential for Australian citizenship in the mid-twentieth century. The director of the Commonwealth Office of Education, R. C. Mills, wrote in 1949 that reading was a necessary skill for Aboriginal children if they were to become fully functioning citizens and participants in modernity. They must be equipped for “newspapers, public notices and documents with which they will have to cope” in order to participate in national discussions.³⁹ Methodist missionary Arthur Ellemor wrote in 1956 that “full citizenship” of Aboriginal people depended on literacy, in order to be “meaningful.”⁴⁰ Likewise, Montgomerie wrote in 1958 that Aboriginal people could not function as citizens without English literacy; “they cannot vote at an election for parliament because they cannot read or write.”⁴¹ Establishing English literacy among Anindilyakwa-speakers, therefore, was a core mission objective. So fundamental was literacy to citizenship that many missionaries did not consider illiterate Anindilyakwa people as functioning citizens, even after citizenship rights were formally granted. For example, when one was asked about the implications of full citizenship

for Aboriginal people, she referred to the 1967 referendum, commenting that although the constitutional change was necessary, including Aboriginal people in the census burdened literate missionaries.⁴²

At first, in the early years of the school, Anindilyakwa people were anxious for their children to learn to write in English. Harris reported in 1945 that on his wife's arrival at Angurugu, people immediately asked, "Are the children having school to-day?" which he interpreted as due to their being "anxious that their children learn to read and write."⁴³ Some parents resisted sending their children to school, though even these children eventually made it onto the school roll. In the 1940s, children learned to read by reading the Bible. Gumbuli Wurramara explained: "Before anything else. Before I could read. Read Bible and Psalms." This suggests that the children were memorizing rather than reading.⁴⁴ By 1952, teachers reported using the "word, sentence, look and say method" of teaching reading and focused on writing words on the blackboard for younger children. The children worked through the First Australian's First Readers series, produced by the Presbyterian Church for Aboriginal mission schools. The series aimed to introduce Aboriginal children to books, and the phrase "First Australian" in the series title reflects the expectation that, through English literacy, the children would realize their status as Australian citizens without losing an Aboriginal identity. The cover image depicted children writing in the dirt, sitting on the ground. It mingled Aboriginal storytelling techniques that use markings in the sand with the new skill of English literacy: an attempt at cultural sensitivity. These books proved very popular, and the CMS teachers even produced their own sequel, illustrated by Gula Lalara. The Commonwealth English syllabus for Aboriginal schools in the Northern Territory, devised in 1950, consisted of the Bush Book series, produced by the Commonwealth Office of Education. These taught assimilationist messages—education and employment—and included *Nari and Minala Go to School*, followed by *Nari and Minala Go to Work*. The plots revolved around learning Western hygiene and work habits, and the children's awe at city living.⁴⁵ In 1953, the Angurugu teachers introduced these Bush Books into the school.

Not only would the children read, they would learn to write as well. In the 1950s, the CMS school aimed for children "to write simple English correctly, with special regard to letter writing."⁴⁶ Nancy Lalara, who attended the Angurugu School in the 1950s, recalled how the school operated with few resources:

We learned without no books, no crayons, no pencils, just with chalk and blackboards and dusters. That's how we learnt to write our sentences that they wrote up there. And we wrote our own stories. We were writing them on the blackboard.⁴⁷

In 1952, teachers gave the older children books for writing English words and definitions, like a personal dictionary. Children also copied Bible verses and decorated them with drawings. Teachers drilled the children in dictation that, according to teachers, was “much enjoyed.”⁴⁸ Nancy Lalara developed a love of reading: “I used to like reading Enid Blyton books, climb up on the mango tree, get away from my little sisters’ hassling.”⁴⁹ Rhoda Lalara (one of Nancy’s younger sisters) also told how she loved going to school and writing stories:

Only the time that I missed out on going to school was when I was sick. . . . I really wanted to learn more. I did a lot of exercises like doing arithmetic, writing stories. On the weekend when we used to go out and came back to school on the Monday “Can you write a story about what you used to do on the weekend?” and we used to do it.⁵⁰

The children were good at it. In 1966, after a school excursion to Darwin, Angurugu school principal Ted Egan reported that “Darwin people expressed amazement at the standard of letter writing (‘I only wish my kids could write as well as that’ was heard many times) achieved by the Groote Eylandt children.”⁵¹ The children’s writing was a visual performance, producing tangible evidence of their progress toward citizenship. Janet Farnell taught at Angurugu in the early 1970s, after it became a government school. She was in awe of the standard of writing of children schooled during the mission period. “You should see their books . . . You look at them and go, ‘oh my god!’ The books were so beautifully ruled up, the handwriting: perfect.” Such was the missionary emphasis on writing well.⁵²

Missionaries set their sights on adults, too. They hoped to socialize adult Anindilyakwa people into a culture of English literacy. From the earliest days of the mission, Harris used “mail boys,” men who walked across the island to exchange letters with Umbakumba and the RAAF base. In 1945, as his wife, Nell, was teaching their son to read, she also taught her “house girl,” Gudjiba. Eventually she loaned her a book, and the girl “brought it back eventually, very dirty, but could read it all.” Her husband, Gula Lalara, “is a reader and helps her,” she wrote. Gudjiba’s eagerness convinced her of the need for more reading material. “I have never allowed natives to take away Primers to their camp or hut before, but I believe the children, who are really anxious to read, would learn much from these primers if we had them to give.”⁵³ The virtue of reading, for missionaries, surpassed other concerns about regulating mission space and of dirtiness and civilized cleanliness. A book was better read than clean. Later, missionaries combined Christian instruction with literacy lessons, gathering women together to read Bible passages



Angurugu schoolchildren (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

aloud in turn.⁵⁴ In 1952, Gulpia was the first adult to begin formal reading lessons.

After they had established the school, the missionaries encouraged adults to become teaching assistants to help manage the classroom, but also to improve their English literacy. Some Anindilyakwa people took up positions. The teaching assistant Danabana was encouraged to use a writing book to practice writing. Danabana also read storybooks to the girls in the mornings, and Nabilya read for the boys.⁵⁵ Yet the system of encouraging adults to practice reading and writing through employing them as teaching assistants was short-lived. When the senior education officer of the Commonwealth Office for Education visited Angurugu in September 1952, he recommended “very limited use of Aborigines as teachers in the school” because it apparently compromised children’s ability to learn English.⁵⁶ By January 1953, only three Anindilyakwa teaching assistants remained in the school: Wudjari, Gula, and Nabilya.

Missionaries inserted writing into everyday work tasks, drawing Anindilyakwa people into their culture of documenting mission life. They encouraged Anindilyakwa people to make records at work and to write letters, diaries, and reports. In 1963, for example, the missionary builder, R. B. Dent, praised his worker, Ken, who asked to copy names into the pay book. “I found

myself a little amused at his earnestness when he said how much he enjoyed 'thinking'—and he wanted to get some more practice!!!!"⁵⁷

For Ken, the mental challenge of writing was a new puzzle he enjoyed. In 1965, Dent encouraged Nandjiwarra to "keep a daily diary and write monthly reports." Spelling was to Nandjiwarra a "heavy job," yet he usually persisted.⁵⁸ From September 1965, Nandjiwarra was welfare officer of the island and wrote monthly reports for the Aborigines Committee. In encouraging Anindilyakwa people to use writing as part of their daily work, missionaries hoped to extend modernity into Anindilyakwa lives through their practices of literacy. The possibility of scrutinizing a written record, they believed, would encourage people to work harder or to make modernizing adjustments to increase efficiency. They hoped that Anindilyakwa people would learn to attribute authority to the written word and value written records as objective accounts.

Anindilyakwa Uses of English Literacy

English literacy was valuable; many Anindilyakwa people embraced the values missionaries attached to writing. Numerous parents saw benefits in literacy. Some sent their children to continue their education in English in Alyangula, the mining town. Some even wanted their children to go to Adelaide for higher education and then return to Angurugu. Lauchlan McIntosh, a BHP engineer, remembered men telling him in the late 1960s that they wanted their children to go to Adelaide for school and "come back with a good education like you have."⁵⁹ Eagerness for children to become literate in English did not necessarily represent submission to a missionary or Commonwealth government agenda. Learning to write had many benefits. Writing could be an embrace of modernity: new skills and new opportunities. Some used letter writing to communicate with family who were away in Darwin.⁶⁰ The ability to adjust to such linguistic change was rooted in rich multilingual traditions that predated European contact. Moreover, people across North Australia had long used encoded objects, such as the message stick, to announce ceremonies. In light of many Anindilyakwa-speakers' familiarity with cross-cultural communication, fluency in other languages (Wubuy, Yolŋu Matha, Kriol, Malay Pigin), and experience with written texts via the Makassans, it is little wonder many were ready to experiment with new modes of communication.

For others, writing gave them a new advantage in negotiating their interests. In 1973, Jambana Lalara "mentioned the desire to be able to read and write more" as he was increasingly required to negotiate with Broken Hill Proprietary, Ltd. (BHP; a mining company that began operations on the island in 1963) and government officials.⁶¹ Martin Nakata sheds further light on the potential value of English literacies for Indigenous peoples. For him,

calls for English literacy were about “working out what the language of ‘white’ people and their institutions do that keeps us at a disadvantage.”⁶² Indigenous practices of English literacies would enable his people to “appropriate a better position for ourselves—to cut better deals for ourselves and our traditional heritage.”⁶³ Although certain methods of introducing literacy—particularly the separation of children and school systems—have been used to eradicate Indigenous language and culture, English literacies have also presented opportunities to Indigenous people. English literacies could be a route to survival and greater independence rather than assimilation; Jambana, for example, recognized this potential.

The missionary expectation was that conversion and civic behavior would quickly follow English literacy. They did not. Instead, literacy unexpectedly empowered some Anindilyakwa people to ultimately reject missionary ideals. Nancy Lalara was a gifted teacher and keen reader. She told of how her high opinion of missionaries changed in the late 1960s as she read widely. She was “really into Christianity” in her youth.⁶⁴ By reading, she discovered Christian history and concluded that, contrary to what missionaries had taught her, Anglicans were no better than Catholics or Methodists. She began to understand the history and structure of settler-colonization in Australia and to question the missionary project and Australia’s involvement in wars. Her education enabled her to judge the missionaries’ sacred text in light of her own experience and broader knowledge. I asked what changed for her. She replied:

Just getting older and reading, thinking. Reading about what happened to my people in all of them days and about those wars around the world, how someone can go and destroy someone else’s country just because you hate that country. We do that amongst ourselves. I changed. I changed because of the way that when things, looking at it in the Bible version of the way that everything was pure. . . . But the more that I grew up with that way, that wasn’t a better life. Reading the Bible twenty times a day, saying thank you for our food when we had it on the table. Other things, reality, sort of crept into me about “that wasn’t like that in the Bible,” “how come it’s like this?”⁶⁵

Literacy alone could not transform Anindilyakwa people like Nancy into the Christian citizens envisaged by missionaries. It could actually turn people away from the faith.

Others did not reject the missionary faith, but found a route to challenge missionary behavior in English literacy. Since missionaries appealed to the higher authority of the text, literate Anindilyakwa people could appeal to missionaries’ own texts as a shared moral framework. For many Indigenous

people, the Bible has provided a religious foundation and ideology for the politics of reform and an inspiration for narratives of salvation.⁶⁶ In 1969 Nandjiwarra Amagula addressed the CMS summer school conference and used literacy—his reading of the biblical commandments—against the CMS:

We have missionaries working among us, teaching the Gospel and helping us live a better life. Teaching us the Gospel, teaching us Ten Commandments. Thou shalt not commit adultery, thou shalt not steal. Lots of our missionaries been working up north never been doing the right thing with the people. They are preaching the Gospel saying “repent of your sins” but those missionaries are doing the wrong thing themselves behind aborigines’ back. Themselves who was running around with aborigine women taking them off in the darkness.⁶⁷

Nandjiwarra’s comments were picked up by the national news, despite CMS attempts to suppress the story. For missionaries, literacy was so bound up in their visions of Christianity and civilization that when it was used in ways that contradicted their work, they were puzzled or angered. Missionaries rejected Aboriginal writing, even punishing writers whose work did not conform to their hopes. At Angurugu, dormitory girls used writing to contact their promised husbands or sweethearts, undermining missionary attempts to abolish child marriage and polygyny. In 1961 the punishment for a dormitory girl discovered “writing letters or giving presents” to a young man was “the strap” and to be “made to go back to the village.”⁶⁸ The girls embraced English literacies, but used writing to undermine the very citizenly behaviors that missionaries hoped it would instill. Men discovered writing “sweetheart talk” letters faced exile from the island. Unfortunately for one man in 1961, his “sweetheart” rejected his advances and handed his love letter over to the missionaries. He was subsequently banished from the island and then (for other reasons) imprisoned in Darwin. But the rumor circulated on Groote Eylandt that, in his brother’s words, he “been sent away by counsel for two years punishmen hes in ploce station now [*sic*]” simply because of “one letter he write a letter . . . no other thing just for one letter [*sic*].”⁶⁹ Although this was not entirely the case, Anindilyakwa people came to believe that unauthorized letter writing was a terrible offense to the missionaries. Despite this belief, the “sweetheart” letters continued to be written; Anindilyakwa people insisted on using writing for their own purposes as an act of resistance. Missionaries were uneasy with these unexpected consequences of Anindilyakwa literacies that they had sought to foster.

English literacy could also be used against missionaries through petitioning, turning English documents against the authorities. Through writing, Indigenous people could get their complaints on the record of board

minutes, making them harder to ignore. Written documents were an opportunity for Indigenous voices to infiltrate the archives (although the preservation of their writing was by no means guaranteed). In 1960, some Anindilyakwa people wrote letters petitioning the Secretary for Aborigines to uninstall the new superintendent, Jim Taylor, and give the superintendency responsibilities to Arthur Howell. Here are two of their letters:

Dear Mr Montgomery. Just a few words from us and to you saying that all the people doesnt want Mr Taylor becuase we have find out that he is no good. All ready we dont wont him to be our boss put somebody as man please not young boy please. A lik mr Harris and Mr Howell a big man got lots of under-standing and knows for people more about this place.

So I am tell to do something for us pleas if you dont well he is looking for a belting from the peopl here in this mission . . .

Every body wants mr Howell when we had a meet last month because he is the only older man here in this mission and he knows more lots then other so wee all wont him and Mr Taylor can be our minister but we don't want him to be the boss he macks it to hard for the people and macks lots of mistak too and that what people don't want we want a good mission not rubbish please so thse will be more letters asking for your helpe.

May God bless and keep you all ways and tell wee meet in haven
Letter from all the people
At Groote Eylandt⁷⁰

Dear Sir

October 19.60

Just are few lines to let you know that all the people here doesnt want Mr Taylor to be boss here at Groote. We all want Mr Howell to be the boss here. We want Mr Taylor for the Church only and not be the boss. So will you please do something about it please Sir.

When he became the boss here he began to change things aroun. And people doesnt like the way he doing things here.

So pleases Sir, will you make Mr Howell be our boss here please Sir.

Im writing this letter, for the sake of the people here at Groote Mission.

Ill close at that for now Sir.

May our God bless you all there in your office.

From all the people at Groote⁷¹

In writing petitions like these, Anindilyakwa-speakers performed the role of the modern "literate citizens" the CMS was training them to become. They positioned themselves within a shared moral order with the missionar-

ies such that their claims could be considered legitimate.⁷² Anindilyakwa people, for example, acknowledged their mutual interest in the quality of the mission—"we want a good mission not rubbish please"—and the legitimacy of the office of superintendent. They implicitly acknowledged writing as the appropriate means to appeal decisions. In fact, they did so in direct imitation of missionaries. Only a year previously, missionaries had circulated a petition "signed by all the single women on staff" calling for Montgomerie to retain the previous superintendent.⁷³ Through petitioning, Anindilyakwa-speakers, like missionaries, participated in the literate, English-speaking culture of white Australia.

Yet, unsurprisingly, the CMS did not welcome these petitions as evidence of "progress" toward Christian citizenship. Instead, the CMS Aborigines Committee doubted their authenticity. They consulted their most experienced missionary, Harris, regarding the letters. It was inconceivable to Harris that Anindilyakwa-speakers would so boldly threaten violence. This objection is questionable, since Anindilyakwa people had used violence against missionaries on numerous past occasions, including against superintendents. Harris inferred that Howell prompted the letters: "Arthur's conduct is not Christian and is not 'cricket.'" His reason for concluding that the letters were concocted or encouraged by Howell was that they were anonymous. "I myself received letters from the men at Groote but these were signed by Nandjiwarra, Nandua and The Single Men."⁷⁴ Perhaps, in this instance, anonymity was intended to disguise the gender or kinship ties of the petitioners. Nonetheless, since the baptized young men (whom the missionaries had long entrusted with leadership positions) had signed letters by name in the past, Harris's assumption was that all members of the Angurugu community would be willing and able to do likewise.

Silencing Indigenous claims by questioning their authorship has been a common strategy of paternalistic authorities.⁷⁵ Some activists, such as Arthur Fernando, were dismissed as not really Aboriginal.⁷⁶ Others were brushed aside on claims that Aboriginal people could never understand what it was they signed.⁷⁷ The CMS had not always discounted Aboriginal petitions. In 1934 a "splendidly emphatically worded petition from the black and half-caste people at the Roper Station, numbering in all nearly 200" calling for the mission to remain open was warmly received. The role of missionaries in eliciting those signatures went unquestioned, but, of course, such a request was exactly what the CMS hoped Aboriginal people would come to desire.⁷⁸ In this case it is not clear whether or how Howell was involved in the petitions from Anindilyakwa people, but for the CMS, the question was, how could a Christian mission have produced these unorthodox and subversive letters? How could "civilized" writers threaten such violence? Missionaries were uncomfortable with the Anindilyakwa cultures of modernity and literacies developing on Groote Eylandt. Though

the CMS hoped to create writers, only a particular kind of writing was welcomed or expected.

The Anindilyakwa petitions also stand in stark contrast to the famous Yolngu Bark Petition, written only three years later, in 1963. When mining interests encroached on their land and missionaries failed to prevent them, the Yolngu people of the nearby Yirrkala Methodist Overseas Mission petitioned the federal government, presenting their demands to land rights in their own language (with English translation) on bark, surrounded by paintings of their Creative Beings. While recognizing the authority of governments and churches, the Yolngu positioned themselves as another authority whose voice deserved to be heard.⁷⁹ They wrote first in their Yolngu Matha language and condescended to provide an English translation. In contrast, the Anindilyakwa authors were submissive (apart from the threat of “belting”) and did not overtly assert their cultural knowledge (though their request upheld the Anindilyakwa culture of respect for older people). Part of this difference can be put down to the differing approaches of missionary societies, and particularly the strong paternalism of the CMS. Anindilyakwa people may have considered it useless, even counterproductive, to assert their knowledge or authority to the CMS’s Aborigines Committee.

The rejection of their letters could only prove to Anindilyakwa people that they were not welcome in the English-speakers’ literary culture. The culture of literacy and writing the missionaries offered did not deliver the benefits it promised. When they participated as modern citizens and submitted their opinions on matters that concerned them, their writing was questioned and rejected as inauthentic. Oral communication cannot have its authorship rejected and be dismissed in this way. To some Anindilyakwa people it would have seemed that learning to read and write would never be rewarded unless they fully embraced the missionary culture to the same extent as the “single men,” that is, the younger generation who formed alliances with missionaries. They would need to adopt not only English literacy but also the broader culture and practices of the missionaries’ literacy. Many were not willing to do so.

There was not much on the island worth reading, anyway. Just as the missionaries experienced a scarcity of reading material, Anindilyakwa-speakers were similarly restricted. Fred Gray observed in the 1930s that literacy did not interest many Anindilyakwa people. It was pointless.

The aboriginal is a dud as far as [reading] is concerned. You see he can’t see that it is useful. After all being able to read Melbourne newspapers won’t help him to catch his bandicoot, nor will it appear his fish for him.⁸⁰

When, in 1960, the acting head teacher at Angurugu ran adult education reading classes, he discovered that “those interested are small in num-

ber.” He averaged twelve pupils. The lack of interest, in his mind, was due to a lack of appropriate literature at an adult level.⁸¹ “Why learn English when there’s nothing to read?” questioned the CMS in 1963; they were aware of the lack of suitable material. Their solution was to produce religious material in simple English. Secular reading was scarcer still. As late as the 1970s, there was “no news” available on the island apart from the *Northern Territory News*, which came “two or three days late.”⁸² Naturally, in this context, Hollywood films proved a more attractive entertainment to many than reading. The English literature available on Groote Eylandt largely did not speak to Anindilyakwa interests or aspirations.

So people were not always concerned to learn to read. The schoolteachers reported that their adult Bible reading classes included only “those who can already read, those unable to read not wishing to learn.”⁸³ Some showed an interest in literate religion, but did not, or could not, conform to missionaries’ expectations. Farley noted that “quite a number of Aborigines, mostly women,” purchased personal Bible study materials, but she found in 1972 that “only very few seem to read them.” “Very few of the Aborigines Christians [*sic*] here have persevered with the S.U. [Scripture Union] notes,” Farley commented the following year, so she focused on individuals, “helping” Danabana read the notes daily “where there is an interest”; she expected interest to wane.⁸⁴ Buying the materials impressed the missionaries, but the women still did not practice literate evangelical Christianity as missionaries hoped. Despite constant missionary efforts to encourage reading, as late as the 1980s Judith Stokes complained that “reading is still not a normal Aboriginal occupation!”⁸⁵

Meanwhile, Anindilyakwa people developed new and specifically Anindilyakwa cultures of literacy. English literacy might have been problematic for its associations with colonizing control, Christianity, and “civilization” (and a corresponding diminution of Anindilyakwa identity), but this did not make it completely useless in their own cultural frameworks. Oral and literate cultures need not be mutually exclusive but can coexist and interact. By the 1970s, Anindilyakwa parents were eager for Stokes to “write down the Aboriginal name” and its meaning for their babies.⁸⁶ Parents were concerned that names be written down “correctly” and thus in some respects adopted the missionaries’ belief that writing could accurately convey reality. But the Anindilyakwa parents used the missionaries’ recordkeeping culture to uphold their own oral practices around naming. It is rare for Anindilyakwa people to use each other’s names in conversation, especially their most important names (people have many names, some secret). Anindilyakwa names come from their clan songs. Names are attributes of Creative Beings, associated with particular places of the Being’s journey along its songline. Names, therefore, have spiritual implications, linking individuals to country, to kin, and to their songs. Names are so important and carry such spiritual

power that to speak them lightly is disrespectful. In some relationships, such as brother and sister, speaking each other's names is prohibited. Names of deceased people are also taboo for extended periods of time. Generally, Anindilyakwa people prefer to use kinship terms or nicknames or to speak of "that old fella" or "her mother." By recording names in Stokes's book, Anindilyakwa people could uphold their own oral practices around naming (or not naming), while also ensuring that the names were kept safe.

So Anindilyakwa people used writing in the context of their own epistemologies. In 1969, when anthropologist David Turner set out to do field work on the island, missionaries were wary. But Nandjiwarra Amagula ensured that Turner could stay in Angurugu because he wanted Turner to "write their Bible."⁸⁷ Anindilyakwa people were willing to use writing as a form of validation, if done in the right way, by the right person. The book or "Bible" Turner produced from his research recorded various clan territories and songlines in print and, inadvertently, played into an ongoing Anindilyakwa territorial dispute. When Turner returned to the island years later, he found that Warnaya had used the book to justify his claim to land, saying that Turner "asked the old people and wrote it down." Anindilyakwa-speakers appealed to the written word as an authoritative record of what the old people had said. Yet this is not to say that Anindilyakwa-speakers gave writing the same authority that English-speakers did or that alternative knowledge systems were abolished. Existing methods of resolving disputes were disrupted, but not overturned. According to Anindilyakwa methods of interpretation, writing was contestable. Turner noted that if his book had not suited Wanaiya's claim, the remark would be simply "what could a white man know about our ways?"⁸⁸ Contrary to Goody's thesis regarding the permanence of writing and thus its effect on cognition, Anindilyakwa people here integrated literacies into their existing cultures.⁸⁹ Writing complemented orality by providing access to the words of the old people who had passed away, but it did not replace oral systems of knowledge or authority.

Books became meaningful objects, even for Anindilyakwa people who did not embrace the English literary culture of the missionaries. Although writing may not have proved a meaningful site of cross-cultural engagement, the book as a ritual and symbolic object could communicate shared meanings. Although missionaries believed that their faith and practice rested on the written word, theirs was not as entirely literate a culture as they believed.⁹⁰ As Alan Atkinson has shown, even in "literate" society, patterns of orality exist. For evangelicals, the Bible was used in nonliterate, symbolic ways—not as text but as object—to affirm a Christian identity. Placing a hand on a Bible confirmed the solemnity of an oath. The tradition of keeping a family Bible, with names and significant dates inscribed in the inside, pointed to a faith in family unity and continuity within a Christian framework; it was a tangible symbol of faith in divine providence across generations. Even the feel of the

fine paper pages or elaborate lettering pointed to the family Bible's elevated status.⁹¹ The book, in Christian tradition, is also a symbol of God's omniscience, of authority, of truth, of judgment, and of finality. The punishment for sin was to be "blotted out" of God's book, and, on the "last day," the "books shall be opened."⁹²

Anindilyakwa people observed these symbolic meanings of books from a young age. For example, Farley used the threat of writing down names to discipline children:

[I] said, "Be quiet or I'll write your names in my book" and I wondered "what will I do then?" Names would not go in my book for nothing! So I said, "you know what will happen if I write your names in my book don't you?" and they said "yes," and were quiet. The threat of the book was all that was needed.⁹³

The threat functioned because the book was a shared symbol of authority, finality, even judgment and threat of punishment. Farley could only use the book to silence Aboriginal voices because of a shared understanding of the symbolic meaning of books. Writing was also used in this way against adults. One missionary suggested "that the names of people with dirty houses be written on the notice board." For him, writing would be an instrument of public humiliation and shaming. Another missionary objected, saying she "felt it was a negative attitude." The council compromised; the names of the people with the dirtiest and cleanest houses would be publicly displayed.⁹⁴ Shaming in writing could work to exercise authority over Anindilyakwa people who understood its meaning.

At the same time, Anindilyakwa used books to assert their own authority. Observing how the presence of books (hymn books or prayer books) was necessary for missionaries' ceremonial life to be valid, they used the missionaries' own symbolic object to negotiate with them. Nangwarra, for example, used the Bible as a symbolic object to reconcile himself to the missionaries in 1959. When speaking to the superintendent about "his past life," Nangwarra placed his Bible between himself and the superintendent. The missionaries interpreted this symbolic gesture as Nangwarra's suggestion that "God was his witness and that he had put the trouble out of his life."⁹⁵ Likewise, at Umbakumba mission in 1965, though the children could not read, they asked for hymn books at evening prayer. "In walked Simon (age 6) by himself," wrote Farley, "and said in perfect English, 'Please may I have a paper (hymn-book)?"⁹⁶ Farley was delighted. She overlooked that in the boy's "perfect English," he had called the hymn book "a paper." His desire for paper objects was sufficient to please her.

Other Aboriginal peoples observed the missionaries' ritual book and used the book of the missionaries' literate religion in their own oral ways. For

example, some Yolngu people used the Bible as a ritual object in ways unlike those of the missionaries. Many believed that the presence of a Bible (for example, sleeping with a Bible under a pillow in hospital) could produce physical healing. They explained that God's power emanates from the Bible in the same way the power of the ancestors emanates from ritual objects or paintings.⁹⁷ On Groote Eylandt, Farley also reported an old woman who treated her Bible as a sacred object. "She can't read and understands only a little English, but the Bible is very precious to her." Farley interpreted the woman's attachment to the book as the woman's way of reminding herself "of a strong God whom she loves and trusts."⁹⁸ But perhaps this woman believed the Bible was a powerful object that might protect her. By protecting her Bible, the old woman also communicated to Farley a respect for the missionaries' spirituality according to oral practices and symbols, even if she did not participate in the same literary culture or mode of Christianity Farley sought to propagate.

Sometimes the missionaries experimented by allowing Anindilyakwa speakers to speak in the church, cut loose from the controlling guidance of writing. But, to their surprise, some Aboriginal people rejected these moves. At Roper River, for example, James Japanma, though he was nearly blind and had memorized the text, felt it was important to hold the prayer book when evangelizing. As missionary Perce Leske remembered:

James was a very good lay preacher, knew just about everything, the prayer book off by heart. He'd put on his glasses and hold the book. It didn't matter if he'd hold the book upside down, it's just that's what you did, you'd hold the book . . . He could read, but his sight wasn't too good. He didn't worry that the book was upside down.⁹⁹

Aringari Wurramara likewise wanted the prayer written down for him to read, just like the chaplain. He claimed he could not pray in church if the prayer was not written down.¹⁰⁰ Seeing that missionaries used texts as a symbol of authority, Aringari did the same. The Anindilyakwa evangelists claimed equal status with the missionaries through the use of missionaries' own ritual symbolic objects: books. Anindilyakwa people took hold of the book's symbolic meanings, using practices associated with the book and writing to assert their own authorities to missionaries.

Leaving the Script

English literacy was not universally appealing to Anindilyakwa speakers. In the context of the mission, writing took on symbolic meanings, which complicated Anindilyakwa responses to writing. Some people were eager to read

and write in English in an enthusiasm to participate in modernity and to assert their interests in the face of missionary and government bureaucracies. Others were reluctant.

For missionaries, English literacy was a foundation of civilization and Christian practice. Instilling English literacy in the Anindilyakwa community was fundamental to their mission. Yet missionaries were uneasy with the very Anindilyakwa literacies that arose from the mission encounter. Anindilyakwa people used literacies in diverse ways, to assert their own interests and to claim power. They did so in ways missionaries did not expect and sometimes could not accept. Some used literacy to question the missionary project. Some used it to uphold Anindilyakwa traditions. Writing did not overturn Anindilyakwa oral traditions, as Western scholars and missionaries doubtless expected, but complemented them. The new Anindilyakwa literacies at Angurugu were embedded in Anindilyakwa cultures and priorities and upheld oral systems of knowledge. They confounded the missionaries' binaries—orality and literacy, pagan and Christian, traditional and modern, savage and civilized—and the frustrating expectations of “progression” from one to the other. Anindilyakwa people used written texts in diverse, oral, and more Aboriginal ways, sometimes to subvert the very “Christian civilization” offered by missionaries. As Derek Peterson argued, the effects of literacy in different cultures are unpredictable.¹⁰¹ The growth of distinct Anindilyakwa modernities and writing practices was unsettling for missionaries, as they could no longer have such faith in English literacy as the seed of Christian civilization. Literacy was out of their control.

But becoming literate in English was complicated, especially for those Anindilyakwa people who did not always accept or welcome the missionaries' agenda. Learning to write could represent a concession they were not willing to make. They observed the symbolic meanings of literacy—its association with the missionaries' religion and “civilization”—as well as the weaknesses of written communication as opposed to oral communication, the lack of interesting reading material, and missionaries' own disapproval of Anindilyakwa writing. As a result, many Anindilyakwa people became disillusioned and disengaged from missionaries' literacy culture. They concluded that English literacy was not worth the effort. For some, failing to learn to read may have been a subtle act of resistance to settler-colonial strategies. When, by the 1960s, Anindilyakwa people did not take up English literacy en masse, missionaries hoped that another approach would entice them to read: Anindilyakwa in print.

THE MAMARIKA WINDS

Turning to Anindilyakwa

In 1952, a young woman from Adelaide arrived at Angurugu and made it her life's ambition to translate the Bible into Anindilyakwa. Judith Stokes was not unusual in wanting to translate the Bible. For over a century, the Protestant missionary movement had championed Bible translation, believing that the Word of God in the vernacular was the foundation of the Indigenous church and the best route to the hearts of the people. Having grown up in CMS circles, Stokes had wanted to travel abroad and translate Scripture since she was a child.

She applied to the CMS to be a missionary in 1949, at the age of twenty-four. On her first application to CMS South Australia, she was clear in her ambition: "Translation and literary work appeal to me."¹ When the CMS raised concerns about her mental health, it looked as if her calling might not be realized, until Stokes heard that the Aborigines Committee of the CMS was desperate for teachers. She wrote to the Aborigines Secretary, J. B. Montgomerie, in 1951.² Montgomerie eagerly accepted the offer. He was aware of Stokes's continuing interest in translation and informed the superintendent of her desire to do language work in addition to teaching.³ He reminded Stokes that although "language translation will naturally occupy" her think-

ing, “full time must be given to the school.” “The [language] study work will be fitted in,” he wrote, “at times convenient to yourself.”⁴ Linguistics was to be a free-time hobby. But, as her colleagues remembered, the CMS “thought dear Judith was a bit of a pain in the neck because she kept pushing.”⁵

Stokes was not the first CMS missionary to take an interest in translating Aboriginal languages. Another, though less well known, was Nell Harris, the wife of Dick Harris, whose Gunwinggu translation of the Gospel of Mark was published in 1942. There was also chaplain Len Harris, who translated the books of Mark and James into Wubuy in 1945.⁶ The CMS praised its translators but was noncommittal about actually funding and facilitating their work. Before Nell Harris’s Gunwinggu Scriptures were published, the CMS relocated her husband to Groote Eylandt. It was sixteen years until she could return to Oenpelli (Gunbalanya) where Gunwinggu is spoken. Len Harris resigned in 1945 but in 1958 offered to return to the Northern Territory to spend six months a year as a linguist. The CMS thought this an odd idea, preferring not to have a linguist at all, rather than a part-time worker.⁷

When the Mamarika winds begin gusting from the southeast, it means the seasons are changing. The Makassans, when they used to come, would return to their homelands. Dragonflies start to appear. Soon the yams will be ready to eat. The Mamarika means the end of the wet and the start of the dry.

The winds of change were picking up speed for Aboriginal Australia in the 1960s. Aboriginal people built networks and planned campaigns, expressing their own voice and political demands. White Australians were made to rethink the place and future of Aboriginal people in the nation and to reconsider their actions and attitudes. This was especially true for the missionaries at Angurugu and their approach to the Anindilyakwa language and to translation. While in the early 1960s, few missionaries learned to speak Anindilyakwa—and those who did, did so in spite of the CMS hierarchy—the winds seemed to have changed.

Or had they? When the new linguistic program changed the language economy of the mission, it interrupted the existing power-laden relationships of the mission, but did not overturn them. Missionaries, Anindilyakwa-speakers, interpreters, and linguists renegotiated their relationships with each other as their language competencies rose or fell in value in the mission context.⁸ The new language policy made many people uncomfortable. It raised questions about the status and role of missionaries, as well as about who had the right to linguistic knowledge. Despite the protestations of many, however, the CMS had little choice but to pursue this language work if it were to maintain its evangelical influence on Groote Eylandt. Although, in some ways, language work became a new iteration of the logic of elimination of the “native,” once again, Anindilyakwa people found they could pursue

their own interests by only selectively cooperating with missionaries and by exploiting ambiguities of translation and misinterpretation.

The CMS and Missionary Linguistics

The CMS was steeped in a long tradition of linguistic study for Bible translation. So, at first glance, it seems surprising that they did not immediately pursue this strategy on Groote Eylandt. Australian evangelical missionaries in the mid-twentieth century continued to revere missionary translators. In 1950, the CMS newspaper reported on the progress of Australian Bible translators in Africa.⁹ CMS stories of missionary accomplishment invariably highlighted a great linguist. In 1939, the CMS newsletter *Open Door* featured William Carey's "covenant" for India, including the principle "to labour unceasingly in Biblical translation."¹⁰ The CMS even asserted that human history itself was ultimately the story of Christian mission and the dissemination of the Bible.¹¹

When Stokes arrived at Angurugu, she taught at the school and learned Anindilyakwa in her free time. After a year, she established rudimentary language lessons with Gula Lalara and Mangalala Wurramara, held once a week for other mission staff. In staff meetings she raised the matter of language, insisting that staff needed more practice than her weekly classes alone. By 1954 Stokes was preaching in Anindilyakwa at weekday church services, the only missionary to do so. She gradually built up a dictionary, writing words on slips of paper she stored in a shoebox. During a brief season of sufficient teaching staff, the Angurugu missionary staff opted to "release" her from the classroom to study Anindilyakwa full time for one year from August 1959. Armed with a battery-operated recorder, she recorded stories from the old people and put Gospel stories and songs on tape. But in September 1959, the assistant director of Welfare Branch visited Angurugu and discovered that Stokes was not in the classroom. The missionaries had not considered that diverting Stokes to linguistic work would disqualify her from receiving the government subsidy for teachers, and they were shocked when the money was cut off. Stokes returned to the classroom, where she was once again attracting government funds for the CMS.

Although it had always been CMS policy that missionaries learn Aboriginal languages, a series of practical and philosophical obstacles meant that Stokes went unsupported in her language work. The Commonwealth government provided subsidies to Aboriginal schools on the condition that English be the language of instruction. The CMS could not afford to experiment with Anindilyakwa in the classroom. It also could not afford to "release" Stokes and replace her with someone else. An almost constant shortage of qualified teachers willing to go to Aboriginal missions (most potential missionaries preferred to go overseas) meant that the CMS needed Stokes in the school.

An even greater obstacle, however, were missionary beliefs about the English language, assimilation, and the Australian nation. The English Bible was, for the CMS, Australia's "vernacular" Bible. Linguistic work and Bible translation would indicate, therefore, that Aboriginal people would remain separate from English-speaking Australia—that is, that Aboriginal people might have an ongoing, distinct identity apart from the settler-colonial culture. This concern was evident in 1961 when the matter arose of whether the English King James Bible was appropriate for Aboriginal people. A CMS chaplain complained that "very few Aboriginal Christians read their Bible every day." This did not lead to calls to translate the Bible into Aboriginal languages, but only to laments over the "low standard of reading." In fact, it was "an achievement," he boasted; at least "folk on our missions are better equipped to read the English Bible than those on some of the missions in the Centre" (where missionaries used the Arrernte or Pitjantjatjara languages).¹² That was in 1961.

By 1967, however, the CMS employed Stokes as a full-time missionary linguist, teaching Aboriginal languages to staff and vernacular literacy to Aboriginal people, and translating Christian texts. The CMS no longer saw language as a free-time hobby for a minority of missionaries, but suddenly began investing considerable time and resources in linguistics. As we shall see, they had no other option.

The Winds of Change

In 1963, Broken Hill Proprietary, Ltd. (BHP) announced it would begin mining operations on Groote Eylandt. The Groote Eylandt Mining Company, a subsidiary of BHP, was formed to exploit the island's vast manganese deposits through open-cut mining. The CMS took out the prospecting rights to the island and negotiated with BHP to hand over the rights in return for royalties paid to the Groote Eylandt Aboriginal Trust Fund. The CMS is very proud of its role in negotiating the agreement on behalf of the Anindilyakwa people. "BHP wanted to pay us £15,000 and write it off, you see," explained the superintendent, Jim Taylor. The board of the trust fund consisted of elected members from both Angurugu and Umbakumba; the CMS superintendents of both missions; Harry Giese, the director of Welfare Branch; and the CMS field superintendent.

Soon after the arrival of BHP, the CMS began paying its Aboriginal workers wages rather than rations.¹³ It had to do so, now that there was an alternative employer on the island. Yet as BHP expanded its operation, more Anindilyakwa men—India, Jambana, Gula, Nandjiwarra, Dubbo—left the mission for the higher wages offered by BHP. CMS missionaries increasingly found themselves training men who then left to work for BHP. The missionary builder complained in 1964 that his most experienced workers were

gone.¹⁴ The mission used the money it was no longer paying in wages to increase the wages of those who remained at Angurugu in an attempt to keep some men at the mission. But they could not compete with BHP. Although the CMS was supportive of the mine for its contribution to assimilation and provision of jobs, the company also threatened the viability of the industrial mission model.

At the same time, missionaries felt winds of change from the south. As they worked in North Australia, the churches and society down south were changing. After the high of the 1959 Billy Graham Crusades, the 1960s proved a disappointing time for evangelicals. There was a sense of crisis, with many predicting the end of institutional religion as they knew it.¹⁵ In the 1950s, all Christian denominations in Australia had experienced growth in memberships, Sunday school enrollments, and enrollments in theological colleges. But in the early 1960s there were signs of decline. Donations to churches and missions fell. Sunday school enrollments plummeted: from 49,000 in Melbourne's Anglican churches in 1960, to 32,000 in 1970, then to only 15,000 in 1975. Christian youth organizations collapsed altogether by the 1970s. While in the 1950s churches experienced a shortage of clergy due to the demands of growth in membership, in the 1960s, clergy and candidates for ordination were resigning, disillusioned.¹⁶ Missions could no longer enjoy the support they presumed in the 1950s. More significantly, though, visions of Australia as a Christian country were fading.

The Anglican Church, in particular, changed drastically in the 1960s. The Anglican Church was unique in Australia because, as Brian Fletcher argued, it "endowed empire, monarchy and race with a religious sanction."¹⁷ But in 1962, the Anglican Church in Australia cut ties with the Church in England through a new constitution. Just as the Australian nation did generally, the Anglican Church embraced a more distinctly Australian identity, as opposed to British. It adopted a new Australian hymn book and Australian prayer book, and changed its name to the Church of England in Australia (and again in 1966 to the Anglican Church in Australia). For the missions, this meant their nexus of Anglican faith, British empire, and English language no longer held together so tightly. What were missionaries doing, then, introducing an English way of life, language, and religion to Aboriginal people?

White Australia's attitudes to Aboriginal policy were also changing, due, in part, to the actions and protestations of Aboriginal people themselves. Aboriginal people had begun to protest more publicly the injustices they had faced. The 1963 Yolngu Bark Petition famously challenged the Methodist Overseas Mission and the Commonwealth government's presumption that mining was good for Aboriginal people since it would encourage assimilation; it suggested that for Yolngu people, assimilation was not a priority.¹⁸ While in the 1950s, assimilation was endorsed by governments and most an-

thropologists a like, in the 1960s, more and more academics and activists rejected the federal government's assimilation policy for Aboriginal people. Some churches—including leaders in the Methodist Overseas Mission and the Australian Council of Churches—began arguing for Aboriginal rights to land and culture.¹⁹ In 1967, the successful referendum to include Aboriginal people in the census and to enable the Commonwealth government to make policy for Aboriginal people also brought Aboriginal rights into the national spotlight. The CMS's longstanding policy of industrial training of Aboriginal people for the sake of assimilation could no longer be taken for granted as being in the best interests of Aboriginal people. Missions, therefore, increasingly needed to justify their presence and actions in the Northern Territory.

On Groote Eylandt, Anindilyakwa people made their own protests. Men who worked for BHP began to insist that the child endowment be paid directly to Aboriginal mothers, rather than to the CMS. Perhaps they had discovered that wives of their white colleagues received the payment directly. Taylor felt this was impossible because the child endowment payments made up nearly half the mission's income.²⁰ The next time the matter arose, Taylor simply hoped the men would not push the point.

But Taylor could not ignore the CMS's own changing position on the matter. When the superintendent at the CMS Roper River mission restructured the mission's finances so that pensions, subsidies, and child endowment payments went directly to Aboriginal people, the CMS Field Council in Darwin called the change a "pioneering venture." Taylor raised his concerns. But others on the council outvoted Taylor and agreed in principle that all government social services payments on CMS missions should be paid directly to Aboriginal people by July 1967.²¹ It was not clear how the Angurugu mission could survive without this income.

Under these stresses, financial and political, the CMS's hold on its North Australian missions began to give way. Umbakumba mission was the first to go. The CMS had acquired it from Fred Gray in 1958, but by 1965 the CMS could no longer staff the mission, so handed it over to the government's Welfare Branch to manage. Rumors circulated that the CMS was "pulling out of the North."²²

Instead of pulling out, the CMS radically reinvented its methods. The industrial mission model was demonstrably no longer possible. So missionaries resolved to maintain an evangelical presence through becoming experts in Anindilyakwa language and culture, and promoting Aboriginal leadership in the local church. This meant changing their approach to Aboriginal languages.

The recent establishment of the Australian branch of the Summer Institute of Linguistics (SIL) in 1961 and the Australian Institute for Aboriginal Studies in 1964, as well as publication of the 1964 Watts-Gallacher report on

bilingual education, gave new impetus to linguistic research across Australia.²³ The CMS hired a new Secretary for Aborigines, John Brook. Given the uncertainty of its future in the Northern Territory in its current form, the CMS was willing to listen to those insisting on the importance of language. In September 1965, the CMS agreed to hand over Angurugu school to Welfare Branch, relieving the long-term shortage of teachers with ones supplied by the government. That same month, Arthur Capell presented a report to the CMS recommending the appointment of linguists on missions who would establish vernacular education in the early years of school and use the vernacular in church. Capell had produced numerous reports along similar lines since the 1940s. This time, Capell's recommendations were accepted by the Aborigines Committee, which made plans for their implementation. Capell also convinced the director for welfare that the employment of linguists at missions could be valuable, provided they focused on education, not evangelism.²⁴ Finally, in 1967—the same year that Australia voted “yes for Aborigines” in the referendum—Stokes commenced work as a full-time linguist on a government subsidy. Eighteen years after applying to be a linguist and translate the Bible in Iran, Stokes wrote home, “Prayer has been answered in my eventual release from teaching to free me for full time linguistic work.”²⁵

The move to linguistics was strategic for the CMS. It was not something that Anindilyakwa people had asked for. It was a project based in evangelical ideas of conversion and in political necessity. Stokes's linguistic work provided a way to continue to justify missionary work as culturally sensitive and, most important, to maintain an evangelical ministry as she translated the Bible.²⁶

The Missionary Linguistic Program

As a linguist, Stokes embarked on a program of teaching Anindilyakwa-speakers to read their own language. This linguistic program, the CMS believed, would have social, educational, and spiritual benefits for Anindilyakwa-speakers. CMS linguists presumed that Aboriginal people found “psychological security” in their languages that could “help them cope with the pressures and tensions of the rapidly changing pattern of life.”²⁷ The “ultimate goal” of vernacular literacy was, of course, to enable Anindilyakwa speakers to read the Bible in their own language.²⁸

Stokes invested considerable energy in convincing Anindilyakwa people to learn to read Anindilyakwa. “We are encouraging people by every means possible,” she wrote.²⁹ One strategy was to scatter literacy material around the mission, at the hospital, hall, and library, to pique people's interest in vernacular reading.³⁰ Stokes praised Nancy Lalara for having learned to “read with good expression.”³¹ At one stage Stokes taught five men who showed “much keenness.”³² After only two weeks Nangeringa read a Bible story at a

weekday service “confidently and well.” Aringari was “keen and capable.” Murabuda was eager. Najirilila was “keen” and “made good progress.”³³ Some of the Anindilyakwa women remembered how they appreciated learning to read Anindilyakwa. Judy Lalara said that it helped with her reading in English and that she found reading easy. “It’s just good for learning . . . It was good learning English and language, both. I was good at it.”³⁴ Rhoda Lalara also wished to learn and so approached Stokes and others working in linguistics.

I wanted to write in our language. I know how to speak, but just learn how to write it down in our language. That’s how I ended up asking them if I could work with them and they said “ok.”³⁵

Anindilyakwa people determined the progress of Stokes’s work. She depended on them and could only work at their pace. She was thankful for Danabana, a woman who “helped me and others with language work and has a good deal of practice in reading her language.”³⁶ She reported who came to work with her and how often, acknowledging her dependence on them: “Nanindjuraba has helped on six occasions . . . Gayangwa helped me once and Danabana nine times.”³⁷ She praised her informants. Aringari Wurramara was “very easy to work with” and “absolutely ‘with it.’”³⁸ When Gula Lalara returned to work with her, it was a “miracle,” she said. “I can’t imagine anyone else being able to help . . . as he has done.”³⁹ Through the 1970s, Stokes and Aringari translated Bible passages together, then the text would be checked by Murabuda. “It is always encouraging when Murabuda explains, ‘it’s all clear,’” Stokes wrote.⁴⁰ Her work was always subjected to Anindilyakwa examination.

But not all Anindilyakwa people supported or prioritized Stokes’s work. Stokes complained that some were too busy, but it is also possible that they simply were not interested.⁴¹ Anindilyakwa people had the power to obstruct her work. Missionary Lois Reid remembered how Anindilyakwa people could not only reject but actively hinder Stokes’s work. It only required a few to dissent since, if she did not have the cooperation of all Anindilyakwa clans, her work would be of limited usefulness as it would be unlikely to be accepted by the whole community.

Those who did cooperate with Stokes were not blind to her evangelistic agenda. They found their own uses for linguistics, taking the literacy skills intended to “civilize” them and assimilating writing into their own perceptions of its nature and usefulness.⁴² Those who identified as Christian were generally most eager to learn to read in their own languages and to work on Bible-translation projects. For Christian people, the translation of Scripture placed them on a more equal footing with the missionary, as they, too, could be interpreters of the sacred text. For those who did not adopt Christianity,



Judith Stokes, Lawrence Jaragba, and Gula Lalara (Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

Stokes's expertise could be used for other purposes, such as recording songs and stories in new media of print and tape.

Despite early enthusiasm, progress soon slowed. In 1970, Stokes coordinated a group of women who helped those who had not learned to read English to read Anindilyakwa. "Several of the women undertook to help to teach others," she wrote. "The project started with enthusiasm," she noted, but enthusiasm dwindled because "the women who are the 'teachers' have not seen that constistence and perseverance is necessary . . . to maintain an interest."⁴³ In 1970, Stokes had three regular pupils: Didjidi, Bayema, and Darugwabanja. Didjidi was "keen to read" but often "lasted about five minutes before family demands whisked her away." Bayema and Darugwabanja began learning together and made progress, but Bayema was injured so went to Darwin. To guarantee that lessons would happen, Stokes became more proactive, going to her pupils every morning. She constantly asked churches in the South to "pray for enthusiasm" among Anindilyakwa-speakers to learn to read their language: "pray for increasing interest in learning to read"; "pray . . . for interest in reading"; pray for them to develop a "real interest . . . to translate familiar but only half understood English into meaningful Anindilyaugwa."⁴⁴ Yet for some Anindilyakwa people this interest never developed. By the late 1970s, Stokes faced criticism that "no Aborigine

at Angurugu is fluent in writing and all but four or five have never written in Anindilyakwa.”⁴⁵ In the mid-1980s Stokes confessed that “unfortunately” even A Ringari, who was by this stage the Anglican minister at Angurugu, “has never wanted to learn to read in Anindilyakwa himself.”⁴⁶

In contrast, at the nearby Methodist missions, Yolngu people strongly supported the missionaries’ developing linguistic projects. Once again, however, they had their own priorities for writing in their language, Yolngu Matha. Yolngu people showed a much greater interest in learning to read their own language than Anindilyakwa people did. A 1965 Methodist Overseas Mission (MOM) Committee of Inquiry cited “the aborigines’ own interest in the vernacular” as a reason to pursue linguistic work, a factor never cited by the CMS. Yolngu people saw potential for keeping their languages strong and ensuring their prestige. The older men were pivotal in the decision as to which *matha* (language) the missionaries should concentrate on (this was a matter of political debate among Yolngu clans). The linguistic work came by a convergence of missionary and Yolngu political interests: The missionaries used linguistics for evangelism and ultimately assimilation, but the Yolngu men used it to ensure the prestige of their culture or their clan.⁴⁷ Missionary strategies could be redirected to suit Yolngu concerns, particularly when it came to use of their language.

Most famously, Yolngu people used their language in print to claim land rights before the federal government in their 1963 Bark Petition. Written in Yolngu Matha, the Bark Petition asserted to white Australia that Aboriginal cultures also have value.⁴⁸ Yolngu people were no longer submissive writers in English, made to appear childlike by their spelling errors and simple syntax. Their cultural sophistication and uniqueness was made visible in the nation’s Parliament in language. While settler-colonial ambitions would have silenced both them and their languages, instead Yolngu people took control of how they would be represented.⁴⁹ The visual representation of their language was tangible evidence that they and their culture had not died, nor would they be silent. The Bark Petition also made the necessity of translation visible. By bringing their language and law inside the space of the federal Parliament, Yolngu people exposed the myth that one law could be simply and unproblematically applied across the continent. In some ways, the petition failed. The mining went ahead. But it did have some successes. The press reported the story of the Yolngu petition in detail. Yolngu people saw that there was power in presenting their culture and interests to white Australia.

As Yolngu people were putting their language in print to political use, Anindilyakwa-speakers on Groote Eylandt felt differently. The CMS’s linguistic program was, for many, an unwelcome interference. Former missionary Jenny Green’s impression was that the linguists “owned” the language and “didn’t like sharing it.”⁵⁰ Some Anindilyakwa-speakers may have interpreted Stokes’s eagerness to study their language as a takeover of their cultural

knowledge. The vernacular literacy program would “reduce” Anindilyakwa speakers, in some ways, to students of their own language, subject to correction by linguists who had “reduced” their language to print. It could be a means of silencing Anindilyakwa voices, rendering them awkward and hesitant as they struggled to read and write “correctly” in their own language.⁵¹ When I asked Jabani Lalara if he had wanted to learn to read Anindilyakwa, he said no. “I didn’t want to learn [to read] Anindilyakwa, because I could speak Anindilyakwa.”⁵² From his perspective, it was already his language, and it was a spoken language; a missionary had no place in teaching it to him.

Writing in Anindilyakwa came to Groote Eylandt only after decades of missionary insistence that Anindilyakwa people needed to learn to read and write in English. It is, therefore, possible that the act of writing itself had, for Anindilyakwa people, become so bound up in missionaries’ Christianizing and civilizing agenda, and in broader settler-colonial designs for their country, that it could not be redeemed, even in their own language. It is also possible that some did not want their language associated with a technology like writing, seeing how writing in English had been used against them and their culture.

The missionaries on Groote Eylandt, however, never questioned their right to write Anindilyakwa down. In other places, the question of whether oral Indigenous languages should or could be written has caused much consternation. Some Gros Ventre speakers in the United States, for example, resisted representing their language in writing because, for them, unlike the English brought by colonizers, their language was a purely oral language.⁵³ It would not be the same language if written; it would become like English—that is, like the language of the settler-colonists who had sought to eliminate and assimilate them. For many native communities, as Mindy Morgan states, “English, writing and institutional power were inextricably linked.”⁵⁴ Where colonial linguists represented oral languages in writing, they dislocated these languages from the mouths and ears of their speakers and stored them, instead, in their own grammars and dictionaries. When a language is represented in writing, its speakers can lose authority over how their language is used and represented, forfeiting that authority to “expert” linguists.

According to the Comaroffs, much of the colonizing power of missionary linguistics was bound up in the “reduction” of Indigenous languages to writing, a systematic Western code. Joseph Errington calls colonial linguists’ work to “reduce” oral languages to writing an “act of symbolic violence.”⁵⁵ Jane Sampson calls it “linguistic colonialism.”⁵⁶ When European missionaries prepared their grammars, they attempted to contain unknown languages in a form they could recognize and control.⁵⁷ By “reducing” the languages, linguists claimed to capture the empirical reality of languages in European letters and symbols without reference to language as embodied talk.

Linguistic reduction was always risky. There was no guarantee that Indigenous people would appreciate their language being represented in this way. In New Zealand, for example, translator Robert Maunsell thought the Māori language too wordy, making books unnecessarily long. For the second edition of the Māori Bible, he set to work literally reducing the language, “compelling, as it were, the colloquial language to reduce its dimensions.”⁵⁸ Presuming that missionaries owned the language by writing it down, he claimed authority to reshape it. Instead of adjusting his purposes, Maunsell attempted to change the language. The Māori did not appreciate his work, and the second edition failed to sell. Demand for Scriptures had been dropping since its peak in the mid-1840s. Even where missionaries reduced Indigenous languages, they were bound by the preferences of Indigenous peoples.

When missionaries wrote *Anindilyakwa*, they claimed control of the representation of this aspect of Aboriginal culture. They reified it, presenting it as an unchanging objective fact on a page—a grammar and a dictionary—removing it from the mouths of *Anindilyakwa*-speakers and cementing it in the dictionary. Stokes described her work in terms of “reducing” *Anindilyakwa*.⁵⁹ Likewise, Montgomerie described missionaries’ work to “break into the languages of the various tribes and to reduce them to a alphabet, dictionary and grammar.”⁶⁰ Missionaries worked to order and define Aboriginal languages and produced a representation of the language back to their speakers.

As the missionaries developed an orthography for *Anindilyakwa*, they re-created it in the likeness of European languages. It now had Latin letters, it was read left to right, it could be understood in a Western framework. As Rachael Gilmour found at African missions, the dream of a uniform orthography was an aspect of the dream of “unification of languages . . . and ultimately unification of Africa under Christianity.”⁶¹ The dream lived on in Australia in 1973 when SIL linguists published a paper advocating a “uniform orthography for Australian Aboriginal languages.”⁶² Standardizing Aboriginal languages would facilitate the work of educators and Bible translators across the nation. Reducing and standardizing *Anindilyakwa*, therefore, was part of an attempt to recast *Anindilyakwa* in Christian terms (print) for Christian purposes.

Despite the attempt to “reduce” *Anindilyakwa*, the language was not easily reduced or standardized. It was as if the language itself resisted. Instead of seeing their culture represented back to them by the colonizers, *Anindilyakwa*-speakers saw English-speakers struggle to master a language that refused to be tamed. In 1972, Stokes was assisted by a consultant from SIL, Velma Leeding. Their work produced a significant change in *Anindilyakwa* orthography. Where Stokes had used the letter *e*, Leeding instructed her to use the letters *i* or *u*, insisting that *Anindilyakwa* had only four vowels,

not five. The combination *au* was also dropped and replaced with simply *a*.⁶³ Stokes “took a lot of persuading” but made changes accordingly. To make things worse for Stokes (“losing a vowel is a traumatic enough experience,” she said), in the following year there were additional changes to the alphabet, rendering Stokes’s hymn books, primers, and library books obsolete.⁶⁴ This was the beginning of a long orthography dispute between Stokes and Leeding that was not resolved until 1989. In the 1960s and 1970s it could not be said that Stokes had reduced the language to writing: The fluctuating vowels meant there was no universal Anindilyakwa orthography. The dream of reducing the language to a uniform system suitable for English-speakers’ typewriters and recognized by Anindilyakwa-speakers remained out of reach. The linguists could not establish themselves as the experts on the language; Anindilyakwa remained an oral language since a definitive script was not established. Its orthography is still contested today.

Teachers and Learners

In addition to getting Anindilyakwa people to gain literacy in their own language, the other aspect of linguistic work was teaching the mission staff to speak and read Anindilyakwa. CMS linguists considered language-learning equivalent to cultural respect, explaining that “when English-speaking people make an effort to learn [Aboriginal] languages they are indicating that they recognize [Aboriginal] culture.” Moreover, the CMS linguists believed that “any attempt on the part of the Europeans to learn the local language” would “help Aboriginal self-esteem.”⁶⁵ The CMS presumed that learning the language would give mission staff a greater spiritual influence on Aboriginal people. Stokes divided the staff into language classes held once a week. For most, the single hour was all the time they could set aside, so “progress [was] very limited.” Nonetheless, Stokes reported that “those who come are interested and language learning has received a new impetus.” As the year progressed, it was difficult to find a time that suited everyone: Schoolteachers went away in school holidays; the shop needed to remain open; people were busy.

Missionaries had varied experiences of learning Anindilyakwa. Some had great success. Julie Rudder remembered unexpectedly discovering that she had a talent for language.⁶⁶ Brian and Kathy Massey wrote to their home church of how, through language, they cultivated friendly relationships with Anindilyakwa-speakers:

Would you believe it!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!! We have just finished our first language exam and the first twelve lessons and can actually be understood by the aboriginal people when we “try it out” on them. Praise the Lord with us——It has required much discipline of

time and loads of patience, (good for us anyway) but oh the thrill of seeing that smile (and sometimes laugh) of their recognition break out on the faces of our friends as they hear us speak their language. It seems so often us teaching them something, but now theirs is the thrill as we grapple with something unique to them.⁶⁷

Others had different experiences. I asked Jim Taylor if he had taken language lessons. He laughed and replied, "Half a dozen, it got me exactly nowhere, I felt that I didn't have any attributes in that direction and anyway, they could talk English just as well as I could."⁶⁸

Missionaries were not typically highly educated. Many had never learned a foreign language (unlike Anindilyakwa-speakers, who often knew multiple languages), most were already overworked, and Anindilyakwa was very different from any European language. Some made a real effort to learn and were frustrated at how little time they could set aside for language study. Others faced logistical barriers: the demands of caring for young children, the difficulty of balancing work and study, or the structure of the classes. Regarding the latter, one missionary said that she "would have been good at the language," but that in language classes "we had to work in pairs," and she and her husband were a poor match. "In tests I'd be getting in the 90s and he'd be getting in the 50s. That was very awkward, . . . so I pulled out."⁶⁹

Some missionary staff found that the lessons aided relationships with Anindilyakwa people. One reported that the classes "create a real bond between ourselves and those with whom we work."⁷⁰ For others, however, endeavoring to learn meant risking that they themselves would be the failure. When Kathy and Brian Massey wrote about their joy in learning Anindilyakwa, they were newly arrived missionaries with no existing relationships with (or over) Anindilyakwa people. For those who had lived at the mission for years, submitting themselves as pupils to Anindilyakwa-speakers was an inversion of how they had become used to relating with Anindilyakwa people. The missions' language economy and subsequent power relationships were shifting. For many missionaries, their own ignorance, slowness, and confusion—all the things English-speaking society typically accused Aboriginal people of—would be exposed in language lessons. This worried some missionaries to the extent that they were anxious when rumors circulated of compulsory language lessons with exams in the style of the Methodists at missions to the Yolngu. Missionaries' language competency, therefore, was strictly confidential. Their instructor recorded that "this group finds it very hard" and "please pray for [him] and language, but not in print."⁷¹ Missionaries feared Aboriginal people would laugh at their broken attempts at language, and so they did. The linguists reminded the missionaries that "one should laugh along at one's own mistakes," but this did not always come naturally to missionaries who had become used being the one

who “knows best.”⁷² The humbling experience of submitting to learn another’s language was, for some, too confronting. Many missionaries simply gave up.

The main factor in determining whether missionaries persisted in learning Anindilyakwa was the actions and attitudes of Anindilyakwa people themselves. By suggesting that missionary efforts were useless, Anindilyakwa people could easily turn missionaries away from the task at hand. Likewise, by encouraging select missionaries, they could help these missionaries progress. Some were eager for missionaries to learn. Gula Lalara’s contribution to Stokes’s language classes was essential to their operation. Murabuda Wurramarrba remembered missionary Dulcie Levitt fondly for her strongly accented Anindilyakwa (“but we didn’t worry about it”). Learning Anindilyakwa was a step toward friendship.

“Hello *diyabarrka* [big sister],” we said, “hello sister,” we used to say. “*Nenikumarnjarrka* [little brother],” “hello little brother,” she said. Was a good woman, you know . . . A little bit of funny, but she was speaking with the language.⁷³

For some Anindilyakwa-speakers, insisting that missionaries learn Anindilyakwa was not simply a matter of facilitating communication (they could already speak English), but also a means of asserting themselves and their knowledge. In 1970 the church councils of Angurugu and Umbakumba insisted that “you white people fail to understand us—you must get to know us better. You must learn our language.”⁷⁴ Anthropologist David Turner reported in 1969 that Warnaya gave him the silent treatment until he could speak Anindilyakwa. Once he had learned, Warnaya was quite happy to use English. The Anindilyakwa language was a test of Turner’s commitment to listening to Anindilyakwa people. Likewise, Turner’s wife Ruth found that Anindilyakwa women would not speak to her until she could communicate in Anindilyakwa.⁷⁵ Stokes’s linguistic program presented an opportunity for some Anindilyakwa-speakers to further assert the legitimacy of their own language as the language of Angurugu, compelling English-speakers to submit to Anindilyakwa preferences.

Not all Anindilyakwa-speakers wanted missionaries to speak their language. Missionary Lance Tremlett, for example, stated that he was told it was better to speak English:

I started to go to language classes and one of the Aboriginal men . . . he said to me “what are you doing learning Anindilyakwa and spending all your time doing that? We want you to talk to us in English and not to try because you’ll never be able to explain it as well in Anindilyakwa as what you do in English, and we need to

be able to learn to talk to you in English so that we can talk to government people. I don't see any need for you to be learning language." I still went to language classes, but I didn't get very far. . . . That was Aringari Wurramara who said that to me.⁷⁶

Aringari Wurramara was a leading man in the church, highly competent in English. For him, English competence enabled him to play the role of mediator and interpreter. If missionaries "explain it in English," he would understand and continue to "explain it" to others. Yet if the Anindilyakwa language were to come to dominate, his mediating role would dissolve and English literacy would lose its value. Those who had engaged more deeply with the missionaries' culture of English literacy, therefore, could have a vested interest in maintaining the status quo. In the struggle over the new shape of the language economy at Angurugu and the legitimacy of English and Anindilyakwa in various mission spheres, Anindilyakwa people adopted varying positions, often in accordance with their own language competencies and relationships.

Jim Taylor likewise "never got the sense" that Anindilyakwa speakers wanted him to learn their language.⁷⁷ Wilma Taylor also remembered a strong reaction against the language lessons:

They were a bit taken aback when we started learning the language because we would know their secrets, they said . . . I think they felt threatened that we were going to learn their language, I mean in bulk, not just one or two people, but there were a lot of us learning it at the time.⁷⁸

Anindilyakwa people may have seen the progress missionaries were making at the Yolngu missions on the mainland, where missionaries thought themselves to have gained complete knowledge of Yolngu Matha. According to missionaries there, it was possible to know the language better than Yolngu people themselves. Missionary Daisy Ingram, for example, believed that missionary linguist Beulah Lowe spoke Yolngu Matha most correctly.

She could speak as well as the Aboriginals in their language, and perhaps better I would say . . . If you heard them all in the bush I could always tell which one was Beulah speaking because she seemed to speak it more correctly.⁷⁹

To the missionaries (but not Lowe herself), Lowe successfully occupied a Yolngu identity by her command of their languages. In fact, she did so better than Yolngu people themselves. Where settler-colonists appropriate Indigenous identities, they work to delegitimize Indigenous people's particular

claim to knowledge and cultural identity.⁸⁰ Though Lowe may have intended to work with Yolngu people, the missionary belief that she could not only master their languages, but even become the authority on them delegitimized Yolngu knowledge and identities as particular to them.⁸¹ Given the ways that language connects Yolngu people to the landscape, the missionary's expertise could be understood as a claim to authority in Yolngu country. White settlers, missionaries believed, could occupy Yolngu country and speak Yolngu Matha in a way that was somehow even more legitimate or more correct than Yolngu people themselves. Anindilyakwa people made sure this would not happen to them.

For those Anindilyakwa people who had carefully used language to evade missionaries, the linguistics program was unsettling. It risked eroding the value of Anindilyakwa as a means of avoiding and outsmarting English-speakers through mistranslation or miscommunication. Thus, although the linguistics program was endorsed by and in fact depended on Anindilyakwa-speakers (particularly a core group of women), it faced resistance from both those who had close relationships with missionaries and those who had avoided missionaries. These groups, in various ways, had worked the existing language economy—particularly the requirement of ongoing translation—to their advantage and had a stake in its perpetuation.

Given these obstacles and the mixed support of Anindilyakwa speakers themselves in the language-learning experiment, there were also varying opinions among the CMS and Welfare Branch staff over language-learning. Stokes believed that the “chief obstacles” were “lack of incentive and lack of a sense of urgency”; staff did not prioritize it as she had hoped.⁸² Stokes requested that the Aborigines Committee pray for “staff to recognise their priorities in language learning.”⁸³ The CMS chaplains noted “a big gap between the desire of the Society that missionaries learn the language and the fulfilment of this desire,” which they attributed to a general attitude of “learn it if possible.”⁸⁴ One complained that the “severest criticism” of language-learning came from “fellow Missionaries who expressed the opinion that such language work was a waste of time.”⁸⁵ Again, in 1970, Stokes reported “quite opposite views” among staff (both Welfare Branch teachers and CMS).⁸⁶ “Some welfare teachers do not see any point at all in the use of the vernacular,” she wrote, but at least, “the majority of the staff see the desirability.” Other staff members constantly took her Anindilyakwa informants away for other tasks. They did not consider language work an important use of time and wanted language-learning to be compulsory only for a few of the permanent staff.

In the face of the staff's resistance, Stokes softened her approach. By 1970 she gave up “trying to encourage all and sundry” and only taught staff who were interested. She would give special attention to those who needed to spend time with people in the village, nurses, and, ideally, the superintendent. For the rest of the staff she recommended only “a minimum selection

of every day phrases.”⁸⁷ Even with these concessions the staff continued to frustrate her. In the mid-1970s, Stokes recorded her problems as a linguist. The staff who wanted to learn were “hindered by lack of time and/or compulsion,” the superintendent lacked “real interest and consequent encouragement to others,” and missionaries generally still held the view that “lang[uage] work is the linguist’s hobby & doesn’t . . . take priority.” She also had difficulties finding Anindilyakwa-speakers who could take time to assist her. Women were “inevitably distracted by ch[ildre]n,” many were “shy,” others were too busy or “not the sort to put their minds to it.”⁸⁸

Stokes also blamed her troubles on Anindilyakwa itself and “difficulties inherent in this language.”⁸⁹ Just as Maunsell had complained that the Māori language as Māori used it was unfit for his purposes, missionaries on Groote Eylandt a century later blamed their troubles on the Anindilyakwa language itself. Although a board installed in the church displayed the Lord’s Prayer in Anindilyakwa, Jim Taylor commented, “I could never say it, it was just atrocious.”⁹⁰ David Woodbridge remembered the “big long words, it was really hard.”⁹¹ Wilma Taylor reported how impressed and horrified she was that Stokes had prepared “nine foolscap pages of the verb ‘to go.’” “One of the words in the creed was about 26 letters long,” she recalled. “It was like saying your alphabet all together.”⁹² Nineteenth-century missionaries’ realization that Polynesian languages were in fact complex and sophisticated brought a “crisis in European self-confidence.” Those languages were complex, subtle, and expressive *like English* and so challenged missionary distinctions between themselves and “heathen” societies.⁹³ At Groote Eylandt, missionaries realized that Anindilyakwa was, in many ways, more complex than their own English language. CMS missionaries for years called it “the world’s hardest language.”⁹⁴ It was, to many of them, an impossible language.

Missionaries also judged the Anindilyakwa language itself to be the cause of some Anindilyakwa-speakers’ reluctance to become literate in their own language. This was a common missionary complaint. In nineteenth-century China, for example, some Protestant missionaries considered the Chinese language a “curse” upon the Chinese, a “snare of the devil,” and a barrier to Western knowledge and logic.⁹⁵ Missionaries blamed illiteracy on a supposedly intractable language. Likewise, missionaries in North Australia believed Anindilyakwa to be exceptionally difficult and a burden to its speakers becoming literate. Stokes commented in 1965 that “it is not easy for [Anindilyakwa-speakers] to learn to read” because “the long words many of which look alike” led to “wild guesses” from new readers.⁹⁶ The language—not the introduced Latin script—was at fault. In 1973 Stokes was hurriedly preparing a bilingual program, using the Gudschinsky method of teaching reading in the vernacular to schoolteachers, but she found that “the long words in Anindilyagwa required some adjustment and delayed the production of the first few vital lessons.”⁹⁷ Anindilyakwa words were to blame. Sarah

Gudschinsky herself, according to Stokes, “found it hard to believe that we could have such long words.”⁹⁸ Anindilyakwa was considered an exceptional case, almost unreadable.

Yet there is also evidence that Anindilyakwa is not as impossible to learn as missionaries felt it to be. Wubuy-speakers, for example, learn it with relative ease (though their language has recently been found to be related). Wubuy-speaker Yulgi Nunggumadjbarr told me, “It’s easy, easy to learn!” before insisting that I “get a tape” and learn more myself.⁹⁹ Jenny Green reported that it was the attitude of missionary linguists that created a barrier to learning. She felt that Stokes liked to be the “expert” and made little effort to make the language accessible to ordinary missionaries. “The linguists worked very hard,” but they “didn’t like sharing it.” She remembered Stokes correcting her spoken Anindilyakwa in public, saying, “No no no! You don’t say that.” She felt she “wasn’t going to learn this language.” Later, once she learned more grammar, she was “gob smacked” when she “found out it was so easy.”¹⁰⁰ Although notions of the impossible complexity of Anindilyakwa served to secure the linguists’ position at Angurugu, they also undermined the language program by deterring English-speakers from even attempting to learn. Despite all the language lessons, linguists, and linguistic material, Anindilyakwa remained a mysterious language, out of reach of the ordinary English-speaker. Linguists’ expert knowledge also silenced other missionaries’ Anindilyakwa.¹⁰¹ By rendering missionaries hesitant and discouraged, the linguists, ironically, ensured that missionaries would always prefer speaking English.

Until the 1960s, the CMS had little inclination to invest in linguistic projects. But as the industrial mission model became redundant, the CMS needed to evolve to maintain its evangelical presence. Linguistic work and literacy training were a key strategy in that evolution. Missionaries and Anindilyakwa people had mixed reactions to this new emphasis on linguistics. Though the changing language economy was welcomed by some people, both Anindilyakwa-speakers and missionaries resisted the linguistics program for the way it inverted established relationships of power. Segments of both the missionaries and the Anindilyakwa population had a vested interest in maintaining the language barrier and depending on translation (and mistranslation). Some Anindilyakwa people endeavored to learn their language in print, but a literary Anindilyakwa culture did not become the norm, as much as Stokes prayed that it would. Many missionaries were uncomfortable about their new vulnerability before Anindilyakwa-speakers, just as some Anindilyakwa-speakers were uncomfortable that they might lose their language to missionary “experts.” Language promised missionaries knowledge of the “Anindilyakwa mind,” an instrument to penetrate Anindilyakwa hearts, but as we shall see, Anindilyakwa people used linguistics for their own ends.

SPEAKING TO THE HEART

The Language of Faith

If missionary reports are to be believed, Angurugu mission was full of “cuppa tea Christians” in the 1960s. The missionaries called Anindilyakwa-speakers “cuppa tea Christians,” suspecting they were simply mimicking missionaries, telling them what they wanted to hear for a “cuppa.”¹ The CMS ambitiously aimed for “the evangelisation of the world,” and on paper they apparently had success on Groote Eylandt: After establishing the mission in 1943, a generation later, in 1971, they had baptized 70 percent of the adult population.² Nonetheless, missionaries believed that “many ‘Christians’” were in fact “non-practicing,” as their faith was “not very evident” as far as missionaries were concerned.³ Anindilyakwa faith was deemed inauthentic.

Why did missionaries doubt their converts? I suggest it had to do in part with longstanding discourses of Aboriginality and insincerity, and with missionary discomfort at the Aboriginal use of English in church. Missionary suspicions that Aboriginal people were inauthentic converts were bound up in settler-colonial conceptions of authentic Aboriginality as well as in evangelical fears of nominal faith. The movement for using Aboriginal languages in church in the 1960s was based on missionaries’ assumption that Aboriginal people were most “authentic” when speaking their own “heart languages.”

By learning languages, missionaries hoped to harness “Aboriginality” for their mission project. This turned out to be more difficult than missionaries anticipated. Anindilyakwa people had their own visions for how missionaries should use their language and how the church should run.

By the 1960s, missionaries increasingly worried that Aboriginal people had not taken their Gospel to heart. While CMS missionaries in East Africa witnessed Christian revivals, those in North Australia were having a very different experience. As early as 1952, missionary Len Harris concluded that many Aboriginal people “profess Christianity for the benefits that might ensue on the mission.”⁴ In 1964, Field Superintendent Jack Langford considered “the spiritual side” of the mission’s work “disappointing,” and lamented that “results seem to be negligible . . . There is little evidence of any real ‘break through’ and . . . not much sign of an Indigenous Church.”⁵ Missionaries had long been aware of the possibility of Anindilyakwa couples feigning conversion in order to benefit from missionaries. For example, in 1954 the chaplain took care to give “much teaching” to be “sure of the sincerity of all concerned” when baptizing children, lest some couples baptize their children out of wrong motives.⁶ By the 1960s, missionaries were increasingly anxious that very few Anindilyakwa people had converted, and that those who seemed faithful might not be sincere.

Sincerity and Aboriginal Religion

Evidence of “backsliding” abounded. Just as churches in southern Australia grappled with the social changes of the 1960s, so the missions in the North experienced a decline in the enthusiasm of their flocks. People skipped church. The chaplain commented that some so-called Christians had “never partaken at Holy Communion.”⁷ In 1966 the chaplain explained that unlike some others, Nandjiwarra Amagula was not a mere “Sunday Christian” but a sincere convert.⁸ Nandjiwarra had been baptized in 1949. But after 1966, even he stopped attending church. By 1970, the superintendent called him “one of our former Christian leaders” who “now never comes to Church.”⁹

Through the 1960s there was a revival of interest in Anindilyakwa ceremony, led by Nandjiwarra, sometimes with “almost non-stop” dancing every night.¹⁰ Taylor requested in 1967 that the “corroboree mob” keep away from the village. They agreed, but nonetheless were soon dancing in the village again, keeping the music going “all night.”¹¹ Rather than banning ceremonies, missionaries attempted to regulate them. Anindilyakwa men were encouraged to ask the superintendent for permission to hold ceremonies so that they did not interfere with the work timetable. In 1971, missionary Bob Gibbes described what he called the “diverse interests competing for the souls of the people.” There was the “open air service” of singing. There were the gamblers, and a hundred yards away from the service, there was a large group

"gathered around aboriginal dancers, singers and instrument players."¹² By 1970 it was "dancing fever."¹³ The "almost continual dancing . . . affected to a great degree the numbers coming to church."¹⁴ The chaplain reported "many 'Christians' here who seem to be non-practicing."¹⁵ The superintendent had doubts about the mission's effectiveness. "One cannot help but wonder how much of an impact the message of Jesus has had upon the lives of these people," he wrote, "certainly Satan is having a good go at the moment."¹⁶ The chaplain suspected that the members of the church were not truly converted; their loyalty was to ceremony, not Christianity.¹⁷

Instances of polygamy, which the missionaries were supposed to have eradicated, persisted. Polygamy was, to the missionaries, "evidence of a reversionary movement towards pagan tribalism."¹⁸ In 1957 and 1958 some missionaries were assaulted when attempting to prevent men from taking second wives. Shockingly, for missionaries, even an older, single woman missionary, Dulcie Levitt, was "punched in the face" in an argument about women in 1958.¹⁹ Nabilya Lalara, who had recently returned from Maningrida (a Welfare Branch Aboriginal settlement on the north coast of Arnhem Land), was spreading reports that Welfare Branch permitted polygamy there. Most Anindilyakwa people were already aware that at Yirrkala, a nearby mission, monogamy had not been imposed on those who had not converted.

Despite the recommendations of Welfare Branch's research officer on the matter, the CMS refused to soften its stance against polygamy, on the grounds that monogamy was "Australian law" and necessary for "rapid integration or assimilation into the general Australian community."²⁰ Nonetheless, polygamy continued through the 1960s in what could be considered subtle resistance to missionary authority. The anthropologist David Turner, visiting in 1969, found that 36 percent of Bickerton Island men were polygamists.²¹ Furthermore, some men were publicly monogamous to "create an impression for the missionaries," but practiced a covert polygamy.²² Even Gula Lalara, who had been among the first to be baptized in 1949 and was the missionaries' trusted mediator, interpreter, and teacher in the school, took a second wife (then a third and a fourth) in the 1960s. Meanwhile, some women seemed more interested in pursuing BHP employees from the new mine than Christian monogamy.

Given the "backsliding," missionaries doubted the sincerity of any Aboriginal Christian. During an apparent Christian revival in 1968, the chaplain reported that "it is difficult to know how deep is the repentance of the many who are now coming to Church."²³ Likewise, at Umbakumba the chaplain believed that there were only "perhaps half a dozen" Aboriginal people in the church whom he considered "trustworthy in a general way."²⁴ Were any so-called Anindilyakwa Christians sincere converts? The prevalence of backsliding, paradoxically, led missionaries both to doubt their own effectiveness and to confirm to themselves the necessity for the continued existence of

the mission and further evangelism. But the missionaries wondered if they would ever know the sheep from the goats, the Christians from the heathen.

At this point it is tempting to ask: Were the missionaries correct? Were Aboriginal people feigning faith in the 1960s? Or were they genuinely “falling away,” rejecting what had been a sincere Christianity? Perhaps we should understand the so-called backsliding as subtle acts of resistance against the mission regime. As we shall see, there is evidence that for some people, such acts were a kind of resistance. But there is also evidence that where missionaries saw “backsliding” or “misinterpretation,” according to their conception of conversion, Anindilyakwa people found productive reinterpretations of Christianity or creative syntheses of traditions. That is, they may have neither simply collaborated with white power nor merely resisted it, but rather made a complex engagement with missionaries’ teaching, though in a context of unequal power.

Incidentally, the notion of the “inauthentic Christian” hinges on a European conception of religion as personal, private, and apart from community practice. As Talal Asad put it, Western religion (especially Protestant) can be “expressed as belief statements” and “practiced in one’s spare time.”²⁵ The missionaries’ accusation that Aboriginal Christianity was mere outward conformity presumed that religion was primarily a personal phenomenon, fundamentally about belief and sentiment, rather than embodied community practice. This distinction might make little sense from Aboriginal perspectives, where spirituality is embodied and pervades all aspects of life. When missionaries disparaged Aboriginal converts as merely opportunistic, this charge may have seemed strange to Aboriginal people, for whom the spiritual world was always connected with daily practice and material realities.

Insincerity, missionaries presumed, also pervaded Anindilyakwa spirituality. The early missionary Alfred Dyer recorded the supposed confession of an Aboriginal man that sorcery was just as the missionary suspected: “a useful bogie to frighten the women and children to keep them in camp at night.”²⁶ Another missionary joked that the “witchdoctor . . . had been singing us to death all night. Strange to say, we were alive in the morning.”²⁷ To him, it was fakery, unmasked by his rational, enlightened approach. So common was this belief that Elkin labored to convince the public that Aboriginal clever men were not “imposters,” “scamps,” or “charlatans,” but men of “high degree.”²⁸ CMS publications in the 1950s continued to describe a ceremony man as “a fake, a rogue, a liar and a troublemaker.”²⁹ The Aboriginal belief in “magic and sorcery . . . makes them frightened, . . . they are always imagining they have some enemy who is going to hurt them.”³⁰ Aboriginal people were, according to the CMS, slaves to their own deceptive and manipulative spiritual beliefs.

The missionaries were especially concerned about insincerity because, as evangelical Protestants, they believed worship must always be heartfelt. Evangelicalism itself originated as a protest movement against “superficial,” nominal Christianity. One was not born a Christian; one had to be “born again.” Evangelicals were especially against what they considered ritualism, particularly in the form of Catholicism.³¹ For them, it was useless merely attending church, reciting the prayers, unless these were accompanied by a heartfelt faith and right emotions. Without these, Christianity was merely “empty ritual.”

Sincerity, they believed, was contingent on clear language. Language, to them, was useful vehicle for truth, but also, when used to excess, a potentially dangerous distraction from it and a barrier to understanding. Thus, the CMS Aborigines Committee in 1964 explained that “the aborigines’ spiritual growth” would depend on “comprehension of the Scriptures.”³² According to evangelical tradition, faith was not purely rational; it had to be experienced emotionally to be sincere (hence John Wesley’s emphasis on “heart religion”), but these emotions needed a rational foundation of comprehension and propositional understanding. Among many objections to Catholicism, evangelicals believed that Catholics, due to their use of Latin in the Mass, had no inner spiritual life (or, if they did, it was ignorant superstition). Latin “only mystified its hearers.”³³ Catholic prayer was not prayer but “recitation,” a “meaningless Latin liturgy.”³⁴ But they knew that Christ taught “when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do.”³⁵ In nineteenth-century England, anti-ritualism became a defining feature of evangelicalism. The CMS missionaries instilled the same anti-Catholic sentiment among Anindilyakwa children, as Nancy Lalara remembered:

We hated the Catholics. I don’t know why. Maybe because we were told that Catholic sucks or something. The Catholic wasn’t part of the real Christian thing. That was the way that people spoke in them days, about their churches.³⁶

Anindilyakwa people, missionaries believed, were particularly prone to nominalism and ritualism. Norman Tindale visited Groote Eylandt in 1921–1922 with CMS missionaries as guides. He recorded a circumcision ceremony as consisting of “frequent chants (apparently wordless).”³⁷ On observing a funeral, he likewise described how “in the camp chants, which apparently are meaningless, accompanied by drone-pipe music and throwing-stick clapping are kept up for several hours.”³⁸ Aboriginal ceremony was, to him, meaningless repetition, empty sounds. This had also been the view of E. C. Stirling on Baldwin Spencer’s expedition to Central Australia in 1894. He wrote that “the natives are quite unable to assign any meaning to the words of these and other chants.”³⁹ Similarly, a 1958 CMS publication described Aboriginal

ceremony as meaningless ritual. “They sing to everything, but it is more like chanting, with a lot of repetition. Some songs have meaning, but magic songs are just so many magic words.”⁴⁰ Arnhem Land songs often have multiple and ambiguous meanings. The words used in songs are not words of ordinary language, and singers refer only obliquely to the song subject. The depths of the many layers of mystery in song meanings are open only to the few who have legitimate access to this knowledge; to young listeners, the songs may make little sense. But the missionaries found the same flaws in Aboriginal spirituality that they also found in Catholicism and believed they had rejected in the Reformation: meaningless noise, hollow repetition, empty ritual. Missionaries believed they were facing an uphill battle if they were to introduce an authentic faith to this apparently duplicitous culture. Were “converts” simply acting according to their supposed Anindilyakwa nature, telling missionaries what they wanted to hear?

The explanation for the apparent “backsliding” of the 1960s was obvious to many missionaries: Christianity had not been made sufficiently “meaningful” to Aboriginal people. Beulah Lowe, an evangelical missionary at Milingimbi, explained in 1968 that missionaries to Aboriginal people must “guard against worship becoming a mere repetition of meaningless words instead of a vital contact with God.”⁴¹ Likewise, Judith Stokes prayed that Aboriginal people would sing hymns “meaningfully.”⁴² Another missionary commented that Anindilyakwa-speakers did “not grasp the depth and fullness of meaning of the Gospel message.”⁴³ According to David Woodbridge, the key was to “make the ‘faith’ meaningful,” but it was a near-impossible task without the vernacular.⁴⁴

Missionaries worried that, by their use of English, their church services had become like the “meaningless” Latin mass of the Catholics or the “magic chanting” of Aboriginal songs. Many knew that Anindilyakwa-speakers could not readily understand the antiquated English of the *Book of Common Prayer*; missionaries themselves found it hard enough to understand. They worried that they were at risk of promoting ritualism and insincerity. Missionary Lois Reid was brought up Baptist, so was more willing than others to criticize the language of the Anglican liturgy as “tedious.” She admitted that missionaries themselves were unmoved in their confessions of wrongdoing; how could they expect anything else from their Aboriginal disciples?

To say Sunday by Sunday “We acknowledge and bewail our manifold sins and wickedness . . .” has become to me a mere repetition of words. What it does to the Aborigine who only has a vague idea of what it is all about, and indeed some don’t even have that, it would not even hazard a guess.⁴⁵

Oral history interviews indicate that most Anindilyakwa-speakers did not fully understand church services; even those who knew English or had memorized the hymns did not always grasp their meaning. It was all “mumbo jumbo,” Nancy Lalara said.⁴⁶ Perhaps she was aware of the irony that she, an Indigenous woman, found missionary religion all “mumbo jumbo.” The term originates in explorer Mungo Park’s early nineteenth-century description of an African character “employed by the Pagan natives in keeping their women in subjection.” “Mumbo Jumbo” was, according to Park, a figure who ceremonially rebuked wayward women in a pantomime where “Mumbo” was usually the woman’s own husband in disguise.⁴⁷ One missionary remembered listening to the old women singing old hymns. She believed that “their interpretation of what it was saying was basically meaningless.”⁴⁸ The missionaries risked an inversion of their own categories for enlightened authentic worship; they were the ones introducing pantomime—“mumbo jumbo”—to the heathen.

Language to Penetrate the Heart

Through the late 1950s and increasing with the “backsliding” in the 1960s, missionaries found in Aboriginal languages a scapegoat for their failures and the hope for their future success. According to Arthur Capell, the apparent failure of the missions to convert Aboriginal people was due to missionaries’ “incomprehensible refusal to learn Australian languages.”⁴⁹ Earl Hughes reported his discovery of the spiritual potential of Wubuy when, after a few weeks’ preaching in English to “blank and uncomprehending looks,” he used Wubuy, which resulted in “much better understanding of the Gospel.”⁵⁰ From 1957 he made “more and more use of Nungkubuyu [*sic*]” and, according to him, this “was the main means through which God spoke to the hearts of many of the Aboriginal people at Numbulwar.”⁵¹ Likewise, Stokes lobbied the Aborigines Secretary in 1965, arguing that the use of vernacular language has “proved itself and borne fruit in the spiritual lives of the people” at Numbulwar.⁵² Barry Butler stated in 1965 that he was “firmly convinced” that the “general lack of spiritual success” was due to “the failure to communicate in their own languages.”⁵³ Norma Farley did not admit evangelistic failure, but still advocated Bible translation, arguing that it would produce still more conversions: “If the Lord has been pleased to bless these people without the Bible in their tongue how much more could He pour out His Spirit upon them if they could feed on the Living Bread of the Scriptures in the language they have always known!”⁵⁴ Over this period, the view of Capell, Stokes, and Hughes became the dominant ideology of the CMS missionaries.

Missionaries were largely convinced that language was a route to the mind of a culture. Misunderstanding and misinterpretation could be abolished by

linguistics and translation. More and more CMS missionaries resolved that they would master the Anindilyakwa language. Missionaries wrote of “tackling seriously the language” and of “tackling it in [God’s] strength.” One maintained that Anindilyakwa was “a very hard nut to crack,” but that Stokes would get it “cracked right open.” Missionaries would “master the tribal language” and “break the language barrier.” They would be “scientifically prepared” at the Wycliffe School of Linguistics to “break into the language.” The Aborigines Committee also wrote of “breaking into a new language” and requested the new chaplain to “make an effort to break into the language of the people at Groote.”⁵⁵ Scripture taught them that God’s Word is a sword, that it cuts people’s hearts, that it is all-seeing and all-knowing.⁵⁶ Missionaries believed that knowledge of Anindilyakwa would give their Gospel message this same power. This was the case in many places. In her history of linguistics in colonial South Africa, for example, Rachael Gilmour argues that missionary linguistics was “indivisible” from the study of “the Zulu mind.”⁵⁷ CMS rhetoric from the 1950s was likewise that language would “reach the heart” of the people, “get into the soul,” “get into the hearts,” “get to the thought and soul of the people.”⁵⁸ Aboriginal hearts and minds were their last frontier, unreached territory. The missionaries would break in through mastering the language.

Capell’s 1965 report on Aboriginal languages was the immediate catalyst for Stokes’s release from the school classroom to full-time linguistics, and it clearly articulated the new CMS thinking. As Aboriginal people across Australia were increasingly demanding rights to land and culture in the 1960s, Capell, too, began using the language of Indigenous rights—but he applied it to Christian evangelism.

It is true that every people has a right to its own language. It is still more true that the more important a matter is to a person the more necessary it is that it be conveyed to him in his own language. Nowhere is this more important than in religion. Religion can never be fully at home in the hearts of the people until it comes to them in the language in which they dream, and finds expression in the mother tongue. The translation of at least parts of the Bible and the conduct of worship in their own language dare not be denied them . . . It is suggested therefore that the time has come to secure this right to the people, for it is at the same time a necessity for efficient penetration to their hearts. . . . It is essential to go beyond such statements of policy and establish special programmes on each station to secure the fullest and most advantageous use of this chief instrument both for the entry of the Word into the individual heart and also for the educational advancement of the people.⁵⁹

The CMS began to argue for the use of Aboriginal languages as not just a concession to Aboriginal people or an expression of sympathy, but as an Aboriginal right. Yet this “right” did not extend to cultural self-determination. Instead, Aboriginal people had the “right” to be enabled to convert to Christianity according to evangelical conceptions of conversion. Capell considered language to be an essential quality of Aboriginal people, an unchanging presence in their thoughts and dreams. The CMS, therefore, would pursue linguistic study in order to “efficiently penetrate” Aboriginal hearts. Ironically, in seeking to change Aboriginal people into authentic believers, the CMS came to assert that Aboriginal people were impervious to change, at least in regard to language.

CMS missionaries explicitly connected facility in Anindilyakwa with gaining power over Anindilyakwa-speakers—a maneuver that resonates with what the Comaroffs later theorized as a “colonization of consciousness.”⁶⁰ Isabel Hofmeyr, similarly, found a missionary ideology of language by which “texts are empowered to seize and convert those they encounter”; for missionaries, the translated text was to powerfully effect conversions.⁶¹ Of course, missionaries believed the Gospel they offered would be a source of joy and hope. Still, their rhetoric of “getting into the thought and soul” also reflects their urge to control Aboriginal people through Aboriginal languages. “There is no power like the word of God in a people’s own tongue,” wrote Earl Hughes.⁶² They used rhetoric of penetrating words, evoking images of violence. Language would ensure “efficient penetration to their hearts.” The vernacular was to be the “chief instrument . . . for the entry of the Word into the individual heart.”⁶³ As Kenneth Pike of the evangelical Summer Institute of Linguistics (SIL) put it, “even the Sword of the Spirit, though it still cuts deeply, seems to have a dull edge unless it is wielded in the language in which a man was born.”⁶⁴ The “sword” of the Word cut deeper when sharpened by missionaries as they cast it in the mother tongue. This rhetoric was not new. It had existed in Christian missionary thinking for centuries. Nonetheless, the idea that through the vernacular, missionaries could reach Indigenous hearts was taken up with new zeal by the CMS missionaries in 1960s Australia. Languages were, according to the CMS Aborigines Secretary, “a pathway to their friendship and a highway to their soul.”⁶⁵ Missionaries hoped that knowledge of Anindilyakwa would allow them to gaze into people’s hearts and enter their very soul.

The missionaries also considered using “simple” English in church services, though they ultimately rejected this option. The concept was to translate the *Book of Common Prayer* and the King James Bible into contemporary English as an interim measure. This would ensure Aboriginal people’s full comprehension without requiring missionaries to learn Anindilyakwa, the development of an Anindilyakwa orthography, or the teaching of vernacular literacy. In 1954 Butler recommended “simplification of the wording of the

Prayer Book Services for the benefit of Natives,”⁶⁶ and he later translated portions of the services into “simple English,” though they retained strong elements of their 1662 flavor (“Spare thou them, O God, which confess their faults”).⁶⁷ Other missionaries were concerned that the push to Anindilyakwa would hinder assimilation. One called it “retrograde” to use Aboriginal languages. For him, Aboriginal languages had “no future,” so were simply a distraction. He considered the argument that the vernacular was necessary as insulting to Aboriginal people; it denied that Aboriginal people have “just as much ability & brains as the missionary.”⁶⁸ The arguments indicate that, for some missionaries, English fluency continued to function as a marker of modernization, intelligence, and civilization.

Yet the value of the vernacular had become to most missionaries more than a matter of simply ensuring comprehension of their message; the mother tongue was somehow more spiritually suitable. But in their eagerness to translate, missionaries failed to remember that the New Testament itself was first written in an ancient *lingua franca*, *koiné* Greek, which was nobody’s mother tongue. In 1956 Earl Hughes stated that “the need for the things of God to be in the people’s own language is just as great as ever” because English was “inadequate in reaching them for the Lord.”⁶⁹ And Barry Butler explained in 1965 that although English might be “natural in a Government policy of Assimilation,” **“nothing can be the medium of truth to a man’s mind better than his own tongue.”**⁷⁰ According to Stokes in 1965, “no foreign language can ever speak to the heart like one’s own mother tongue.”⁷¹ Farley also was “convinced more than ever of the futility of trying to teach the people . . . in English,” even though she acknowledged that they were “educated in our language and culture” and could understand English.⁷² By 1976, the CMS linguists stated that “English could not be used effectively to evangelize, in prayer or in worship.”⁷³ Only the vernacular could convey spiritual truths.

Only the “heart language” would do because the mother tongue became to missionaries a matter of authenticity. By encouraging Anindilyakwa people to worship in English in the past they had encouraged them—even forced them—to be insincere, merely mimicking missionaries’ English religion. But when they spoke their own language, they were truly themselves. The “ultimate goal” of twentieth-century missionary linguistics, according to anthropologist Courtney Handman, was for “Christianity to seem as indigenous as the local language.”⁷⁴ The mother tongue would supposedly enable Indigenous people to feel that the church was truly “theirs,” seamlessly making Christianity part of Indigenous cultures. The evangelical dream of establishing “Indigenous churches” in all places had long imagined mother tongue as a sign of true Indigeneity.⁷⁵ On Groote Eylandt, while missionaries had previously distrusted Anindilyakwa culture and religion, believing it fostered insincerity, now they found in the Anindilyakwa language the foun-

dation of an authentic Anindilyakwa Christianity. When missionaries equated Aboriginal languages with authentic Aboriginality, they essentialized Aboriginal identities in a way that served the colonizing culture. That is, missionaries created a vision of authentic Aboriginality which, they believed, would aid evangelical conversion and re-create Aboriginal people in their own image.

Aboriginal people have long endured demands that they be somehow more “authentic.” Mick Dodson outlined colonizing cultures’ “preoccupation” with “labelling Aborigines and Aboriginality” along with white Australia’s “manipulation of authentic Aboriginality” according to its colonizing interests.⁷⁶ Eric Michaels likewise described the white fascination with an imagined Aboriginal authenticity.⁷⁷ Patrick Wolfe has written about “repressive authenticity” imposed upon Indigenous peoples as a strategy for settler-colonial power. This repressive authenticity is constructed as a kind of precontact, pure Aboriginality, which exists to exclude those deemed “inauthentic.” The idea of authentic Aboriginality works to deny the claims made by those Indigenous people deemed to be “inauthentic.”⁷⁸ This tendency among non-Indigenous Australians to insist that Aboriginal people be more “authentic” persists even today and presents a continuing challenge for reconciliation. In the North Australian missions, however, missionaries used their notions of authentic Aboriginality with authentic faith, using a settler-colonial concept of how “real” Aboriginal people should think and feel as a yardstick to judge Aboriginal converts as believers or not. If Aboriginal conversion was deemed insincere or inconsistent with an essentialist vision of Aboriginal culture, Aboriginal people could not yet be trusted to manage themselves on issues of faith, church leadership, or theology.

The ideology of the mother tongue as the “heart language” was by no means universal. Anindilyakwa-speakers had their own views of language. Language is vital to Anindilyakwa identities, though not in the ways the missionaries imagined were universal. Aboriginal people do not necessarily identify with the language spoken in childhood, which English-speakers call the “mother tongue.” Rather, one’s language is inherited through the father. It is the father tongue. The father language gives one the authority to travel in ancestral lands because language and country are spiritually linked.⁷⁹ The father language might not be the language one speaks most fluently or the only language one is identified with (monolingualism is not the norm). The mother language is also important, as is the language of one’s mother’s mother’s clan. Hence, Wubuy is also important for many Anindilyakwa-speakers. Since language relationships reflect kinship relationships, language is a way of relating to kin, of showing respect and acknowledging their country. Moreover, the European vision of language and nation does not correspond well to Anindilyakwa-speakers’ lives on Groote Eylandt. On Groote Eylandt, clan identity is more important than language identity. Groote Eylandters

understand themselves in terms of songlines from which they derive clan groups—extended families, connected through various relationships—rather than as a single Anindilyakwa nation or language group, as Europeans might.⁸⁰ The European notion of the mother tongue underpinning national and cultural identity is foreign.

Most significantly, for Anindilyakwa-speakers, “important” language is a means of concealing deep meanings, of speaking about things that only “wise men” will perceive. The missionaries thought that using “ordinary” Anindilyakwa would communicate deep spiritual truths to the heart. But for Anindilyakwa-speakers, “important Anindilyakwa words” are “different,” to be understood only by those who know the meaning. Language, for Anindilyakwa-speakers as in many Aboriginal languages, is a means not for broadcasting spiritual knowledge, but concealing it. Gula Lalara emphasized the way his language operated—through diversity and secrecy—when Judith Stokes recorded his speech, paradoxically attempting to make it clear for linguistic analysis:

Agina ayagwa waga arungurungawa lan̄wa
Wurragagurma lan̄wa what meaning agiyadagina.

That speech wise men use is different
 For those who know the meaning.⁸¹

Anindilyakwa Ownership of the Heart Language

To the missionaries’ great frustration, many Anindilyakwa-speakers were ambivalent about the use of their language in church. From the very beginnings of the new approaches to language, missionaries struggled to persuade Anindilyakwa church leaders to abandon English in church activities. The chaplain wished that Anindilyakwa men would “take responsibility for giving the message in Anindilyaugwa” instead of being pushed by him.⁸² When he suggested more use of Anindilyakwa at morning prayer services, “there was almost a growl that it should be kept just as it was.”⁸³ In 1970 Stokes found that Anindilyakwa-speakers were reluctant to remove English from church; “English . . . cannot be replaced without a struggle.”⁸⁴ When, later that year, Anindilyakwa church leaders voted on the issue of language for church, no one voted for exclusively Anindilyakwa; all wanted both languages.

This was not simply a difficult transition period. The reluctance to abandon English in church continued for decades; as late as 1987 Stokes was still struggling to convince Anindilyakwa-speakers to cast off English. “The English habit in church,” as she called it, was “hard to overcome.”⁸⁵ Anindi-

lyakwa churchgoers themselves did not always see the need to make church more “Aboriginal” or “meaningful,” as missionaries did.

This reluctance was also a problem for missionaries elsewhere in North Australia. Although the Yolngu supported bilingual education, they were less enthusiastic about the translated Bible. Some missionaries remembered a distinct preference for the Bible in English. One explained that the Yolngu people were happier using the English Bible because reading it was an “ego boost.”⁸⁶ Beulah Lowe attributed Yolngu reluctance to support her Bible translation work to a Yolngu perception of English as a “prestige” language and the desire to show off their English literacy.⁸⁷ CMS missionaries, in contrast, had never complained that too many people wanted to read English. Quite the opposite, there was never enough interest in literacy in any language. Still, Anindilyakwa people preferred to hear the sound of English at church.

According to Stokes, the preference for English was due to Anindilyakwa-speakers’ desire to accommodate those who did not speak Anindilyakwa. She had long suspected that Anindilyakwa-speakers preferred English, believing this was a language everyone, missionaries included, could understand. Perhaps Anindilyakwa-speakers also were reluctant to alienate missionaries in the church, preferring it to be a site of collaboration across cultures. Still, for some, there was a desire to keep their language separate from the church and to maintain autonomy in Anindilyakwa-language matters without the involvement of meddling missionaries. As Nanggaringa explained in a recording made by Judith Stokes, there should be no mixing of languages.

*Äbina aduwaba ñarra-bi-yäñgelabaja manja ñagurruwawa
wäna ñarri-yäñbina manja aduwaba, ñarra-magina manja
wurrugwala wänamamalya naga lañwa nuñwanyuñwa ñarrugwala
ñanamamalya ñarri-yäñbinama ñarri-ñwunyerrgwajinama
amangadirra augwa amalya. Agina aberraja wuberra
wurradediyawangwa iya wäneniyawangwa emba amamalya
embugwa agi-yäñbina manja guw-ängirrajama wurragina.
Aberraja wäna wurremangadirra yagi-yäñbina manja yäläbina
ayaugwa ma yagwalañwa Änindilyaugwa maba agina ñawa
Änindilyaugwa narre-ñayindäbana yagi-yäñbinama änindilyaugwa
ma ñawa, emba amangadirreama gi-yäñbina, amangadirrama
ñawa gi-yäñbina. Emba wäna wäna yagwalañwa aduwaba
wurremangadirra yirra-be-mini-ñayin-dänama yagwalañwa
ma ayaugwa yaga-maginama wurrugwala wänamamalya.
Agäna änindilyaugwa ma yagwalañwa ma yagi-yäñbinama aara
ñerñwuyerrgwajema amangadirra augwa änindilyaugwa awurrariya
agina.*

When these white missionaries ask us that today when we speak today, when we tell other Aborigines about our Father in Heaven some of us Aborigines speak we mix English and our language. The old women and old men don't understand those words of ours but if we only speak our language they'll understand. Those white people when you and I speak in our Änindilyauga they want just Änindilyaugwa us to speak just Änindilyaugwa. But if you speak English, just speak English. But these white people of ours today want us to speak to other Aborigines in our language. But we will speak in our Änindilyaugwa not mix English and Änindilyaugwa that is bad.⁸⁸

Speaking in his own language, Nanggaringa said that the missionaries were diluting his language. When missionaries insisted Aboriginal people use A nindilyakwa to speak about missionary religion ("our Father in Heaven"), Anindilyakwa became mixed with the missionaries' language so the old people could not understand. "We will speak *our* Anindilyakwa," he concluded, using the separation of language to assert Anindilyakwa authority on religious matters.

Other missionaries blamed Anindilyakwa-speakers' failure to embrace their language at church on an innate Anindilyakwa conservatism. The chaplain, David Woodbridge, reported with some frustration in 1970:

The strong preference was shown for English. This shows the conservatism of these people. (i.e. the Prayer Book was in 1662 English when we first received it . . . and that is how it should stay!!!).⁸⁹

In his oral history, Woodbridge explained his belief that the reluctance to alter the service was due to Aboriginal conservatism, originating in oral traditions.

[Aboriginal people] respected the Gospel, the Bible as it was taught by the missionaries. That was it. Move away from it and you were in trouble. Maybe it wasn't all that thought out, they just knew, "this is it, these people brought the Bible to us, so this is what we have. If it's not there, it can't be right." . . . At one stage I tried to introduce a simple English service to Roper. It was just Morning Prayer in a simple, simple English, not Kriol. And [Elizabeth] wouldn't have it. "This is not the service the missionaries brought us." 1662 is what they brought! And she wouldn't have a bar of it. . . . They are an oral society, all their stories, they come that way.

So don't change it, even if it is archaic English and you don't speak English anyway.⁹⁰

Missionary Perce Leske also remembered a similar incident when asking Gumbuli Wurramarrba about his choice of prayer book:

I asked [Gumbuli] "which book do you use, do you use the new Prayer Book." He said, "you can use that, but we use the proper book," the old one. Anything that they'd been introduced to from the beginning, that was always right because in Aboriginal society being an oral tradition, everything had to be word perfect and nothing could be changed.⁹¹

Missionaries were unaware of the irony of labeling as "conservative" Aboriginal people who had, in the space of a generation or two, integrated a new religion into their lives and were now asserting how they would practice it. The average tenure of a missionary was only four years, so they could be forgiven for overlooking the considerable innovations and changes made by Anindilyakwa people over the previous thirty years. Blaming Aboriginal oral cultures for Anindilyakwa-speakers' unwillingness to give up the old prayer book reflects a missionary misunderstanding of oral tradition. Anindilyakwa oral tradition does not involve memorizing songs word for word, passing them down through the ages, as if it were simply a poor substitute for writing or reading from a hymn book. Instead, there is considerable scope for flexibility and innovation on the part of singers to introduce their own flavor to songs.⁹²

Likewise, the view in Aboriginal cultures that the world has an underlying stability creates opportunities for accommodation and innovation through finding continuities. David Turner found that on Groote Eylandt there had been considerable changes in Aboriginal thought and activity since the arrival of the missionaries.⁹³ Nonetheless, he found that Anindilyakwa systems for negotiating change remained. For example, while many people at Angurugu had accepted belief in the Bible, they did not do so on the same grounds as missionaries (divine inspiration) but on the grounds of the sanctity of the past. As Turner explained, "What the old White men in the Bible said seemed just as credible to certain people as what the old Aboriginal men had to say."⁹⁴ Innovation was guided by an underlying changelessness; in this case, the authority of the "old people" long ago. Where missionaries saw conservatism, Anindilyakwa people were actually incorporating new things into their traditions through finding commonality and continuity. Anindilyakwa people's insistence on the old prayer book and the continued use of archaic English, therefore, does not reflect an innate conservatism, but a

desire to innovate and integrate these new ideas by finding continuities with their own traditions, which value things passed down by the old people.

For the missionaries, the Aboriginal unwillingness to adopt the new services thrust upon them by a later generation of missionaries was due to the essential ritualism and traditionalism of Aboriginal oral cultures. Oral traditions left Aboriginal people slow to change and innovate, they believed. The culture of repetition and ritual, according to missionaries, prevented Aboriginal people from seeing the value of change and using language they understood. Missionaries thought they were finally offering Aboriginal people the opportunity for a “vital” and “authentic” faith, one that reached Aboriginal hearts and minds through the “heart language.” The supposed conservatism of Aboriginal cultures prevented Aboriginal people adopting the “authentic” and “cultural” worship missionaries now offered.

Anindilyakwa people played a pivotal role in any missionary translations or linguistic efforts, which casts doubt on the viability of theories of the “colonization” of their consciousness. Missionaries could never be free of their dependence on native speakers in translation.⁹⁵ Historian Joseph Errington, for example, found that the Spanish missionaries also used linguistics to “appropriate [Indigenous] speech” in order to “give a language back to its own speakers as the medium of Christian discourse.” They transformed the meanings in the languages and imbued them with their own symbolism to fit them for Christianity. They attempted to bring Indigenous words “into closer alignment of God’s word” and thus transform Indigenous thought.⁹⁶

Yet the missionary linguistic project turned out to be more difficult than the monks had anticipated. Rather than displacing Indigenous meanings, they created a kind of syncretism. SIL linguist Kenneth Pike, who had taught Stokes and Farley at the SIL summer schools in the 1950s, explicitly recommended that missionary linguists attempt to imbue Indigenous words with Christian concepts. Pike recommended that translators “choose the closest pagan equivalent” to whichever word they would translate and “trust the Spirit to build it into a Christian concept.”⁹⁷ Yet even Pike acknowledged that the translator is powerless to effect the acceptance of the new meaning in the speech community. As much as the CMS would wish to portray Stokes as an “expert,” a “master” in the language, she was dependent on informants or Aboriginal cotranslators. Stokes’s early translation method was to explain biblical concepts in English to Anindilyakwa translators, who then gave the concept back to her in Anindilyakwa. Stokes herself was alarmed that CMS officials might consider her an expert. In 1966, on hearing a rumor that she was to be based in Darwin, she responded angrily, “does CMS think incidentally that I already know Anindilyaugwa thoroughly? I may know more than anyone else—but I will need to do a lot of research!”⁹⁸ As Rachael Gilmour found, colonial linguists were dependent on dialogue with native speakers who taught, advised, and interpreted. Though linguists may have sought to

“mitigate or manage” the presence of native speakers, they could never erase their influence.⁹⁹

Anindilyakwa people themselves controlled whether translations would be acceptable. For example, the most difficult, but the most important, translation for missionaries was finding a word for the divine, for “God,” in a “heathen” language. Missionaries took care not to “take the name of the Lord thy God in vain.” In some missionary contexts, it was necessary to demonstrate that Indigenous peoples had a concept of the divine, as this would prove to their detractors that Indigenous peoples were fully human and could be converted to Christianity. For example, the early Presbyterian missionary William Ridley defined the Kamilaroi word *Baiame* as “God,” describing the figure as a “Maker” or “Supreme Being.”¹⁰⁰ In Central Australia, missionary Carl Strehlow and anthropologist Baldwin Spencer clashed over the translation of the Western Arrernte word *altyerre*. Strehlow translated it “God,” Spencer called it “the dream times.”¹⁰¹

Using existing words to describe the spiritual realm risked confusing Christian doctrine with “pagan” ideas, but it could also be a deliberate strategy to eliminate Indigenous concepts. At the Yolngu missions, missionary Theodore Webb was determined to use Yolngu ideas in his translations, so he chose the Yolngu word *wangarr* to refer to the Christian deity. *Wangarr* are Yolngu spiritual or totemic beings: the ancestors. Missionary Wilbur Chaseling explained the intent of this translation. It would effect slow, almost imperceptible, and yet radical change on Yolngu culture.

Wangarr can be filled with Jesus’ conception of “God the Father” without doing damage to Aboriginal culture. No cleavage becomes apparent, except that killings, due to ignorance and superstition, are disappearing, and new life and vigour are infusing their ancient but stagnant nature-religion.¹⁰²

The objective was to use language to dissolve Aboriginal people’s distinct spirituality without Yolngu people ever noticing. Chaseling sought to fill Yolngu Matha with Christian meanings in a kind of “colonization of consciousness.”

But, in fact, the reverse occurred. The Christian God became a Yolngu Creative Spirit. When revising their Bible in 1976, Yolngu leaders opted to retain the word *wangarr*, not because it had been emptied of its original Yolngu meanings, but because they believed the Christian God fit within the same order of beings as their *wangarr*. They had assimilated God into their cosmology, and their Bible would affirm the existence and power of their *wangarr*.¹⁰³

Most missionaries chose to import a loan-word, rather than risk the identification of the Christian god with a foreign deity. This also carried some

risk. When it came to God, rather than “colonize” an Anindilyakwa word, the CMS introduced the word *god* into Anindilyakwa. Stokes’s songs and Bible translations also used the English word *God*. One might see in this the disdain the CMS had for Aboriginal ceremony; no word could be “redeemed” and used to refer to God.

Despite missionary debates over naming God, the decision was ultimately made by Indigenous converts. Sometime in the 1970s, Anindilyakwa speakers began referring to God as Neningikarrawara, which means “Him belonging to above.”¹⁰⁴ “Above” was where missionaries located Heaven. But the mythic figure Nambirrirrma, also came from above, coming down from a cloud on the rain to Bickerton Island where he established the marriage laws for the people of the island. Some people suggested he came from God. Perhaps the name “belonging to above” was chosen due to an association of God with Nambirrirrma, the law-giver from above.¹⁰⁵ God was now imagined geographically, in relation to the landscape and sky. In naming, Anindilyakwa speakers asserted themselves as able to name the divine in their own language. God became Anindilyakwa—exactly what the missionaries had hoped for—but this occurred despite the missionaries’ own translation decisions. Anindilyakwa speakers found their own words for Christian beliefs, and missionary linguists had to rewrite their translations accordingly.

Though missionaries cared about Aboriginal people, they were conflicted about their “Aboriginality.” “Aboriginality” could mean insincerity, untrustworthiness. A boriginal culture was inherently disingenuous and insincere. Throughout the 1960s, however, missionary conceptions of “Aboriginality” developed as they became convinced that the “heart language” was essential for authentic, sincere worship. In a bizarre paradox, capturing the power of “Aboriginality” through Aboriginal language was increasingly the key to sincere faith. Missionaries turned to linguistics to “penetrate” the elusive Aboriginal minds and hearts, to communicate on a deeper level and to know for sure if conversions were genuine.

Unexpected Authenticity

Although some missionaries may have aimed at what could be called a “colonization of consciousness” through language, their dependence on Anindilyakwa cooperation made this impossible. If missionary linguistics was a tool to penetrate the mind, it was at best a blunt instrument at Angurugu. The missionary linguistic project on Groote Eylandt was fraught with difficulties and obstructions. Perhaps if the mission had produced more translated texts and taught more Anindilyakwa to read them, they might have succeeded in implanting their evangelicalism in Groote Eylandt. But this project depended on substantial Anindilyakwa cooperation and enthusiasm for use of their language in the church that was not forthcoming.

Anindilyakwa engagements with the missionary linguistic projects cannot be flattened out as simply resistance against missionary power. To presume this is to join with missionaries in assuming that any Anindilyakwa participation in English-speaking missionary Christianity was inevitably insincere, based on a similar essentialist vision of Aboriginality.¹⁰⁶ Despite the expectations of today's West that Indigenous conversions were only "mimicry" or "false consciousness," Indigenous people embraced missionaries' Christianity in their own ways.¹⁰⁷ In so doing, they rejected "repressive authenticities" prescribed for them by settler-colonists. On Groote Eylandt, the Anindilyakwa refusal to abandon English in the church suggests that for some Anindilyakwa-speakers, Christian worship in English had become meaningful and important, though in ways that differed from missionaries' own evangelical experiences. A translation was under way.

SINGING IN TONGUES

Translation through Song

Music and language are twins. Like speech, music is organized sound. It has sentences, phrases, and punctuation. It uses recurring symbols—tonality, cadence, chords—such that it comes close to communicating concepts.¹ In the Western tradition, music and language have long been thought to share a profound connection. The Enlightenment philosopher and composer Jean-Jacques Rousseau mused that song and speech emerged together at the birth of human society.

The first discourses were the first songs; the periodic and measured recurrences of rhythm, the melodious inflections of accents cause poetry and music to be born along with language; or rather, all this was nothing but language itself in those happy climates and those happy times.²

Song, like spoken language, is ephemeral. Until the arrival of mechanized recording, it existed only for the moment in performance, as sound in time. Unlike words or notes on a page, songs are events. Other forms of writing can fulfill their purpose in print, but songs notated in books exist to be

realized in oral form, to be vocalized. In song, literacy is the servant of orality.

Singing is also an embodied practice, an experience. The experiential aspect of songs, their evanescence and their ability to evoke mood and memory, makes them powerful influencers of thought and identity. Songs create formative experiences that instill beliefs and values and identities.

The power of music to forge identities raises the questions of whether or how Indigenous people maintained their identities in the face of influential missionary musical traditions. As Jean and John Comaroff explain, missionaries fostered hymn singing in the hope that “sung creeds would imprint themselves on reluctant hearts.” For the Comaroffs, song was an “indirect” means for missionaries to reach their target; through constant repetition, Christian songs would become “imperceptibly written on the minds of the people.”³ The use of religious songs in the Angurugu school, it seems, had a similar purpose. Kirstin Dutcher Mann examined music as an instrument for evangelism in colonial New Spain and argued that music fulfilled many functions of the mission, far beyond simply attracting Indigenous people and teaching them doctrine. The repetition of songs helped establish social control over the Indigenous population. Although music was intended as an instrument of control, a “rich, syncretic musical culture” evolved, even among those who ultimately rejected the mission and its faith.⁴

In Australia, Aboriginal people made Christian music their own, transforming it in order to assert Aboriginal identities. For example, globalized forms of Christian worship have become a new avenue to express Yolngu relationship to country and ritual senses of identity.⁵ At Ernabella, Christian hymns became an expression of connection to country and of an Ernabella Christian Aboriginal identity.⁶ Christian hymns learned in mission have become central to the formation of Christian Aboriginal identities in the face of the loss of traditional knowledge. Aboriginal people formed “gumleaf bands” and choirs that toured across New South Wales and Victoria in the interwar period, performing hymns and mission tunes, but bringing their own fresh interpretations to the genre.⁷ As Ngarrindjeri woman Leila Rankine explained, her people accepted mission hymns “as part of [their] cultural heritage.”⁸

While the role of Christian songs for asserting Aboriginal Christian and mission identities is well established, the other ways in which Aboriginal people engaged with mission music are not so well understood. If songs established and reasserted Aboriginal identities, did they also deny others? What about the identities of those who did not embrace the church—what did the songs mean to them? How, then, did the encounter with the missions and their songs on Groote Eylandt shape other Aboriginal songs, those outside the church and missionary Christianity? Was singing a site of resistance in the face of missionary attempts to control, or was it a space for adaption,

accommodation, and even exchange? What was found, or lost, in the translation of music at the mission?

Anindilyakwa Singing Traditions

When Europeans arrived on Groote Eylandt, they noticed the music. In 1921, anthropologist Norman Tindale witnessed the “usual nightly performance” of the *yiraka* (didjeridu).⁹ Tindale claimed the camp could not sleep without the sound of the *yiraka*, which continued, unceasing.¹⁰ Yulgi Nunggumadjbarr remembered as a child listening to “didjeridu, clapping sticks, singing in the night. Old men used to sing all night.”¹¹ In her visits in the early 1960s, musicologist Alice Moyle was impressed by the diversity of music she heard in Angurugu. There were Christian choruses from the camp service, the “strumming of triads on a cheap guitar,” and even Indonesian pop music, picked up on a transistor radio. Indigenous Anindilyakwa music, however, dominated camp life. The sounds of men singing with the didjeridu continued through the night into the early hours of the morning.¹²

Anindilyakwa people sing for pleasure, they sing to their children, they sing to teach and learn, and they sing for ceremony. Songs are central to Aboriginal cultures. Musicologist Catherine Ellis called music “the main intellectual medium through which Aboriginal people conceptualize their world.”¹³ Nancy Lalara stated that “nothing can match the power of the Songs for Ceremonial people.”¹⁴ As Anindilyakwa people insisted, to understand Anindilyakwa culture, one first had to understand the place of songs.

Each clan has its own songs (*emeba*), though from an Anindilyakwa perspective it would probably be more accurate to say that it is the songs that have the clans. These songs are sung for entertainment, but they also have deep spiritual significance. The *emeba* are songs that were sung by the Creative Beings as they traveled over the landscape, imbuing the land with form and meaning, and leaving something of themselves behind. What they left in the land eventually established the spiritual identities of the people who “incarnated” these places.¹⁵ Aboriginal songs recount the activities of their Creative Beings: hawk, stingray, shovel-nose shark, parrot. People belong to the land from which their “songline” emanates—that is, the place where the Creative Being began its journey. By referring to the Creative Beings and places they visited, the songs assert clan affiliation and territory. Songs are so important to clan identity that to find out what clan a person belongs to, one could ask, in Anindilyakwa, “what is your song (*emeba*)?”¹⁶ Songlines, not clans, are also the primary way of determining relationships between people. To understand how the various clans are interrelated, one must ask not who has married whom, or who lives where, but who sings together in ceremony. Songs connect land and family, and are intimately linked to all areas and practices of life.



Johnny with accordion (Keith Hart Collection, Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

When somebody dies, the *emeba* are sung. When the body dies, the spirit returns to what David Turner called the “other side” after traveling pathways over the landscape.¹⁷ The songs sung during mortuary rituals carry the spirit of the deceased on a journey through his or her country, following the paths of Creative Beings and describing their activities in the landscape as they travel.¹⁸ The spirit of the deceased will encounter various mythic beings on the journey. Through singing, the songmen accompany the spirit. They travel together through important places, tracing the geography around the island, naming the places in the songs as they follow the songlines of Creative Beings. Beginning at the place where the body was buried (or, in pre-European times, the platform on which the body was placed), the spirit goes on to a special “Big Name” place on the coast in his or her country. Then, the mourners sing the spirit out into the ocean, swimming through the water to Amburrgba (North East Island) and then to Wuragwuga, which Turner calls a “kind of gateway” to Braulgwa (also called Deludula in Anindilyakwa), a land of the dead, somewhere under the sea beyond North East Island.¹⁹ The songs are forms of *amawurrena*: a deep spiritual power or spirituality, which allows the singers to “carry” a place around them as they sing. Though *amawurrena* is inside all created things, it can only be truly grasped while singing.²⁰



Men in funeral dance for Quartpot, 1968 (Keith Hart Collection, Groote Eylandt Linguistics)

Songs are not composed or invented, as Westerners would understand the compositional process. A *nindilyakwa* music is a manifestation of the original songs of creation that are reenacted in performance. Singers “find” the songs, “discover” them, pick them up, and follow them.²¹ Some Aboriginal peoples of North Australia receive songs through esoteric experiences with spirits or from spirits in dreams. The voice of the spirit gives power to the song.²² Turner explains that *Anindilyakwa* singers “dream up” tunes of their own, then take elements from a father or grandfather’s tune and “twist it in,” to make a new creation song, so the song is not entirely new but reimagined and rediscovered.²³ Judith Stokes recorded Gula Lalara’s explanation of how an *emeba* singer finds words by “following” the songlines in his mind. It was not as easy as one might have thought:

*Nara emeba ena ng-angkarrauma nungkuwa-wa. Ku-mebinama
ningkakina akweyekeyema, mena emikirra nara angkarruma
ngalabakiya-ba. Ningkakina k-angmakwulalama, wulkwa
k-engkirrajama mibina-langwiya mamurukwa, ebina-langwiya
angalya ki-likaja-mulangwiya, ebina-langwiya angalya
ki-lawurradina-mulangwiya, ebina-manja angalya ka-lyungkwena-
murrumanja. . . . Ene-ka eyukujiya warka kirri-yaminama-na?*

*Meme-ka mangma nungkwa-langwa kumardadinamurre-ka
ki-yakuwerribikina-manja akina-da.*

These *emeba* don't come running to you! You have to sing the *akweyekema* [tune], because the words don't come by themselves. You'll have to sit thinking about nothing else except the track where it comes from, which country you'll be passing through and how far you have to go. . . . You think it's easy, don't you? Your head will ache when you try to work it all out.²⁴

The *emeba* are not open to anyone to sing and understand. Only those connected to the songline of the Creative Beings and initiated into secret knowledge have a right to sing these songs. Restrictions on singing must be carefully observed. Aboriginal songs are owned. *Emeba* are owned by individuals who "found" or composed them, and they are also owned by clan groups (or, more correctly, the *emeba* own the clans). As Gula explained:

Ena emeba eningakwulyungkwa nare-ka, ena eningukwureya-me-ka. . . . Enene-ka emeba ningi-yame-ka ningu-mebinu-manja nganyangwa-langwa-langwa yirra-makinama. Ningi-yeliyanguma ningena, ningumurdaburridanguma. Eningaba akweyekeyema ningu-mebinurra, umba emeba emikirra ningeniki-yengbija ningi-yeliyangumurra. Ku-kwiyerribunuma angerriba eningadar-rbulangwu-wa emeba amikirra. Ku-kwiyerribenuma angerriba mamarika-wa, Anindilyakwa-wa. Ku-kwiyerribenuma angerriba amarrba-wa, ku-kwiyerribenuma angerriba eningamakarjirrakba-wa. Ku-kwiyerribenuma angerriba amara-wa.

The *akwulyungkwa emeba* [mortuary songs] aren't for fooling around with. . . . When I sang this type of singing, for my part I was scared, I can tell you. I might have sung the ones belonging to the Warnindilyakwa clan. I might have sung the ones belonging to the Wurramarrba, or the Warnungwamakajirrakba or the Wurramara clans.²⁵

Aboriginal people have learned each other's songs for centuries. Some Groote Eylandt ceremonial songs are not Indigenous, but were brought to the island by mainland clans. The Blaur song cycle, for example, comes from deep in the mainland and was passed to Groote Eylandt via the Nunggubuyu and Bickerton Island people.²⁶ It could even be argued that these mainlanders were a type of "missionary" when they came to share their ceremonies.²⁷ The Makassans also brought their songs, introducing an Islamic flavor to Arnhem Land music.²⁸ A surveyor, George Goyder, became aware of the

transmission of songs across the Northern Territory when setting up camp in Port Darwin for the first time in 1869. To his amazement, the Larrakia people sang, in English, “John Brown’s Body” (first performed in 1861).²⁹ The song had journeyed around the world. Larrakia people had learned it from Woolna people, who had picked it up from white settlers from the Adelaide River. In 1952, anthropologist Peter Worsley found that Anindilyakwa people had created their own adaptation of “John Brown’s Body,” singing about various groups who visited their island. It went, “Wanamalja, Wurabalanda, Djabani, Malei,” meaning “Anindilyakwa, Europeans, Japanese, Malay.”³⁰ Anindilyakwa people had a well-established tradition of learning, adapting, and incorporating new songs into their repertoire and continued to do so with the establishment of the mission.

Missionary Singing Traditions

The missionaries were singers, too. Apart from singing at Sunday services and the weekday morning services, they also gathered for evening sessions exclusively for singing. In the early 1950s, missionaries met in the church every weeknight for choruses. In 1955, at a staff meeting, they opted to reduce the singing to allow more time for prayer meetings. But they still sang on at least two nights a week.³¹

For evangelicals, their Word dwelled with them in their songs. They sang to celebrate, to teach, to comfort, to build solidarity, and to praise their God. Christianity, from its beginnings, has been a singing faith. According to historian David Hempton, the most distinctive characteristic of the first evangelical revival was its transmission by means of hymns. The renowned evangelical hymn-writer, John Wesley, stated that his *Collection of Hymns* contained “all the most important truths of our most holy religion.”³² Many of these continued to be sung in the twentieth century, not least by the CMS missionaries. It could be argued that hymns, rather than sermons or Bible studies, have had the greatest theological influence on most Christians. For this reason, evangelicals (including the CMS missionaries in North Australia) took the selection of hymn books very seriously, debating the strengths and weakness of various collections.

The experience of hymn singing is also a means of transmitting community experience, values, and history from one generation to another. The old hymns evoke the past and earlier generations of singers, bringing them into the present and creating the sense of a timeless community.³³ Hymns provide a way for individuals to express their faith as a community across time and space. The missionaries literally sang from the same hymn book as Anglicans in England and around the globe. Hymns were transmitted from earlier generations, and so an evangelical and Anglican identity was passed down through songs. The missionaries learned their hymns in childhood and

cherished them for the memories they evoked. Stokes even attributed her decision to become a missionary and her ability to persevere at Angurugu to a chorus she learned as a teenager.³⁴

From the first arrival of the missionaries in the 1920s, interactions with Anindilyakwa people were easiest through song. The “shared language” of singing presented a cross-cultural opportunity; songs created a space where missionaries and Anindilyakwa people could share experiences, despite differences of languages and cultures. Missionaries and Anindilyakwa people heard each other’s songs, and listened to them with curiosity. There were many similarities between the missionaries’ songs and Anindilyakwa songs: the belief in song as an instrument of spiritual power; the use of song to express identity down through the generations.

Missionaries’ songs were a welcome addition to Anindilyakwa musical life, bringing shared joy and entertainment. Music created a context where Anindilyakwa people and missionaries could relate as friends. When the mission acquired a piano in 1966, Lois Reid wrote how it enriched Angurugu’s social life, as missionaries and Anindilyakwa people entertained one another with their musical talents. One played hymns, another jazz, another scales; Myingarrawa was apparently learning to play “Do-Re-Mi” from *The Sound of Music* on the piano, to missionaries’ delight.³⁵

Many Anindilyakwa people embraced hymn singing in English. They began holding their own hymn-singing sessions in the village in the evenings, and asked if they could use the church building for this purpose in 1959. The missionaries were overjoyed that their musical culture had caught on. One missionary commented on “their great love of song,” “accuracy of note,” and “great ability to memorize both words and tunes.”³⁶ The children liked the Sunday school songs and sang them around the mission for fun.³⁷ Anthropologist Fiona Magowan has pointed out the dissonance between other missionary methods of teaching—sermons and Scriptures with an emphasis on doctrine—and the emotionally intense Aboriginal forms of teaching through song and dance.³⁸ While missionary preaching may have been culturally foreign to Aboriginal people, the singing of hymns went some way to bridge this cultural gulf in pedagogy.

Yet significant differences between Aboriginal and Western evangelical singing cultures made it unlikely that missionaries’ hymns would resonate with Aboriginal people on a deep level. For example, evangelical song was almost identical in each re-singing. Singing, for missionaries, was a repetition of a prior event (singing), word for word, just as they believed their sacred text was copied and transmitted, unchanging, through the ages. The unchanging nature of tune and words through the use of hymn books meant that the whole congregation could sing in unison. Anindilyakwa song, however, is characterized by improvisation and flexibility, demonstrating the skill of the songman and tailoring the song to the circumstances of that

particular singing. Every performance is a new manifestation of the song, bringing new features to light. In *emeba* word order and word form are not fixed. Insertion and deletion of material is common. In fact, Arnhem Land songs are constructed in such a way as to encourage personal innovation, so long as the “flavor” of the theme remains present.³⁹ In Anindilyakwa songs, the relationship between words and melody is not fixed. The words can change from one performance to the next, but the song is still considered “the same.”

Furthermore, in evangelical song melody is subordinate to lyrics. This reflects a theological commitment to the power of the meaningful word over the meaningless note. The Word is paramount. Evangelicals believed that, long ago, the universe was spoken into form: “In the beginning was the word.”⁴⁰ Wesley urged hymn singers to sing the exact words, to sing heartily and spiritually, but also modestly, so as not to be “carried away” by the sound. “Complicated music,” he said, might “corrupt” its singers, who could be caught up in the sound.⁴¹ The melody must not distract from the message. In Anindilyakwa song, however, the melodic contour of the song traces the pathways of the Creative Beings. Anindilyakwa people understood the land as having been *sung* into form, as the Creative Beings traveled. Melody is supreme because of its connectedness to the landscape. The words serve as vehicles for the melody, so must sound right on the melody and conform to the requirements of melody.⁴² For this reason, when singing *emeba*, it is permitted to insert or remove syllables from Anindilyakwa words or even to change the vowels of words, obscuring the meaning, but retaining the tune.

While the spiritual power of evangelical song was in its ability to convey a message—“Yes, Jesus loves me!” was a spiritual truth even an infant could grasp—the power of Anindilyakwa song was in its secret, deeper meaning. Aboriginal songs use special forms of language. In the Northern Kimberly, songs can be sung “halfway,” that is, blending words from various languages or pronouncing words differently and in ways that connect with the language of the spiritual world.⁴³ Songs from the Daly Region of the Northern Territory are sung in the language of the dead, a grammatically complex older language that differs from everyday speech.⁴⁴

The Anindilyakwa *emeba* use special language and have obscure, ambiguous meanings. Listeners are not expected to understand every word.⁴⁵ *Emeba* rarely mention the actual name of the Creative Being concerned. The mystery is deliberate. It separates listeners according to their understanding and controls the dissemination of secret and powerful knowledge. As Turner explains, “what separates the men from the boys, the women from the girls and the men from women is knowing what Song is really being sung.”⁴⁶ Songmen test new initiates to see if they really understand. The ability to mask the meaning of the songs of his country from the old men and women

in other lands, and even from those of his own, is a mark of an accomplished songman. There is no expectation on the part of listeners that they will understand the meaning of songs or that songs should be in a language they know. Exclusion from knowledge of song meanings is traditionally along gender lines. On Groote Eylandt, traditionally only the men sing and dance. Evangelical song, in contrast, claimed universality; these songs could be sung and understood by anyone, anywhere.

Yet these very differences between Aboriginal songs and Western singing traditions may also have contributed to the welcoming of missionary music. From an Aboriginal perspective, it may be possible to sing Christian songs without necessarily applying the same meanings as the missionaries expected, or even understanding the words. As Anindilyakwa people were used to singing in languages that were not understood, language did not prevent missionaries' songs from quickly becoming popular, even in English. The songs were a way of embracing modernity and the new, of incorporating new things into their cultures without necessarily ascribing to Christian beliefs. Like Anindilyakwa *emeba*, Christian songs taught spiritual truths. Unlike *emeba*, however, these songs were open to everyone, even little children. At Angurugu, women were more involved in the church and more eager to sing than the men. According to Yulgi Nunggumadjbarr, who at the time of her interview was the Anglican minister in Angurugu, "there's a lot of woman in the church," but the men, "they've got the ceremony and they've got that sort of thing."⁴⁷ Church and its songs proved particularly attractive to women, but men had ceremony and its songs. At some missions, the openness of Christian knowledge to women and children led some men to consider that Christianity might not be as powerful as ancestral law.⁴⁸ To many women and children at Angurugu, however, it held great appeal: They, too, could sing.

For some missionaries, it was not sufficient that songs were sung and enjoyed. For example, Judith Stokes, from her arrival in 1952, was exasperated by the prevalence of poorly understood English songs. She used the Anindilyakwa love of singing to further her case for linguistic research in the 1960s. She believed it was important to demonstrate that, unlike the *emeba*, Christian songs should be comprehensible to all. The mass appeal of Christian songs was, to her, a major concern. "There is a danger," she wrote in 1962, "that they do not understand all they sing."⁴⁹ Stokes observed how readily songs spread. She realized Aboriginal people were circulating Christian songs from missions on the mainland, but was alarmed that the songs would lose their evangelical content if missionaries did not intervene. "Their versions didn't seem to make much sense," she noted, but, disturbingly, "the children were quite content to sing it whether it made sense or not."⁵⁰

Christian choruses, she feared, would become like another "tribal song," which most Anindilyakwa people could not understand. Stokes believed that

through translation missionaries could control content and harness the existing cultures of song transmission to effect conversions. Thus, the “simple teaching” of translated hymns and choruses would “reach everyone from the old people to the little children.”⁵¹

Hymns in Anindilyakwa

Stokes began her translation work with Christmas carols, expanding the Anindilyakwa repertoire every year. In 1956 she translated two Christmas songs into Anindilyakwa.⁵² In 1958, the children sang several of Stokes’s hymns and choruses in Anindilyakwa.⁵³ Stokes’s cotranslator, Danabana, also translated hymns on her own, completing “When I Survey the Wondrous Cross” in Anindilyakwa while Stokes was on furlough. By 1962 the mission had a substantial and growing collection of Christian hymns and choruses translated into Anindilyakwa. By 1966, the missionaries were selling hymn books for fifteen cents.

Missionaries saw the translated songs as a great success. Some felt that translated songs paved the way for the CMS’s eventual support of linguistic work in the late 1960s. Earl Hughes related that when Anindilyakwa and Nunggubuyu people began “singing with gusto,” previously skeptical missionaries were convinced of the evangelistic potential of linguistic work.⁵⁴ Singing from hymn books wove literacy into the oral practice of singing, creating an incentive to read while upholding oral expressions and ways of learning familiar to Anindilyakwa people. According to the Angurugu chaplain David Woodbridge, translated songs were the leading cause of interest in vernacular literacy. More than that, they were the best way to promote vernacular literacy because of the incentive of reading the hymn book.⁵⁵ At Numbulwar, according to missionary complaints, the only Wubuy-language material that people ever cared about were the hymn and chorus books.⁵⁶ At Angurugu, likewise, Aboriginal people found the written form of their language most useful in the context of church songs, where orality and literacy were intertwined in the hymn book. In other areas of life, however, they preferred to use their language in oral form.

Stokes learned her method for translating hymns from the Milingimbi mission linguist, Beulah Lowe, who was trained by SIL. The process was to read a line of the song and discuss its meaning with an Anindilyakwa cotranslator, brainstorming related words in Anindilyakwa. Then she took the Anindilyakwa words and, experimenting with various combinations, fitted them back to the tune. The simple melodies imposed limitations on word choice, so the resulting translated song could have meanings vastly different from those of the English-language original. A very simple chorus such as “This Is the Day” remained much the same in Anindilyakwa (the English itself

is a translation from the original Hebrew of the psalm), though the syllables might be difficult to fit to the tune:

ENGLISH	ANINDILYAKWA	BACK TRANSLATION
This is the day	<i>Mema mamawurra</i>	This day/sun
That the Lord has made	<i>Ngumanekburrakama</i> <i>God</i>	Made by God
We will rejoice	<i>Narriyekiyerra,</i>	We will rejoice
And be glad in it.	<i>Akuwerikilyelyingma</i> <i>jungwuna.</i>	And be glad in it. ⁵⁷

Others had only subtle differences. “Yes Jesus Loves Me” translated into Anindilyakwa asserted that “Jesus loves you”; the closing line, “the Bible tells me so” became in Anindilyakwa “the book tells me” or even “the paper tells me” since *jurra* (*dyurra*) can refer to any paper object.

Yes, Jesus loves me	<i>Yawa, Jesus nilyälyimina</i> <i>nayuwa,</i>	Yes, Jesus loves me,
Yes, Jesus loves me,	<i>Yawa, Jesus nilyälyimina</i> <i>nunguwa,</i>	Yes, Jesus loves you,
Yes, Jesus loves me,	<i>Yawa, Jesus nilyälyimina</i> <i>nayuwa,</i>	Yes Jesus loves me,
The Bible tells me so.	<i>Dyurra gumagina.</i>	The Book/Paper tells me. ⁵⁸

Fortunately, the new translation no longer referenced “chest hair” as it did in 1921! (See the introduction, above.) The new Anindilyakwa version placed emphasis on the authority of the written word over the oral word, rather than emphasizing the authority of the Bible in particular, as in the English. Yet the “book” or “paper” did indeed symbolize the Bible. Literacy’s primary use was, again, supposed to be reading the Bible.

For more complex hymns, the meaning in Anindilyakwa changed dramatically. An example is Danabana and Stokes’s translation of Isaac Watt’s 1701 hymn “When I Survey the Wondrous Cross.” “Love so amazing, so divine, demands my life, my soul, my all,” became in Anindilyakwa simply “I shall go to Him and ask Him to take away my sins.” “Did e’er such love and sorrow meet?” was reduced to “nailed on the uplifted cross.” The pious language and emotive imagery were lost. Anindilyakwa *emeba* are full of subtly, allusion, and metaphor. It is hard to imagine the Anindilyakwa songmen developing an appreciation for evangelical hymns when stripped back to such simple concepts in translation. Generally, missionaries had shown little concern for the aesthetics of their translated hymns. In China, for example, missionaries admitted their translated songs “sound very poor,” but this was

of little consequence because “it is not the words nor the form, but the *heart* that is required.”⁵⁹ Conveying the meaning was more important than aesthetic considerations, or considerations of the sophisticated thought of Indigenous singers. For Stokes, it was difficult enough to fit long Anindilyakwa words to simple European hymn melodies, let alone retain metaphor, subtlety, or imagery.

In some places, translated hymns have been used by missionaries to attack Indigenous beliefs. At the Cape Bedford Lutheran mission, the translation of German hymns into Gugu Yimithirr was done in a way that aimed to discredit and ridicule traditional ceremony.⁶⁰ Though Stokes did not intend to ridicule, her translations spoke more directly to missionary concerns than did the original hymn. In particular, they addressed the missionary concern that Anindilyakwa people followed evil spirits. For example, the song “Tell Me the Story of Jesus” (translated into Anindilyakwa by Aringari Wurramara and Stokes) changed dramatically in translation:

Fasting alone in the desert	<i>Nagugawura nambilya manja,</i>	While he was alone
Tell of the days that are past,	<i>Satan nānu-guderrgama.</i>	Satan tempted Him.
How for our sins He was tempted,	<i>Agāna nara gen-ängirrāna,</i>	But he did not listen,
Yet was triumphant at last.	<i>Nānināba nambilyemerra.</i>	He did not sin.
Tell of the years of His labour,	<i>Nu-warduwardanuma ŋawa</i>	He kept on doing
Tell of the sorrow He bore;	<i>Nunwānigba laŋwa warga,</i>	His Father’s work,
He was despised and afflicted,	<i>Agāna na-wara Änuwa</i>	But His own people
Homeless, rejected and poor.	<i>Änelaŋwa waŋemamalya.</i>	Rejected Him. ⁶¹

The Anindilyakwa version more explicitly mentioned temptations from spirits (rather than general temptation, as in the original). It stressed the need for obedience to Christian teaching over loyalty to kin (“his own people rejected him”). Partly this was a product of removing the passive voice of the English original. Strangely, it omitted references to place—the desert—that might have been of more interest to Aboriginal singers. It also omitted references to Jesus’ poverty and homelessness; these were not traits missionaries wished Anindilyakwa people to imitate.

In 1960, Stokes reported a “new and thrilling development”: the composition of hymns and choruses in Anindilyakwa by Anindilyakwa-speakers

themselves.⁶² She published the story of the first Anindilyakwa hymn, composed by Danabana, in 1961 in the CMS newspaper.⁶³ By 1962 Stokes reported the “growing collection of Anindilyakwa hymns.”⁶⁴ According to Stokes, that some of these songs were written by Danabana “greatly increases their value.”⁶⁵ For Stokes, Anindilyakwa people’s composition of hymns was the highlight of her career. She called it a “thrill when Aborigines started composing their own Christian songs.”⁶⁶ Stokes hoped to encourage Aboriginal creativity. Nonetheless, that creativity would operate within the mission’s Christian agenda; Stokes continued to check and edit songs to ensure their orthodox content.

Eventually Aboriginal women were writing what Stokes called “streams of new songs” for the Angurugu church.⁶⁷ The dominance of women in the early hymn-writing movement is significant. As in other places, mission singing presented women with an opportunity to challenge the patriarchy in their own lives through singing in public.⁶⁸ Moyle had tried in vain to coax Anindilyakwa women to sing for her, but they would not, not even one of their lullabies.⁶⁹ But, in the first recorded song sung or composed by any Anindilyakwa woman, Danabana asserted her voice: “God hears us.”

*God neñäberaga äniñabawiya,
Ñarränugwa, nilyälyiñma ñagurruwa.
Nara ayaugwabidyema Änuwawa.*

God made everything good,
He gives them to us; He loves us,
Don’t forget Him.

*God nänelarrgama Nänugwänigba
Ñagurruwa yada. Nidyujwunumerrada
Nänibeda nelgana garrawaruwa.*

God sent His Son for us.
After he died He went back alive to
Heaven.

*God nängirradyama ñagurruwawa,
Ñarreberiyämina mandya nängirradya.
Nara ayaugwabidyema ñagurruwa.*

God hears us.
He hears us when we pray.
He does not forget us.

*God niyaugwabidya awurrariya
Änelañwa-lañwa wañamamalya.
Wuniyändabadya
Änambilya nuñguwa mandya arrawa.*

God forgives the sins of his people.
Ask Him to stay within you.⁷⁰

Danabana’s song is beautifully crafted. The second half mirrors the first: “God . . . loves us” / “God hears us”; “Don’t forget him” / “He does not forget us”; and finally a reference connecting people to place: “He went back alive to heaven” / “Ask Him to stay within you.” Her song upheld the missionaries’ theological framework. Through song, Danabana herself became a missionary evangelist, as her song implored others to “Ask God” into their hearts. This evangelism through song harnessed existing Aboriginal traditions of

orality and song transmission. Unlike government bureaucracies and missionary officials, she sang, “God hears us . . . he does not forget us.” This was an assertion of the equality of Anindilyakwa people to whites, and an appeal that the white man’s god would not overlook Aboriginal people. Furthermore, it functions as a subtle indictment of those who would not listen to her and her people, indicating that such behavior was less than Christian. Danabana used Christian song as a framework to assert Anindilyakwa identities and politics in new ways.

Anindilyakwa people had their own distinct conception of hymn composition. Like *emeba*, their hymns were not invented or created, but found and discovered, sometimes in dreams. Christian songs were distinct from the *emeba* and were not discovered in precisely the same way. Peter Gundu from Numbulwar explained that “they were making up their own songs not like ours, dream ways or our culture ways, not like that.”⁷¹ Nonetheless, the missionaries encountered difficulties as they took charge of the editing process, refining the songs, making them more suitable, according to missionary expectations. Missionary Lance Tremlett remembered that “they didn’t like you touching [their songs] or changing them because they thought they’re the words the Holy Spirit gave them. That was a problem.”⁷²

The word missionaries used to translate “Holy Spirit” in Anindilyakwa was *amawurrena*. That is the same word as the spirit (or spirituality) that is encountered when singing *emeba*, and which became incarnate as the man, Nambirrirma, at Bickerton Island (somewhat like Christ). *Emeba* songs are understood to be forms of *amawurrena*, which are found and re-enacted afresh in singing.⁷³ When Anindilyakwa Christians insisted that the Holy Spirit gave them their songs, they used not only existing Anindilyakwa frameworks for song writing (presuming that songs are found rather than composed), but also existing Anindilyakwa cosmology. Their spiritual songs continued to be understood as connected to *amawurrena*, known in English as “the Holy Spirit.” While missionaries presumed that Anindilyakwa Christians believed the Holy Spirit gave them the words, it is possible that the Anindilyakwa people understood their songs as not simply inspired by, but somehow a form of, the Holy Spirit/*amawurrena*, and therefore not open to correction. These Anindilyakwa hymns are hybrid responses to colonization—Christian, while at the same time thoroughly Anindilyakwa, and adapted to the circumstances of mission.

Despite the possibilities of translation and reinterpretation of cosmological concepts involved in the Anindilyakwa composition of Christian hymns, for many Anindilyakwa people, Christian songs could never match the *emeba*. Nancy Lalara remembered her “de-conversion” from Christianity in the 1960s. For her, it was about songs. As she explained in her memoir, she found no Christian substitute—not even hymns composed by her own sisters—for the *emeba*.

I was already defined by my father's Songs. I sang them in my head to put me to sleep at night; after I'd said my prayers. I tried to make the prayers mean something, but they weren't really a part of me . . . And when I needed real comfort I turned to my father's Songs not the Bible.⁷⁴

Though Christian songs took on Anindilyakwa forms and meanings, they could never match the *emeba* in terms of personal significance to her.

Given the success of Anindilyakwa-language hymns, missionaries began a campaign to make hymns still more "authentic" and "Aboriginal" by using Aboriginal instruments, such as the *yiraka* (didjeridu) and *alyingba* (clap-sticks). In 1959, Arthur Capell recommended adapting "incidents of the Bible" to "the corroboree." As he described it, "an aboriginal 'songman' could work out a dance that to his mind would express the theme suggested by the missionary." He explained to CMS missionaries that "corroboree was not wrong in principle" because "the Christian Church has its 'corroborees, also,' in the form of daily services, baptism, and the eucharist."⁷⁵ Earl Hughes, therefore, first tried an "experiment in using tapping-sticks for keeping time for the singing" in November 1959 at Numbulwar.⁷⁶ Beulah Lowe argued that missionaries must "present Christ in as meaningful a way as possible, in as Aboriginal a way as possible." This meant considering the use of "didjeridoo, clap sticks and Aboriginal tunes."⁷⁷ Stokes prayed in 1970, therefore, that her translated hymns would be replaced by "indigenous hymns." Again in 1972 she prayed "for the development of an indigenous hymnology," implying that hymns composed by Aboriginal people were not yet fully Indigenous; they must also use traditional musical forms.⁷⁸

There was an element of control in attempts to "Indigenize" the church through music. As the CMS official Irene Jeffreys wrote, "Aboriginal people should develop their own form of worship in accordance with [their] own culture." Still, she argued it would be "better" if this were done under the CMS's "cooperation and guidance." She pointed to the situation in Africa, where churches that "sought to express themselves in a much more African way" went on to become completely independent.⁷⁹ If the CMS itself were to guide moves to Indigenize the church services, it could maintain its influence over Aboriginal churches. Her attitude reflects an awareness of the risks involved in vernacularizing and localizing the Gospel. The new meanings of translated texts and Christian practices could, for her, amount to syncretism. By guiding and even by driving the Indigenization of the church at Angurugu, the CMS hoped that Christianity would be vernacularized but also, somehow, remain under its influence, never fully subject to reinterpretation along Indigenous lines.

Some missionaries considered such a missionary-led Indigenization of church problematic. Barry Butler, the chaplain at Ngukurr, believed

missionaries lacked the cultural knowledge (but interestingly, not the authority) to make such innovations. He noted in 1961 that missionaries had considered “incorporating genuine ‘aboriginal’ features into the service,” even discussing the possibility of “Christian corroborrees.”⁸⁰ He thought it was a bad idea, believing that, in their ignorance of the nuances of Aboriginal cultures, missionaries risked manufacturing a nonsensical ceremony. He was aware that there were many layers of meaning and symbolism in Aboriginal ceremony to which missionaries had no access. Worse, by creating “Christian corroborrees,” missionaries might endorse Aboriginal practices that, from a missionary perspective, were irreconcilable with Christianity.

Upholding Distinctions

But Aboriginal people did not conform to missionary expectations for their music. They set limits on how their traditions would be translated into Christianity. Woodbridge remembered the response to his suggestion of using didjeridu in church.

On Groote Eylandt it was absolutely taboo. . . . They would say, “no this is a ceremonial instrument, we play this at corroboree, we don’t play it in God’s house, no, no, no, no, no.” In my innocence once I thought, “it would be good if we had a didjeridu play in the church, perhaps we could make up some Christian songs to sing to it.” So I went down to the guy who was really the chief didjeridu man, he was one of the really good players and obviously involved. So I said to him, . . . “why don’t we compose some Christian songs so we can sing them with didjeridu and clap-sticks?” He looked at me aghast.⁸¹

According to Butler in 1961, missionaries suggested introducing Aboriginal musical forms, “a didjeridoo in the service or tapping sticks,” but these were rejected as “not proper.”⁸² Julie Rudder (née Waddy) also reported that she found it difficult to find a Christian man who was prepared to play the didjeridu.⁸³ Missionaries also suggested putting Christian words to traditional Aboriginal melodies. Butler had no success at Roper River in the 1960s, blaming Aboriginal “conservatism.”⁸⁴

On Groote Eylandt in the early 1970s there were some instances of using Christian lyrics to traditional Anindilyakwa melodies. In the early 1970s, a Warnungwadarrbulangwa (Bara family) tune was given Christian lyrics, but since the Bara family continued to own the tune—only they could sing it—it was never appropriate for church.⁸⁵ In 1987, Ross Wurrawilya, Millie Mamarika, and Colleen Mamarika wrote the hymn “*Jesus ni-yengbinuma na-*

kina a yakwa" to a Mamarika tune.⁸⁶ Still, the practice remained rare. Aboriginal engagement with Christian music, therefore, was different on Groote Eylandt than in other places. Methodist missionaries reported a Yolngu "Easter Corroboree" with traditional music and painting in 1964.⁸⁷ At Ernabella, Anangu people performed Christian songs to their own existing melodies, and in 1978 Warlpiri Christians performed another "Easter corroboree" featuring traditional song series, dancing, and designs.⁸⁸ Anindilyakwa people, however, were concerned to maintain Christianity and ceremonial life as distinct from each other, and they did so through rejecting moves in the 1960s and 1970s to incorporate ceremonial instruments or melodies in the church.

Perhaps this was due to an internalization of generations of missionaries' teaching that church and ceremony were opposed to one another, even in competition. In the 1950s, the missionaries had hoped their singing sessions would provide sufficient "evening entertainment to distract [Aboriginal people's] attention from the camp life of corroborees etc."⁸⁹ To occupy children in the evenings, keeping them away from the camp, the mission staff took turns to run "chorus singing" in the church from Monday to Thursday nights to teach new choruses and revise old hymns.⁹⁰ As Nancy Lalara recalled, she learned from missionaries that her father's and grandfathers' songs were "evil," but missionaries' songs were "pure."⁹¹

It is also possible that Anindilyakwa people actively preserved separate spheres for church and ceremony in order to maintain their own authority in ceremonial matters, without missionaries' meddling. As Magowan explains, in Arnhem Land ritual contexts, didjeridu accompaniments are "inalienable expressions of ancestral identity." The songs and rhythms cannot be made openly available since they "were laid down in the ancestral past."⁹²

Yolngu people at Elcho Island mission faced similar pressures to those felt by Anindilyakwa people. In what came to be known as the 1957 Adjustment Movement, some leaders decided to publicly reveal some (not all) sacred ancestral objects (*rangga*) to missionaries, women, and children alike by displaying them outside the church. They placed a Christian cross atop the central *rangga*. Anthropologist Ronald Berndt was first to document the events. He considered it an "attempt to integrate the 'traditional' Aboriginal world with the outside world."⁹³ The Yolngu leaders, he said, were finding ways to place "a positive value on traditional life" as well as to take "advantage of what is offered by Europeans."⁹⁴ The public display of the *rangga* was intended to unite all Yolngu, to demonstrate that traditional religion must be understood differently and openly from now on, and to assert the value of Yolngu traditions.⁹⁵ Magowan described the Adjustment Movement as a "gift" to the missionary superintendent and a "payment" for European knowledge. Yolngu leaders were "educating the missionaries about their religious belief

system,” while showing their understanding of Christian beliefs.⁹⁶ Howard Morphy understood it as an assertion of an exchange of “perceptions of value” whereby Yolngu asked for acceptance of their culture in return for acceptance of certain European values.⁹⁷ Anthropologist Ian McIntosh, after new conversations with Yolngu leader David Burrumarra, concluded that the Adjustment Movement was intended as “a springboard for community revitalization” based on a fresh interpretation of existing Yolngu stories.⁹⁸ For Burrumarra, the Adjustment Movement marked the end of an older policy of separation and disharmony between Yolngu and Europeans. It was a statement of “reconciliatory intent.”⁹⁹

For some Yolngu, however, the adjustment was scandalous. Burrumarra and the others faced opposition from the beginning, and were prevented from bringing out more *rangga*. The women at Elcho mission were terrified. Some fled to Mililingimbi or to the mainland, spreading news of what had occurred across Arnhem Land. When they returned, they refused to look at the *rangga*. Berndt recorded the response of Yolngu at Yirrkala: “As soon as the *mareiin* (sacred objects) were shown the people went mad . . . As soon as we heard this word, this new custom, all of us at Yirrkala were very worried—and we still are.”¹⁰⁰

Furthermore, missionaries did not seem to appreciate the gravity of the revelation of the *rangga* as a reconciliatory action. The Methodist missionaries on Elcho Island were comparatively open to Yolngu cultures and yet interpreted the Adjustment Movement as a victory for Christianity through the demystification of the *rangga*. They called it an answer to prayer.¹⁰¹ Missionaries at Yirrkala, according to Berndt, “knew little about it.”¹⁰² Morphy concluded that the Yolngu leaders’ actions were interpreted by missionaries (and even some other Yolngu) as desacralization of the *rangga*.¹⁰³ Even Burrumarra eventually concluded that it did not achieve the unity and peace it sought.¹⁰⁴

Having seen the outcome of the radical Yolngu opening of their *rangga*, what, then, could Anindilyakwa people gain by opening up their *emeba* to be sung in the church? Perhaps Anindilyakwa people did not even hold out the hope that their missionaries might understand the significance of the *emeba* and so would not risk their displacement. On hearing of events at Elcho Island mission, Anindilyakwa people likely resolved to manage the missionaries differently. Subsequently, their sacred instruments and melodies were not allowed to fall into missionary hands. Meanwhile, there were other new instruments, such as guitars and keyboards, that presented an opportunity to Anindilyakwa people for new musical expression and creativity while preserving the sanctity of the *yiraka* in its ritual context. Through maintaining distinctions of ceremony and church, Anindilyakwa people resisted what the Comaroffs call the “web of symbolic and material transactions” that would bind them to the colonizing culture.¹⁰⁵

Creative Retranslations

The resistance to missionaries' attempts to bring the *emeba* and *yiraka* into the church sphere, however, did not mean that Anindilyakwa people were uninterested in innovation. On the contrary, they selectively translated elements of missionary teaching, weaving aspects of Christian belief into the *emeba*. The biblical text, filtered through an English tradition, took on new meanings and implications in the context of Groote Eylandt. Missionaries could never control the interpretation of their translated texts. Turner, for example, found the Mardayin ceremony was "replete with Christian symbols, including a reference to 'Old Testament Law' and is managed by 'Bishops and Priests.'" ¹⁰⁶ In particular, Christ's teaching on the "narrow way" was re-interpreted in translation and incorporated into the *emeba*. ¹⁰⁷

Inspired by this text, the seventeenth-century writer John Bunyan created his hero, Christian, in *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678), who found the Wicket Gate on his journey to the "Celestial City." *The Pilgrim's Progress* was a seminal text of evangelicalism, used extensively in both home and foreign missions as a "shadow" Bible through the nineteenth century and into the twentieth. Missionaries at Angurugu showed films based on *The Pilgrim's Progress* in the 1950s. The chaplain believed that, since the story was based on a "dream," it would be particularly resonant for Aboriginal people who believed in a Dreamtime. ¹⁰⁸ The Christian mission organization Gospel Recordings supplied the CMS with texts for Indigenous evangelists to translate and record. The messages were biblically based, but also mediated through the evangelical tradition of *The Pilgrim's Progress*. ¹⁰⁹ In 1951, Nabilya recorded various texts. Judith Stokes later transcribed his recording and retranslated it back into English to uncover what he had preached.

God niyämamerra mambilyuma magina mamarugwa. Muwilyaba nemelegadya waramwa, muwilyaba nemederrenda arrawa. Muwilyaba mäniñaba, muwilyaba mämawurriya. Muwilyaba Jesus-lañwa mamarugwa, miñga wurramugwa-lañwa mamarugwa. Jesus-lañwa mamrugwa nemelegadya añubinawa, mäniñaba mamarugwa magina. Wurremendagibina mäniñaba mamarugwa magina. Wurremendagibina mäma mandya gale-gadyama wurriyägirrärä. Alanguwurra-riya narrelanguwurranga—Jesus nelarrñ-guwurranga agina. Wurramugwa-lañwa mamrugwa nemelegadya arrawa. Wurremendagibina nalegadyamerra magina mandya mamarugwa nara alegañuma añubinawa. Gañwadurñwadäyina wurragina añwura mandya arñgwulyaba. ¹¹⁰

God says there are two roads. One goes above, one descends. One is good, one is bad. One is Jesus' road, the other is the devil's road.

Jesus' road goes above, that is a good road. Those who go on this are happy. They have thrown away their sins—Jesus has thrown them away. The devil's road goes below. Those who go on that road won't go to Heaven. They will cry in the fire for ever.¹¹¹

The theme of the “two roads” was common in other Anindilyakwa-language texts. Stokes's early Anindilyakwa prayers, for example, mention God's “good road.”

*Nuḡwānuḡwa abalgaya aṅubina mandya,
yirriyāṅbina nuṅguwawa māna neṅge-
lyälyiymina baba yirruwa. Nara alegaṇuma
wurramugwa yirruwawa, emba
yirredederra-
gina wurragina laṅwa . . .
Yirrenugaṅbidiyina nuṅgulaṅwa
mamarugwa māniṇaba. Garreberreṅgena
wanuḡwa. Yälaugwa wurraṅgwulyemeda
aṅalya mandya. Äṅgirradya yirruwawa,
mäna yirriyāṅgelabadya Jesus-laṅwa-ma
agirra.
Amindaṅwa.¹¹²*

Our father above heaven in
we talk to you because you
love because us. Don't let come
evil spirit to us but protect us

harm from . . .
Show us your
road good. Watch over them
the people here all of them
camp in. Listen to us.

The repetition of the road metaphor in Anindilyakwa-language missionary teaching spoke to Anindilyakwa understandings of the intersecting spiritual and geographical worlds. *Mamarugwa*, translated as “road,” is also the word for the “road” the spirit travels across the landscape through its country after death. When anthropologists discussed beliefs about the after-life with Anindilyakwa elders, they found that, for some, the message of the “two roads” had taken root in Anindilyakwa cosmology. Yet this happened not in ways missionaries might have expected, but rather according to Anindilyakwa beliefs in the journeys of Creative Beings. Peter Worsley in his 1954 dissertation mentioned that although the old people would go to Braulgwā after death, many believed that the young would go to Heaven instead.¹¹³ When Turner visited Angurugu in 1969, he found songmen singing dead people's spirits along a new *mamarugwa* (road), not to Braulgwā but to Heaven. Turner spoke with a leading songman, Warnaya, who had been doing this since his brother's death in the mid-1950s, as well as with Gula Lalara, who also led the innovation.¹¹⁴

Warnaya explained that since the Bible taught that when people die their spirits go to “a place in the sky” or to “a place called Hell,” but the ancestors taught that all people go to Braulgwā, he had concluded that the ancestors were unaware that there were actually two destinations. Since the ancestors had no

knowledge of God or Jesus (inhabitants of Heaven), Braulgwa must be the place the missionaries called “Hell.” In the past, “the ancestors had taken the spirits there by mistake, to a bad place, because they did not know of the existence of this good place.”¹¹⁵ To get to the “good place,” instead of singing the spirit to Amburrnga (North East Island), spirits must be sung up Yandarrnga (Central Hill) and, from there, up into the sky. Yandarrnga, the rock that had spread their words over the land, became the route to Heaven. The songman explained:

When you sing the song, it’s like closing your eyes and imagining you are going along through the places. First I take the dead person’s spirit with me to Heaven. Then I and all the other spirits come back together into this world. When I get here I have to take all the spirits back again. I let them go as far as I want, then I come back myself.¹¹⁶

Warnaya informed Turner that he had reached his conclusions based on a picture the missionaries had shown him.

This poster, or ones like it, were used at Aboriginal missions to promote the benefits of conversion and to display the frightening consequences of rejecting missionary teachings. The missionaries’ poster, though based loosely on the biblical text, is strongly influenced by *The Pilgrim’s Progress*. It features the Wicket Gate, the evangelist pointing the way, and the burdened pilgrim whose heavy load falls away upon reaching the Cross: all images derived from Bunyan. It reflects a Christianity translated for English-speaking evangelicals. When placed in the Anindilyakwa context, however, the biblical text, mediated through translated teachings in Anindilyakwa and the missionaries’ image of “The Two Ways,” took on new meanings.

For Warnaya, the hill at the end of the “good road” to Heaven as seen in the poster was clearly Central Hill, Yandarrnga. On the “new road,” instead of encountering mythic beings as on the “old road,” the dead person’s spirit would arrive at a large wooden cross before beginning the ascent. Although the “new road” led a different way to a different destination, mortuary rituals associated with the “new road” were otherwise the same as along the “old road.”

Not all Anindilyakwa people welcomed the innovations made by songmen at Angurugu. The songmen at Umbakumba kept following the “old road.” Nangmenara, also a leading songman, told Turner that “they make up a new road—they sing up Jandarrnga [Central Hill] to heaven—that’s not right.”¹¹⁷ Some compromised by singing “two ways”—that is, singing a spirit to Heaven when the leading songman requested it and to Braulgwa when he did not.¹¹⁸ In his Anindilyakwa version of “The Two Ways,” Nabilya explained, “*Jesus nelegadyamerra ünelanjwa mandya mamarugwa nungunuwa*”



“The Two Ways” poster (from Turner, *Tradition and Transformation*)

(“Jesus goes on his road with you”).¹¹⁹ What did this mean to him? Did Jesus accompany the spirit of the deceased along with the songman and ancestors on its journey? Turner attributed the belief in the “new road” to a literal interpretation of the missionaries’ picture of “The Two Ways.” Yet I consider it a more complex engagement with the missionaries’ teaching and an example of the way Christianity in translation was, in Elbourne’s words, “out of control.”¹²⁰

Minoru Hokari found that for the Gurindji people, to “follow the right way” had both a moral and spatial dimension. “The right way,” he explained, “includes a geographical Dreaming track as well as ethical behavior.”¹²¹ It had to do with the songlines of Creative Beings and journeys across the landscape. The “right way” was not an abstract concept of moral living, but actually a way of traveling and being in country. It is similar for Anindilyakwa people. For example, Anindilyakwa people will sing upon entering certain

countries or visiting certain places to apologize for disturbing the spirit of the place.¹²² Morality and geography are intertwined.

When missionaries and Anindilyakwa people spoke of going God's "good road," Anindilyakwa people understood that the "right way" had both geographical and moral dimensions. Over the years, Angurugu's mission Christianity had developed a spatial dimension. The mission was Christian space, and for some Anindilyakwa people, missionary Christianity was rooted in place, that is, in the physical surrounds of the mission. Christianity had made the Jewish hope of rest in the Promised Land a universal hope for all people in all places. As occurred in other mission contexts, Aboriginal people made this universal hope local and particular again.¹²³ God's country became a geographical reality on Groote Eylandt. In the early days of the mission the punishment for "misconduct" was to be "sent off" by the superintendent for a period of months.¹²⁴ Those discovered "fighting" were sent on "punishment walkabout."¹²⁵ In the 1960s the punishment for "abducting girls" from the dormitory was also to be "exiled in punishment."¹²⁶ The mission's punishment mirrored ancient Israel's exile to Babylon, with Angurugu as the Promised Land. Jenny Green remembered the old men telling girls in the late 1960s, "if you want to play up, you go and live in Darwin. This is a mission, you behave yourself here!" She commented that Anindilyakwa Christianity "was tied to the fact that you lived on a mission, you were a Christian, if you didn't want to, you lived in a town and did whatever you want and then you came back."¹²⁷ Likewise, Yulgi Nunggumadjbarr saw Darwin as a source of sickness and wrongdoing: "they go to Darwin, they drink, they smoke, they do a lot of things and all that sickness came."¹²⁸ Darwin represented a "lawless" space beyond the Christian mission environment. Occasionally, Anindilyakwa Christians would confess to the chaplain "things in Darwin," "wrong-doing while in Darwin," and be reconciled to the mission community when returning to Groote Eylandt.¹²⁹ While for the missionaries, place was neutral (their universalist Christianity held the same morality for all places), Anindilyakwa people had a keen sense of relationship with country and understood law to be embedded in geography, on both land and sea.¹³⁰ Thus the missionaries' spatial punishment of exile communicated to some Anindilyakwa people a particular relationship to, and right way of living in, the mission space.

The translated message of the roads opened up new interpretive opportunities and new readings for Anindilyakwa people. Singing the spirits across their country and up to Heaven meant imbuing the landscape of Groote Eylandt with Christian meanings. The Christian Heaven was mapped into the land by the Angurugu songmen, translating missionary Christianity in unexpected ways. Austin-Broos describes religious conversion not merely as a journey, but as a quest for *habitus*. Conversion is more than "travel," it involves "an encultured being arriving at a particular place."¹³¹ For some

Anindilyakwa people, this passage involved converting a geography into a landscape with Christian significances. The encultured journey entailed a reconceptualization of the land itself.

At least one missionary, Judith Stokes, was aware that songmen were singing people's spirits up Yandarrnga to Heaven. When a Christian woman died in 1972, three male relatives, Bayima, Abadjura, and Narragidjarra, sang "Christian words for the customary music." Stokes recorded the event and the music.

They sang several different clan totem tunes, improvising words relating to her spirit's journey to Heaven instead of to Berralgwa [Braulgwa], the traditional place of departed spirits. This singing cannot be repeated, but Bayima recorded it and although no Europeans were present at the time I was able to copy it, and later Narragadjarra went through the tape with me. From time to time I have talked to Bayima about using Aboriginal music for hymns, and this could be the opening we are hoping for.¹³²

Stokes was not concerned that the singing might amount to syncretism. As an evangelical she could be expected to reject suggestions that people might enter Heaven through songs and not through faith alone. Perhaps she hoped singers merely sang *about* the journey to Heaven rather than actually effecting it. Perhaps she saw the practice of singing spirits over the landscape to Heaven as a step toward what would eventually become a more orthodox Christianity. In her concern to encourage an "authentically" Anindilyakwa Christianity (underpinning her desire to see similar songs used in church), perhaps she did not consider how different such a Christianity was from her own or question whether it even was Christianity. Or perhaps Anindilyakwa Christianities had changed her own understanding of faith, leading her, too, to see Christian meaning in the island's landscape.

Conversion, Creativity, and Misunderstanding

It could be said that music was the context where missionaries experienced their greatest success in vernacularizing and disseminating their Gospel for willing listeners. Perhaps this has to do with the importance of song for Anindilyakwa people. Even then, Anindilyakwa people set limits on missionaries' musical projects; their *emeba* would not be "colonized" for the church. Instead, the translation of songs became a means for Anindilyakwa people to appropriate and reinterpret missionary faith and ideas, to find new meanings and create Anindilyakwa Christianities. Missionaries' songs took on new and unexpected meanings when endowed with Anindilyakwa words,

and Anindilyakwa people found that missionaries' words had resonances with their own songs and beliefs.

In light of these innovations, how should we view the "backsliding" that so unsettled missionaries? For some, it was likely an assertion of their own culture in deliberate resistance to the missionary regime. For example, around the same time as Nandjiwarra Amagula reinvigorated ceremony and stopped attending church, he also spoke out publicly against missionaries. For others, however, their "backsliding" may have been an attempt (possibly with increasing assertiveness and confidence) to reconcile new and existing spiritual teachings in a changing world in ways missionaries did not understand. For example, Murabuda Wurramarrba explained that although missionaries dismissed his ceremony as "backsliding," according to his interpretation of the faith, ceremony perfectly complemented the Gospel.

They didn't let us have the ceremony, missionary. "Don't worship other god," they say. But we got the strong law in our ceremony too . . . But we learn from in the beginning when the missionary come. We just got a real foundation in life, strong. After that we bin go through the our culture, our ceremony, is to come that way. And those two just work together, Missionary Law, gospel song or gospel story and those things.¹³³

Anindilyakwa people engaged with the missionary faith in complex and diverse ways, sometimes resisting it, but sometimes also reinterpreting it. Although missionaries dismissed their Christian practice as inauthentic, Anindilyakwa people selectively translated Christianity into their own world in ways meaningful to them. Anindilyakwa people used song to engage with and reimagine Christianity in their own ways, rather than in ways that missionaries might have encouraged, expected, or understood. Missionaries, instead, found themselves compelled to accommodate Anindilyakwa preferences for Christian worship. Anindilyakwa people found that translation permitted sweeping reinterpretations of the missionaries' stories and traditions according to their existing intellectual and ceremonial traditions. This included incorporating their vision of Christian teaching into their own sacred songs, the *emeba*, as they saw fit. It could be said that many did convert, particularly when they imbued the landscape of Groote Eylandt with Christian meanings, connecting the island with a Christian Heaven. Anindilyakwa people wove Christian themes into the land, making them belong to the earth, becoming Indigenous, in a way settler-colonists could not. Where the message was translated, they reinterpreted the missionaries' Gospel in unexpected ways, finding the road to Heaven in their country and claiming the right to name God for themselves, in their own tongue.

CONCLUSION

God gave us this land. God gave us the power and the thought to move from the Tower of Babel to 297 languages on Australia's soil.

—Gerry Blitner, 2007

In 1951, Nabilya Lalara translated and recorded the biblical story of Babel in Anindilyakwa for the missionaries to play on their gramophone. It could be called a “mistranslation.” In his version, there was no city, not even a tower. Instead of the tower reaching to Heaven and a vain attempt to “make us a name,” the great sin in Nabilya’s telling was the decision to “stay in one place” and “talk one language.” The sedentary, monolingual people of Nabilya’s Babel story were losing the ability to listen.

Awilyabamerra ayaugwa wurragina näyänbinemerra. Näyäma, “Awilyabamerra añalya aragba agambilyada!” Adrrunwana mandya ägbelgurrariya nuwambilya wurragina. God nederrenda biya nänerrenga. “Awilyabamerra ayaugwa näyänbinamerra, na?”

niyāma “Nara āngirrigaṇuma ṇayuwawa, nara ayauguwārribigaṇuma ayaugwa,” *niyāma*, “Gederrendamerra niṇāna gamendarrgu warruguradyinamerra ayaugwa.” Aragba aginamerrada wanamamalya nāyāṇbāyina āngiyāṅga ayaugwa. Nuwāṅgārrbalina ānguwa ānguwa aṇalya.

They spoke one language. They said “we will stay in one place now.” They lived on a big plain. God descended and saw. “They’re talking one language, are they?” He said, “they won’t listen to me, they won’t remember my word,” He said. “I shall go down and change their words!” From that time people spoke different languages. They spread out in all directions.¹

Though Nabilya told the story differently to the missionaries, his message of the importance of listening and understanding is deeply biblical: “Having eyes, see ye not? and having ears, hear ye not?” Jesus asked in the New Testament.² Although he told the missionaries’ story a fresh, Nabilya had been listening.

At the same time, this rendition of the story also reflects more Aboriginal values. He depicted monolingualism as stubborn ignorance. As Gerry Blitner, one of the “half castes” who worked at the mission, insisted, the 270 Aboriginal languages across the Australian continent are God’s gift. Those who are mature, who really understand, will know many languages. Perhaps in Nabilya’s Babel lies a critique of monolingual settler-society. Perhaps it was the English-speakers who, long ago, were punished and made to “spread out in all directions.” Perhaps this is why they left England in the first place and scattered themselves all over the world, even to Groote Eylandt. They had spread out across the earth, restless, unable to listen, with no connection between their words and land. Do not become like them, he warned Anindilyakwa-speakers. Keep listening, keep connected to your own country, or you will lose your words. Perhaps Nabilya also recognized this sentiment of the God of his story: “they won’t listen to me . . . [so] I shall go down and change their words!” The missionaries, like gods, had wielded the authority to exile people who did not listen to them and had attempted to change their language. Did the missionaries, on reading Nabilya’s message, empathize with God or with the people in the story?

Mutual Conversions

Just as in Nabilya’s reread Babel, Anindilyakwa people selectively embraced missionary teachings, to various degrees and in diverse ways, unintended by missionaries. The CMS principle was that missionaries could not “enter into

or support” ceremony, calling it “in direct opposition to the Gospel” even into the 1970s.³ Yet Anindilyakwa Christians continued to recognize the validity of ceremony and came to their own conclusions about the relationship between ceremony and church. When Michael Gumbuli Wurramara was ordained as an Anglican priest in 1973, the ordination service had strong ceremonial overtones. In the words of missionary chaplain David Woodbridge, “the men from Groote . . . danced [Gumbuli] from the ceremony ground to the church. . . . They released him from that somehow . . . so that he would not have to be involved anymore.”⁴ This event was not a denial of ceremony’s spiritual validity, as some missionaries might have hoped. Rather, through being “danced” to the church, Gumbuli acknowledged the reality of his ceremony as a spiritual force and identifier, even though he felt he could no longer participate.

Meanwhile, other Anindilyakwa people asserted that ceremony could be understood in a Christian framework: “Might be God did give us these ceremonies a long time ago,” suggested one Aboriginal Christian to the missionaries in 1968.⁵ As Murabuda proposed, deep down, ceremony and the Bible are the same.

And this ceremony, we just been go through with that ceremony. We don’t want to go on swear. We don’t want to go be speaking to another woman. You know, all that. It’s the rules. You know. Things been going on beside the missionary, you know. . . . They explain us, . . . “Thou shalt not kill” and “Thou shalt not swear,” the missionary they say . . . Exactly the same our ceremony too. Same law. And we learn, we learn both way.⁶

While missionaries had taught that ceremony was “in direct opposition to the Gospel,” Murabuda found connections and continuities that missionaries did not anticipate.⁷ He reinterpreted the Ten Commandments as affirming the continuing validity of Anindilyakwa ceremony. This Anindilyakwa Christianity was reimagined according to Anindilyakwa values and in continuity with an Anindilyakwa past.

By the late 1960s, Anindilyakwa people increasingly asserted the value of their traditional spiritual practices even to missionaries, insisting that missionaries learn to understand their laws and culture.⁸ They urged missionaries to recognize their ceremony as legitimate. Some Christian converts requested that missionaries attend ceremony, even though they no longer participated themselves.⁹ David Woodbridge remembered how Christian converts wanted him to recognize the value of ceremony:

There was a lot of angst on the part of Aboriginal Christians, men, who were wanting to sort this out in their own head. “This isn’t

wrong, these ceremonies that we conduct.” And so they invited all the chaplains . . . to attend a very sacred ceremony. We didn’t know what to do, so we went. And they showed us all this stuff. Goodness me! I’m not supposed to tell you about this, it’s a men’s thing. But there were objects, huge images that they resurrected from the bush. There was all sorts of stuff going on and there was dancing. It was a law corroboree and it went on for a long time, several days. And we, I suppose, had the privilege of being there as spectators. They didn’t expect us to agree with it or to have anything to do with it, but they just wanted us to see that what they were doing wasn’t evil. It was pagan, but it wasn’t evil.¹⁰

By inviting missionaries, even converts claimed the continuing validity and significance of ceremony. When Yolngu displayed their sacred objects to missionaries in 1957, they asserted that Europeans were not the only ones with valuable cultural knowledge; their own culture was rich in value.¹¹ Similarly, the Anindilyakwa converts sought to win the missionaries’ respect for their ceremonies—proving they were not “evil”—and to undercut the missionaries’ assumption that Christianity was the only religion with such depth of meaning and symbolism. They had some success; after witnessing the ceremony, Woodbridge could no longer call it evil. To my own surprise, when I visited the old men at Angurugu, they insisted on showing me a DVD of a Mardayin ceremony held a couple of years earlier. “Are you sure you want me to see this?” *Yawa* [yes].” They wanted me to know, too.

Howard Morphy described a “mutual conversion” that occurred when Methodist missionaries encountered Yolngu people. Morphy found that the Methodist missionaries’ early openness to religious dialogue on encountering Yolngu beliefs produced a “syncretic dialogue” of religious accommodation and “integration” of Yolngu and Christian religious forms.¹² My own interviews confirm this. One missionary remembered the old men telling him, “It’s necessary for you to be taught too.” “I became the pupil,” he said.¹³

It would be going too far to call the missionary response to Anindilyakwa ceremony and Christianity a “conversion,” as Morphy does for Yolngu missions. Yet there was a degree of reciprocity at Angurugu. Missionaries’ translation programs necessitated what Joseph Errington calls the “double paradox of translation and conversion.” On the one hand, missionaries hoped to determine the acceptable and unacceptable aspects of Indigenous lives and cultures. On the other hand, to acquire the language, they needed to engage fully with the lives and cultures associated with those languages.¹⁴ Missionaries’ commitment to vernacularizing their universal Gospel compelled them to submit, to some extent, to Indigenous ways of viewing the world. Through their acquisition of cultural knowledge, they could find themselves accommodating or even accepting practices they had once sought to unravel.¹⁵

The more missionaries undertook to learn Anindilyakwa, the more they perceived the riches and complexities of the language and the more the aggressive rhetoric of “penetrating” or “reaching” into the hearts softened and was abandoned. While some missionaries had desired to “colonize consciousness,” the reality of learning the language and discovering the depths of Anindilyakwa spirituality that became evident caused some missionaries to realize that any such project was futile.

Instead of “penetrating Anindilyakwa hearts” in order to change them, missionaries themselves were changed. Immersion in Anindilyakwa language had unintended consequences for missionaries. Stokes’s faith was imbued with new meanings on her engagement with Anindilyakwa people and language. In 1960 she reworked Capell’s original translation of the Lord’s Prayer. Anindilyakwa traditions and meanings caused her to reconsider the prayer she had always known. She thought Capell’s translation of “give us today our daily bread” sounded “a bit greedy” in Anindilyakwa. It read “give me every day our food,” while Anindilyakwa-speakers would expect the food to be shared. In Stokes’s translation, “hallowed be thy name” became “help us to speak well of your name,” giving the prayer a new emphasis on speaking honor, not shame, and on the importance of names in showing respect. “Lead us not into temptation” became “protect us from sin (or evil).”¹⁶ Her version of the prayer had Anindilyakwa meanings not obvious in the original English version. It asks for power and protection in the face of evil powers (since “sin” and “evil” are the same word), rather than deliverance from moral failure as in English. The Lord’s Prayer in Anindilyakwa has distinctly Anindilyakwa meanings; it also held new meanings for Stokes.

Dulcie Levitt and Julie Rudder (née Waddy) also came to unexpected appreciation of Anindilyakwa knowledge. Levitt began at Angurugu as the missionary agriculturalist—intending to teach Aboriginal people how to make use of the land—but her exposure to Anindilyakwa knowledge of the environment led her to work with Anindilyakwa women to compose an encyclopedia of their knowledge for their children. She recorded dozens of Anindilyakwa remedies and medicines, bush plants and their uses.¹⁷ Continuing Levitt’s work, Rudder recorded Anindilyakwa systems for classifying plants and animals, including data on Anindilyakwa stories, place names, and language. She called Anindilyakwa classification a “complex system which deserves to be recognised.”¹⁸ At first, she said, she “had no sense” of the spiritual significance of the names she collected. “I was just asking from a white person’s perspective.”¹⁹ Yet later she developed an appreciation for Anindilyakwa cosmology. Worsley later praised Rudder’s work as “so authoritative” and described Levitt as the “pioneer of Groote Eylandt biological research.”²⁰ Before their encounter with Anindilyakwa people, these missionaries might not have considered such research relevant to missionary activity. Yet it is evident that they came to view the world from more Anindilyakwa

perspectives, appreciating connections between the land, the spiritual world, and people's lives, and therefore reaching the view that knowledge of the earth was essential for missionaries.

The *emeba* songs also had the power to change missionaries. As Stokes worked at translating her evangelical songs into Anindilyakwa, she also translated the *emeba* into English. In May 1962, musicologist Alice Moyle came from Sydney University, returning five times between 1962 and 1969. She worked with Gula and Stokes to record and translate *emeba*, including some recorded by the 1948 American-Australian Scientific Expedition. Gula Lalara, Nabilya Lalara, and Jock Wurragwagwa were their main songmen. The project has been of great value to Anindilyakwa people today, now that there are fewer songmen.

The song project had various benefits for the CMS. Stokes and Moyle believed they were doing a service to Anindilyakwa people. They intended to communicate respect, recognizing the artistic and intellectual merit of the *emeba*. The recording and translation of Anindilyakwa *emeba* was an opportunity to promote the work of the CMS to the Australian general public. By producing English translations of songs, Stokes was able to present a positive image of Anindilyakwa people. The songs showed that Anindilyakwa people had their own rich cultural heritage, which would, the CMS hoped, generate a greater public interest in Aboriginal mission work. The transcription and translation of the *emeba*, Stokes hoped, would encourage a literary culture among Anindilyakwa-speakers as the Anindilyakwa transcriptions of the *emeba* were used as literacy aids in adult vernacular education.²¹

Though the songs were intended as enticements for Anindilyakwa people to learn to read, it was missionaries who developed an appreciation for the *emeba*. Missionary Lois Reid grew to love the nightly sound of the *yiraka* and *alyingba* (clap sticks), though she did not understand it.²² Stokes was obviously fascinated by the songs and the language. Rudder also worked on the song project and developed a passion for the intricacies of the *emeba*. She holds the songmen in the highest regard. She spoke with awe of the beauty and complexity of Anindilyakwa songs. Gula was “just absolutely amazing” at word-play and poetry in song. She spoke of “unravelling” the meanings of songs with Gula, discovering in a song apparently about the oystercatcher hidden meanings about traditional burial platforms, complete with allusions to fluids from the deceased's body dripping down. It was “mind-boggling,” she said.²³ Rudder's growing appreciation of Anindilyakwa thought even shaped the way she understood her own spiritual life. She came to articulate her own Christian faith to me in terms of Aboriginal secret ceremony business.

With ceremony knowledge, there's levels of meanings, so with paintings and songs there's layers of meaning, and so it goes

deeper and deeper inside. . . . From a Christian perspective, if you've really grasped hold of what a relationship with the Lord means, it goes deep inside. And not just another layer, but deep.²⁴

The song exchange was never equal, nor could it be, due to the closed nature of Aboriginal knowledge, yet it did represent a willingness to engage with Anindilyakwa cultures. The translation of *emeba* into English was never given the same value by Stokes as the translation of Christian songs and Scripture into Anindilyakwa. When the song project with Moyle took far longer than Stokes hoped, Barry Butler wrote to her reiterating the need to prioritize Bible translation.²⁵ Stokes herself later said she felt "guilty" spending so much time on translating *emeba*, even though she saw linguistic and anthropological value in the work.²⁶ It still did not fit well with her evangelical priorities. Though translation occurred in both directions, missionaries never incorporated influences of the *emeba* into their own singing. Nor could they—the *emeba* are owned by Anindilyakwa people who continued to assert their authority in this domain. Despite these limitations, the evangelical recognition of the value of the *emeba* represents a selective embrace by missionaries of aspects of Anindilyakwa culture.

Instead of a "colonization of consciousness," the mission was a site of dialogue, of cross-cultural flows, as Anindilyakwa people and missionaries each appropriated and translated the ideas and symbols of the other. Of course, the exchange occurred within a context of inequality; it was the missionaries who attempted the colonization of Anindilyakwa hearts and minds, not the other way around. Missionaries did not face the same pressure to change as Anindilyakwa people did. Still, the missionaries themselves did not emerge unchanged or unchallenged from the encounter. Thus, distinct Anindilyakwa Christianities emerged as missionaries and Anindilyakwa people reinterpreted their faiths in light of the cross-cultural, translating context of the mission. The missionaries who went to Angurugu and sat down with Anindilyakwa-speakers returned south with a different Christianity than when they left home. No one emerged from the mission encounter unchanged. The translation and reinterpretation of symbols and meaning at Angurugu occurred in a multitude of ways; it was fluid, unplanned, unexpected.

The End of an Era

The year 1973 brought many changes for the missions. The Anglican Church ordained its first Aboriginal priest in the Northern Territory, Michael Gum-buli Wurramara, a Groote Eylandter. The "spiritual ministry" in church was no longer the domain of white missionaries alone. In the federal election of December 1972, a Labor government came to power for the first time in

twenty-three years. The new Whitlam government dismantled the Welfare Branch and replaced it with a Department of Aboriginal Affairs. It pursued a new policy framework for Aboriginal people: Assimilation was gone and “self-determination” was in. The Anindilyakwa language was officially allowed into the Angurugu classroom. Kim Beazley Sr., the new minister for education, suggested bilingual education for Aboriginal schools to the prime minister one afternoon in December 1972. Whitlam announced the new policy later that same day on the evening news.²⁷ The new bilingual program came in a hurry. Stokes was overjoyed, at first.

Angurugu was chosen to be among the initial schools to implement the scheme. Stokes was anxious. The schoolteachers were “pessimistic.” They were unsure if they had enough Anindilyakwa-speaking teaching assistants for the program to work. Once again, Anindilyakwa people themselves were not consulted. There were very few Anindilyakwa teachers in the school at the time, meaning that most work fell to Nancy Lalara, while Stokes attempted to produce lessons in a form that might interest potential teaching assistants in the bilingual program. Stokes prayed that “the scheme may not be jeopardized by rushing into it.”²⁸ Angurugu school was operating bilingually by June 1973, by which stage Stokes’s expectations for the program were low, anticipating that the project might “fail before it starts.”²⁹

Stokes’s prayer for the bilingual program was not answered. The vernacular education that Stokes and Capell had advocated for years was introduced far too quickly. The program was suspended in Angurugu in 1976 due to a shortage of teaching assistants, high staff turnover, lack of resources, and an unresolved dispute between linguists over Anindilyakwa orthography.

Stokes remained at Angurugu as linguist until her retirement in 1989. Wilma Taylor helped care for Stokes in Adelaide when she developed Alzheimer’s disease in her old age. Taylor told me the Anindilyakwa language was so dear to Stokes that it was one of the last things she lost.

Even in later life when she was not quite with it and there were a couple of the Aboriginal ladies down here to see Judy, she was sort of with it, but not quite, and answering direct questions. But then the two ladies said something in Anindilyakwa and Judy responded in the language. They were overjoyed. And then they tried to get her to do it again, but it was a reflex action and she couldn’t do it again. It just happened. So that’s how much the language was in her.³⁰

Stokes died in June 2003. At her funeral service in Adelaide they sang in Anindilyakwa two hymns she had translated into Anindilyakwa. This was Stokes’s own request.³¹

Gula Lalara, the “professor” of the island, never returned to Christianity, though he continued to work closely with Stokes and Rudder. He was known for his long white beard, his three wives, his drinking, but mostly his wisdom, knowledge, and skill as an exceptional songman.³² Despite the inequalities and tensions of the mission context, missionaries and Anindilyakwa people established reciprocal and even intimate relationships. Some became friends. Judy Lalara, for example, told me how her father, Gula, gave her the name Judith, after Judith Stokes.³³ Her love of his language had earned his respect. Gula died an old man in 2005. First the missionary, Julie Rudder, spoke at his funeral at St. Andrews Church in Angurugu. Then the songmen sang his spirit over the island and the sea, through his country, on the *emeba* songs.

Babel and Missions

Missionaries all over the world faced the challenge of sharing their Word with another culture, another language. Their determination to evangelize and to communicate their Gospel message meant they could not avoid translations of some sort. This imperative meant that missionaries always relied on cooperation with local people and on local hospitality. Yet the missionary determination to translate also meant that Indigenous languages and cultures might become vulnerable to “colonization” by the missionary “expert” who, through translation, turned Indigenous languages themselves into instruments of settler-colonialism. That is, translation could enable what the Comaroffs called the “colonization of the mind.”

Missionaries used language both to assure themselves of their own ascendancy and to coax Indigenous people to listen to their teachings. They wielded language—both their English-language literacies and texts as well as Indigenous languages in print—as instruments to reshape Indigenous people into their vision of civilized Christians. Yet the missionaries’ dependence on interpreters, teachers, and informants meant that missionaries’ power was always limited, their message mediated, and their teachings translated. Indigenous people found space for themselves in the ambiguities of translation. Furthermore, missionaries themselves were not homogeneous groups; they had different individual ideas of what they should be doing and how, as well as differing experiences, expertise, and access to authorities. Missionaries were compelled to negotiate and sometimes struggle even with each other, and they interpreted the same events differently. Christian missions, therefore, were less ordered or controlled than missionaries would have liked to believe.

On Groote Eylandt, although some, but not all, missionaries may have envisaged what could be called a colonization of the Anindilyakwa mind, Anindilyakwa people constantly subverted missionary intentions and rein-

terpreted and misinterpreted the Word according to their own diverse needs and interests. Many Anindilyakwa people embraced English, missionary literacies, and Christian songs, finding opportunities for innovation and engagement with modernity. Others resisted attempts by missionary “experts” to colonize their language; still others engaged with missionary language projects for their own ends. Anindilyakwa people found ways to keep their secrets, to maintain separateness from the missionaries, and to disengage from missionary projects where necessary. At the same time, differences in language and practices of orality and literacy, as well as possibilities of translation, allowed some Anindilyakwa people to selectively embrace missionary teachings. Throughout their dialogue, Anindilyakwa people incorporated and reinterpreted what the missionaries brought and taught, making it their own, and not necessarily in ways missionaries expected or understood. Missionaries, too, found themselves transformed or “translated” in unexpected ways as they were increasingly immersed in Anindilyakwa language, culture, and society. The translation and reinterpretation of symbols and meaning at missions was fluid, unplanned, unanticipated.

The Groote Eylandt case is, in many ways, unusual. Unlike many other places—across the Pacific or even across nearby Arnhem Land—missionary linguistics on Groote Eylandt never succeeded in generating a culture of vernacular literacy on a large scale. This was for various reasons, including the ambivalence and resistance of Anindilyakwa-speakers themselves. Bible translation was minimal, conversions were, in the end, few; the mission could be judged a failure. Yet even there, Anindilyakwa people persistently engaged with the missionaries regarding both material and spiritual matters. The imperative of translation between languages—and the subsequent opportunities for mistranslation and misinterpretation—opened the space for much of this sometimes covert, often creative engagement.

This meant that, on Groote Eylandt, translation was at once an instrument of settler-colonialism and an opportunity for Indigenous agency and challenges to colonization. The mission’s colonizing processes and Aboriginal initiatives occurred simultaneously in dynamic and overlapping ways. The controlling nature of the mission institutions and their complicity in settler-colonialism cannot be denied. The dormitory, the school, the church, the work regime, the rations—as well as subtler instruments such as English-language documents and missionaries’ Standard Australian English—were all mechanisms to hold Anindilyakwa people under missionary authority and, ultimately to absorb them into the settler-colonial society. Even these impositions, however, had uneven impacts on Anindilyakwa people, as they responded in various ways to the mission encounter.

So historians should be skeptical of missionaries’ overconfident claims that might lead us to think a “colonization of consciousness” took place. While some (though not all) missionaries envisaged such a process in their

assimilatory ambitions, they were unaware of the extent to which Aboriginal people guided and influenced missionary agendas and practices (of course, other missionaries were profoundly aware of their dependence on Aboriginal cooperation). Ironically, as missionaries worked to mold Aboriginal people in their own image, Anindilyakwa people were already interacting with the missions' teachings and practices in ways missionaries did not recognize. In fact, Anindilyakwa people hid it from them. Their actions did not fit into a binary of either resistance or collaboration with colonizers. Instead, Anindilyakwa people engaged with missionaries and their Word in diverse ways, some supporting missionaries, others reacting, resisting, or disengaging, and still others translating and reinterpreting missionary imports for an Anindilyakwa world, quite apart from any missionary or settler-colonial visions for them.

In the Babel myth, the divine scattering of humanity gave rise to languages belonging to every place and people. Portraying missionaries as simply builders of Babel or colonizers of consciousness can obscure their own unsettledness. Missionaries were often confused, speaking the wrong languages in foreign places. Unsure of what Indigenous people heard and uncertain of how they read the Word the missionaries had brought, missionaries were dependent on mediators and interpreters, often unable to convince Indigenous peoples to cooperate, sometimes wondering if God were still with them. Missionaries scattered themselves across earth, as if trying to pick up the pieces after the Babel scattering, hoping to coax the whole Earth to listen, to speak their "language," and believe their "Word." Like restless wanderers, the missionaries to Groote Eylandt traveled to a distant island, trying to induce the inhabitants to become "sedentary" like them. In some ways, English-speaking missionaries were more like the wanderers than the builders of their Babel story.

Unexpectedly, perhaps, Indigenous people have found ways of asserting particularity, uniqueness, and identity—especially attachment to place and kin affiliations—through translation and the reinterpreted, reimaged, Indigenous Christianities that emerge from it. On Groote Eylandt, Gerry Blitner found in the Babel story evidence of divine provision of Aboriginal land and languages, a reading that contested colonization and its installation of English as the language of the land.³⁴ Against missionary expectations, Aboriginal people of the Groote Eylandt archipelago found ways to make their own names for themselves, asserting their identities and separateness as they negotiated change. For Groote Eylandt's story, it is best to understand missionaries and Anindilyakwa people as both builders of Babel and wanderers from it: each with missions or projects; each trying to make a name, an identity, for themselves but doing so in a contested place, a confusing, plural, and translating world.

EPILOGUE

Like visitors before me, whenever I visit Groote Eylandt, I notice the music. During the day in Angurugu an occasional Toyota drives past, stereo thumping. Otherwise it's quiet. But at night, the music erupts. From each house comes a different tune; Angurugu's musical repertoire is far more diverse and international than my own. Around nine o'clock at night in the dry season, the songs of the fellowship group begin, a tradition that evolved from the camp services of the mission days. They turn the amps right up so they can preach, pray, and sing for everyone (even those who do not come are made to share the fellowship by sheer volume). They sing missionary tunes: "This Is the Day," "Take a Little Time for Jesus," "You Are the Lamb of God." But it's a distinctly Aboriginal genre. The keyboard player selects a drumbeat and supplies the chords, while the women, who sit on a low stage, sing the melody in octaves into the microphone. They sing late into the night, just as the old men used to sing and play didjeridu into the dawn. It's hard to sleep for all the music, but I think people like it this way.

On the last Sunday of one of my visits, I wandered down to St. Andrew's Anglican Church. On my previous visits, there had been CMS missionaries living on the island. Every Sunday they would drive around town, gathering

up old people who remembered the mission days and taking them to church. But this time the couple had left the island, and no one would be replacing them for the time being (though recently the CMS has sent a new couple to continue the mission).

I sat in the pew and waited, reading, for an hour or so. Nobody came.

As I was leaving, the familiar cadences of a Hillsong chorus drifted over the town. (Hillsong is a Pentecostal mega-church in Sydney.) I followed its sound to a newish Pentecostal Gospel Hall. An Indian-Fijian man, Pastor Roy, greeted me. He had married a local woman and had been living in Angurugu for twenty-five years. Their church hoped for success where the CMS, supposedly, failed. He introduced me to this morning's preacher. This man came from Papua New Guinea—in some ways, a new kind of missionary to Aboriginal people, in others, just the latest iteration in a long story of the network of Pacific missions. I could not help but see contrasting legacies of diverse mission histories in our miniature transnational encounter.

I was early. The preacher talked with me as we waited for others to come. He quietly expressed his disappointment with the community. "They don't want to listen," he said. The women in the congregation were also from Papua New Guinea. They had moved to the island because their husbands worked for BHP. "You must miss your church at home," I commented. "Yes, at home we have three, sometimes four thousand people each week."

Eventually, three Anindilyakwa people came to the service. We sang. It was all in English. Two of them, apparently, had "given their lives to Jesus" the night before and would be baptized next week. I wondered if they would be back.

Notes

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4. Niranjana, *Siting Translation*, 186.

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2. Niranjana, *Siting Translation*, 2.
3. Rafael, “Betraying Empire,” 83, 86.
4. Nicholas Thomas, *Entangled Objects*; Ballantyne, *Entanglements of Empire*.
5. Harris, “Hiding the Bodies.”
6. van Egmond, “Enindhilyakwa Phonology,” 1.
7. Worsley, *Knowledges*, 5; Martin Thomas, *Peter Worsley Interviewed*; van Egmond, “Enindhilyakwa Phonology,” 1.

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16. Bourdieu, *Language and Symbolic Power*, 57–58.
17. Wolfe, *Settler Colonialism and the Transformation of Anthropology*, 163; Veracini, *Settler Colonialism*, 14.
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19. Van Toorn, *Writing Never Arrives Naked*, 12–13.
20. Hofmeyr, *The Portable Bunyan*, 13–14.
21. Van Toorn, *Writing Never Arrives Naked*, 14.
22. Hofmeyr, *The Portable Bunyan*, 13.
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24. Niranjana, *Siting Translation*, 21.
25. *Ibid.*, 186.
26. Rafael, "Betraying Empire," 92.
27. Comaroff and Comaroff, *Of Revelation and Revolution, Volume 1: Christianity, Colonialism and Consciousness in South Africa*, xi.
28. *Ibid.*, 252.
29. *Ibid.*, 218. See also Fabian, *Language and Colonial Power*.
30. Comaroff and Comaroff, *Of Revelation and Revolution, Volume 1: Christianity, Colonialism and Consciousness in South Africa*, 310; Comaroff and Comaroff, *Of Revelation and Revolution, Volume 2: The Dialectics of Modernity on a South African Frontier*, 117. See also Fabian, "Missions and the Colonization of African Languages," 183.
31. Sanneh, *Encountering the West*, 15–17.
32. Walls, *The Missionary Movement in Christian History*, 100; Cox, *Imperial Fault Lines*, 15.
33. Peterson, "Colonizing Language?" 257.
34. Gilmour, *Grammars of Colonialism*, 3.
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37. Gardner, "'New Heaven and New Earth,'" 310–311.
38. Cox, *Imperial Fault Lines*, 16.
39. Veracini, "Telling the End of the Settler Colonial Story," 14.
40. Rowse, "Indigenous Heterogeneity," 310.

CHAPTER 1. MEETINGS

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2. Keary, “Christianity, Colonialism, and Cross-Cultural Translation,” 120.
3. Threlkeld, *An Australian Language as Spoken by the Awabakal People*, 88.
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7. Gardner, “‘New Heaven and New Earth,’” 297.
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10. Sanneh, *Translating the Message*, 51, 298.
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12. Kriol developed from a pidgin English and became some Aboriginal people’s first language (a creole language) in the early twentieth century. It was first standardized by an evangelical mission organization, the Summer Institute of Linguistics, in the 1970s. Kriol-speakers have in the past referred to their language as variously as “pidgin,” “pidgin English,” “Roper pidgin,” or simply “language.”
13. Matsuda, *Pacific Worlds*, 145.
14. Porter, *Religion Versus Empire?* 40–41.
15. Gunson, *Messengers of Grace*, 39, 80.
16. Matsuda, *Pacific Worlds*, 147; Gunson, *Messengers of Grace*, 255.
17. Nicholas Thomas, *Islanders*, 98–101.
18. Ibid., 103; Newbury, “Pacts, Alliances, and Patronage,” 143–146.
19. Matsuda, *Pacific Worlds*, 158–159; Ballantyne, *Entanglements of Empire*, 107.
20. Ballantyne, *Entanglements of Empire*, 28.
21. Thornley, “‘Through a Glass Darkly,’” 132.
22. Gardner, “‘New Heaven and New Earth,’” 296.
23. *Twenty-Eighth Report of the British and Foreign Bible Society* (London: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1842), lxxiii.
24. Gardner, *Gathering for God*, 33.
25. Ibid., 51.
26. Lange, “Indigenous Agents of Religious Change in New Zealand,” 280–284.
27. Wetherell, *Reluctant Mission*, 96.
28. Matsuda, *Pacific Worlds*, 144.
29. Gardner, *Gathering for God*, 57.
30. Elmore, *Like Them That Dream*, 19.
31. Hamilton, “God in Samoa,” 96.
32. Johnston, *Missionary Writing and Empire*, 6, 208.
33. Close-Barry, *A Mission Divided*, 6–7.
34. Stevens, “Kāi Tahu Writing,” 32–33; Gunson, *Messengers of Grace*, 266.

35. *Twenty-Fifth Report of the British and Foreign Bible Society* (London: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1829), xvii.
36. Ballantyne, *Orientalism and Race*, 152.
37. *Seventy-Third Report of the British and Foreign Bible Society* (London: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1877), 303–304.
38. Roe, *A History of the British and Foreign Bible Society, 1905–1954*, 125.
39. *Seventy-Third Report of the British and Foreign Bible Society*, 309–311.
40. Elsmore, *Like Them That Dream*, 56.
41. Lineham, *Bible and Society*, 20.
42. Gardner, “‘New Heaven and New Earth,’” 311.
43. Gunson, *Messengers of Grace*, 213.
44. Johnston, *Missionary Writing and Empire*, 128.
45. Gardner, “‘New Heaven and New Earth,’” 296.
46. Johnston, *The Paper War*, 104.
47. Threlkeld to George Burder and W. A. Hankey, 2 February 1825, in Threlkeld, *Australian Reminiscences and Papers of L. E. Threlkeld*, 2:178.
48. “Second Half Yearly Report of the Aboriginal Mission Supported by the LMS,” L. E. Threlkeld, 21 June 1826, in *ibid.*, 2:204.
49. Keary, “Christianity, Colonialism, and Cross-Cultural Translation,” 119, 130, 142–146.
50. Hilary Carey, “Lancelot Threlkeld, Biraban, and the Colonial Bible in Australia,” 460.
51. *Ibid.*
52. Threlkeld, *An Australian Language as Spoken by the Awabakal People*, 127.
53. Woolmington, “Missionary Attitudes to the Baptism of Australian Aborigines,” 285.
54. Mitchell, “Flesh, Dreams and Spirit,” 64–65.
55. *Ibid.*, 336.
56. Gunson, *Messengers of Grace*, 90.
57. Porter, *Religion Versus Empire?* 283–285.
58. Editorial, *Argus*, 29 May 1860, 4; editorial, *Argus*, 5 June 1860, 4.
59. Johnston, *Missionary Writing and Empire*, 18.
60. Jenz, “Imperial Critics,” 189–191.
61. Kenny, *The Lamb Enters the Dreaming*, 14.
62. F. W. Spieske to Chase, 14 February 1860, in *Christian Times, Missionary Success among the Aborigines* (Melbourne: Christian Times, 1860), 4.
63. Kenny, *The Lamb Enters the Dreaming*, 15, 111.
64. Point McLeay mission and Lake Tyers were taken over by governments and became Aboriginal stations. Over the course of the nineteenth century, the Australian colonies introduced laws for the “protection” of Aboriginal people. These gave government-appointed Protectors of Aborigines power to remove Aboriginal people onto reserves, missions, or stations. Aboriginal stations are often referred to as “missions,” even though they were government-run institutions. Some had previously been Christian missions, and missionaries often visited or managed the station.
65. Teichelmann and Schurmann, *Outlines of a Grammar*, v.

66. Harris, *One Blood*, 832–834.
67. Ballantyne, *Entanglements of Empire*, 41.
68. Roe, *A History of the British and Foreign Bible Society*, 117.
69. The interaction between settler-colonialism and Christian missions in South Africa is another interesting example. John Comaroff argues that three types of colonization occurred in South Africa. While the Boers pursued settler-colonization, the British sought a “state colonisation,” and missionaries, critical of both, advocated “civilising colonisation.” These competing colonialisms were each present in Central and North Australia in the late nineteenth and twentieth centuries, but the South Australian colonies in the nineteenth century began as distinctly settler-colonies, with missionaries following afterward. See John Comaroff, “Images of Empire,” 178–186; Rowse, “Indigenous Heterogeneity,” 303–307.
70. Johnston, *Missionary Writing and Empire*, 121.
71. Grimshaw, “Missions, Colonialism and the Politics of Gender,” 7.
72. *Thirty-Second Report of the British and Foreign Bible Society* (London: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1847), cxvi.
73. Press, Christchurch, 10 May 1865, 2, quoted in Lineham, *Bible and Society*, 142.
74. Elsmore, *Like Them That Dream*, 72–74, 100.
75. Grimshaw, “Missions, Colonialism and the Politics of Gender,” 6.
76. Ibid., 7; Mitchell, “Flesh, Dreams and Spirit,” 64–65.
77. Wolfe, *Settler Colonialism and the Transformation of Anthropology*, 163.
78. Hilliard, *God’s Gentlemen*, 156–157; Kenny, *The Lamb Enters the Dreaming*, 298.
79. Close-Barry, *A Mission Divided*, 3; Veracini, “‘Emphatically Not a White Man’s Colony,’” 199–200.
80. Van Toorn, *Writing Never Arrives Naked*, 13.
81. “Toughest Mission Job in the World,” *CMS News*, April 1957.
82. Capell, “Linguistic Change in Australia,” 257.

CHAPTER 2. TRANSLATING THE LANDSCAPE

1. They were Old Charlie Wurramarrba, Old Banjo Lalara, Old Bill Wurramara, and Maradjuwi Murrungun.
2. Jabani Lalara, “Looking for a New Place to Live,” transcribed and translated by Groote Eylandt Linguistics, 2012. Used with permission.
3. “Ungooraku,” *Australian Round World*, 1 March 1944, 6.
4. Arrowsmith and Begbie, *These Australians*, 73.
5. Jabani Lalara, oral history interview with author, 10 December 2012.
6. Nunggubuyu is a contraction of *nung*, meaning “person,” and Wubuy, their language.
7. Clarke, “Winds of Change,” 22.
8. Urry and Walsh, “The Lost ‘Macassar Language’ of Northern Australia,” 94.
9. Macknight, “Studying Trepangers,” 19.
10. Urry and Walsh, “The Lost ‘Macassar Language’ of Northern Australia,” 95.
11. Ian McIntosh “Islam and Australia’s Aborigines?” 59.
12. Judith Stokes, “Macassan Words Which Have Come into Anindilyakwa,” Australian Institute for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Studies

- (hereafter AIATSIS), MS 3518, Box 4, Folder 25; Macknight, “Macassans and Aborigines,” 295.
13. Ibid., 302.
 14. Mudabuda Wurramarrba, oral history interview with author, 10 December 2012.
 15. Evans, “Macassan Loanwords in Top End Languages,” 52.
 16. Murabuda Wurramarrba, oral history interview with author, 10 December 2012.
 17. Colossians 1:13 (King James Version).
 18. Church Missionary Society of Australia, *Decade*, 6.
 19. A. J. Dyer, “Description of First Party to Start Groote Eylandt in 1921,” NTAS 693, Box 1.
 20. Hubert Warren to Ellie Warren, 8 December 1916, Mitchell Library (hereafter ML), DOC 1970.
 21. Letter dated 25 May 1917, National Archives of Australia (hereafter NAA), A659 1943/1/70.
 22. Seafild Deuchar, 18 March 1920, NAA, A659 1943/1/70.
 23. Ibid.
 24. Martin Thomas, *Gerald Blitner Interviewed*.
 25. H. E. Warren, “Report on Work of 1927,” NAA, A659 1943/1/70.
 26. Connie Bush, oral history interview with Mickey Dewar, 1987, in Dewar, *The “Black War” in Arnhem Land*, 25.
 27. S. Port, “Regulations for Village People,” NTAS 868.
 28. Clarke, “Damper and Fish, Tea and Sugar,” 104.
 29. “Report on Groote Eylandt Mission, Inspected 4–6th September, 1934,” NAA, A659 1943/1/70.
 30. W. Leathbridge, “The Groote Eylandt Imps,” *Australian Round World*, 1 April 1938, 8–9.
 31. J. W. Burton to T. Paterson, 30 June 1937, NAA, A431 1948/226.
 32. Aborigines Committee Minutes, 14 February, 1945, ML, MSS 6040/4a.
 33. Edith Mamarika, oral history interview with author, 8 September 2012.
 34. H. S. Poll to C. L. A. Abbott, 13 August 1939, NAA, A431 1948/226.
 35. C. E. Cook to Robert Weddell, 1933, NAA, A659 1943/1/70; C. E. Cook to Robert Weddell, 17 January 1934, NAA, A659 1943/1/70.
 36. Connie Bush, oral history interview with Mickey Dewar, 1987, in Dewar, *The “Black War” in Arnhem Land*, 34.
 37. W. E. Harney, “Report on Groote Eylandt Mission,” June 1942, NAA, A453 1951/536.
 38. Minutes of the Meeting of the Federal Council, 15–17 October 1946, ML, MSS 6040/1a.
 39. Minutes of the Meeting of the Aborigines Committee, 7 February 1945, ML, MSS 6040/4a.
 40. Veracini, *Settler Colonialism*, 35.
 41. Riseman, “Disrupting Assimilation,” 250.
 42. W. E. Harney, “Report on Groote Eylandt Mission,” June 1942, NAA, A453 1951/536.
 43. Murabuda Wurramarrba, oral history interview with author, 4 September 2012.
 44. Murabuda Wurramarrba, oral history interview with author, 10 December 2012.

45. McGregor, *Indifferent Inclusion*, 14, 17.
46. Thomson, *Donald Thomson in Arnhem Land*, 119.
47. Donald Thomson, *Interim General Report of Preliminary Expedition to Arnhem Land, Northern Territory of Australia, 1935–1956* (Department of the Interior, April 1936), 45.
48. Grant and Webb, *Aliens in Arnhem Land*, 64.
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50. “The Church Missionary Society Throws a Searchlight on the Aborigines,” *Open Door*, January 1940, 10.
51. William Palmer, “An Account of the Missionary Work in N Australia,” 1949, ML, MS 6040/39.
52. Elkin, *Citizenship for the Aborigines*, 30.
53. Gray, “A Deep-Seated Aversion or a Prudish Disapproval,” 93; Attwood, “Anthropology, Aboriginality and Aboriginal Rights,” 109.
54. Montgomerie, “That They Might Have Life and Have It More Abundantly.”
55. CMS, Constitution and Policy, May 1944, ML, MSS 6040/6.
56. Russell McGregor, “From Old Testament to New,” 42.
57. CMS, Constitution and Policy, May 1944, ML, MSS 6040/6.
58. Pigginn, *Evangelical Christianity in Australia*, 127.
59. Arrowsmith, “Towards the Conversion of Australasia.”
60. Attwood, *The Making of the Aborigines*, 1.
61. Breward, *History of Australian Churches*, 141–142.
62. Montgomerie, “That They Might Have Life and Have It More Abundantly.”
63. Palmer, “An Account of the Missionary Work in N Australia,” 1949, ML, MS 6040/39.
64. Veracini, *Settler Colonialism*, 14.
65. Porter, *Religion Versus Empire?* 330.
66. “Aboriginal Sunday—January 30th,” *Open Door*, January 1944; “What of the Aborigines,” *Open Door*, January 1944.
67. R. J. Hewett, “New Year Message from Our Federal Secretary,” *Open Door*, January 1950.
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69. Minutes of Meeting, 28 August 1946, ML, MSS 6040/4a.
70. A. R. Driver, 5 August 1947, NAA F1 1945/258.
71. J. B. Montgomerie to S. R. Warren, 6 December 1954, NTAS 871, Box 12.
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75. G. A. Pearson, “Statement by the Regional Secretary—the Groote Eylandt Problem,” 7 June 1962, NTAS 873, Box 16.
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82. Jabani Lalara, oral history interview with author, 10 December 2012.
83. Jabani Lalara, oral history interview with author, 15 June 2012.
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85. Worsley, "The Changing Social Structure of the Wanindiljaugwa," 290.
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92. Elizabeth Taylor, 6 April 1945, NAA, A453 1951/536.
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105. Judy Lalara, oral history interview with author, 11 December 2012.
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109. Cole, *Groote Eylandt Mission*, 50.
110. Stanley, "Conversion to Christianity," 155.

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122. Policy for Aboriginal and Half Caste Education, 1946, ML, MMS 6040/1a.

CHAPTER 3. EARS TO HEAR

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3. Romans 10:17 (King James Version).
4. Jenny Green, oral history interview with author, 23 August 2012; Gwen Tremlett, oral history interview with author, 18 November 2011; Julie Rudder (née Waddy), oral history interview with author, 7 January 2012.
5. CMS Policy in North Australia, July 1969, ML, MSS 6040/6.
6. A. P. Elkin, "Missionary Policy for Primitive Peoples," ML, MSS 6040/21.
7. Fishman, "Who Speaks What Language to Whom and When?"
8. De Fina, "Code-Switching and the Construction of Ethnic Identity."
9. Attwood, *The Making of the Aborigines*, 6.
10. Baker, "Chaos and Control," 110.
11. Sandefur, "The Aboriginalisation of the Church at Ngukurr," 49.
12. "Tom and Betty Visit Groote Eylandt," *Australian Round World*, 1 October 1949, 9.
13. Worsley, "The Changing Social Structure of the Wanindiljaugwa," 290.
14. Sandefur, "The Aboriginalisation of the Church at Ngukurr," 75.
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16. "Groote Eylandt April," 1944, NTAS 1098, Box 1.
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22. A. Barker, "Angurugu Chaplaincy Report," March 1967, NTAS 1098, Box 2.
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24. Montgomerie, "That They Might Have Life and Have It More Abundantly."
25. James Taylor to H. Giese, 16 July 1962, NTAS 1098, Box 1.
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42. E. P. Milliken, "Report of Research Sponsored or Conducted by the Welfare Branch in the Period June 1967–June 1969," Missions/Administrations Conference, June 1969, NTAS 56, Box 4.
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44. Capell, "Linguistic Change in Australia," 247.
45. "Groote Eylandt Mission School Biannual Report for Six Months Ending December 1953," NTAS 868, Box 1.
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49. Lesly Lyon, "Mugs, Toothbrushes and 'Frere Jacques' at School at Umbakumba," *Open Door*, July 1962, 23.
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51. John Brook to the Head Teachers of CMS Aboriginal Missions, 5 May 1965, AIATSIS, MS 3518, Box 3, Folder 1c.
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56. N. Farley, "Groote Eylandt Mission School Report, June 1954," NTAS 1098, Box 1.
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59. Barry Butler, oral history interview with author, 5 October 2012.
60. Murabuda Wurramarrba and Jabani Lalara, oral history interview with author, 4 September 2012.
61. Sutton, "The Politics of Suffering," 154.
62. S. R. Warren to J. B. Montgomerie, 10 February 1958, NTAS 868, Box 6.
63. J. B. Montgomerie to S. R. Warren, 7 March 1958, NTAS 868, Box 6.
64. E. C. Evans to J. B. Montgomerie, 20 June 1958, NTAS 868, Box 6.
65. David Woodbridge, oral history interview with author, 17 October 2011.
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68. Kathleen Mamarika, oral history Interview with author, 5 September 2012.
69. It is difficult to know from the sources whether the "pidgin" that missionaries referred to was Kriol, a form of Aboriginal English, or a pidgin. Up to the late 1960s little scholarly attention was given to any English-based language spoken by Aboriginal people. To confuse matters further, Kriol-speakers have in the past referred to their language variously as "pidgin," "pidgin English," or "Roper pidgin"; "lingo" or "pidgin lingo"; or simply "language." I use the term "Aboriginal Englishes" broadly to include instances where the language spoken was unclear.
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81. Jim Taylor, oral history interview with author, 1 July 2012.
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86. Jabani Lalara, oral history interview with author, 4 September 2012.
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90. Dulcie Levitt to E. Louis, 28 January 1958, ML, MS 6040/39.
91. James Taylor to George Pearson, 8 April 1962, NTAS 1098, Box 1.
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93. Nancy Lalara, oral history interview with author, 28 April 2012.
94. Keith Hart to Bishop Kerl, 9 October 1961, ML, MSS 6040/36.
95. Murabuda Wurramarrba, oral history interview with author, 4 September 2012.
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98. Ray Wood, "Hygiene Report, Angurugu Groote Eylandt, July 1969," NTAS 1098, Box 2.
99. Irene Jeffreys to Stanley Giltrap, 24 October 1973, CMS SA, Box 19.

CHAPTER 4. THE LETTER KILLS

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3. Goody, *The Interface between the Written and the Oral*, 298–300.
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5. Baker, "Indigenous Workers on Methodist Missions in Arnhem Land."
6. Mathew, "Mary River and Bunya Bunya Country," 176.
7. Morphy, "The Art of Northern Australia," 17.
8. Goody and Watt, "The Consequences of Literacy," 39.
9. Errington, *Linguistics in a Colonial World*, 96.
10. Quoted in Bebbington, *Evangelicalism in Modern Britain*, 4.
11. Ibid., 12.
12. Oliver Allison, "That They May Have Life," *Open Door*, 1 May 1950.
13. The Collect for the Second Sunday in Advent.
14. "What Are You Reading," *Open Door*, April 1963, 1.
15. James Carey, *Communication as Culture*, 15.
16. Norma Farley, "Breaking the Language Barrier," *Open Door*, July 1962, 7–8.
17. Damousi, *Colonial Voices*, 142–143.
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19. Sugirtharajah, *The Bible and Empire*, 2.
20. Atkinson, *The Europeans in Australia: A History: Volume Three: Nation*, xiii.
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23. Morgan, *The Bearer of This Letter*, 86.
24. Atkinson, "Speech, Children and the Federation Movement," 36.
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CHAPTER 5. THE MAMARIKA WINDS

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CHAPTER 6. SPEAKING TO THE HEART

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CHAPTER 7. SINGING IN TONGUES

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CONCLUSION

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